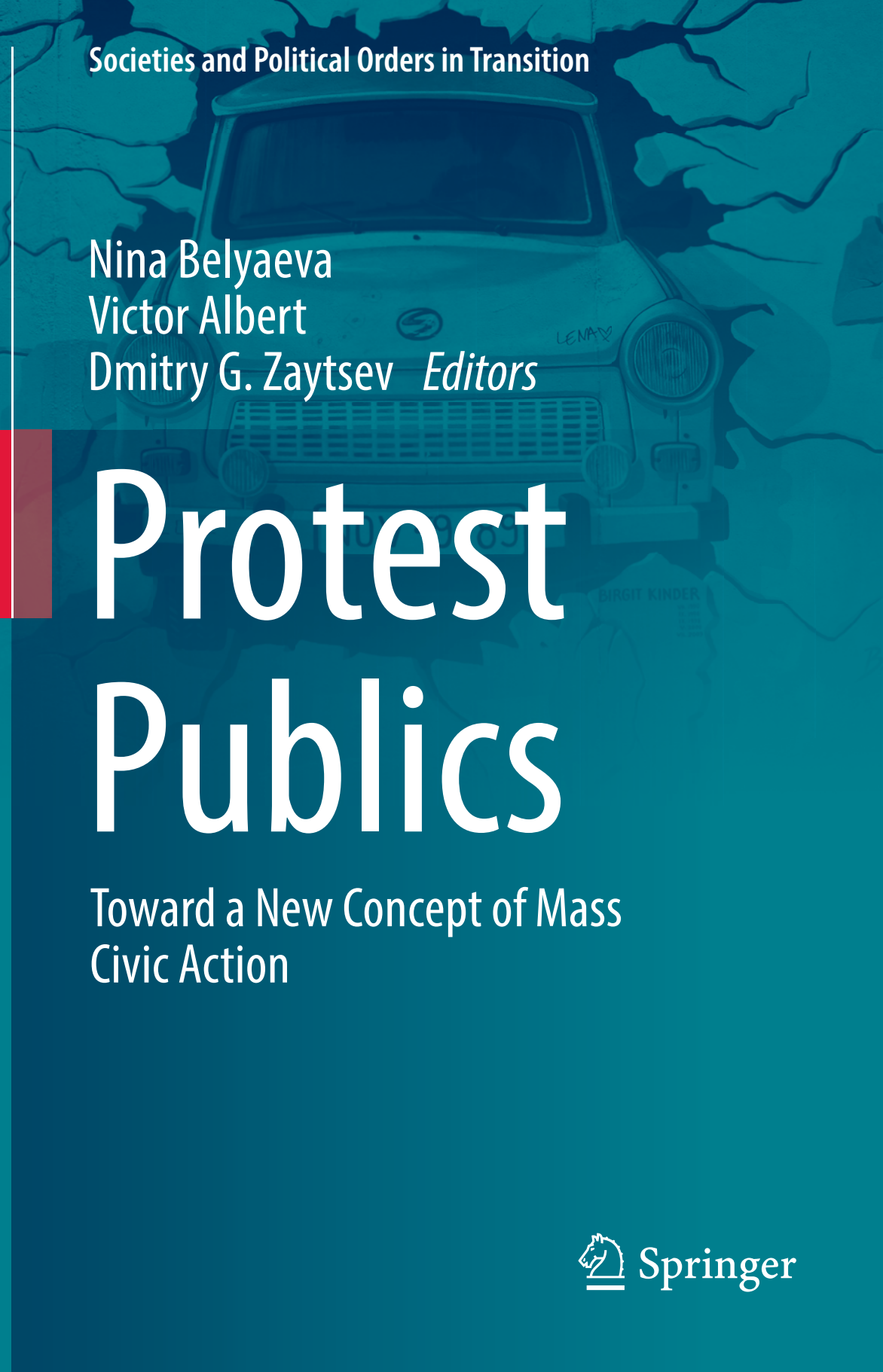
Societies and Political Orders in Transition



Nina Belyaeva
Victor Albert
Dmitry G. Zaytsev *Editors*

Protest Publics

Toward a New Concept of Mass Civic Action

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Societies and Political Orders in Transition

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ISSN 2511-2201 ISSN 2511-221X (electronic)
Societies and Political Orders in Transition
ISBN 978-3-030-05474-8 ISBN 978-3-030-05475-5 (eBook)
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5

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Foreword

Many brilliant new ideas have come out of Russian social science: Simon Kuznet's invention of national accounts, Wassily Leontief's input-output tables, and Pitirim Sorokin's historical sociology. This book provides another major contribution from Russia—as all three editors are from the Russian National Research University Higher School of Economics—to the analysis of social dynamics—the concept of "Protest Publics."

Our understanding of social protest has changed dramatically over the last century. New concepts arose with both advances in the social sciences and changes in the character of protest and the actors who carry it out. In the nineteenth century, Charles Mackay (1841) and Gustave Le Bon (1896) treated crowd behavior as a manifestation of delusions and irrational mob psychology. In the mid-twentieth century, George Rudé (1964), Neil Smelser (1963), and Herbert Blumer (1969), by contrast, treated crowd behavior—now given the more scientific term "collective behavior"—as purposive, responding to wider social dysfunction, and generated through shared understandings of the aims of protests.

In response to the student, feminist, and civil rights protests of the 1960s, scholars such as William Gamson, Charles Tilly, Doug McAdam, and Sidney Tarrow framed social protest as the actions of excluded or disadvantaged groups in democracies to seek inclusion in mainstream political discourse and policy. Gamson (1975) argued that a key determinant of social movement success was their degree of internal organization. Tilly (1978) emphasized the need for protest groups to acquire resources, including financial support and strength in numbers, to sustain their actions. McAdam (1982) introduced the notion of "political opportunity"—that is, weakness or divisions within state authorities or those resisting the protest movement's goals. Tarrow (1994), from his focus on Italian labor movements, added the idea of social movement protest cycles, noting that protest goes through rising and falling phases as the internal and external conditions of a movement change over time.

Yet in the last two decades of the twentieth century, it became clear that these formulations were not adequate to explain ongoing social protest events. First, it

became obvious that protests were not only undertaken by disadvantaged or excluded groups. Movements of the well-to-do and sophisticated, who simply felt that their particular policy goals were being neglected by governments, arose in the leading democracies. These included the antinuclear, environmental, and animal rights movements in Europe, Japan, and the USA, and most importantly, the Tea Party movement in the USA.

Second, as demonstrated by Jack A. Goldstone (2004) and others (Goldstone 2003), social movement activity in democracies was not limited to organizing protests in support of excluded groups; rather all kinds of movements employed both public protests and other kinds of activities to change policy, including lawsuits, political campaigns, participation in hearings and expert panels, lobbying officials, and even launching political parties (such as the Green Parties in Europe) or seeking to take over existing parties in order to elect political leaders to enact their programs. Protest activity was often just one element of a multifaceted portfolio of actions that social movements would employ to pursue their goals.

Third, from the late 1980s up through 2015, there have arisen multiple examples of vast and sustained social protests in authoritarian societies. Such societies seemed to offer far less scope for protestors to organize, acquire resources, and take advantage of political opportunities. In some cases, formal organizations were at the core of such protest activity: in Poland, the Solidarity labor movement and the Catholic Church played crucial roles, as did the Lutheran Church in East Germany and the Muslim Brotherhood or professional organizations of Lawyers and Teachers in several of the Arab nations. Yet in many cases huge crowds seemed to assemble almost spontaneously, in a manifestation of outrage to conditions such as state corruption, inequality, or fraudulent elections spurred by the sharing of ideas and views on social media.

Whether in authoritarian regimes (such as the Russian Federation under Vladimir Putin or Egypt under Hosni Mubarak), hybrid regimes (such as Turkey under Recep Tayyip Erdoğan prior to 2018 or Ukraine under Viktor Yanukovych), or democracies (as in Spain and Greece and other democracies in the wake of the Great Recession and austerity policies), such large protests, not produced by any previously formally organized movement organization and making effective use of social media, seem to be a globally widespread phenomenon.

In this volume, Nina Belyaeva with her two coeditors Victor Albert and Dmitry Zaytsev and contributors from different countries explore these events, developing theoretical and comparative approaches that help us understand how they are generated and how they unfold. Using the framework of "protest publics"—a term that beautifully identifies events when a large section of the public has mobilized itself for protests—they have created an important new conceptual scheme. This volume shows how powerful this scheme is in explaining the global wave of distinctive protest events.

"Protest publics" are clearly important in today's world. But they have given rise to a vast range of different outcomes. Here the earlier concepts of "political opportunities," and the blending of protest with other tactics, again become relevant.

In some cases, the actions of protest publics achieve quick success. A government that is not united, or not secure in its position, may simply back away from the policies that have caused outrage once a large protest public has assembled. For example, in the case of the Gezi Park protests in Turkey (discussed in chapter "'Shoulder to Shoulder Against Fascism': Publics in the Gezi Protests"), the Erdogan regime backed away from its plans to bulldoze the park and replace it with new structures. Similarly in Iceland (examined in chapters "So Strong, Yet So Weak: The Emergence of Protest Publics in Iceland in the Wake of the Financial Crisis" and "Protesters as the 'Challengers of the Status Quo' in Embedded Democracies: The Cases of Iceland, the United Kingdom, and the United States"), protests against the follies of the major banks led the government to undertake special investigations and an exceptional restructuring of government and the financial sector unlike any other country in Europe. In other cases, protest publics achieve massive mobilization but then fade out and end without any effect. I witnessed this myself in both New York City (the Occupy Wall Street Movement) and Hong Kong (the Umbrella Movements, so named for the umbrellas protestors used to shield themselves from tear gas). In New York City, Occupy Wall Street stunned people with the scale of its spontaneous demonstrations and encampments and the power of its slogan "we are the 99%." Yet neither the US government nor the major financial sectors felt any deep pressure to change, and the protests faded out without impact. In Hong Kong, even larger protests arose. Initial student protests demanding more democracy for Hong Kong were met with a harsh and violent police response. In outrage at this action, hundreds of thousands of Hong Kongers suddenly filled every major thoroughfare, closing down the major arteries of the commercial center. Over the next few months, demonstrations persisted but the number of protestors declined, until the protests finally ended when police cleared the remnants from the city center. The mainland government, however, whose antidemocratic policies were the target of the massive protests, remained untouched and unmoved. Even vast and sustained protests thus had no success against opponents who remained secure and gave no "political opportunity" for protests to wreak change.

Two other trajectories for protest publics also appeared. In many authoritarian countries, the protest publics found common cause with civil society and professional organizations that had opposed the existing regime. Outrage over particular events, conditions, or policies then developed into sustained campaigns to overturn the existing government, uniting multiple networks across society. In the communist countries of Eastern Europe in 1989–1991 and in the Arab countries in 2010–2011 (discussed here in chapter "Protest Publics as the 'Triggers' of Political Changes in Hybrid Regimes: The Cases of Tunisia, Morocco, and Egypt"), protest publics acted as triggers for successful revolutions. In many democratic countries, a similar extension and formalization of protest arose, but in these cases through the protest public melding with or giving rise to political parties which then successfully supported new candidates for high office. In Italy, protest publics triggered the rise of the Five-Star party in Italy (examined in chapter "Five Stars of Change: The Transformation of Italian Protest Publics Through Grillo's Blog"). Similarly, processes arose elsewhere in southern Europe (explored in chapters "The Grammar of

Protest Publics in Skopje, Macedonia, May 2015," "Retracing Protest Publics in Portugal: A Generation in Trouble," and "The Transforming Role of Protest Publics in Processes of Sociopolitical Change in the Global South and Southern Europe: From Occasional Challengers to Institutionalized Watchdogs. Conclusion: The Common Features and Different Roles of Protest Publics in Political Contestation"). In the USA, protest publics have arisen in response to many actions of Donald Trump as President, particularly his treatment of women and immigrants; they hope to trigger a sweeping Democratic Party victory in the 2018 midterm elections.

Protest publics have therefore become a key event structure in the political dynamics of modern nations. Even in India and Bangladesh (examined in chapter "Emergent Protest Publics in India and Bangladesh: A Comparative Study of Anti-corruption and Shahbag Protests") and in Indonesia and Malaysia, protest publics responding to corruption are challenging or changing governments. Elsewhere, protest publics have produced revolutions, political realignments, and policy shifts.

This volume provides vital new insights into these critical events. I congratulate Belyaeva and her colleagues and contributors on their research advances, which will benefit all scholars of social movements and social protests.

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Self-Organized Publics in Mass Protests: An Introduction



Nina Belyaeva and Victor Albert

In his oft-cited work, *Publics and Counterpublics*, Michael Warner reflects on the tense relationship between public and private life. Modernity has given rise, he holds, to disconnections between our private and public selves, generating 'a romantic longing for unity' (Warner 2002, p. 25). The manifestation of unity may emerge in expressions of personal taste and emotion or gender and sexuality (a key focus of Warner's). But it can also be more explicitly political in nature, as individual reflections on and reactions to political events generate collective, solidaristic responses (Jasper 1998). In this way, public manifestations of privately held beliefs seek to bring the public sphere into line, if only temporarily and provisionally, with the private. Such manifestations can be more or less routinized or transgressive, individual or collective, depending on the local contexts and causes of private discontent and their public forms.

The public expression of political discontent has been a marked feature of the latest crisis of global capitalism, initially triggered by the US subprime mortgage bubble in 2008. This discontent has been highly variable. The Occupy movement emerged first in Zuccotti Park in New York before spreading, both as a practice and a discourse, to cities across the globe; the self-immolation of Mohamed Bouazizi, a street vendor in Sidi Bouzid, Tunisia, after continued mistreatment by the authorities, gave way to the Arab Spring, a rippling of political unrest that fomented protest campaigns and revolutions in North Africa; protests have also broken out in Spain, Greece, and Portugal in response to neoliberal, austerity policies, which have consigned many young Southern Europeans to precarity. Unrest has also taken place in Russia, Hong Kong, Brazil, and Turkey, in reaction to authoritarianism, corruption, and misrule. The immediate effect of these protests has been unsurprisingly different from place to place; in some cases, it has resulted in directly

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N. Belyaeva et al. (eds.), *Protest Publics*, Societies and Political Orders in Transition,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5_1

observable political changes, such as in Tunisia, while in others, such as the Occupy movement, it has helped to shape public discourse through foregrounding the structural inequalities of capitalism.

Though highly variable in its local aims and content, there are some similarities in the means of mobilisation and social organisation that can be noted among these protests. New media has been key. Activists have shown how digital media can be used to summon scores of otherwise disconnected members of the public into places of strategic and symbolic importance at a moment's notice and at least in part fulfilling the democratic promise of the early technological utopians. Moreover, these protests have often occurred without the 'dense networks of relations to support massive recruitment' that we are led to expect from mainline social movement approaches (Della Porta 2017).

This has led some to describe these protests as 'spontaneous', a characterisation that has been contested in the case of Spain's Indignados (Flesher Fominaya 2015). Regardless, spontaneity is only a function of sociological abstraction. Apart from the most immediate motor responses—such as blinking or protecting oneself from an expected blow—human behaviour is culturally shaped. What is considered unjust, and indeed insupportable, is one of the key provocations of public protest, leading us to examine public and individual morality as triggers of protest (Jasper 2011, 2012). Moreover, spontaneity is an analytical dead end, providing no paths for revealing how merely seemingly spontaneous events are prefigured in public and political discourse, culture and associations (e.g. Yates 2015). Yet, if mainline social movement theory was ill-prepared to account for these new protest campaigns, then what theories might be adapted and employed to this new brand of political activism that is less wedded to organisational structures than protest movements of the past?

In this book we propose 'publics' as a useful frame for examining these new waves of public protest. Emerging originally in the work of John Dewey, who saw the vigilant public as a key ingredient of a healthy democracy (Dewey 1927), the notion of the public has attracted intermittent interest over the twentieth century—some of which was in dialogue with Dewey—but has become popular of late, in communication studies (Asen 2000; Asen and Brouwer 2001; Porrovecchio 2007), geography (Staeheli et al. 2009), anthropology (Cody 2011; Fassin 2013; Phillips and Cole 2013), and political theory and science (Ferguson 2010; Fraser 1990). Here we advance the term 'protest publics' to denote a new form of contention that has arisen in recent years, enabled by mass communication technology, and highly variable in its local manifestations. But rather than attempting to create a strong theoretical programme, we instead consider this volume as a space for exploring the common dimensions of these publics in their different forms and their effects in different parts of the world.

While in part a result of a search for a new theoretical lens for the unrest that has spread across the globe in recent years, it is also the product of our own experience of protest publics. It began as a reflection on the Bolotnaya Square protests, which took place in central Moscow in 2012, not far from our department windows in the Higher School of Economics. This was not a movement we were typically told to expect, as resulting from organised groups that drew on histories of activism. People—and

many of us—spilled out onto the street. This volume is part of the exploration of the phenomena which we observed and in which we participated. As part of this exploration we engaged with partners, presented our findings at conferences, and also invited contributions from foreign authors. The first half of the book explores the dimensions of protest publics, how they emerge in different times and places, their characteristics, and cultural and political influence. For this half we invited contributions from foreign colleagues and collaborators, in addition to foregrounding the collection with a theoretical essay.

Publics have been approached in quite different ways, from a necessary ingredient of liberal democracy to a constituent body produced by a text and its circulation. The first chapter, written by Nina Belyaeva, outlines the theoretical lineage that informed the production of this volume. Ekim Arbatli then takes us to Gezi Park, in a chapter which documents how a protest at an urban construction in Taksim Square snowballed quickly as a reaction against police repression. It demonstrates the dynamic and flexible nature of protest publics, which achieved the immediate goal of forestalling construction in the Park, but lacked longer-term policy outcomes. Giuseppe Mastruzzo analyses the evolution of the Five Star Movement and the problematic relationship between a new political party and the movement's online roots. His chapter underscores the importance of combining virtual and physical spaces which can re-energise the institutions of representative democracy. Cristina Sarmento, Patrícia Oliveira, and Patrícia Tomás next write about Portugal's generation in trouble. Like Mastruzzo's chapter, their contribution examines the relationship between the protests of disenfranchised youth which helped to constitute the protest publics and the emergence of a political coalition, the 'geringonça'. Arnab Chowdhury and Ahmed Abid present a comparison of protest publics from India and Bangladesh. They show how these protests, while not organised by established social groups, nonetheless were partially successful in achieving socio-political transformations and achieved policy change. Rastko Antic examines the protest public that emerged in Skopje, Macedonia. Antic shows, among other things, how the horizontalism of the protest public has helped produce internal democracy in a new party called Levica. Victor Albert's chapter, meanwhile, examines the Homeless Workers' Movement in Brazil. Engaging with pragmatic sociology, his chapter examines how individuals and the collective develop public-facing strategies.

In addition to these qualitative case and comparative studies, we also wanted to map out—so far as is possible—the political effects of protest publics. While such an endeavour invariably risks the reification of what may be a relatively ephemeral social (and at times chiefly discursive) phenomena, we believe it to be analytically fruitful. In the second half of the book, we thus compare the different roles protest publics play and different effects and influences of protest publics in different political regimes. Dmitry Zaytsev, Anastasiya Galina, and Anna Sokol provide an overview of existing theories of how collective actors effect social change and propose a research design to evaluate protest publics' contribution to politics, policy dynamics, and democratisation. Nikita Shmaltsev and Dmitry Zaytsev analysing the cases of the USA, the UK, and Iceland argue that in embedded democracies protest publics played the role of challengers to the status quo which

promote a new agenda for improving the quality of democracy and effecting social change. Sambhavna Biswas and Sanjay Kumar Rajhans examine protest publics as watchdogs which struggle to improve the quality of democracy in the polyarchies of the Global South (Brazil, India, and South Africa). Łukasz Jakubiak, Artem Uldanov, and Hamid ait El Caid analyse the extent to which protest publics influence political change in the hybrid regimes of Morocco, Egypt, and Tunisia. Artem Uldanov, Fedor Alekseenkov, and Tatyana Davtyan explore how protest publics effect social change in authoritarian countries such as Russia, Turkey, and China and establish alternative democratic practices. Finally, Sanjay Kumar Rajhans contributes to our understanding of protest publics in the consolidated democracies of the Global South by comparing them with cases from Southern Europe: Italy, Spain, and Greece.

This volume does not attempt to develop an all-explanatory theory of protests in the new millennium, but rather seeks to explore the new phenomena of self-organised publics that come together for joint protest and possess shared features that are quite different from conventional social movements. By moving away from the mainline literature and conceptualisations, the scope for debate on contemporary protests has been broadened, and the conceptual frame of 'publics as social actors' is tested. As the forms of public participation are constantly evolving and public discontent shows its ability to reshape social norms and political regimes, it is worth opening new spaces for discussion and agenda-setting to reflect on what is different and problematic in the emerging waves of protest in late capitalism.

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Part I
Dimensions of Protest Publics in the Recent Wave of Unrest

Exploring Protest Publics: A New Conceptual Frame for Civil Participation Analysis



Nina Belyaeva

1 New Mass Protests as a Challenge to Social Theory

The need for new analytical instruments often comes all of a sudden, when some unexpected social events take place and analysts are called on to explore them. While it is natural to use existing theories and frameworks, it may be noticed that those old instruments do not fully explain the nature of the social events they try to understand and interpret. This is indeed what happened with the mass public protests in Russia in 2011–2012 that we take as example for this analysis.

Beginning with the first real mass meeting on December 10, 2011, in Moscow, there were many attempts made to define "who all these people were." Several sociological surveys on protesters had presented a tremendous diversity of participants in terms of their age, social backgrounds, education level, current occupation, and level of income while also disclosing a wide variety of reasons that had brought them to the protest action (WCIOM 2011; Volkov 2012). In a search of some common name, protesters were first called "angry citizens" (The Moscow News 2012), even though it was not clear what exactly they were angry with. As the protest was shifting its focus and as the polls had reported a significant number of wealthy people involved, growing protest events were called a "middle-class uprising" (The Economist 2011) or even a "fur-coat revolution." However, this was not adequate either, as there were many people with quite low income among protesters. Finally, recognizing the high level of education among protesters, all the participants were referred to as the "creative class" (The Moscow News 2012), but this also happened to be only part of the truth. So, the proper definition of "who were all those people," participating in mass protest during winter 2010–2011, remains to be found.

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N. Belyaeva et al. (eds.), *Protest Publics*, Societies and Political Orders in Transition,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5_2

Since Moscow events were part of the global wave of protests, which had received considerable attention from global research community, there is a vast literature describing the protests in every part of the world, while the comparative analysis of those protests was conceptualized either through the theory of civil society (Boulding 2014) or through the social movement theory (Della Porta and Mattoni 2014), thus presenting two conventional theoretical models that are usually applied to the analysis of these protest events: civil society and social movement theory. Recognizing strong explanatory power of both theories, the claim of this chapter is that neither of them can fully grasp the nature of these mass protests.

Civil society initially seemed to be the most natural conception to be applied, because there were several visual similarities between the Moscow events and the peaceful democratic "velvet revolutions" in Eastern Europe in the end of the 1980s, when former "Soviet Bloc" countries were liberating themselves from communist regimes through consolidated and coordinated protest actions, led by broad political and civil coalitions. During those events citizens expressed their deep mistrust in political elites, pushing governing regimes either to peaceful transformation through a dialogue with protesters, like in Poland, or led to its total collapse, like in Romania. In most of those cases, democratic transformation was attributed to the "victory of civil society" over corrupt communist regimes (Cohen and Arato 1992). Also, several prominent scholars were writing about protests in Russia using the concept of civil society (Robertson 2009; Yanitsky 2012; Volkov 2013; Vorozheykina 2014).

However, the attempt to apply this concept to specific events of Bolotnaya protests of 2011–2012 was not adequate on both theoretical grounds and for practical reasons. The theoretical concept of "civil society" presupposes intense and long-lasting organizational work within communities prior to common action, as the "civil society" itself is commonly understood as the "space between family, market and the state" (Salamon et al. 2004, pp. 3–10). Other definitions are filled with a plethora of multiple types of voluntary associations, which in the practical sense of most research projects is reduced to "organized society" or studying of NGOs—whether formal or informal—but all having some clear organizational structure and regularly working with their members and constituencies (Salamon et al. 1999; Anheier 2002; Heinrich 2004; Aleskerov and Belyaeva 2008; Belyaeva and Proskuryakova 2008).

In the Moscow protests of 2011–2012, it was clearly not the case—neither in terms of "prior organization" of protest events nor in terms of mass NGO members participating.

Social movement theory seemed to be more applicable as it sees civil participation in a more dynamic way and defines social movement as "an organized public effort, making a collective claim on the target audience" (Tilly and Tarrow 2009; Clement 2012). Social movements often employ many different forms of political action, from petitions to mass rallies and demonstrations, but they always do so after a lot of prior organizational work, including the creation of stable organizational structures or "special purpose coalitions," that can insure "a sustained and organized" manner of collective actions. Participants of social movements are usually clear about their own common identity, as one of the major claims that they make to the other political actors and to the broader public is "who we are" or "a name for

'us'"—"Cherokees" and "diamond cutters." These are called "standing claims" distinguishing members from nonmembers, as well as "program claims" that are being addressed to their target audience (Tilly 2004).

This approach appears to be more applicable, because at a certain period, namely, from December 2011 to February 2012, Bolotnaya protests had the potential to develop into a real "Movement For Fair Elections," but by 2012 the identity of participants was not clearer than "anti-government" and "anti-Putin," nor did their "program claim" stand firm on "election procedures" but shifted to a political mobilization with a general protest against the political regime. Social movement theory also has a limited application to the protests in Russia in 2011–2012, because it does not explain the very emergence of those protests, as there were no prior "claimants" with any clearly set "program claims" and even participants themselves, when questioned about the reasons for their participation, had very different explanations, which makes it hard to speak about their common identity.

It is important to mention here that in her most recent work, Donatella Della Porta, who very closely monitors new developments of global protest movements, makes an important statement that "classical" social movement studies cannot explain certain new features of new mass protests, in particular: how can they emerge without opening new political opportunities that allow to form new alliances and in the absence of mobilizing structures of dense political networks that were believed necessary for mass movement participant recruitment (Della Porta 2017).

Using this statement, we want to argue that to be able to catch the very essence of Bolotnaya and similar protest events, new theoretical concepts are needed, which we suggest can be found in the emergent "theory of publics," where the public is considered to be not a "target audience" but a social actor (Belyaeva 2012) and where it is distinct both from "civil society structures" and from communities (Belyaeva and Dzhibladze 2014). As there are recognized different types of publics, for the goals of our chapter, we will focus just on one particular type—"active public" or *agent public* (Mahony and Clarke 2013, p. 948) that is capable of performing as a collective social actor, involved in meaningful protest behavior—without prior long organizational work, either by civil society actors or social movement organizers.

We believe that this is an important novelty that protest publics bring to the scope of participatory practices: an almost total absence of prior organization, believed to be necessary. This makes them a valuable object of study and requires a new conceptual framework, which we will try to develop.

2 Understanding "The Public": From Dewey to Warner and Beyond

Studies of the public as a social collectivity that in certain circumstances becomes a collective social actor are not completely new; they have a substantial history, which still needs to be reconstructed, distinguishing between mutually supportive and

exclusively controversial visions and definitions of *the public* and its role in social relations. Being a relatively new field of study, it is already highly interdisciplinary, resting on contributions from different fields of social sciences, including philosophy, political science, communication theory, and psychology, and complemented by an important body of practical knowledge from journalism, marketing, and public relations.

The major division between these approaches is the level of "social actorness" of the public. It raises the major question: to what extent *the public* is viewed as an "object of influence" and the "target audience" or it is seen as capable of realizing its own potential as a social actor, playing an important role in social development?

As we are interested in the latter vision, we begin with one of the first important works on this subject in modern political science, *The Public and Its Problems* by John Dewey, published in 1927. This work appeared as a polemic response to Lippman (Lippmann 1993), which was primarily addressed to journalists and organizers of public opinion polls. Lippmann was arguing that journalists gave too much weight and attention to opinion polls, as the level of complexity of governance has increased so much that the "ordinary citizen" or "member of the public," who has been asked on almost every issue to "share his opinion," could not have an opinion on every single matter of governance, but could only "react emotionally," while the duty of formulating ideas and solutions had to be retained by experts and politicians (Lippmann 1993).

Dewey responded with quite an alternative vision of an active public, consisting of groups of citizens that assemble spontaneously in response to a problem that emerges as a consequence of a particular action, often a government action that people are not satisfied with or want to question (Dewey 1991). Thus, if Dewey's approach can be simplified, publics consist of people who are concerned with the same problem and want to do something about it. Therefore, because there is an endless chain of possible actions that can cause problems or worries, those spontaneous publics constantly emerge, overlap, and, eventually, disintegrate, but make a decisive demand on public officials.

With this vision, Dewey was the first to point out several fundamental features of the public: its fluidity and its ability to quickly assemble in response to a challenge and to disseminate when the common risk or common need is over.

Another important feature he was able to capture is the cognitive ability of the public to be more than just consumers of information but to be able to add and produce knowledge through communication with each other and politicians as experts.

As a political philosopher concerned with the development of democracy, Dewey contributed to the debate on the role of the public in relation to the state and its structures, suggesting a vision of transformative power of the public that can "break existing political forms" and seeks to establish new forms of political institutions, "which suit its associational behavior," making the state respond to the public's demands. This vision of Dewey, formulated almost a century ago, found new life along with Habermas and Foucault and contemporary debate on public and counter public (Peshkopia 2008, pp. 26–27, 29–33).

The other important step in understanding the public and its capacities are contributions from James Grunig and Gabriel Vasquez, who observe the public from communication science and public relations theory, but are interested in the public not in terms of market share or target audience for marketing, but in exploring its cognitive and self-organizational capabilities, which makes a strong contribution to its further "actorness."

Grunig conducted field studies of environmental publics in rural and urban areas, focusing on the emergence of those publics, based on their situational perception and communicative behavior. He distinguished their cognitive strategies in dealing with those issues and several levels of their self-organization—from "nonpublics" to "aware publics" and to "active publics"—depending on their ability to recognize a common problem and be able to self-organize to deal with it. Grunig was also trying to see the connection between cognitive strategies and demographic characteristics, but the conclusion he makes is that "publics, characterized by behavior similarities, cannot be defined by demographic indicators" (Grunig 1983).

Vasquez, developing some of the ideas and findings of Grunig, further focused on the public cognition process and the ability of certain public groups to develop their own language, describing their common problem, their own narratives, that allow them to recognize each other and to distinguish themselves from other groups. This ability of publics to develop a "group consciousness around the problematic situation" allowed Vasquez to call them "Homo Narrans," a term that he suggested to be used for the development of theory of public relations (Vasquez 1993).

After the importance of "common thinking" and "group consciousness" was developed, the next important step in recognizing the role of publics in policy process was started by Frank Fisher and his colleagues, who published a volume called *The Argumentative Turn in Policy Analysis and Planning*. They proved through numerous examples what was intuitively felt much earlier; the political process of developing and formulating policy agendas and adopting political decisions is done through language and the ability of those governing and those who are governed to formulate, to argument, and to communicate their message—a message that has to be properly understood. In short, democratic policymaking "is all done through language and argumentation on one hand and the ability and willingness to understand and accept the message—including mechanisms of through group consciousness to support or object to governing message—on the other" (Fischer and Forester 1993).

This importance of public language and cognitive group consciousness and discourses built around certain problematic issues was underlined in the development of "discourse coalitions," suggested in the same volume by Maarten Hajer, that brilliantly presented the dynamic of social change within democratic society, based on "competition of discourses" and a possibility of a strategic victory in political competition on both agenda setting and decision implementation in policymaking. When a discursive battle is won, it changes the very way people *think* about social problems, because it shapes the way people act on them (Hajer 1993).

Most recently, Michael Warner approached the topic from a different academic tradition and developed a comprehensive conceptualization of contemporary publics

as a new social phenomenon: a collective social actor that is capable of action on its own. In answer to the underlying question of "what is a public," Warner claims it to be an "obscure question, considering that few things have been more important in the development of the modernity" and "an essential fact of social landscape"; it is still a puzzle to say what exactly they are (Warner 2002, p. 49). Warner then follows that because the "idea of *a public*," as distinct from *the public*, as any bounded audience understands, is so common to modern culture that everyone seems to understand it intuitively, so he claims his task and his role is "to bring some of our intuitive understanding into the open in order to speculate about the history of the form and the role it plays in constructing our social world" (Warner 2002, p. 50).

What emerged as a result is a theoretical descriptive model, applicable to the analysis of all types of publics at every major phase of their existence and the role they play in transforming social reality and, in certain circumstances, in political sphere. Among many reviewers and followers of Warner's work, the one definition that was given to his contribution to the field was produced by Jessica Blaustein, calling her substantial review of Warner's book *How Publics Matter: A Handbook for Alternative World-Making* (Blaustein 2004, p. 171).

While Warner is approaching public from a broader angle of cultural studies, he is observing very different types of publics and gives them multiple characteristics (Warner 2002). For our purpose, we will select and further develop those characteristics that help to define most important features of publics which voluntarily assemble for collective protest activity and which we conceptualize as protest publics.

The first important feature that Warner is attributing to *a public* is that it is self-organized and that public comes into being by the virtue of being addressed, as publics, according to Warner, are "a spaces of discourse, made by discourse itself," when "books are published, shows broadcast, speeches delivered, opinions produced" (Warner 2002, p. 50).

Warner claims that publics assemble in response to the text addressed to them, including the texts in visual or audio forms, as far as they can be understood and reflected upon and that in this sense, the phenomena of public are completely modern, as "neither *crowd* nor *audience* nor *people* nor *group* will capture the same sense" (Warner 2002, p. 51).

But to be "called upon" or be "addressed" is not enough, as a public, appearing in practice as the public, "must have the way of organizing itself as a body" and "must be organized by something other than the state" (Warner 2002, p. 51).

We consider this to be an absolutely crucial characteristic of protest publics—to have a capacity to organize itself outside of state structures and beyond any influence from both state and other "pre-organized structures," as political parties, trade unions, corporate organizations, or churches, to name the most obvious, if we expect them to act on their own and explore their actorness.

The second feature of publics that we argue is also related to our goal is their functioning as "relations among strangers," as publics, for Warner, have to be "more than someone's list of friends" and have to include strangers that come out to react to the same publicly broadcasted text or message (Warner 2002, p. 55).

We also consider this very important and directly applicable to protest publics, because this approach provides a new vision of social collectivity: those are the individuals themselves, who decide if they "belong to this public," as they may find themselves "interested," "concerned," or "related to the issue," regardless of what was the initial goal of the public message transmitted. Thus, publication of official election results in a municipality and comments on those numbers may have quite limited public interest, but might also call on quite a large number of "strangers" to discover that they have a stake in it and to find their own way to react to this message.

The third selected feature, attributed by Warner to phenomena of public, calling it "the social space created by the reflexive circulation of discourse" (Warner 2002, p. 62) we find particularly relevant to our study of protest publics at different stages: at the stage of their assembling and self-organizing, during the active phase of street protests and other public actions, and at the stage when an active phase is over. This common social space allows the public to continue reflexive activities on their common experience, and by this sustaining itself as "a joint body," providing this public sense of unity and belonging.

The last two selected features, which Warner uses to describe publics, in our view, have the most important explanatory contribution to the field. In Warner's counting it is statement six, making a claim that "publics act historically, according to the temporality of their circulation" (Warner 2002, p. 68) and statement seven, which attributes to publics a unique function of creating a poetic view of the alternative world they create through their discourse, claiming that having been able to be a public "is a poetic world-making" (Warner 2002, p. 82).

Taken together, those two points may explain *the public mystique*, as attempting to explain, how is it ever possible, that publics—being so loosely organized—are still able to both sustain themselves as one collective body and to produce a new world vision, which can mobilize its members for social change. For this reason, we will disclose them in more detail.

Explaining "temporality," Warner is calling it "punctual rhythm of circulation," which he sees as "crucial to the sense that ongoing discussion unfolds in the sphere of activity" (Warner 2002, p. 68). Applying this to protest publics, we immediately recognize how important is it to constantly keep people connected, but what Warner adds to this is that connectedness has to be both by discourse exchange and by activities, which mutually support each other.

In order to bring any social results, common discourses, created by counter-publics, particularly those of protest publics that often experience aggressive pressure through the dominant discourse which they try to oppose, must continue to circulate through time, and the more intense, the better, so that they would make more and more members of the broader public hear, read, speak, write, and talk in this same discourse. The more this happens, says Warner, the closer this public stands to politics.

As for the poetic function, the importance of this feature is also hard to overestimate, as Warner brings into the open what many social and political activists have already known and used for a long time: to make your action successful, make it attractive, creative, and theatrical. Modern publics have a hard time to respond to mere "calls for support" or "fighting against" if it is not packaged in unusual,

amusing, or humorous ways and presented in an interactive environment, allowing for participants to express their own creativity. The best example of it in Russia is the case of regularly held "monstrations"—mass street marches, mostly by young people, on regular state holidays, with funny slogans that seem absurd, but have hidden protest meanings (Novaya Gazeta 2018).

For Warner, this is merely the initiating text, to which the public can respond to and start generating and circulating further discourse, and this is true for protest publics as well, because any action of government that the public decides to react to may be considered "a certain message," like the decision of the former president of Ukraine, Yanukovych, not to sign the Association Agreement with the EU, which had caused the start of protests in Kiev, or announcing the estimated costs of organizing the World Championship in Brazil, which caused mass protests against government spending on games instead of schooling and health. But for the sake of a common language with the research community on protests and social movements that refer to the causes of initial protest reaction as "events," rather than "text" and calling them "triggers," and in the attempt of creating a common discourse both with "text-oriented" and "event-oriented" researchers, we suggest to find a common term that would satisfy a reference to both "text" and "event" and call it a "troubling message," because it refers both to the event that caused public attention and a text connected to it that was then heard and interpreted as troublesome by the public, which have chosen to protest.

Let us now summarize the most important features we had selected from Warner's characteristics of a public, which we believe are essential for the analysis of protest public:

- Such public have to be self-organized, which should be done outside of the state or other pre-existing organizational structures.
- Reaction to "troubling message" is realized through "relations among strangers," where participants individually decide to react to this message.
- Creating "social spaces" for common discourse production and circulation provides connectivity.
- Acting "historically" is dependent on temporality of discourse circulation intensity.
- Public is able to create a "poetic view" of the alternative world.

As it is evident from our brief overview, Warner's text is thought provoking and invites debate, so it is not surprising that his work was widely recognized and many further interpretations and developments followed (Wittenberg 2002; Blaustein 2004; Peshkopia 2008). In this chapter we want to refer to a particular one, by Mahony and Clarke, who are focusing their recent research on the particular ways in which publics are "called into existence" or "summoned." Analyzing different public speeches of politicians, addressing publics in the UK in the context of various interpretations of the economic crisis, they analyzed the different ways in which publics were being addressed and different positions those publics were invited to occupy, which led them to the conclusion that those mediating practices of summoning the publics are not themselves neutral; on the contrary, they are consequential for the sort of public that has been summoned and the role it is invited to perform. On this basis, they suggested

a rough typology of publics, depending on the role prescribed to them: abject publics, which are affected and immobilized and need to be "spoken for and on behalf of" (Mahony and Clarke 2013, pp. 933–954); audience publics, which are summoned as choice-bearers, but the choice is limited and predecided, like the one between "schools or roads," where the public is viewed as very minimally autonomous (Mahony and Clarke 2013, p. 947); and "agentic public," the most independent type of public that is imagined and addressed as reflexive and creative, which "is supposed to find an identity, form a view" (Mahony and Clarke 2013, p. 948), and create its own structure, capable of organizing collective action.

This division suggesting three types of publics, depending on "the levels of freedom" they are given by those who summon them, suggested by Mahony and Clarke, which also, we argue, depends on particular publics' own capacities to exercise this freedom, is particularly relevant to this paper. This is because those suggestions are close to our own previous writings on actors and actorness, where we distinguish a similar triad of levels of actor's independence capacities: minimal level, when activities are guided by outside forces performed in the interests of others (similar to abject); when actorness is marginal, due to limited resources (audiences limited choice); and full-fledged actorness, including cognitive ability, free will to unlimited choices, and adequate resources to implement chosen strategies (Belyaeva 2007, 2011a, b).

In concluding this theoretical part, using the summary of selected most important features of "publics," and combining it with the role that independent "agentic publics" play in mass and lasting social and political protests, we want to suggest a working definition, which can be the starting point for further research.

We define protest publics as spontaneously self-organized peaceful assemblies, emerging in response to the publicly transmitted "troubling message" for a joint protest action, united by unique common discourse, collectively demanding deep social change, expressed in a poetic form, addressing both to wider society and the public authorities in charge.

The definition can help avoid misperceptions when starting analysis, because often it is hard to judge a protest action or some public event that looks like a protest, we do not yet know, if it is, in fact, a protest action of a certain self-organized public or something else, like a historic reconstruction of prior dramatic public events, or artistic performance or administratively managed gathering, where participants were forced to participate. So, to be sure we are dealing with a protest public—of whatever type and level of actorness—we would need to go through several analytical steps that together create a new conceptual framework of protest event analysis.

1. Reconstruct the "troubling message" that was the initial reason of this particular public assembling, paying attention to distinguish between the text and the event that had triggered public response and its interpretation by protest public itself.
2. Explore the process of this public self-organization and if it was in fact happening outside government structures and influence, as well as any other form of pre-existing organizational form or authority.

3. Identify the public spaces, where the unique discourse of this public is being produced, shared, enriched, and exchanged, paying attention to diversity of its forms, styles, genres, and circulation mechanisms.
4. Assess the intensiveness and regularity of discourse exchange and circulation, paying attention to temporality and "winning the headlines" of regular and social media.
5. Evaluate the creativity and attractiveness of the poetic message of the alternative world this public is creating and representing.

We believe that this conceptual frame makes it possible when applied to particular protest events, to address some practical questions: Why certain publics, including those assembled for joint protests, sustained and grew while others did not? What are the factors that enable those publics to be effective social actors? What enables them to have transformative power—both on the broader social environment and on themselves? Whether those protest publics can sustain and reproduce themselves, without creating traditional organizational structures used for political contestation—like political parties or clearly structured social movements? Can those publics, while keeping their nature of being connected "by mere discourse," be successfully reproduced?

3 Protest Public of "Bolotnaya Events": One or Many?

Let us briefly reconstruct the sequence of events that had later got the name of the "Bolotnaya Movement." Mass political meetings of the citizens of Russia had begun after the elections to the State Duma of the VI convocation, held on December 4, 2011 (TASS 2011); protest actions continued to grow during and after the Russian presidential election campaign from March 4, 2012 (RIA Novosti 2013a), which was monitored by an unprecedented number of election observers, who had presented a lot of evidence that both elections were accompanied by serious violations of law and massive fraud (Vedomosti 2012).

The main slogan of the first phase of protest actions was "For free and fair elections!". The major symbol of protest was the white ribbon (BBC News Russia 2011a). The central theme of all the protests was their anti-Putin character.

Mass actions of protests in Moscow and St. Petersburg began on the evening of December 4, right after the preliminary results of elections were announced. The first mass meeting took place in Moscow on December 5, 2011, organized by the "Solidarity" movement at the Chistoprudniy Boulevard with the following slogans: "Elections are a farce!", "Give back the choice to the country!", and "Give the power back to people!". Information about the meeting was disseminated through LiveJournal, Twitter, and Facebook, and the action brought into streets from 2000 to 10,000 participants. Speeches were made by well-known leaders of political opposition (Gazeta.ru 2011).

According to *The Economist* journalists, it was the largest public assembly in Moscow since the 1990s (The Economist 2011), after which there were massive

clashes between protesters and police at Lubyanka Square. As a result, more than 300 people were arrested (RIA Novosti 2013b).

On December 10, 2011, protests were held in 99 cities in Russia and 42 cities abroad (Lenta.ru 2011). The Moscow opposition rally at Bolotnaya Square became the largest in the last decade (according to other data—the largest since the beginning of the 1990s). Moscow authorities stated that the rally gathered around 25,000 people, but according to independent observers and foreign journalists, Bolotnaya brought together between 85,000 and 100,000 participants (Forbes Russia 2011). Among the demands of the protesters were new elections, as well as the release of political prisoners and the resignation of the head of the Central Electoral Commission of Russia, Vladimir Churov (BBC News Russia 2011b).

Two weeks later, on December 24, even larger-scale protest rallies took place in Moscow, at prospect Akademika Sakharova, that were prepared by the "protests' organizing committee," formed after the Bolotnaya meeting. At a meeting at Sakharova, Moscow, about 100,000 participants were observed (RBC.ru 2011). Many protest meetings were held the same day in other Russian cities.

In February 2012, there was a new series of mass actions "for fair elections." Rallies and marches were held in more than 100 cities in Russia and abroad (Pravda 2012). On February 4, one of the largest rallies was held against rigged election results called "For fair elections!"—it was a rally through Yakimanka Street with a meeting at Bolotnaya Square in Moscow. According to different estimates, this meeting collected up to 120,000 participants (RIA Novosti 2012a).

An important role in organizing the protest marches was played by social networks, where members of the organizing committee discussed the dates of actions, slogans, and speakers of the meetings. The date February 4 was chosen not by chance—it was timed for the 22nd anniversary of the "March of the Democratic Forces" in 1990, initiating a mass protest of citizens against the socialist regime.

At the end of February and in March 2012, mass protests once again took place. On March 5—the day after the election of the president of Russia—a protest rally took place in Moscow with 14,000 to 30,000 participants (RIA Novosti 2012b). On March 5 and 10, in Moscow, two major events were held, each of them gathering from 10,000 to 30,000 people. The rally at Pushkin Square was broken up by riot police (RIA Novosti 2012c).

The last mass protest rally took place in Moscow on May 6, 2012, connected to the symbolic attempt against Putin's Third Inauguration, when the rally was stopped and broken up by police, many people were injured and more than 400 arrested, which later resulted in the famous "Bolotnaya Case" with criminal charges against more than 30 meeting participants, most of whom were accused and sentenced to prison, despite of tireless work of hundreds of activists to collect evidence of their innocence and regularly coming to court hearings in their support (see OVD-Info 2012).

Though there were more protests in Moscow after those events of May 6, 2012, and they were attended by a large number of the same people that participated in 2011–2012 winter protests, that had got a common label of "Bolotnaya Movement" by mid-may 2012 it was largely over. The opened state repressions had destroyed that "common social space", that allowed Bolotnaya protest participants to associate

themselves with peaceful and positive social collectivity and the 'joint body' of "Bolotnaya public", already very diverse, had fallen to even smaller pieces, completely abandoning common discourse.

Now, attempting to apply the concept of analysis of protest publics to "Bolotnaya events," lasting from the first protest meeting on December 5, 2011, to the last rally on May 6, 2012, the author is guided by a major conceptual point that the publics do not readily exist and they only emerge at the point of being called for and assembled. What was important about those events is that each time masses emerged in protest actions, it was a slightly different public—both by demographic characteristics and discourses that united them. While first meetings were full of white flowers, fun, and humor, the last—on May 8, 2012—was moved by anger and outrage.

For this reason, we will only apply our framework analysis of the "Bolotnaya Public" during two events, which were both at the beginning of the mass protest meeting, when the public was just emerging, not far apart from each other and almost equally massive, "Bolotnaya-10" December and "Sakharova-24" December, which we claim to be a "protest public in the making," to which we will try to apply our five-point analytical frame.

Reconstructing a "troubling message," we consider this to be the publication of election results, which were seen by thousands of observers not only as fraud but also as a sign of totally ignoring both existing rules and popular belief, in the "change of power through elections."

The self-organization of this protest public was remarkably quick: from the first meeting on December 5 to the truly massive rally on December 10, it was less than a week later—and this public was self-organized not only "apart from the state structures" but also apart from other pre-existing organizational forms; though important initiatives were taken by Solidarnost, the organizing committee was promptly enlarged, involving journalists, public opinion leaders, and social volunteers.

As for the avalability of public spaces that were available to this public to express their views and discuss plans for the upcoming events, we consider them to be limited and not easily accessible, because there were scarce opportunities to organize live meetings; as the election issue was considered "sensitive" and the online spaces were few, not well moderated, and not suitable for deliberations and developing common discourse, they rather focused on merely organizational issues. What played an important positive role was media support from a part of the "official media," which created and aired a number of public appeals from opinion-makers to join the protests.

Discursive exchange was limited, as it mostly happened only during public meetings themselves, when an amazing number of participants were creating their own slogans that the public could read right at the rallies. Some of those slogans expressed deep despair and outrage with election fraud, like "Those elections were farce!", "Freedom of choice cannot be faked!", "New elections!", and "Falsifiers of elections must be brought to trial!" (Radio Liberty 2011). Some issue groups expressed their own identity and position like "Gays and lesbians against crooks and thieves!"—meaning that the ruling party created by Putin got a nickname "Party of crooks and thieves" (LGBT-grani 2011). There were even several columns of

people that marched under common banners: "Medical workers," "Moscow State University," "Petersburg," "Column of universities and schools" (Polit.ru 2012), and "Biryulyovo (district of Moscow) against Kremlin!" (Radio Liberty 2011). There were also slogans with great deal of humor, like "No Putin, no cry. . ." (Russian Blogger 2012) and "No pasaran, no kruassan, no marzipan. . ." (Novaya Gazeta 2011). But, as for the slogans of desirable future, there were mostly two often repeated slogans—"Russia will be free!" and "Russia without Putin!" (Radio Liberty 2011).

As for the "poetic message" and the "vision for a better world" that creative and *agent publics* have to produce and present to manifest themselves, the best of those that we had found to be a common is a vision of the "solidarity of free people" during the "White Ring" action. On February 26, 2012, thousands of participants with white ribbons and other white symbols connected hands around the Sadovoye Koltso [Garden Ring Road] in Moscow, which is 16 km long (RBC.ru 2012). This was really creative: because participants decided not to use the roadway and stayed on the sidewalks, there was no need to have any authorization for an action, which brought together over 50,000 people and created an atmosphere of free spirit celebration. But such a unique action was hard to reproduce. In terms of common poetic view of the future, it did not go further than "Russian without Putin," which is rather political than poetic.

In sum, the Bolotnaya–Sakharova winter protest public was rather well-organized, clearly independent, and fairly creative, which allows us to consider it as an agent-type public. But it could neither create a common identity nor develop enough public spaces to produce and reproduce a common discourse and deliberation on a specific vision of a "better world" and ways to approach it. Specific communities that either existed before and joined the protest, like ecologists or left political activists, or those which were formed during protest actions like the "Movement of 5 December" had developed their specific discourses, but not a common one. This allows us to formulate a conclusion that the Bolotnaya chain of events, even at its most consolidated first months, still was not able to consolidate one protest public, but existed as many "mini-publics", which makes it much harder to coordinate and make a strong impact.

The absence of a unified and consolidated protest public with strong common discourse through a long time is quite an often case in spontaneous mass protests; they simply have no time to develop common identity, while traditional social movements do an enormous amount of identity building (Tilly and Tarrow 2009). This is why, while analyzing mass protest events, we often use term "public" in plural, as "protest publics."

4 Gazprom Versus Skyline in St. Petersburg: Defending a Living Heart of the City

After applying the analytical frame of "protest publics" to mass protests on Bolotnaya, where the public appearance and public drive were obvious, the question remains, if the same frame is fruitful when applied to purely social protests that are

driven by very specific problems of social well-being like healthcare, quality of food in local childcare centers, or attempts to preserve the historic heritage of the surrounding city environment.

Social protest is usually studied within the approach of social movement theory, which provides good tools to inquire into their social strata origins, its activist motivations, leadership patterns, mobilization techniques, and methods of coalition building, which allows to broaden the scope of actions and involve more resources into movement activities. Many researches focus on these studies on understanding social movements' internal structure and their developmental dynamics between and within other social organizations that allow them to join a wider and more effective collective social action (Clement et al. 2010; Clement 2012).

We want to look at social protests from another angle, to see them as publics united by common discourses and the ability to communicate and exchange this discourse with a broader society, and to consider them as "mini-protest publics" or "publics-in-the-making" and explore if this can explain more about them, including their sustainability and dynamics, as well as their effectiveness in developing their identity within a larger public sphere.

For this we will switch the logic of analysis from the traditional way of describing social protests through the scheme, problem-leaders-public mobilization-activities-results, to focus more on their "publicness" and the qualities of protest publics, beginning with analyzing a "troubling message" that a particular public found important to respond to, followed by self-organization and designing social spaces for the creation of common discourse, including ways of communication, this discourse to a "wider public."

The case we selected for such analysis is the protests in St. Petersburg against the construction of Okhta Center Tower by the state-owned company Gazprom that lasted from 2006 to 2010 (Kommersant 2010) and mobilized quite a broad and vibrant protest public, uniting a broad range of individual "city defenders" and specially created ad hoc groups, joined by wide associations of several artistic unions; research communities; veterans organizations, including the survivors of the Leningrad Siege; legal and technical experts; industrial worker collectives; university students; secondary schools; public intellectuals; and many different pre-existing groups in support of the city's cultural and historic heritage, creating such a strong and consolidated protest, which, eventually, was able to stop the construction plans. The author has chosen this particular protest for applying protest public research framework, because it is widely known both through media coverage and through prior research (Dixon 2010; Gladarev 2012) so there is less need to retell the major events and we could concentrate on analysis.

Before addressing the case itself, it is important to notice the very special atmosphere and special "aura" that exists in St. Petersburg in relation to its cultural heritage, because here we are dealing with a special type of not only "pre-existing" but also an "ever-existing public" that had been created in relation to what is known as the "Myth of St. Petersburg" (Gladarev 2012, pp. 28–29) that sustained for years and formed around a specific moral and ethical unity of its citizens in relation to the

city which they feel to be "a living subject," with its own soul, character, and inner life, that they are connected to and called on to protect (Gladarev 2012).

Such special groups, concerned with particular risks to historic buildings, since their appearance, continue to function and join other groups, for example, "Salvation Group" started in 1986 by students of history and journalism in an attempt to save the house of Delvig; the group "Ecology of Ordinary Architecture," started in 1987 in support of preservation of the historic Angleterre Hotel; and the same year a group "For return of historic names" and the "Council for Ecology of Culture" that itself consisted of a big number of small informal groups, which were previously formed to protect and preserve specific cultural sites. Later, in 2005, a local group of citizens of Vasilievsky Island formed to protect it from having a highway constructed through the island as well as a sea passenger terminal. Those and many other local movements accumulated their efforts in a movement called "Living City," which opposed the city-planning policy of Mayor Matvienko.

The activities of these "protest mini-publics" created a particular environment, in which, by the time of November 2006, when the major "troubling message" had emerged from the city administration about the plans of Gazprom to build its office in the historic center, with a 300-m-high skyscraper, there was enough of the "pre-existing protest public" ready to immediately respond to this challenge.

It is important to note, referring here to Warner's theoretical claim that "publics never exist before been addressed," that the St. Petersburg case presents a particular situation, when such "culture protection" publics did not only "pre-exist," but they were—to use the theatrical term—sort of "warmed up" as they were repeatedly bothered by destructive and threatening activities of the city administration before, so the public, concerned with preservation of historical heritage, had enough time to get "self-organized outside of the state" for a long time prior to this particular event.

The risk of dramatic damage to the city center, in terms of its ecology, transport system, living conditions of citizens of Okhta region, architectural standards, and, mostly, beautiful historic skyline, making city center a part of UNESCO heritage, immediately galvanized all the existing protest mini-publics and called for the creation of a much broader public, including people who were not participating in any such activities before.

At the peak of broad public protests against Okhta Center in August 2009, a broad "Citizen Coalition in Defense of St. Petersburg" had united about 20 different organizations, including long existing, experienced, and well-resources NGOs like the non-governmental organization "Memorial," ECOM Center of Expertise of the St. Petersburg Society of Naturalists, the city branch of the All-Russian Society for the Protection of Monuments of History and Culture; well-known in St. Petersburg urban social movements of citizens, like "Living City," "Okhtinskaya Arc," "Defend Vasilievsky Island," "League of Women Voters," "Solidarity," "Green Wave," "Movement of Civil Initiatives," as well as small groups of active citizens, "Square Ivan Fomin," Council initiative groups of Moskovsky district of St. Petersburg and others. Noticeable, the Coalition was joined by regional branches of political parties of St. Petersburg, *Yabloko*, "Left Front," *Spravedlivaya Rossiya* [Just Russia], the Communist Party of the Russian Federation.

In terms of creating spaces for discursive formation and exchange and plans for possible joint protest activity, there was a vast variety of both online communications and offline actions, which all coalition members were organizing both using their own resources and joining forces—from expert round tables on technical and legal issues of construction to organizing humorous performances with "alternative competitions of Gazprom tower," from writing poetry devoted to beloved city areas to discussions with war veterans on the moral issue of defending the city, and from the speeches of writers and film makers that were broadcasted by local media to collecting signatures for a referendum on this issue.

Together with offline activities, there were special online resources, created by the coalition and its members, which were in some way specialized in their functions. For example, the website of the Living City Organization (see Living City), which was always a place for developing a common discourse of "people who love their city" and "care about its heritage," was publishing UNESCO documents related to St. Petersburg that were available for free download, results of sociological surveys on the issue, and news about the anti-Gazprom campaign.

The website Gazprom-City (see Gazprom-City 2018) that was specially created to unite the protest public was publishing all the official documents and critical expert materials concerning the construction, including expert opinions from architects, ecologists, economists, and analysis based on public interests. This resource, which was opened for public deliberation, allowed different opinions to be posted and made it possible to vote on discussed issues, which also very much contributed to a deeper understanding of the whole issue and allowed the broader public to form its own opinion about the construction and its potential benefits and risks and consolidate their joint attitude.[1]

Finally, the joint website of the coalition members called "NO to Tower" was used for merely technical purposes, such as collecting signatures and disseminating campaign advertising, posters, booklets, and leaflets, that were available for downloading.

This quick overview demonstrates that a wide variety of communication spaces were created, which allowed members of a broad protest public in St. Petersburg not only to develop a joint discourse but also to communicate it regularly—both within their specialized mini-publics, like lawyers or engineers or architects, working on the issue and between those mini-publics, which created broad joint understandings and common goals, for example, defending the city, and created a common identity as "city defenders."

The poetic message, created by this public—"people united to defend the beauty of their city from greedy strangers and corrupt powers"—is a particular strong one, because it brought together the love for the city, defending history and culture and

[1] Another web resource that is worth mentioning was a website called *Spasi Piter* [Save Petersburg] (http://www.spasipiter.ru) that was specially created for the monitoring of the court cases campaigns that were organized by construction protesters, so that everyone interested could read legal documents regulating the process of construction and follow all the stages of court hearings.

opposing nontransparent business relations between state-giant Gazprom and the city administration.

The results of this broad and lasting public protest were victorious, and this victory can be claimed to be political, legal, and cultural, the latter being the most important in the context of the analytical frame of exploring publics and public engagement. The political victory took place on December 9, 2010, when Mayor Matvienko made a public statement that she agreed with Gazprom leadership about moving the construction of their office out of the historic city center, and the legal one came shortly after, on December 20, 2010, with the decision of the St. Petersburg city court to ban construction of any buildings more than 40 m high at Okhta cape.

But what was even more important in the context of our analytical frame of exploring protest publics and their role as a social actor is that in this case, they were able to win culturally by creating such a clear joint identity for multiple citizen groups as "city defenders" and a powerful discourse of "defending the living heart of St. Petersburg against profit-seeking megacorporation" that even official government actors, initially fully siding with Gazprom, had nothing with which they could counter and switched sides. This positioned the protest-driven "counter-publics" as the authors of the dominant discourse. This demonstrates the creative, "transformative power" of strong public discourses that are able to suggest a poetic "alternative vision"—blue ribbon, symbolizing unique historic skyline—that had passed a test of "transformation of both polity and identity in the city" (Dixon 2010).

5 Conclusions

The mass protest movements that have spread over the globe in recent years are demonstrating that forms of citizens' self-organization have not been exhausted and when conventional forms do not work or are perceived to be ineffective, new forms emerge, like protest publics, whose major resource and transformative power lay in its discursive practices.

There have been several theoretical frameworks created by social scientists to analyze various forms of public participation, and because its forms are rapidly evolving, analytical instruments should also evolve in order to keep up with social practice.

This chapter offers a new conceptual framework for addressing public protests, based on an analysis of protest publics that emerge through those protests, which allows us to distinguish their different types according to the level of their actorness. The protest public framework also allows us to explain their social origin not on the basis of demographic data or belonging to a particular social group, like students, workers, or middle class, and not binding all the diverse participants by one common interest but, rather, disclosing its formation on the basis of shared discourse and common ethical demands toward centers of power. An important capacity of protest publics is their ability, rather than to aggressively confront their opponents, to develop

alternative poetic discourses about the "other world possible," while such a transformation also includes members of protest publics themselves. This can be expressed by one of the slogans at Bolotnaya, addressed both to political elites and to protest publics in an attempt to shape their identity: "We are not an opposition, we are your employers. We are not just protesting, we are firing you!" Together with the social movement theory that is focused on "formation, activities, and outcome" of movements, its leadership, organizational structure, and diffusion mechanisms, the "theory of publics" is mostly concerned by the question of "how publics are made," "how are they summoned and sustained," and "how do they communicate their alternative vision." Those approaches, while dealing with the same object of study, have a different focus of attention and can successfully complement each other: while social movement theory judges movement's success mostly by the number of followers and "political outcomes," the success of protest publics is linked to their sustainability and creativity and the transformative power of their "world vision."

Often based on ethical demands, broad protest publics have a greater potential to transform societies at large, including both elites and protest members, rather than just pushing for specific policy decisions that can be short-lived.

Publics motion toward possible horizons, and this is why it is often hard to find an immediate "output" or "result" of the activities of "protest publics," because, as Michael Warner had argued, it takes time for those new world visions to develop and take root. Working with protest publics and other types of *agent publics* and creative *counter-publics*, we have to be patient and remember that: "Publics act historically. They are said to rise up, to speak, to reject false promises, to demand answers, to change sovereigns, to support troops, to give mandates for change, to be satisfied, to scrutinize public conduct, to take role models, to deride counterfeits" (Warner 2002, p. 88). So, it is a worthwhile analysis in support of those publics to develop.

The other conclusion that could be made by observing recent examples of protest public activities, starting with "purely social protests," be it organized labor, demanding adequate payments, or safe working conditions, or civic mobilization against garbage utilization in a close vicinity of an industrial city, it is hard to predict if such issue-based protests, driven by mini-bublics, will stay marginal to national agenda. If "troubling message" is broad enough, local protests can grow from specific public mobilization to a much wider and stronger nationwide protest public that can not only pressure authorities for immediate improvement but create an ability to discuss and develop an alternative vision of governance and more open channels of public participation in decision-making.

This is more likely to happen in nondemocratic countries where many social problems emerge out of ineffective governing structures and an absence of working democratic mechanisms to address those problems.

But in developed democracies, there are also many cases where governing institutions need democratic renovation to better meet the needs of their citizens. Broad nationwide protest publics can decisively contribute to this goal.

We hope that in the following chapters exploring protest public activities in different countries, more examples will be shown, illustrating how protest publics have emerged as a new social actor and contributed to social and political development.

Funding The chapter was prepared within the framework of the Academic Fund Program at the National Research University Higher School of Economics (HSE) in 2016–2017 (grant № 17-05-0018) and by the Russian Academic Excellence Project "5-100."

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"Shoulder to Shoulder Against Fascism": Publics in Gezi Protests



Ekim Arbatli

On 28 May 2013, next to Istanbul's central Taksim Square, about 50 environmental activists organized a small sit-in at Gezi Park against a much-contested urban construction project that sought to demolish the trees in the park to build a shopping mall. In swift response, the ruling government of Justice and Development Party[1] resorted to disproportionate police violence. As the police kept attacking protestors with clubs and tear gas, more and more people unexpectedly joined the initial few, camping in tents in the park to prevent the bulldozers. The government in return launched a second and massive police attack on peaceful protestors, burning their tents and using water cannons to dispel growing numbers of participants from the scene. Although the mainstream Turkish media deliberately overlooked these attacks, video footage of events received widespread coverage in the international press and quickly disseminated through the social media networks.

This strategy of violence by the authorities tremendously backfired, however, as the public sentiment turned from shock to outrage in a matter of hours. Tens of thousands of people in Istanbul took to streets to reach Taksim Square, and solidarity protests soon flared up in multiple cities including the capital Ankara. On June 1, about a million protestors occupied Taksim Square and pushed out the police, and the "Gezi Resistance" soon spread to eight cities across the country. According to estimates, over four million citizens took to streets throughout the events (Ortiz et al. 2013, p. 34). During a month of clashes between the protesters and the police, 5 people died, 10 were blinded, and 7832 people in total were injured

[1]Hereafter AKP (in Turkish—*Adalet ve Kalkinma Partisi*).

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N. Belyaeva et al. (eds.), *Protest Publics*, Societies and Political Orders in Transition,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5_3

(Ensaroglu et al. 2014, p. 34).[2] Sporadic events continued, mainly in Istanbul and Ankara, for a few more months.

Overall, in terms of both intensity and the number of participants, Gezi protests were the largest urban resistance in the history of modern Turkey. They revitalized grassroots movements, further polarized the already divided Turkish society, altered the political landscape, and sent shock waves among the incumbent elite who believed they were ruling without serious public opposition until June 2013. The trajectory of the regime and the elite survival strategies profoundly changed after 2013 to meet this new challenge.

The protest publics model proposes a new theoretical framework for examining this emerging protest pattern, which can also shed light on our understanding of the Gezi events. In this chapter, the Gezi protests will be analyzed under the analytical framework of protest publics. First, I will show why this framework is appropriate for understanding the Gezi protests. Second, I will briefly discuss the political outcomes of the Gezi events by focusing on the transformative potential of protest publics in semi-authoritarian settings.

1 Protest Publics as an Analytical Framework

From Reykjavik, New York, and Cairo to Moscow, São Paulo, and Istanbul, a major wave of protests around the world made the front lines following the global economic crisis of 2008. On the one hand, the grievances of citizens varied widely across countries, such as fraudulent elections, anti-austerity measures, corrupt officials, reduced living standards, and heavy-handed authoritarian governments. On the other hand, scholars observe a swift diffusion of slogans, repertories, and frames across seemingly very different contexts (Flesher Fominaya 2014; Della Porta 2017a; Arbatli 2017). Over a short period of time, the protesters developed "a shared articulation of claims across North–South or East–West divides" (Glasius and Pleyers 2013, p. 547). Hence, rather than individual events, this transnational phenomenon is better understood as a global wave of protest that started in the 2000s.

As Della Porta (2017b, pp. 454–455) notes, two key assumptions of mainstream social movement (SM) studies fall short of addressing the current protest wave. First, these theories posit that protest increases when political opportunities are more open and when new alliances are available. To the contrary, most of the contemporary mass protests seem to have evolved in highly unfavorable political opportunity structures—either in closed authoritarian regimes or in democracies where traditional allies (such as left-wing political parties or labor unions) were unavailable to protestors. Second, classical SM theories assume that the existence of dense political

[2]The numbers quoted in Ensaroglu et al. (2014) are taken from the Turkish Medical Association report on Gezi protests.

networks is necessary for large-scale mobilization. This assumption, largely based on observations about Western social movements in the 1960s and 1970s, fails to account for new types of political organization facilitated by digital technologies.

The protest publics model differs from SM analysis in multiple key aspects. According to Warner (2002, p. 59), protest publics are a self-organized body of strangers who are "united through the circulation of their discourse." Publics are characterized by low levels of institutionalization, multiple and diffuse leadership, and an orientation toward common discourses as opposed to common identities. Hence, this framework is increasingly more appealing, especially looking at the protests of the last decade. A key defining characteristic of these contemporary protests is the lack of institutionalization and centralized leadership in collective action (Castells 2015; Glasius and Pleyers 2013; Tufekci 2014; Krastev 2014). Many authors have noted this trend across the globe from the Occupy movement (Juris 2012) to the Arab Spring (Weyland 2012; Howard and Hussain 2013). This lack of institutionalization and the protesters' rejection of vertical power structures can be partially explained by a general disillusionment with the political processes and institutions (Flesher Fominaya 2014; Zuckerman 2014; Della Porta 2017b). Since public trust in traditional political institutions has steadily eroded in the last two decades, looser forms of organization and attempts at participatory democracy are gaining ground as the new modus operandi. By the same token, representatives or leaders are also perceived as both the symbols and perpetrators of the order that the protesters have come to openly despise. Hence, they are seen either as outdated and unnecessary or as counterproductive and harmful to pluralist decision-making.

Secondly, a hallmark of current protests has been their success in bringing together individuals from very different (and sometimes conflicting) ideologies and backgrounds. It is important to understand that the uniting factor for protestors is not a shared identity but rather the existence of common grievances and demands. The protestors gather around the discourse based on the necessity and possibility of change. Hence, rather than a full-blown and solid articulation of political demands, the public focuses on the "troubled message." The circulation of this shared discourse is facilitated by the existence of new public arenas of debate, such as the cyberspace and social media. Nonetheless, more traditional forms of direct deliberation such as physical gatherings in symbolic centers, public space occupations, and neighborhood forums have also continued to coexist alongside the use of digital technologies.

2 Gezi Protests and the Protest Publics Model

Walking in the streets of Istanbul and Ankara on the first days of June 2013, one could read the public mood in a wall writing: "Wow, it really *is* revolution!" (*Ay resmen devrim!*). This element of widespread surprise accurately describes the Gezi protests. Not only the government but the protestors themselves were also shocked at such an outburst of mobilization in the matter of a few days. From the onset, it was

clear that these events emulated the self-organized, unexpected, and eruptive pattern of protests around the world in the 2010s. Based on this observation, the following section analyzes Gezi protests under the criteria of the protest publics model.

Low Level of Institutionalization For social movements, the prior existence of dense political networks is generally considered to be an important factor of mobilization (Della Porta and Diani 2006, pp. 114–121).[3] However, as the earlier discussion suggests, the recent wave of global protests did not necessarily benefit from already established networks and high levels of institutionalization. Gezi protests are a good example of a self-organized body of people that have little prior experience of protest or institutional structure. The Konda survey of June 2013,[4] conducted in the premises of Gezi Park during the events, shows that 55.6% of respondents have never been involved in a political protest, march, or sit-in before. Moreover, 93.6% of the interviewees identified their participating role in the protest as "ordinary citizens," compared to only 6.4% who defined their role as representing an organization. This fact becomes even more striking when we observe that 21.1% of these respondents are actually members of a political organization and an overwhelming percentage of them did not identify their participation with any institutional motive.

Like its contemporaries, the Gezi protests were marked by not only a lack of institutionalization but also with the explicit refusal of any central leadership claims. This is not surprising given the very broad and diverse social base of participation. Since the protests involved many different groups, a common leadership corresponding to the needs and claims of all parties was highly unlikely to emerge. Rather than easily identifiable public figures, the protestors adopted an alternative leadership style that is "interpersonally oriented, democratic, collaborative, all inclusive, and transformational" (Eslen-Ziya and Erhart 2015, p. 483). The general discourse revolved around unification and solidarity against a common "enemy," as apparent in the very widely used slogan "shoulder to shoulder against fascism!" (*fasizme karsi omuz omuza!*). With this spirit, in most instances, the protestors improvised and volunteered for practical tasks such as setting up makeshift healthcare tents for the wounded, distributing food around the park area, or helping the victims of pepper spray recover. The immediate decisions were usually taken on an ad hoc basis by the people who happened to be present at the scene.

Although the protest publics remained without any central leadership, the civic group "Taksim Solidarity (*Taksim Dayanismasi*)" served the function of a deliberative platform. This loosely structured umbrella group was formed in February 2012, and it brought together a total of 128 constituents ranging from professional

[3]We should also note that most of these observations are based on countries with prior democratic experience and grassroots civic involvement. Especially in hybrid or authoritarian regimes, the lack of prior mobilization experience on the part of protestors is not surprising, given that a window of opportunity for large-scale protest is rarely available in these settings.

[4]Retrievable from http://konda.com.tr/wp-content/uploads/2017/02/KONDA_GeziRaporu2014.pdf (Accessed 15 February 2018).

associations to neighborhood platforms, from LGBTI rights groups to trade unions, and from some political parties (Elicin 2017). The group had no centralized leadership or political affiliation. However, in the lack of a representative organization during the protests, Taksim Solidarity assumed a de facto role in disseminating the main demands of the protestors via multiple press releases.[5] These demands included the cancelation of the construction projects on Gezi Park premises, the inclusion of citizens in a deliberative process about the organization of public spaces around Taksim, the withdrawal of the police from main city squares, and stopping police violence against protesters.

It is hard to gauge the exact role and the effectiveness of Taksim Solidarity in the protests, but arguably the initiation of serious political charges against its members shows that it was perceived as an important threat by the government. After the Gezi protests, five members of Taksim Solidarity were put on trial with the charges of "founding a criminal organization" and "provoking others into participation in an unauthorized demonstration," facing up to 15 years of imprisonment. According to Amnesty International's report (2014, p. 15):

> [n]one of the information presented in the indictment against the five people constitutes evidence of participating in or incitement to violence or any other conduct not protected by human rights law. The evidence relates instead entirely to their peaceful presence at a gathering in Gezi Park on 8 July 2013 and their activities as members of the Taksim Solidarity coalition.

A New Model of Collective Action How do publics get together and disseminate their message in the absence of institutionalization and centralized leadership? The protest activities of the recent decade present us with two distinct realms of gathering. Most of the time, these two realms are used simultaneously by protest publics to formulate, debate, and convey a common discourse around the "troubled message." The first one is the direct occupation of public spaces and their usage as alternative arenas of deliberation. A common element in the recent wave of protest has been a concern with public space (Della Porta 2017a; Örs 2014; Tuğal 2013). The occupation of public spaces as arenas of deliberation is a recurring pattern across many cases. The second and more debated realm is the social media. Indeed, the logic of collective action in the digital age is markedly different from earlier episodes of contentious politics, leading Bennett and Segerberg (2013) to rename it "connective action." According to Tufekci (2014), "[t]he current civic moment of noninstitutional but thick engagement with politics is made possible exactly because these tools allow movements to undertake some endeavors, including quite impressive ones, without needing to grapple, at least initially, with the implications of choosing not to build certain institutional capacity" (p. 207).

An important part of the Gezi protests' success in mobilizing millions of participants can be attributed to this simultaneous usage of both realms. The availability of

[5]These press releases can be found in the Taksim Solidarity's website, retrievable from http://www.taksimplatformu.com/basinodasi.php (Accessed 19 February 2018).

public space played a crucial role on multiple fronts. First of all, the occupation of Gezi Park (and later Taksim Square) which is situated at the heart of Istanbul provided the key advantage of visibility to protestors. Although the mainstream national media initially collaborated with the government in an attempt to ignore the gathering crowds, the central location of protests made this strategy unsustainable. Second, the neighborhood of Taksim was a highly symbolic area in many ways. On the one hand, it represented a modern, multicultural, and all-encompassing view of multiple and coexisting lifestyles. On the other hand, especially since the 1970s, Taksim Square was the main venue of the nation's biggest political demonstration for many actors from trade unions to LGBTI rights groups. Last but not the least, the occupation of space provided the much-needed ground for public deliberation and decision-making within the fluid gathering. In all likelihood, the first group of protesters that arrived and set up their tents in Gezi Park on May 28 had not calculated this extra advantage, since their primary aim was halting the government's attempts to bulldoze the park by being physically present in the scene.

The second realm that has shaped large-scale mobilization was the social media and digital space. On May 28, when only about 50 activists were present at the Gezi Park to stop its demolition, one symbolic photo (later named "the woman in red") taken by a Reuters reporter quickly spread throughout the media. As aptly described by journalist Max Fisher (2013):

> [t]he dynamic between the woman in red and the police officer in the photo is fascinating, a microcosm of the relationship between outraged Turks and not just the police but perhaps the Turkish government itself, which they see as increasingly authoritarian. The policeman is hunched over slightly as if braced for combat as he, in almost Orwellian cruelty, sprays a few tablespoons of what appears to be pepper spray directly into the face of a young woman who is clearly a threat to no one.[6]

The woman in red quickly became an iconic image and a symbol of resistance for the angry crowds gathering around Taksim to protest police brutality. In the following days, similar images of anonymous protesters went viral with the caption "Our Heroes" (*Kahramanlarimiz*), featuring a collection of the most memorable acts of peaceful resistance such as a protester calmly playing his guitar in front of the approaching police riot vehicle ("Guitar Hero"), a man in a wheelchair facing the police water cannon ("The citizen without disability"), and an elderly woman in headscarf wearing a Guy Fawkes mask during the march ("V for Aunt Vildan"), among others.

These images spread throughout the social media gave a powerful message and helped mobilization, as more and more people filled the squares around the country to demand an immediate end to police attacks on peaceful protesters and innocent bystanders. During the events, 49% of protesters interviewed in the Gezi Park said that they decided to join the protest when they saw the police violence against

[6]Retrievable from https://www.washingtonpost.com/news/worldviews/wp/2013/06/03/the-photo-that-encapsulates-turkeys-protests-and-the-severe-police-crackdown/?utm_term=.480732a3a535 (Accessed 20 May 2018).

citizens (Konda 2014, p. 18). These individual decisions to participate culminated into large-scale mobilization in a very short time, which is a key advantage of digital technologies that traditional methods of communication are generally lacking. By the time the mainstream media started reporting on the protests, the number of participants were already swelling to hundreds of thousands across 80 cities.

Building a Common Identity Although the large-scale mobilization and broad-based participation in Gezi protests were sudden and unexpected, in retrospect, the period of 2012–2013 was fraught with social unrest and political activism from multiple segments of the society, as the regime became more socially conservative and authoritarian. A series of protests by Kurds, Alawites, Kemalists, women's rights groups, students, workers, intellectuals, environmentalists, LGBTI activists, and football fan groups took center stage in turn, as these actors separately opposed various different policies and decisions of the government. According to Yoruk and Yuksel (2014, pp. 109–110), the number of political protests in Turkey rose "from fewer than 60 in July 2012 to over a hundred a month from September to December 2012; from 150 in January 2013, to over 200 in March and 250 in May, spiking at over 400 protests in June 2013." The decision to demolish Gezi Park was, in this sense, the proverbial straw that broke the camel's back.

It has been claimed that contemporary mass protests are driven by the increasingly educated and informed middle class whose expectations have been repeatedly disappointed by the ruling elites (Fukuyama 2013; Della Porta 2017a, b). Although the same argument has also been made about Gezi protests, many scholars point out that the events cannot be reduced to a middle-class uprising (Boratav 2013; Yoruk and Yuksel 2014; Gürcan and Peker 2015). According to these scholars, the class configuration points to a mixture of various wage-earning class fractions and notably the manual and nonmanual working class. The participants were heterogeneous in terms of values and identity.

What underlying grievances united these very different actors as a public and gave them a common identity? Although the protests initially started as an environmentalist reaction against the demolition of trees in Gezi Park, it quickly became apparent that the participants were making broader political demands. According to the Konda survey,[7] 34.1% of the interviewees in Gezi Park said that they were joining the protests for their "freedoms," while another 18.4% protested "against rights abuses." A further 9.7% of the respondents came out "against dictatorship and oppression," and 9.5% said that they came to demand the government's resignation. Overall, nine out of ten survey respondents participated in the protests for reasons directly related to their disapproval of the government's policy decisions.

From the onset, the motley of participants was centered around the image of an ideal future rather than on immediate policy goals. Some of the most popular slogans of the protest clearly reflected this motivation: "Everywhere is Taksim, resistance everywhere," "This is just the beginning, continue the struggle," and "Taksim is

[7]Retrievable from http://konda.com.tr/wp-content/uploads/2017/02/KONDA_GeziRaporu2014.pdf (Accessed 15 February 2018).

ours, Istanbul is ours." Although these slogans were very powerful, none of them voiced any tangible policy demands. Rather, they were conveying the message of determination and solidarity for a common imagined future. By this token, they primarily echoed the belief that "another world is possible." Hence, the common identity was broadly constructed around the ideals of increased political participation, the protection of individual freedoms and lifestyles, and a more open and inclusive political system.

Diversity of Public Self-Representation As the discussion so far suggests, a common identity has to be built through discourse rather than being automatically assumed. The representation of the protest public helps to both reinforce and be affected by this self-image. Hence, the processes of identity-building and self-representation can be perceived as reciprocal and interactive. In the Gezi protests, this dynamic process of identity-building and self-representation is primarily to be found in the positioning of the public against the authority. A prevalent example is how the protesters chose to name themselves. In a public speech on the first days of the events, Prime Minister Erdogan used the word "capulcu" (meaning, roughly, looter or marauder) to describe the protestors. The public quickly reappropriated this word and started referring to themselves "capulcular" (looters) and even coined together a mock verb "capuling" (chapulling, a hybrid of Turkish and English) to refer to their acts of protest. The anonymous video titled "Everyday I'm Capuling" (inspired by the lyrics of LMFAO's Party Rock Anthem, "everyday I'm shuffling") soon went viral on the Internet and social media. In a matter of days, the word "capulcu" transformed being an insult directed against protestors to a self-claimed identity proudly reiterated by the protest public to signal their discontent.[8]

Although the common identity was built in action, it is not necessarily expressed by the same repertoires across the public. One clear point of separation from earlier social movements is the multiplicity and diversity of self-representation in contemporary protests. This is partially explicable by low levels of institutionalization. Since the public is not bound by an overarching structure, the drive to "join an acronym" (McDonald 2002) or to be limited to a predetermined set of slogans and banners is considerably lower. Moreover, the tendency of individual participation within a public, rather collective action under a predetermined identity, is a result of rising individualism and diversity among protestors (Bennett and Segerberg 2013; Tufekci 2014).

An important source of individual expression in Gezi protests was the widespread use of humor throughout the tweets, banners, and slogans of protest. A general mistrust of traditional politics to solve problems, especially among the youth, was visible in the aversion of traditional political slogans as well. As Emre et al. (2014, p. 437) aptly observe, the element of humor created a zone of "teenager language" inspired by social media and quickly gained ground as a nonconventional discourse. For example, in reference to one of the Prime Minister's earlier speeches where he

[8]Retrievable from https://www.theguardian.com/world/2013/jun/10/turkish-protesters-capuling-erdogan (Accessed 15 May 2018).

urged every family to have at least three kids, a young protester held up his banner: "Hey Prime Minister, do you *really* want three more kids like us?" In another good example of street humor, a wall writing aimed at the police read: "We are already emotional kids, no need for tear gas!" Besides mocking politicians' speeches, the banners, slogans, and wall writings also made frequent references to contemporary Turkish and foreign movies (e.g., Star Wars, V for Vendetta), TV series (e.g., Game of Thrones), video games, and popular culture.[9]

The existence of many different publics among the protestors led to many different ways of self-expression. As one famous example, the football fan groups became a central actor that introduced their own style of protest that circulated well and resonated with the protest publics. The ultra-fans of the three largest rival football clubs in Istanbul (Galatasaray, Fenerbahce, and Besiktas) came together for the first time around a common cause, establishing the group they named "Istanbul United." Given their prior experience of clashing with the police on multiple occasions in football games, they became crucial actors helping protestors fight the police, build barricades, and recover from tear gas. They also used creative modifications of well-known football slogans used in the stadiums. For instance, besides the popular slogan "Tayyip, resign!" (*Tayyip istifa!*), the protesters also frequently used the chant "Jump, jump, if you don't jump then you're Tayyip!" (*Zipla, zipla, ziplamayan Tayyip!*). In a tongue-in-cheek style, it urged the crowd to jump up and down as they chanted, to show their disapproval of the Prime Minister and his ruling style. Both Istanbul United and more notably the Besiktas fan club named "Carsi" soon became highly visible figures of the protests. Their slogan "*Carsi* is against everything!" (*Carsi her seye karsi!*) was appropriated and used by many protestors, who affirmed that they were indeed against many aspects of what they saw as an increasingly repressive regime.

The LGBTI community also turned out to be one of the most active publics within the protests. This active participation is remarkable in a country like Turkey where the members of this community do not freely enjoy their rights and public visibility. Although homosexuality is not legally a crime, discrimination and harassment against homosexual and trans individuals are widespread within the society. For this very reason, the language of resistance and change during the Gezi protests clearly resonated well within the LGBTI community as a historically oppressed and vulnerable group. Moreover, many homosexual and trans individuals who joined the protests had prior experience of police violence and confrontation with the authorities, which also increased respect and appreciation toward LGBTI people from other protestors in the scene (Shevtsova 2017, p. 91). Consequently, the Pride Walk that happened in June 2013 attracted the biggest number of participants to date, leading

[9] A detailed discussion of the many interesting slogans, banners, and social media content is beyond the scope of this analysis. For a good treatise of the topic, see Emre et al. (2014).

observers to comment that the increase in participation is partly attributable to the Gezi protests.[10]

Another significant public was women from all walks of life, often overcoming differences in age, generation, ideology, party affiliation, and religious background. According to the Konda survey, 50.8% of the participants in Gezi were women,[11] which made them a significant force in the protests. Although many feminist groups were also present and visible in the scene, most of the Turkish and Kurdish women were not necessarily gathered around these groups. Some of them, like the "woman in red" mentioned above, quickly became individual icons. Others engaged in group action to stand against the aggressive and masculine language of the authorities. In one famous example of women's resistance, on June 14, the Mayor of Istanbul asked all mothers to "come and fetch their children," claiming that their security could not be guaranteed by the state. In response, a group of hundred mothers gathered around Taksim Square to form a human chain against police attacks, chanting the slogans "Mothers are here!" (*Anneler burada!*) and "Mothers are everywhere, resistance is everywhere!" (*Her yer anne, her yer direnis!*). This symbolic act of "resisting mothers" carried an important message against the conservative rhetoric of the government, which sought to designate an ultimate role for women exclusively as wives and mothers, safely confined in their homes. By showing up in Taksim Square, the women asserted that being mothers did not prevent them from taking civic action in the public sphere.

As this discussion shows, the Gezi protests united people from very different backgrounds. Nonetheless, publics' self-representation centered on one common theme: the use of collective resourcefulness against a brutal authority. Since the authorities were using "disproportionate violence" (*orantisiz guc*) against them, the publics sought to respond by "disproportionate intelligence" (*orantisiz zeka*). This concept of "disproportionate intelligence" became a prevalent discourse of how the protest publics characterized themselves, more resourceful, more educated, and more open-minded crowds who would unite their efforts around creative forms of civil disobedience and resistance, against an authority which resorts to violence because it lacks the capacity to address them otherwise. A very symbolic image of this "disproportionate intelligence" was the photo of a young protester standing against the riot police in Gezi Park and reading a book to three (equally young) police officers, who are dressed for action and clearly not interested in listening. This symbol of art and intellect against brutal force was a central theme in the protests.

Context Political opportunities can be defined broadly as "those aspects of the political system that affect the possibilities that challenging groups have to mobilize effectively" (Giugni 2009, p. 361). According to McAdam (1996, p. 27), the four main dimensions of political opportunity have been stressed in the literature: (1) the

[10]Retrievable from http://www.milliyet.com.tr/taksim-deki-onur-yuruyusu-ne-bbc/dunya/detay/1730407/default.htm (Accessed 20 June 2018).

[11]Retrievable from http://konda.com.tr/wp-content/uploads/2017/02/KONDA_GeziRaporu2014.pdf (Accessed 15 February 2018).

relative openness of the political system, (2) the stability of elite alignments, (3) the presence of elite allies, and (4) the state's capacity and propensity for repression. Examining the Gezi protests from these four angles, it is apparent that the political opportunity structure was not very favorable for a large-scale movement to form. The political system was moving increasingly toward closure from an electoral democracy to competitive authoritarianism. The elite alliances available to protestors were few in number and undecided on a clear strategy. Moreover, the state had both the capacity and the propensity for various types of repression.

Although political opportunities are an important determinant of movement success, scholars have noted that not only opportunities but also common threats can encourage mobilization (Goldstone and Tilly 2001; Della Porta 2017b). This observation is especially valid for the Gezi protests, where the opposition was traditionally fragmented, polarized, and, in many instances, divergent. According to Sahan (2017, p. 112), "unification did not happen around separate movements slowly building up their separate agendas into a conducive setting for the opposition. On the contrary, the protests developed very swiftly against a political opponent and around political issues, in an atmosphere that lacked any strong movements."

As discussed earlier, the political demands of protesters culminated around the concerns of increasing authoritarianism and social conservatism. In this sense, the political structure itself constituted a realm of contention rather than opportunity. The initial stance of the government against protestors was one of antagonism and polarization, and not one of public deliberation. It is no surprise that the public as an actor that seeks profound political change will find it hard to form elite alliances, especially in instances where the anger and criticism are directed against all political elites. The protest public seeks redress on the streets when the institutional mechanisms of deliberation are depleted or nonexistent to begin with. This is not necessarily the best strategy for obtaining policy outcomes, but in certain contexts, it may be the only available option for finding an outlet to voice the troubled message.

3 The Outcome of Gezi Protests: "*Du Pareil au Même?*"

What are the political outcomes of Gezi protests? On the one hand, one may be tempted to argue that the AKP government survived this crisis without major electoral losses or concessions. On the other hand, the Gezi protests set off a series of sociopolitical forces which seem to be active to this day. Turkey has been classified as a hybrid regime for a very long time, and many scholars classify it as a case of competitive authoritarianism after 2013 (Arbatli 2014; Igsız 2014; Herzog 2015). Clearly, the dynamics of protest in hybrid regimes differ from those that happen in democratic settings (Tilly 2004; Davenport 2005; Robertson 2011). The main political result of the protests has been repressive backlash, pushing the regime toward competitive authoritarianism. The year 2013 proved to be a turning point for the trajectory of the Turkish regime, where the survival strategies of the incumbent elite underwent a significant change from broad-based legitimation to widespread

repression (Bayulgen et al. 2018). Although Gezi events are clearly not the only driver of this authoritarian reversal, they altered the sociopolitical landscape in some important ways.

The most tangible gain on the part of the protest public was that the Gezi Park construction project was stopped for the foreseeable future. Although the government officials announced their intention to restart the project multiple times, the plans have not been put into practice at the time of this writing. In this sense, the symbolic meaning of the park became a lot more important than its physical location. Not only did the protesters defend a city park, they also asserted their identity and voiced their political opposition to policies of urban gentrification and environmental destruction for private profits. From this idea arose new local environmental initiatives such as the Artvin Cerattepe Solidarity and the Defense for Northern Forests.

Moreover, Gezi protests can be seen as the first widespread experiment in public deliberation and alliance formation across different segments of the society. Erhart (2014, p. 1729) argues that "[n]ationalist and Kurdish groups, socialist and anti-capitalist Muslim groups, and white-collar and blue-collar workers, too, formed similar alliances which, if they last, may have a transformative effect on Turkish society." Five years after the protests, it is not certain how many of these societal alliances remain strong and prevalent. However, the findings of Acar and Uluğ (2016) through a set of 34 interviews with protesters from diverse backgrounds suggest that the protests helped in prejudice reduction among participants and achieved a newfound appreciation for other groups through perspective-taking and forged solidarity. According to the interviewees, these new alliances included a level of solidarity between Turkish and Kurdish nationalist protesters, between football organizations that were former rivals, and between the LGBTI community and the rest of the participants. Similarly, Shevtsova (2017, p. 93) argues that "the clear anti-government position expressed by Turkish LGBTI community [. . .] allowed increased visibility of LGBTI protesters and influenced positive changes in societal attitude during Gezi events."

In short, what the protests failed to achieve was long-lasting policy gains. Ironically, on this front, both the power and the weakness of protest publics lie in their noninstitutionalized nature. Because of their fluidity and the gathering around discourses as opposed to fixed identities, they can achieve high and broad-based participation in a very short time. However, precisely because of this lack of structure and their diffuse leadership, the demands of protest publics remain oblique and uncertain. Even when the authorities are willing to negotiate, they are faced with the critical question of finding legitimate representatives that can speak on behalf of the participants. Hence, the central concern for protest publics as a political actor is finding ways to formulate long-term strategies, build lasting alliances, and fight for meaningful policy change.

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Emergent Protest Publics in India and Bangladesh: A Comparative Study of Anti-corruption and Shahbag Protests



Arnab Roy Chowdhury and Ahmed Abid

1 Introduction

In April 2011, mass protests began in India against various aspects of corruption, such as kleptocracy, electoral fraud, and black money. The protesters demanded the enactment and enforcement of strong legislation against perceived political corruption. They used non-violent repertoires of civil disobedience such as hunger strikes, marches, and rallies. To organize, communicate, and spread their message, they used social media.

Initially nonpartisan to politics, the mobilizations fought for the Jan Lokpal Bill (also known as Citizen's Ombudsman Bill), which was introduced in parliament in 2011. Later, the core activist group splits into two: one group formed a political party called Aam Aadmi Party (AAP; Common Man's Party) in 2012. The AAP won the Delhi legislative assembly polls and formed the government in 2013. The state passed the anti-corruption Citizen's Ombudsman Act (or the Lokpal and Lokayuktas Act) in 2013. This was a significant success of the mobilizations.

Bangladesh won independence from Pakistan through a bloody war in 1971 (Muktijudhho). During the war, the Pakistani army violated human rights and conducted genocide on a large scale. In 2009, the ruling Awami League (AL) government formed an International Crime Tribunal (ICT) to try alleged war criminals. In 2010, the tribunal delivered its first indictments against groups considered enemy "collaborators" and "traitors" (Razakars, Al-Badr, and Al-Sham). But these indictments divided the country

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N. Belyaeva et al. (eds.), *Protest Publics*, Societies and Political Orders in Transition,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5_4

into seculars and Islamic hardliners: seculars embraced the Bangladeshi national and linguistic identity, demanded capital punishment for war criminals, and found the indictments too lenient and Islamic hardliners nursed their severed links with Pakistan and tried to save the war criminals.

In February 2013, groups of seculars started a massive public protest in the public square at Shahbag, Dhaka, to demand capital punishment for war crime convict Abdul Quader Mollah and a ban against the radical Islamist group Jamaat-e-Islami. These protesters used non-violent actions and mobilized people through social media and blogs. Though the hardliners murdered many activists, the secular protests were successful—many of the convicted were given capital punishment.

In both cases, "protest publics" (Warner 2002; Mahony and Clarke 2013) emerged; they were the central protagonists of these protests and had distinct characteristics. These publics were a citizen actor of social change; this social actor did not act as a caste, class, or religious group. These protests were not organized through civil society organizations (CSO) or social movements. They successfully brought about sociopolitical transformations. Mostly, the youth participated in these protests and used only non-violent actions, even though the opposition at Shahbag used massive violence.

These Indian and Bangladesh protests were influenced by the Occupy Wall Street movement and the Arab Spring (Nigam 2012; Sabur 2013) but were located between the local and global. They were influenced by global protest cycles (Nigam 2012), but raised national identity, consciousness, and conscience as a public issue, and demanded direct participation in the formulation of national policy.

There were differences, too. In India, protests led to the formation of a political party (which formed a local state government) and changes in the law, after which it petered out. In Bangladesh, the oppositions of Shahbag protesters started a spiral of counter-violence, radicalization, and "terrorist" attacks that engulfed society.

We compare these two cases of protest publics using an analytical framework derived from the theory of "publics" (Habermas 1962 [1989]; Calhoun 1993). We trace the emergence of the "protest public" and map its characteristics (Warner 2002; Mahony and Clarke 2013; Belyaeva 2012; Zaytsev 2017).

2 Conceptual Framework

These kinds of protests have been explained through two theoretical models—social movement theory and civil society theory (Belyaeva 2012; Anufriev and Zaytsev 2016, p. 36).

Social movements are characterized by specific methods of organization and clarity about their common identity, claims, programs, and goals. They also have a target audience and authorities against who the strategy and course of movement action is decided (Della Porta 2014).

However, the social movement theory does not fully explain the India and Bangladesh protests. The protest participants clearly lacked proper organization.

There was a variety of reasons for participation in these movements, which shows a clear absence of coherent goals and programs of mass action. Participants also lacked constant interaction with authorities or a target audience.

Civil society theory does not explain these protests either, as the theory emphasizes a clear organizational structure and long-lasting organizational activities before any action takes place. The protest in South Asian cases clearly lacked that.

We argue that the theory of publics can explain these protests with clarity. Warner (2002) describes a public as a self-organized entity formed by being "addressed" or "summoned." It is constituted through messages delivered through speeches, shows, books, pamphlets, discussion, and debates. These messages are an aggregate of audiovisual "texts" that create and circulate the discourse and amplify its effect. A public assembles in response to this "text," but not merely as an audience in response to a summons; it emerges in a self-organized, self-motivated fashion—outside the purview of the state (Warner 2002, p. 51) and other pre-organized structures [such as nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) and the church] (Belyaeva 2012). It is not as if a rational public "waits" to be persuaded through rational discourse; rather the theatrical politics of spectacle often attracts the public to participate and take to the streets (Warner 2002, p. 82). Belyaeva (2012, p. 11) uses the term "troubling message," as it covers both texts and events that disseminate a problematic or troublesome message to that public, which then leads to a protest. Warner also talks about a unique characteristic of public discourse—the public holds a poetic view of creative world-making or the possibility of an alternative world—which can be termed as the "public mystique" (Belyaeva 2012, p. 10).[1] We refer to the importance of these typologies to the South Asian cases in the discussion.

In a similar vein, Mahony and Clarke (2013) argue that as entities, publics are always mediated and emergent "rather than being pre-existing, readily identifiable and available to be mobilized"; they are called into existence or summoned. They argue that the "mediating practices" of summoning a public is political—not neutral—and that the sort of publics summoned, and the roles that they perform, depend on those mediating practices. They classify publics into "abject," "audience," and "agentic." Whereas the "abject public" is immobilized and should be represented by someone else, the "audience public" is relatively mobilized and summoned as choice-bearers; but the choice and programs are limited and predecided elsewhere, and so the audience public is only partially autonomous. The "agentic public" is imagined to be autonomous, reflexive, creative, and self-organized; have the capacity to exercise choices; and transcend any kind of imposition or mediation (pp. 946–947). We return to this typology in the conclusion.

These categories should be understood as ideal types; a particular protest public might not fit neatly into any one of these types. Also, publics might go through transitional phases of increasing "actorness," or agency, and transform in the life cycle of a protest. We will see in one of the South Asian cases a progressive transformation in the actorness of a public.

[1] As the World Social Forum slogan "Another World is Possible" puts it so evocatively.

We analyze and compare the emergence of protest publics in each country to look for similarities and differences in their characteristics. We use secondary data gleaned from extant papers, newspaper archives, and documents available in databases, online portals, and repositories.

3 India and Bangladesh: Common Threads of Connections

In this section, we argue that colonial and postcolonial historical legacy matters in the emergence of "protest publics" in India and Bangladesh. Scholars argue that a "public" is emergent and does not preexist a summons or address (Calhoun 1993; Warner 2002; Mahony and Clarke 2013); nevertheless, we emphasize that a "protest public" might have some historical legacy. A public issue might circulate for a long time through discourses, and the possible text for a summons takes some inchoate shape in the discursive public sphere, which is then deployed through mediations to summon the public. This is particularly possible if similar issues and demands have been raised before within a national context, as in the cases of India and Bangladesh, which have historical antecedents with similar demands.

India and Bangladesh share considerable similarities: an entangled colonial and postcolonial history and the regional context of South Asia. Both countries were part of the same colony in South Asia that the British ruled over for 200 years. In 1947, when the Indian colony gained independence, it was partitioned into India and Pakistan. The region now called Bangladesh was then part of Pakistan and called "East Pakistan." Eventually, in 1971, after a bloody war, East Pakistan became an independent nation of Bengali speakers named Bangladesh. The Indian state actively intervened in the war to create the Bangladeshi nation.

After independence, India remained largely a country with a Hindu majority and a constitutionally secular, stable, and democratic government, and Bangladesh emerged as a Muslim-majority country with a procedural democracy and secular vision but an unstable government that succumbed to frequent coups and slow radicalization by Islamic hardliners.

3.1 The Indian "Context" and the Anti-corruption Movements of the 1970s

Initially, anti-corruption issues emerged as social movements in the 1970s. Later, in the 1980s, various routes of civic engagements arose. These issues were raised again in 2011 by the characteristically different form of "protest publics."

The Indian National Congress (INC) party, which played a central role in the anti-colonial struggle against the British, assumed the government of the independent Indian state in 1947, led by Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru.

The Indian state embraced liberal and secular values constitutionally, and socialist policies were adapted and promoted by Nehru in the political economic sphere. A small number of elites emerged in the 1950s and 1960s; they were part of the state power structure, bureaucracy, and state-protected industries (Roy Chowdhury 2013, 2014). The existence of caste in society played a significant role in the consolidation of inequality and the emergence of these massively corrupt elites. They adopted western education and consumerist values and enjoyed the fruits of "development." The rest of society was excluded from these structures and was deeply affected by the scarcity of resources (Roy 2016).

The emergence of anti-corruption protests in 2011 was novel in some sense, but not entirely unprecedented. In India, corruption has always been an agenda in search of a movement (Harriss-White 1998). Social movements against corruption were held in the 1960s and 1970s. The notion of citizen's ombudsman against corruption (or Lokpal) was first suggested in the 1960s (Sitapati 2011, p. 39). These themes of national renewal and democratic reform began to animate Indian politics in the 1970s. Nav Nirman (reconstruction), a student-led movement against political corruption, emerged in Gujarat. Jayaprakash Narayan, a Gandhian activist and political leader in Bihar, led the Total Revolution movement in the 1960s and 1970s, an India-wide campaign against political corruption (Shah 1977; Rajhans 2017). The increasing popularity of these movements, and the political threats these posed to the government, led the ruling INC to declare a state of emergency in 1975. It was withdrawn in 1977.

In India, caste and class elites monopolize mainstream politics, and claimants and groups who felt excluded formed the various social movements that emerged before the state emergency. They organized campaigns, contentious repertoires, and collective action to press their demands against other groups and stake their claim to state resources. These movements were popular, but the Indian citizenry was still largely divided. No single class emerged that represented the voice of the nation. During this phase of repressive state emergency, the new Indian middle-class citizens' consciousness developed against the state and the antidemocratic tendencies of the political elite (Rajagopal 2011).

Roy (2016, p. 362) argues that "angry citizens" emerged as a legitimate political actor in postcolonial Indian democracy in the 1970s. "Civic anger" is historically constituted and sociopolitically embedded; it is not a subjectively and individually experienced feeling. The rise of angry citizens is part of the distinctive political agency that talks about the cure, reform, and renewal of democracy or "curative democracy." This idea of civic anger and curative democracy manifested itself through judicial-legal routes, civil liberty movements, and civil society actions; created a third space of social action and nonparty politics; and worked to triangulate democracy (Roy 2016, p. 372). These kinds of political mediation from below became an essential democratic practice in India[2] after 1970s.

[2]However, Roy (2016) argues that a section of middle-class activists and bureaucrats who were "insiders" to this democracy was promoting this politics as they had a stake in improving it.

In the era of globalization and neoliberal reforms in India (after the 1990s), there is an intercourse between the national and global, in which the notion of "anti-corruption" has gained discursive power. In India, corruption is seen as having prevented the fruits of growth and development from reaching the large mass of the toiling poor and as a failure of neoliberal economics, good governance, and, ultimately, democracy (Jenkins 2014, p. 41).

The anti-corruption "protest public" mainly emerged in 2011, after neoliberal India had existed over a decade. Now, the fight against corruption has gained new legitimacy; it is no more considered just a group or community matter but an issue of public (and citizens') concern and a democratic right of the citizen that can be demanded from the state (Roy Chowdhury 2014; Kipgen and Roy Chowdhury 2016). The middle class in India, already ideologically dominant, raised their voice against this perceived corruption of politicians and acquired a hegemonic voice of representation of citizens at large in the public sphere, which called for public assembly and protest.

3.2 The Bangladesh "Context" and the Language Movements in the 1950s

In similar vein, the Shahbag public protest that emerged in Bangladesh and the issues it raised have a historical legacy. Bangladesh has a long history of struggle for democracy, social justice, and secularism. Since it was part of Pakistan (as East Pakistan) in 1947, it has undergone many political and social reforms as well as upheavals.

Bangladeshi national identity is fragmented along linguistic and religious identities; its history is a tussle for hegemony between linguistic and religious groups (Zaman 2016b). In 1947, the Partition of India brought the independent nation of Pakistan into existence but divided into West Pakistan in the west of India and East Pakistan in the east. India sat exactly in the middle of this divided nation. West Pakistanis were Urdu-speaking ethnic Muslims who had historically exercised hegemony and power over the Pakistani "nation." East Pakistanis were largely Muslim and ethnic Bengalis that had a linguistic and cultural dis-affinity with West Pakistanis.

In the 1950s, a language movement sought to establish the Bengali linguistic identity over the hegemony of the Urdu language in East Pakistan (present-day Bangladesh). A painstaking movement for democracy and autonomy from Pakistan followed in the 1960s. It led to a 9-month-long war in 1971 that ended with the formation of independent Bangladesh. In Operation Searchlight, a counterinsurgency operation, the Pakistan army killed a large number of Bangladeshi civilians and raped an equally large number of women.[3] Many paramilitary outfits in East Pakistan helped the Pakistan army in this

[3]It is widely perceived as genocide, where around 3 million people were said to have been killed and more than 2.5 million women were raped (Khan 2015).

purge. These outfits of mainly Islamic fundamentalists and conservative politicians claimed to protect their religious rights and the Islamic Republic of Pakistan from disintegrating (Zaman 2016a).

After the independence of Bangladesh, the Collaborators Order and International Crime Tribunal Act, an ordinance passed in 1973, banned the Al-Badr, Al-Sham, and Razakar, identified their members as enemy collaborators, barred them from entering politics, and called them to trial (D'Costa 2013, p. 39). But this plan was sabotaged by a military coup in 1975 and the assassination of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, the first president of Bangladesh. The military leaders and Islamic fundamentalists usurped power and rehabilitated and reinstated these "collaborators" in national politics for their own benefit in the same year. In 1975, the Razakars were allowed to form a political party named Jamaat-e-Islami. They have been contesting elections since 1986 (Zaman 2016b).

Therefore, people who participated in mass killings of Bangladeshis and in other atrocities against them were not brought into the judicial-legal procedure of crime, punishment, and justice; instead, they were given entry into politics and, hence, power in society. Hardcore Islamic radicals and war collaborators formed parties like Jamaat-e-Islami to Islamise Bangladeshi society and promote a narrow, unitary, orthodox Muslim identity against and above a Bengali language-based Bangladeshi national identity. Parties like the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP, the main opposition party) supported and promoted these religious-radical groups directly or indirectly to gain their support in winning electoral advantage over the ruling AL. This historical discourse of the liberation war and the history of the Bangladeshi nationalism created a fault line and conditions for two antagonistic political mediations, which fought for sociopolitical dominance.

In 1992 Jahanara Imam, the mother of a freedom fighter killed by war criminals, started a group *Ekattorer Ghatak-Dalal Nirmul Committee* (EGDNC),[4] for the first organized protest for the prosecution of war criminals. At a symbolic tribunal arranged in a public park, the committee produced a verdict of death penalty for the chief of the Jamaat-e-Islami, a major Islamist political party on ten specific charges of war crime. The Shahbag protests that emerged in 2013 clearly bore its legacy to this group.

4 Analyzing the "Protest Publics" in India and Bangladesh

In the following subsections, we analyze the emergence, demands, and characteristics of the protest publics in India and Bangladesh, test the theory of protest public, and define them as new actors in the political arena.

[4]Committee to liquidate the killers and collaborators of 1971.

4.1 Models of Collective Action

The India Against Corruption protest of 2011 started with an "event." On 5 April 2011, Anna Hazare, 73, started a public "fast unto death" at Jantar Mantar,[5] New Delhi. Hazare was protesting against the INC-led central coalition[6] government's lack of political will and inability to curb large-scale corruption. The event had a David-versus-Goliath kind of visual imagery—a frail old man takes on corrupt politicians and demands better governance and transparency.

This symbolic and visual imagery, circulating text, and event acted as a "troubling message" (Belyaeva 2012) and summoned a public to protect democracy from the politicians who earlier had the onus and privilege of protecting it. The protest claimed to be "apolitical" and nonpartisan and to speak on behalf of the "common man" who otherwise dislikes corrupt and unworthy politicians.

Pamphlets and placards read "Are you against corruption? Then come and join us." To disseminate the message of corruption and unite the public, the protest used slogans such as *Hindu Muslim Sikh Isai*, *Anna tere char sipahi* (Hindu Muslim Sikh and Christians all are supporting Anna), and *Gali gali me shor hai, desh ke neta chor hai* (in every nook and cranny people say that our political leaders are corrupt). Its demands were reasonable—transparent and accountable governance and distribution of public goods not plagued by leakage or corruption.

As the news of anti-corruption protest quickly spread all over India, people took to the streets. The Internet played a significant role in the public circulation of the "troubling message." To circulate and amplify the call and the protest discourse, protesters used candlelight vigils and a social media campaign that included text messages, Facebook posts, and tweets (using hashtags such as #ISupportAnna, #JanLokpal, #QuitCorruption, #AntiCorruption, and #CleanMyIndia).

The anti-corruption protests explicitly demanded a stringent anti-corruption law— stronger than the Lokpal Bill that the government had already formulated—and that civil society be involved in drafting it (Sitapati 2011, p. 39). Anna and his team of activists drafted an anti-corruption Jan Lokpal Bill (Citizens' Ombudsman Bill). It proposed to merge all existing anti-corruption and vigilance agencies into ombudsman institutions at the central level (Jan Lokpal) and state level (Jan Lokayukt); these would be entirely independent and have administrative and financial freedom as well as the freedom to punish the corrupt (Goswami and Bandyopadhyay 2012, p. 10).

By then, the INC-led coalition government at the center was mired in big corruption scandals, such as the 2G spectrum allocation controversy and the Commonwealth Games fiasco. The government's effort to curb corruption is just eyewash, Hazare said, and outside participation was the only way to ensure a strong anti-corruption law. So, although the protests were aimed specifically against the

[5]Jantar Mantar, a public park in central Delhi, is a space where protests and demonstrations are organized regularly.

[6]United Progressive Alliance (UPA).

INC-led coalition government, it was actually the political ruling class in general that was the target of these protests.

Its demand for transparent governance hit the political elites hard as it questioned the veil of secrecy political corruption hides behind. Implicitly, the protest raised an alternative imaginary of a national political space free of corruption, a promise of national renewal, akin to the Indian movement for independence. The demands it raised in the name of citizenship directly or indirectly make national identity and the state powerful. Its demand for more, better, and transparent governance is not opposed to the idea of the state or Indian nation; rather, it strengthens those ideas and entities (Jayal 2014).

The "public mystique" and poetic worldview that the anti-corruption protest public promoted were around the possibility of a "direct democracy," which was already questioning the quality of democracy and politics in India. The protest framed these demands into democratic aspirations of citizens and called upon the public to form a collective that has nothing in common other than shared citizenship.

Similarly, the Shahbag protests started in Bangladesh with a chain of events. In the 2008 elections, Bangladesh voted the AL government to power. In 2009, the government set up the ICT to try the leaders who had helped the West Pakistan army for war crimes. In 2013, the ICT found Abul Kalam Azad and Abdul Quader Molla (secretary of the right-wing religious organization Jamaat-e-Islami) guilty. It gave Azad capital punishment but Molla life imprisonment, although he was found guilty of killing more than 300 people, as the government did not want to anger the religious clergy by giving Molla capital punishment. The entire country was taken aback, and it felt that the legal procedure of the ICT was politically tainted and the tribunal was not strong or old enough to deliver justice. As Molla came out from the court, he smiled and flashed the crowd a victory sign ("V"). That gesture, aired on television nationwide, triggered public anger and protest.

Political leaders and civil society members expressed little concern over this judgment, but the event acted as a "troubling message" and circulated through virtual networks and the public sphere. People discussed it over social media platforms like Facebook and Twitter and decided to gain closure on deeply traumatic historical events that remain fresh and unresolved in Bangladesh's collective memory (Lewis 2013).

A group of bloggers and online activists known as the Bangladesh Online Activist Network (BOAN) acted as the "conscience collective" who summoned the public to a demonstration at Shahbag, a public square near Dhaka University. On 5 February 2013, around 50–60 people assembled to express their frustration about the verdict along with BOAN activists. By midnight, several thousands gathered, spontaneously and unplanned, and swelled to a million over the next few days. The public constructed a makeshift stage and termed it as *Gonojagoron Moncho* (Stage of Public Awakening). To mark the culmination of demands of generations against war criminals and the use of politics in religion, the public renamed the square *Projonmo Chattar* (Generation Square).

The Internet and social media played an integral role in the Shahbag protests. It was cyber warfare, in which many educated Bangladeshi residents and nonresidents

participated actively (Fuchs 2012). The supporters used the hashtags #Shahbag and #JoyBangla and created a Facebook page called *Shahbag Cyber Juddho* (Shahbag Cyberwar) (Arefin 2014). They reclaimed the Bengali linguistic identity in the spirit of the liberation war of 1971 and gave a call to embrace it through slogans such as *Ami Ke*, *Tumi Ke Bangali*, *Bangali* (Who are you? Who am I? Bengali, Bengali). They expressed their thoughts through blogs such as *Muktomona*, *AmarBlog*, and *Somewherein and Sachalayatan* (Sabur 2013, p. 7).

The Shahbag protesters delivered a six-point list of demands to the government on 21 February 2013 (*Bhasha Dibas* or International Mother Language Day). The central demands were that the government should ban the Jamaat-Shibir (Jamaat-e-Islami, its youth-wing Bangladeshi Islami Chhatra Shibir, and Hefazat-e-Islam), block their funding, and punish the 1971 war criminals that the Jamaat-Shibir was protecting. They also demanded that the government make the ICT a permanent, legal institution and check all terrorist activity to ensure safety for all Bangladeshi citizens. The target authority, apparently the AL-ruled central government of Bangladesh accused of treating war criminals leniently, was actually diffuse.

The "public mystique" they created and the poetic message that Shahbag delivered implicitly and explicitly were of an alternative world, where justice can be delivered in a perfect democratic setup and religion can be (and should be) separated from politics.

These demands by the Shahbag protesters threatened the radical-religious section of society and provoked it to respond. They labeled Shahbag protesters *nastik* (atheist) and "enemies of Islam"; this acted as a "troubling message" for the radical public. They raised counter-demands: ban the Shahbag protests, give the main activists the death sentence, implement Sharia law, and tighten anti-blasphemy laws.

They eventually gained significant power and organized a counter-protest by a critical mass of the public at Shapla Chottor, another public square, and perpetrated violence. The Shahbag protesters tried their best to stand against this violence and argue that they were believers, not atheists; besides, Islam had no connection at all to the protests; and all they opposed was terrorism and the use of religion in politics. But their arguments were not heeded. Violence spread widely and engulfed Bangladesh in a few days, and unidentified groups of fundamentalist youths hacked a number of Shahbag bloggers to death (Khan 2015).

The opposition also took to cyber warfare and used online propaganda with equal force. They set up blogs and used Twitter hashtags such as *#SonarBangla*, *#BasherKella*, and #SaveBangladesh (Sabur 2013). These groups altered images digitally and used these to glorify their leaders and clergy and spread rumors against the Shahbag protesters to malign them. The radical protesters attacked police stations, political activists, and religious minority communities and their property.

The opposition's main target was Shahbag protesters and the state government, who they believed were being pressurized by the protesters.

4.2 Level of Institutionalization and Political Opportunity

In both India and Bangladesh, the organizational structure of the protest public was loose, as is typical of protest public.

Anti-corruption activists spread the "call" in Delhi, and social media users, as well as the national electronic and print media, helped to spread the message to other metros and smaller cities. The "troubling message" roused people in other Indian metros (such as Mumbai) and smaller cities (such as Shillong). Though the public emerged in Delhi was somewhat mediated by a core leadership that tried to give protesters a direction, plan, and program, the public that emerged in cities outside Delhi was fully self-organized, emergent, autonomous, and capable of making independent decisions without a strong, centralized leadership. They took to the streets and participated in marches, demonstrations, rallies, and candlelight vigils (Goswami and Bandyopadhyay 2012, p. 10).

The protests in 2011 began on 5 April and lasted until the end of June in various phases and places in India. In solidarity, various CSOs participated in these protests, but as minor players at best—not as central actors. However, these organizations and their youths, along with Hindu religious organizations such as Baba Ramdev's trust, provided the protesters in Delhi food, shelter, and necessary logistical support.

However, these mobilizations were not led by civil society and were not social movements either. Many political parties wanted to mediate the protest in a certain direction by sharing the stage with the protesters, but they refused because of their nonpartisan stance.

A "political opportunity" (McAdam et al. 2001) was available to the anti-corruption protesters; on the one hand, the INC-led coalition faced charges of severe corruption, and on the other hand, the capacity of the coalition government to resist any kind of opposition was low.

Similarly, at Shahbag, the protests were spontaneous and emerged through a secular and conscientious "summons" with little political mediation. People gathered in an open space and the assembly grew in size every day. They stayed there continuously for more than 3 weeks, and as the government took up their demands, the protesters petered out.

Student organizations from various universities supplied logistics and supported the protesters. The bloggers who placed the call over the Internet provided leadership. People brought food from their home and for their fellow protesters. The Shahbag was nonpartisan to any political party or even religious organizations.

On the other hand, the religious conservative public that emerged against the Shahbag protests did not organize spontaneously; it was engineered primarily and carefully through politically and religiously motivated mediation to perpetrate violence against Shahbag protesters and religious minorities and create an environment of terror in Bangladesh. The protests at Shapla Chottor were mediated by the Hefazat-e-Islam and supported by Jamaat-Shibir and the BNP. These organizations managed to organize a protest composed mainly of religious and rural folk trained in particular radical ideologies and provided these groups all logistical support. These

groups were more organized than the Shahbag protesters, though the protest lasted for about 3 days. The violence, however, continued sporadically in various places.

"Political opportunity" (McAdam et al. 2001) was available also to Shahbag protesters, who emerged when the AL government was already working with the ICT. The values of Shahbag protesters align with the core values of the AL, which bears the legacy of secular Bengali progressive nationalism and of the Bangladesh liberation war of 1971. The already powerful opposition (who was not the ruling regime) was looking for an opportunity to fan violence and religious polarization of public to gain a vote bank. The capacity of the AL-led Bangladeshi regime to control mass mobilization and violence was low anyway.

4.3 Public Self-Representation and Identity

The anti-corruption protest had a strong moral overtone. Hazare claimed to draw his legacy from the anti-colonial struggle led by Mahatma Gandhi and used this high moral ground to continue that fight against corrupt political parties and their leaders (Sengupta 2012). Hazare, an avid Gandhian, locates himself in the space that connects social reform and political emancipation, deploys Gandhian methods and morals, and emphasizes personal probity (Sitapati 2011, p. 42).[7] He draws upon techniques such as *satyagraha* (seeking truth).[8]

Hazare, the main activist, also deployed some symbols closer to the Hindu religion and worldview. While Hazare fasted, a portrait of Mother India (*Bharat Mata*), a largely Hindu religious icon and symbol of sacredness and piety, and also used during the Indian independence struggle, was displayed on the wall behind him. The national flag of India was unfurled at various corners; it replaced sectarian party flags and signified the unity of the public—but it did not signify nationalism as we understand it (Menon and Nigam 2011, p. 18).

However, leaders such as Hazare alone cannot explain this public protest. Before 2011, Hazare was a regional figure on the Maharashtra activist circuit. Yet, when the fast began, within a few days, the public grew from hundreds to millions—across India (Jenkins 2014, p. 42). The troubling message and the call to form a public through the discourse generated by mass media and social media certainly had greater power than Hazare's figure. Hazare became an "empty signifier" (Laclau 1996, p. 44) or a common reference point and a symbol—itself devoid of meaning—that enabled heterogeneous publics and their disparate narratives to interact and unite to form an identity of the public. Even antagonistic groups rallied

[7]Yet, this mobilization was not based entirely on Gandhian ideals (Sitapati 2011, p. 42; Banerjee 2011, p. 14).

[8]Mahatma Gandhi had used these successfully as instruments of non-violent but militant civil disobedience against the British; now, using this technique against a democratically elected government is considered void and unconstitutional (Chakrabarty 2005).

around this empty signifier in the hope of a "national renewal" and awakening (Menon and Nigam 2011, p. 17).

Initially, the middle class led the anti-corruption protest and participated in it, but the government's rejection of some of Team Anna's proposals infuriated common people and spurred them to participate.[9] There were certain mediations in the protests, and conflicting opinions about their demographic composition (Roy 2016, p. 362; Nigam 2011), but it was indeed a manifestation of nationwide public anger. The protests mobilized urban and rural upper- and lower-middle classes in and around Delhi, the catering servicemen (dabbawalas) of Mumbai, farmers in Haryana and Punjab, rickshaw pullers, auto-rickshaw drivers, vendors, students, and the youth (Banerjee 2011, p. 12). It captured the imagination of nonresident Indians, who extended their support and solidarity mainly through social media.

The Shahbag protesters were constituted of the secular, progressive, and democratic public. Despite several military and reactionary interventions over the past four decades, a sizable part of the population is still committed to the principles of socialism, secularism, and democracy—on which independent Bangladesh was established in 1971 after waging a liberation war against Pakistan—and supported the Shahbag protests. This public supports the AL and the Bangladesh liberation war and its legacy. They are proud of the Bengali language and their Bangladeshi nationalist identity. They are based mostly in urban areas and received secular education (in Bengali and English).

These protests, thus, brought out an innate Bengali cultural value set and moral stance being suppressed by territorial propaganda and religious orthodoxy. Activists at the forefront of this protest, such as Imran Sarkar, describe these protests as cultural (not political); he meant that these protests were nonpartisan, nonreligious, and outside and above narrow electoral political interests and uphold the Bengali-speaking Bangladeshi identity (Majumdar 2013). Khan (2015) argues that the emergence of a "protest public" at Shahbag was made possible by the existing real-world Bengali history of sociality and culture (and public sphere) of *adda*, or discussion and debate on political issues (like the *salon* in Revolutionary France), which online activists transposed to the virtual world. This combination of virtual and public space shaped each other and made Shahbag possible.

On the other hand, the radical public that emerged in reaction to the Shahbag protests promotes a religious nationalism based on a radical Islamic identity. They are conservatives who think that the Bangladesh liberation war was a mistake and regret the severance of their ties with Pakistan. These radical-religious conservatives live mainly in rural areas, received religious education in Urdu at madrasas from groups like Hefazat-e-Islam, and consider themselves first as Muslim and member of the global Islamic public and then as Bangladeshi and Bengali.

[9]Some civil society groups and the Left accused the group of being middle class and maintained an ideological distance. Activists and scholars such as Menon and Nigam (2011, p. 18) criticized the Left strongly for failing to see a movement pregnant with possibilities and for ignoring it.

The Shahbag protesters termed this opposition "Razakar" (a private militia, which participated in the genocide of Bangladeshis) and proclaimed their own protests (and identity) as the secular and socialist "soul" of the nation. In turn, the opposition termed the Shahbag activists "atheists" and "enemies of Islam."

4.4 Brief Discussion on Outcome

Both these movements had their share of success and failure. We will touch upon that very briefly.

The Indian state succumbed to the pressure and passed—after making some amendments to the Bill and much parliamentary debate—the anti-corruption Lokpal and Lokayukt Act in 2013. It came into force from 16 January 2014. This act was different from Team Anna's Jan Lokpal Bill but was still a major achievement.

However, the protests had their own terms of failure. Firstly, it largely remained centered around the charismatic figure of Anna (as a kind of personality cult). Secondly, the public that emerged split after the protest ended, in 2012, over differences in politics and ideology. One group formed the AAP, a political party that won the Delhi state elections. Hazare formed his own Janatanra Morcha (Protesters for Democracy). Thus, a nonpartisan protest that found "corrupt" political parties and politics abhorrent ended up being a part of the political system. It was argued that they wanted to change the system from within. Hazare retained his nonpartisan stance.

The Shahbag protest can also be considered partially successful. The prosecution against Quader Molla found the sentence of lifetime imprisonment too light and appealed to the Supreme Court; it revised the sentence to the death penalty. Molla was hanged on 12 December 2013 (Ahmed and Das 2013). Eight other criminals were given capital punishment; of them, six have already been hanged. Many others absconded and are undergoing trial in absentia.

However, the protest was also a failure—a strong, religiously orthodox public emerged against the Shahbag protesters and split the Bangladeshi national public space into two deeply antagonistic groups. This division created a deep fissure within Bangladeshi political and civic life that is difficult to breach. It is equally difficult to say whether such divisions within two publics in society would benefit democracy or governance in any way. Terrorist attacks, mob rule, and attacks against religious minorities have risen recently in Bangladesh. These will profoundly affect the shaping of democratic institutions and practices.

5 Conclusions

This chapter presents two cases of the emergence of protest publics in South Asia—the anti-corruption protests of 2011 in India and the Shahbag protests of 2013 in Bangladesh—and maps their characteristics.

There are several similarities. Both cases show the characteristics of the emergence of protest publics. Both these "protest publics" have features in common with the Arab Spring, which swept the Middle East and North Africa in 2010. Both were autonomous and self-organized. Their demands had to do with the democratization of state and society. And they held a poetic message—it is possible to create a world in which sociopolitical justice can be delivered without fear of the powerful.

Like in the Arab Spring, they spontaneously claimed public spaces for demonstrations and protests. They expanded the limits of parliamentary democracy such that citizens can now bring difference, dissent, and antagonism to the streets and directly call upon political actors for deliberation and transformation.

In both cases, the endogenous history of nation and nationalism played a significant role in the nature of the publics that emerged and the ultimate goal they achieved. In both cases, the appeal was around "nationalism" and "nation building," and the limited imaginaries played around demands for a democratic and just "nation state," not exactly for a cosmopolitan and global society.

There were significant differences also. The "protest public" that emerged in response to a call to protect India from corrupt politicians was conceptually positioned somewhere between "audience public" and "agentic public." We see initially the emergence of an "audience public" that took to the streets with an anti-corruption agenda predefined and somewhat mediated by a group of activists. Hazare became the central icon of the protest, which eventually led a spontaneous and self-organized "agentic public" to emerge India-wide. The demands and strategies of this mobilization were still centralized. Public activism, online and offline, was not completely autonomous. The anti-corruption protest remained, to some extent, a mobilization centered on a personality cult, despite the emergence of an "agentic public" later. The protest public brought about "institutional change"—a law was enacted—but ultimately the protests petered out. The protest public split into two; one group, which initially despised national electoral politics unequivocally, became partisan to it.

The trajectory of Shahbag protests was considerably different. Given the sociopolitical fault line in Bangladesh, eventually, two different kinds of publics emerged with the different "troubling message" that was brought forward by the clash between Shahbag protesters and its opponents. From the beginning, Shahbag dealt with an issue more sensitive and controversial than corruption and intricately related with the question of identity, nationalism, and the Bangladeshi nation, which is fragmented between linguistic and religious nationalist forces. When online activists "summoned" a public to punish war criminals, they deployed the historical memory of the Bangladesh liberation war—fought largely on the basis of a secular, progressive, socialist, and linguistic ideology.

The Shahbag protests occurred at the juncture of a slow but steady radical Islamisation of Bangladesh. Their summons and the protest constituted a direct and timely attack on the growing Islamic orthodoxy vis-à-vis the selective amnesia of war atrocities. But, for the same reason, the Shahbag protests became vulnerable to violence and attack from Islamic radicals.

In response to the protests and the secular and progressive autonomous and self-organized "agentic public" that emerged, radical forces started their own political mediation, summons, and mobilizations to create a religious "audience public" organized around radical agendas to pit against the secular forces. The emergence of two antagonistic publics divided the national popular identity in Bangladesh and polarized it. The state did not commit much violence, but it did not control it either—choosing instead to watch the conflict as a bystander. The Shahbag protest was successful—the state met their demand of giving war criminals capital punishment and made an "institutional change" to the ICT—but the division within the national public led to violence that engulfed society and made citizens' life and democracy in Bangladesh even more vulnerable than it was.

Funding The article was prepared within the framework of the Basic Research Program at the National Research University Higher School of Economics (HSE) and supported within the framework of a subsidy by the Russian Academic Excellence Project "5–100."

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The Grammar of Protest Publics in Skopje, Macedonia, May 2015



Rastko Antić

Public spaces are susceptible to numerous forms of signification. This is where market and cultural exchanges happen and where the international image of a city is represented. It is also the stage of news, history, and—sometimes—demonstrations. In a report on a trend of Western nations violating the right to use public space for democratic assembly, Richard Seymour concludes: "The reorganisation of states today in an authoritarian direction is part of a longer-term project to contain democracy while retaining a minimum of democratic legitimacy. That is what the anti-protest laws are about" (Seymour 2013). It is the reverse of how media is used to talking about protests, which are more typically seen in the heroic light of freeing people from authoritarianism (Lee 2014). The changing state attitudes to demonstration and how protesting publics have adapted need to be explored further. This belongs to the larger problem of delegitimized democracy.

If in consolidated democracies the right to demonstrations are already being threatened, as Seymour says, what is the situation in a hybrid regime? A hybrid regime is defined as containing a degree of political competition that is rendered unfair by corruption in state institutions and organization (Robertson 2011, p. 6). Hybrid regimes have become a greater part of the global public imagination as media have followed the political uprootings incited by the Arab Spring, Maidan Square, and beyond. Critical thinkers from established democracies are also starting to acknowledge the similarities between their political systems and hybrid regimes as democracies are being "contained". The linear nature of democratization processes is challenged. "Frictions between global capitalism, the state system and an emerging international civil society are framing the conflicts of the twenty-first century", claims Majid Tehranian (2002, p. 3). The role of states under global competition is committed to a triple function: national security, economic growth, and corporate and social welfare (Ibid. pp. 5–6). These goals imply a positive not a negative state, re-regulation instead of deregulation

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N. Belyaeva et al. (eds.), *Protest Publics*, Societies and Political Orders in Transition,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5_5

(Isin 2000, p. 155).[1] This places the state at the service of private enterprise—which is unelected ruling bodies without limited terms of public service (Tehranian 2002, p. 23).

Using theories of contentious publics and counterconduct, the first part of this chapter will examine the forms of contestation in the modern nation state to describe the global atmosphere at the time that upwards of 1000 people assembled spontaneously in Skopje to demonstrate against state corruption. As a young hybrid regime, the former Yugoslav Republic of Macedonia[2] too had formally democratic political institutions which contested for legitimacy under authoritarian principles. Levitsky and Way describe that in similar competitive authoritarianism regimes which have extensive ties to the West—particularly the Americas and Central Europe—external pressure was usually enough to democratize institutions even under unfavourable domestic conditions (2010, p. 24). Macedonia is cited by them as the only competitive authoritarian country which had a proximity to the West but failed to democratize; ethnic conflicts were cited as the reason that autocrats could not consolidate their power (Ibid. p. 66). Indeed, a surefire method of deflecting from social and political problems in the Balkan region at large has been to reinstate ethnic division—this is an ongoing barrier for the region (Howard 2012, pp. 155–169).

In the early stages of demonstration, however, the public did not allow itself to be manipulated into panic and division along ethnic lines. Macedonian and Albanian flags were continuously raised side by side at the demonstrations, alongside flags of minorities in the May 2015 #protestiram protests in Skopje; all movement demands and documents were published in at least the two major languages and shared by activists from all nationality groups on the territory. To "remain calm while [politicians] play dirty games" was the prime protest response against the government (Kjuka 2015). The second part of this essay will describe in detail three critical events at the start of the protests: (1) 5 May 2015, when a spontaneous rally broke out against Prime Minister Gruevski in reaction to leaked information about the police murder of a young man; (2) 9 May, when 18 people were killed and 37 wounded in Kumanovo during a shoot-out between former liberation fighters and the police; and (3) 17 May, which marks the first day of the ongoing demonstrations in front of the government office organized by the opposition. The case study is built on the grounds of empirical, academic, and media research.

The ways in which this movement morphed and manifested from those early stages is interesting. Without a strong protest tradition to call on, the diversity of the expressions of discontent that could be seen on the streets of Skopje was impressive.

[1]Engin F. Isin's full quote is: "Despite all the rhetoric of the reduction of government and the rollback of the state, advanced liberalism has not abandoned its will to govern but merely shifted its focus and, more importantly, rationalized some old techniques as well as invented some new techniques of government. Therefore the state in liberal democracies is perhaps stronger and more effective in more sectors than it was in the 1970s. And yet the image that persists is the decline of the state, if not its death".

[2]Henceforth "Macedonia". By using the shorthand of the country's full title, I do not intend to make a value statement about the name dispute the country was having with Greece until June 2018. The country is now known as the Republic of Northern Macedonia.

The third section of this chapter has these in mind as we discuss the potential of misconduct to incite political awareness and change. Using the metaphor of grammar, I will show how the most effective modes of opposition were the ones that broke away from or played with the familiar forms of conduct in society and communication. A prime example of this is Sharenata Revolucija, a later iteration of the #protestiram movement, which used paintballs—rather than violence—to reclaim the city and disrespect the undemocratic changes that were forced onto it by means of the urban renewal project Skopje 2014.

It was more than the cityscape that they were trying to renew; a fully-fledged revision of local history was underway to solidify the country's claim over Macedonian identity which has long been in question by Greece. Twenty-eight buildings have been built as part of Skopje 2014, including an Orthodox Church—also 8 parking lots, 34 monuments, 39 sculptures, 2 fountains, 4 bridges, 5 squares, and 6 façades, among other details (Prizma 2015). It is a prime example of the corruption of the ruling party at the time VMRO-DPMNE. Critics denounce the project for a lack of transparency or debate (Spaskovska 2014, p. 151), poorly delegated and corrupt officials (Ibid. p. 24), the rule of law being violated (Chausidis 2013, p. 98), authors not approving changes to the façades of their buildings (Spaskovska 2014), an evidently rigged competition to author the project (Muhić 2014, p. 141; Kubiena 2012, p. 87), and not to mention the questionable legitimacy of the government itself (Chausidis 2013, p. 98)—which was the point raised in common among the protestors of 2015 from 5 May onwards. It was only a matter of time before this environment mobilized protesting publics in Macedonia.

1 A Place for Counterconduct in Nation State History

The manner of living—one's occupations, ventures, and habits—has almost always been under scrutiny. Quite simply, every*one* cannot live any*how*. Community regulates the behaviour of its members: that is the question of government (Isin 2000, p. 149).[3] National governments were not the first to enforce mass control of conduct. It was earlier practised by religion and landed gentry (Federici 2013, p. 34). From the sixteenth century in Western Europe, there was a turn from following the doctrines of faith to the laws of state and bureau of police (Foucault 2007, p. 208). The police are agents for managing conduct of peoples once the means of conduct have been decided by the governing body. It has been argued that the role of the police is to enforce good conduct, blurring the boundaries of conduct of (other) peoples and conduct of self (Ibid. p. 386). Since "good" conduct is defined by what is

[3]The use of the word government in theory, as it has been inspired by Foucault, might be summarized, so "any authorities and agencies, employing a variety of techniques and forms of knowledge, which seeks to shape conduct by working through the desires, aspirations, interests, and beliefs of both those who govern and those who are governed".

useful to the nation state, a direct correlation between a state's strength and an individual's happiness is created (Villa 1992, p. 714).[4] In lieu of a social contract, an individual's freedom is bought by submission to service to the state.

The model of the nation state developed at this time is the one that was, and continues to be, exported or superficially imposed on other peoples. States wanting to become or remain competitive—or simply wanting to engage in the exchange of consumer goods, technology, communication, and knowledge—must be open and inclusive, which means engaging with other states and international organizations cooperatively. In order to do so, state values have tended to appropriate "universal" values[5] which have greatly homogenized the global political landscape in a short time but also formed important linkages between states (Debord 1970, p. 93). At the time of the demonstrations, Macedonia finds itself in this situation of a young nation state, which influences local political choices. The present-day region of Macedonia has been extremely vulnerable in the past to shifting rulers; "throughout history, everyone tore down and re-built and not for their own sakes nor for the welfare of citizens, but as a symbol of their dominance over this city and this part of the Balkans: Romans, Byzantines, Ottomans, Serbs, Bulgarians, communists, Yugoslavs" (Chausidis 2013, p. 140). Macedonia became a sovereign state under the nation state model for the first time in 1991.

It isn't only states in relation to each other that claim sovereignty. The people were sovereign too, as publics always are, according to the position of Warner in *Publics and Counterpublics* (2002, p. 51). Warner is concerned with how people engage with texts in the essay; he writes "It is not texts themselves that create publics, but the concatenation of texts through time. Only when a previously existing discourse can be supposed, and a responding discourse be postulated, can a text address a public" (p. 62). Through the concatenation of texts, then, a normative discourse for that public is developed and reasserted by continued use. Like every text, every public possesses not only its own ideology but also its own rhetoric which allows "participants in its discourse to understand themselves as directly and actively belonging to a social entity" (p. 75). Eventually, the social entity can even grow to make claims on the state.

If we take into account state projects of creating national publics—as any mass conduct of peoples must be to some degree—the sovereignty of its members is threatened as the gap between the ideology and rhetoric of that public and the state decreases. The circulation of critical discourse is essential to any democratic system. In a smooth-functioning state, critical discourse is usually practised by way of democratic elections and an active civil society. However, this is often not so; what happens when the discursive circulation of the dominant public is state-

[4]Dana R. Villa points out that this contract, which supposedly intends for the preservation of rights, is a technology for mystifying the coercion into self-surveillance and lack of free will.

[5]Nominatively "universal" but, in actual fact, corresponding to the principles of the hegemonic states. These are capitalist and neoliberal values which favour North America, Western Europe, and East Asia.

controlled and not something that a majority can or chooses to actually identify with? Warner's account doesn't broach this question, but I will tackle it in this chapter. The crucial binary of Warner's essay is between dominant publics and counterpublics. Not belonging to the dominant public is a favourable basis for becoming a political, thinking being. By acting *other*wise, the "counterconducter" develops a positive relation to being, i.e. has an active role in one's choices. Similarly, Warner had said that "[f]riction against the dominant public forces the poetic-expressive character of counterpublic discourse to become salient to consciousness" (Ibid. 86).

People are brought into contentious politics by poor protection of rights and recognizing that you yourself are accountable for the protection of those rights, not the state. Post-communist states struggle with this particularly as they are constructed around a dependency model with citizens (Mungiu-Pippidi 2010). Yugoslavia, although an exception on many accounts, was not different here. But without a tradition of counterpublics, which are outlawed in single party systems, it is difficult to imagine a situation where the people do stand up for their rights in a meaningful way. "No less than in the case of religious rituals or civil celebrations, contentious politics is not born in organizers' heads but is culturally inscribed and socially communicated" (Tarrow 1998, p. 20). In other words, the means of contention are always a part of the fabric of a society—some forms of rebellion are naturalized in specific contexts, while no counterconduct whatsoever is naturalized in others. Inherited cultural understandings are only part of the story; movements must compete with the public media, which transmit messages that are at least as influential as cultural tradition (Ibid. p. 22). States have superior means to movements of influencing meaning, especially in hybrid regimes.

Sidney Tarrow and Charles Tilly form the crux of the school of contentious politics and social movements. Contentious politics fits the picture of counterpublics Warner describes. Tilly and Tarrow believe that "[d]emocracies channel contention. They do so by facilitating claims that follow the forms of electoral politics and legislative representation, tolerating claims that fall within the rules of association, assembly, and speech, but vigorously repressing claims that take place outside the standard repertoire" (2009, p. 11). As nation states expanded their mission of controlling the conduct of society, they became the direct targets of contention—no longer private and local actors (such as the bourgeoisie) or the town parishes (Tarrow 1998, p. 63). This is called centralizing the targets of collective action. It gives opportunity for contention movements to combine, negotiate demands between themselves, and grow in their own right.

Hardt and Negri lead the academic vocation that revolution is the only way for multitudes to assert their will onto a democracy (devise democracy), but revolution needs to be reinvented for the new globalized era. "The primary material of counterpower is the flesh, the common living substance in which the corporeal and the intellectual coincide and are indistinguishable", they claim (2003, p. 1). Importance isn't in individuality, rather in the collective occupation of physical space.[6]

[6]It is a reverse invention of Arendt's bare life.

The individual loses her individuality to become a part of something greater and becomes, in the same stroke, political. Becoming is enjoyment. Tilly and Tarrow take a different approach that resembles closely Warner's theory of creating publics through texts. "Because they are creating a collective actor, movements do an enormous amount of identity building through their interaction", where interaction occurs internally between members of that public and externally between members and significant third parties—that is to say, sympathizer, institutions, and opponents (Tarrow and Tilly 2009, p. 8). In the process of identity building, the ideology of the collective and its rhetoric are negotiated and mitigated in order to persuade sympathizers to become members, get institutions on board, and neutralize opponents.

For an event to become a movement, it needs to create its own public; as Warner has shown, a continuous discourse is needed for this, i.e. time. "A campaign is a sustained, organized public effort making collective claims on targeted authorities. Unlike a one-time petition, declaration, or mass meeting, a campaign extends beyond any single event—although social movements often include petitions, declarations, and mass meetings" (Warner 2002, p. 7). While social movements have been a part of the nation-building process, events of contention no longer enjoy state support. Nation-building, where it is necessary, is a top-down project of the state. The case of Macedonia is a clear illustration: a mythology around a national identity has been institutionally enforced—without public input—while events of contention have been increasingly subdued.

2 The First Days of the Protests

2.1 5 May

A bomb in the Macedonian political context isn't the same as elsewhere: it is the term locals and media use to describe the regularly leaked recordings on YouTube of government officials who were being wiretapped along with over 20,000 citizens. The leaks revealed the government's grip on the judicial system (Marušić 2015),[7] electoral fraud, widespread corruption, and political intimidation on police and private business owners (Petrushev 2015). The term "bomb" was introduced by opposition leader, Zoran Zaev, to refer to the first released recordings on 9 February 2015—their content was of conversations from leaders of opposition parties as proof of surveillance as well as from ministers belonging to the ruling party VMRO-DPMNE. For the threat, Zaev was announced a traitor in a public address on 31 January 2015 by Prime Minister Nikola Gruevski (Brif 2015). Although the several dozen bombs preceding 5 May were by no means ignored by the public, a spark was hit by the particular revelation on this day: the 2011 death of Martin

[7]This source cites Zaev as saying "I do not recognize the judiciary as an independent authority[. . .] It is under the complete control of Nikola Gruevski".

Neskovski was confirmed to have been a police cover-up, as protestors gathering immediately after the beating demanded to hear then (Marušić 2015). A tradition of "Stop Police Brutality" demonstrations had already existed; 7 June 2011 and 5 May protests belonged to this tradition of demonstrations, which had always begun 18 h. With Zaev's bomb confirming the details, social media sites were being inundated with suggestions to protest again at 18 h.

Around 1000 people showed up in front of the government building for a peaceful demonstration as the movement #protestiram; they were chanting the familiar slogans of their "Stop Police Brutality". Skopjans had a counterpublic tradition to call upon, however young. Rather than thinking about other international movements, such as Maidan, it felt more like a local matter at a moment of urgency. Activists describe the importance of protests that took place over a 5-year period in Skopje and the coming together of various leftist groups and ethnicities that don't normally march side by side. Some demonstrators were holding signs reading "Together we're more powerful". The various ideological positions were united out of necessity, and the debating was saved for later. What the protests allowed for was their close contact again and a reinvigoration of dialogue which would be continued in the citizens plena in the next days. Plena are a part of the counterpublic tradition of Macedonia; starting in October 2014, student plena were a regular occurrence initiated to discuss alternatives to the proposed state exam that they saw as ineffective. Plena were held regularly and on democratic principles between 200 and 400 participants (Sakalis and Stefanovski 2015).

One interviewee recounts the first impression on joining the 5 May protest as delight at seeing so many people present, gathered not just because of Neskovski's murder or police brutality but also against other oppressive policies. The second impression was of having walked into a party; there was empathy and solidarity everywhere and even hope.[8] Another activist said that it felt like a liberation of public space after it had been abducted by the construction barricades of Skopje 2014. All activists interviewed confirm this was a spontaneous protest—some interviewees held the position that it was embarrassing that it took 4 months of bombs for the people of Macedonia to mobilize to take action. It was a sign of the deinstrumentalized civil society in the country and region at large.

In a bid to defuse police aggression while at the same time dramatizing their peaceful intentions, protesters had flowers at the ready all along the cordon. Elsewhere, protesters were posing as sacrifices for the police in homage to Neskovski. Famously, Jasmina Golubovska used the reflection of a guard's shield to put on lipstick and kissing the shield in the same vein of banalizing the police (Elgot 2015). But it was not a passive protest. A low fence around the government building had to be jumped to reach the cordon in the first place. Interviewees confirmed they were headed for the entrance but also that there was no particular end in sight for that

[8]The same source confirms that the communal feeling continued when police started to openly attack the crowd. People were helping one another to escape. The next day, social media were used to redistribute lost or abandoned items in the scurry to run away.

target. Provocateurs had infiltrated the protest, throwing objects at the police.[9] The police attempted to intimidate protesters by bringing in armoured vehicles and water cannons.

Failing to disperse the crowd, they resorted to excessive use of force indiscriminately on peaceful protesters and more aggressive ones alike (Protestiram home page 2015). People were being chased down the streets for some kilometres from the site. The Helsinki Committee report that police even entered a library, Brakja Miladinovci, where they beat any youth there—some studying from schoolbooks—on the pretext that there were demonstrators using the library as a refuge (Helsinki Committee 2015).

2.2 9 May

Evidence surrounding the Kumanovo clashes of this day is dubious. The government's official statements are that "the gunmen [were] former rebel commanders from neighboring Kosovo, which broke from Serbia in war in 1999 and inspired an ethnic Albanian insurgency in Macedonia two years later" [i.e. Kosovo Liberation Army] (Robinson and Bytyci 2015) and that both NATO and the EU had been informed by President Gjorge Ivanov earlier in the year but failed to act (Tanjug 2015). It is crucial that the attacks, as portrayed in the official rhetoric, are put into a historical context. The EU rapporteur on Macedonia, Ivo Vajgl, is also noted as suspecting "Islamic militants" (MacDowell 2015). The unofficial version of events is that this was a government plot (Tumanovska and Coalson 2015)—"a stunt by Gruevski to cover up Zaev's revelations", as one of the many who had to flee their Diva neighbourhood homes put it. Indeed, Kumanovo locals have been the mouthpiece of the sceptical perspective, adding they had noticed neither suspicious behaviour nor a terrorist presence leading up to the events (Sim 2015). The clashes themselves were called a Bollywood production (Deralla 2015) or Shizniland (Velichkovikj 2014).

The second version of events was picked up by protesters in Skopje who developed the many political conveniences of these clashes, such as the incitement of police sympathy and ethnic division or as obdurate fear tactics. The former director of security services, Goran Mitevski, develops these points further from an insider's perspective, adding that the incompetence of the defence signals contradictory interests considering their claims of having been aware of the presence of terrorist action there (A1 2015). Three resignations resulted on 12 May from this and the political upheaval: the Minister of Interior Gordana Jankuloska, Minister of

[9]Provocateurs were recognized by their lack of unity with the group, not calling out any of the slogans, and by their near immediate disappearance after the initiation of violence, interviews revealed. It is not known who they worked for, but their purpose was clear: to depict the mass as savage and uncivil. Between protesters, however, there were no doubts—given the small community, it is very difficult to penetrate.

Transport and Communications Mile Janakieski, and Director of the Security and Counterintelligence Agency Sasho Mijalkov (Protestiram home page 2015).

Determining which version is accurate is not crucial to this study, nor would it be possible; it is adequate to describe the effect it had on the Skopje demonstrations 40 km south-west. Here, I will not treat the clashes as a government plot even though I recognize it as a possible state technology of suppression. The state's discourse and further responses—which are treated in the analysis—are revealing unto themselves that these were fortuitous incidents for them, politically speaking, regardless of the government's role in their unfolding. Nevertheless, the study assumes that, when discussing space, the everyday inhabitants will have superior knowledge to that presented in government statements. Inhabitants are also the ones who will be feeling the effects in their immediate space, firstly by having to flee it. At least eight homes are not repairable (Robinson and Bytyci 2015).

Eighteen people were killed in the Kumanovo clashes, eight of whom were police officers, while thirty people were arrested with charges of terrorism. The nationalities of the arrested were published immediately by the Macedonian Information Agency. The dead and 37 wounded police officers were esteemed by Gruevski for "highly professional, patriotic and heroic action and neutraliz[ing] terrorists who wanted to destabilize Macedonia" (Kristina 2015); 2 days of mourning was announced. Protests in front of the government building in Skopje continued but also made gestures to honour the dead with candles, silence, and more flowers. The police was also requested to not follow anti-constitutional commands in a bid to be treated by protesters as people rather than institutional actors (Deralla 2015). One interviewee identifies these events as having brought about changes in the rhetoric of the demonstration, abandoning the stop police brutality slogans and negotiating direct demands in citizens' plena (Protestiram home page 2015). The three demands settled on 10 May were (1) immediate resignation and accountability of the entire government; (2) urgent release of all activists detained from 5 May onwards; and (3) the forming of a government for the democratization of public institutions (Ibid.). These demands, as with all other #protestiram documents, were published in Macedonian and Albanian; Macedonian and Albanian flags were continuously raised side by side at the demonstrations, alongside flags of minorities. To "remain calm while [politicians] play dirty games" was the prime protest response against the government (Kjuka 2015).

2.3 17 May

By the time Zaev announced the 17 May protests that would continue until an agreement[10] was reached began, the #protestiram movement had already been on the

[10]An agreement was reached on 15 July 2015 which, although not satisfying to demonstrators because it gave VMRO-DPMNE too much power in the agreed elections the following year, still left hope for democratizing the hybrid regime of Macedonia.

ground for 12 days, defined its demands, and created a unique identity. #protestiram demonstrations, not being permitted before the government building, were held near to it just outside the police cordon (Protestiram home page 2015). An open plenum—which incorporated members of the student plena—was held on 15 May to discuss what association they should have with the opposition's protest. The opposition was not so secretly making a coup, after all. The next day, #protestiram sent out a call for all to join the 17 May demonstrations "as a reminder of the long-term and collaborative battle of all citizens" (Ibid.); it was not agreed whether SDSM is the right party to form a government for the democratization of public institutions, but at least they were agreed on the fate of VMRO-DPMNE. "The opposition claimed there were up to 100,000 protesters, while the state media reported a turnout of 20,000" (MacDowell 2015)—using the smaller figure, this already amounts to 1% of the nationwide population being physically present to call for the government to stand down. This is in spite of accounts that roads to the capital were blocked and transport companies were cancelling that day's connections (Marušić 2015).[11] A counterdemonstration camp started the next day. Gruevski asserted he had no intentions of resigning and warned that police would "respond accordingly" to any unrest.

The protest began at 13 h in front of the Primary Court, where it was demanded to have the political prisoners of 5 May and onwards released. A march to the government building followed, where the regular 18 h protest was held. The slogans being chanted were now "Resignation", "He is finished", "Nikola the little dictator", "No justice, no peace", and "Farewell Nikola". Afterwards, tents were put up for a long-term sit-in protest; people were immediately prepared to spend the winter there if need be. Some called it Macedonia's Maidan moment (Deralla 2015). Solidarity demonstrations were held in Sofia, Belgrade, Ljubljana, Sarajevo, Amsterdam, and London on or near to this date. Some interviewees said that the international element also took the inverse form in that the Maidan and Tahrir experiences were in the subconscious of protesters by this point—indeed, one interviewee adds that Macedonian upheavals have always been part of a regional, European, or some other context and that this was the first time the public was organizing itself. Another said, "I don't know where the famous Macedonian apathy comes from, but I know that since the end of last year [2014], for the first time in my life I have gained hope that it can and will diminish, and maybe even disappear at some point in the future".

[11]"Before the rally, social media were full of messages suggesting that the authorities had tried to stop protesters arriving from other Macedonian towns. The opposition said frequent police checks on buses and cars were aimed at stopping protesters going to the capital and a photo was posted of a truck allegedly blocking the highway from Veles to Skopje. The opposition also said that transport companies cancelled buses that were booked to carry protesters to Skopje".

3 Protests Play with the Grammar of Social Conduct

Near the beginning of the fourteenth century, a European-wide trend of abandoning Latin as the favoured language for writing took off.[12] Although slow and admittedly variable between regions, it changed society in profound ways by boosting literacy levels in the provinces, giving the average person access to books and pamphlets—which would also allow them to become more politically engaged or study the national laws—and it was crucial in replacing hegemonic rule with distinct cultural identities of vulgar tongues, as they were known. Since the international revolts of 1968, it might be said that protest is the vernacular tongue of the modern world. Just as most people were excluded from written texts, the modern masses feel they have been denied engagement in political discourse. The argument that this voice is granted to the people in voting does not hold up in a hybrid regime, it has been shown, where elections are rigged or tailored. Even in electoral democracies, political engagement should not end in the voting booth. Through assembling, people can struggle to have an influence on the political stage. As with past colloquial tongues, protest speech needs to fight for its legitimacy against the official discourse of institutionalized politics. We have also established that demonstrations have been growing in popularity, in frequency, and in legitimacy in the public eye since 1968. Like languages themselves, their grammar changes with each experience in order to signify more meaningfully and to circumvent state technologies that prevent their effectiveness. The project of this book is to update the grammatology of protest publics to describe what we actually see today.

Without the sanction of its subjects, a government must be considered to be in a tug of war with its people. It is a rigged game. After all, the state controls the laws that determine rights of assembly and to the city as well as determining the punishments incurred for violating those same laws. While it is normally advisable to follow their rules, there comes a point at which it incurs less damage for individuals to practise misconduct than to conduct oneself according to hegemonic norms.[13] I will use *mis*conduct instead of the more usual Foucauldian term counterconduct as an envelope term to incorporate more minor misdemeanours as well as significant challenges to systems of power; extending the term is deemed necessary in the context of hybrid regimes which have only emergent or abeyant counterpublics.

From that unfavourable starting point, Skopje has been developing a new tradition of demonstration based on the principles of misconduct. In the first few months of the movement, it had taken the following shapes: a protest choir called Singing Skopjans (Mašta 2015), #protestiram sealing the entrances of institutions to claim their right to them (Protestiram home page 2015), concerts and poetry at the anti-

[12]Dante Alighieri composes the first treatise on eloquence in vernacular tongues, *De vulgari eloquentia*, around 1302.

[13]A sentiment inspired by Henry David Thoreau. “An Essay on Civil Disobedience”. 1849. http://xroads.virginia.edu/~hyper2/thoreau/civil.html (accessed 7 October 2015)

government camp, plena of all types, alternative educational city tours that were meant to lay new ownership over the changed city (Spaskovska 2014), symbolic gestures in demonstrations such as giving flowers to police officers or banalizing shields of cordons by using the reflection to apply lipstick (Gelevski 2011), bicycle street blockades to challenge bad roads (Mihajlovski 2015), and protecting police from provocateurs from 6 May onwards. It is promising ground for the continuation of a misconduct tradition which will ensure a power relationship between the states, publics, and public space which is better balanced. These protesting publics will then be armed to challenge other state inadequacies. In October 2015, the same year, for instance, a similar protesting public used its acquired skills to demonstrate for the rights of refugees passing through the Balkan route during, what was referred to as, the European refugee crisis.

By the following April, less than a year since the protest publics in Skopje were invigorated, a second movement was making even bolder claims over the city. Dubbed Sharenata Revolucija—the Colourful Revolution—supporters of this movement went to mass assemblies armed with water balloons filled with paint to vandalize the changed façades of the city, new monuments, and institutions of power. They also put soap and red paint in the fountains and, wherever possible, made a farce of the objects they consider symbolic of those responsible for the political crisis in their country. The first assembly of this type happened on 12 April 2016, as a response to the interim president—Gjorge Ivanov—pardoning the many dozens of officials who were under scrutiny regarding the wiretapping affair which had started #protestiram. As with the earlier movement, they met every day until their demands were met. Sharenata Revolucija protests were largely peaceful and very effective—especially for being photogenic. Emblematic photographs of this movement spread like wildfire across the region and beyond.

The colours spilt into all larger cities in Macedonia, where similar protests took place. Sharenata Revolucija created an unexpected and powerful grammar of its own which could be understood immediately and transferred outside of Skopje. The name of this protest public seems to have drawn inspiration from the Coloured Revolutions which spread throughout the Eastern Bloc a little more than a decade earlier. The Coloured Revolutions were typified as democratization processes, but these are by and large considered failures today as hybrid regimes have consolidated in their wake. With the name Sharenata Revolucija, activists of Macedonia distinguish themselves from those earlier revolutions and criticize the narrative of linear democratization—indeed, many left-leaning demonstrators on the street were against European integration. The name furthermore gives a nod to the LGBTI community, which was at the forefront of organizing assemblies since it had the most experience doing so as an under-protected group. This was a sign of respect that didn't go unnoticed or unappreciated by members of that community.

Such predispositions for the protest publics in Skopje to go under different names, to demonstrate for a variety of causes, and to assemble alongside the opposition party, even though not all of the protesting body was in support of it, are all indicators that the publics were more than prepared to leave behind identity politics and get to work. This is similar in tone to their refusal of falling into the ethnocracy

trap, discussed earlier. Part of the protesting body ultimately sided with social democrats, SDSM, which was finally elected as the replacement of the new government in mid-2017; Zaev was at its head. Another part of the protesting body formed a new party called Levica—literally, "the Left". This party hasn't been influential until this stage, securing only three consulting positions in local elections of 2017. They got 12,000 votes in the parliamentary elections, which accounts for 1% of the total votes. Levica does not have formal leadership, choosing instead to make decisions by way of party plenums.

What hasn't disappeared along with Gruevski is the violence constructed by force into the city structure with Skopje 2014. Painting the changes was effective for Sharenata Revolucija, but it didn't permanently solve the problem. The right to the city is inherently accompanied by a notion of rebuilding the city, and this is a serious task that will need to take place in Macedonia. David Harvey argues that without a redesign of the structure of capitalist life or the urban space, any victories regarding the reduction of exploitation of labourers must be viewed as temporary seeing as the infrastructure is already in place for the inequalities to resurface (Harvey 2012). In order for public spaces to be democratic, they need to have the capacity of having multifarious functions rather than multifarious restrictions.

The lowest common denominator of subjection into this code system is the human body, since being is an uninterrupted series of occupations of physical space. Harvey develops this further in a later part of *The Condition of Postmodernity*, identifying "the space of the body as the irreducible element in our social scheme of things, for it is upon that space that the forces of repression, socialization, disciplining, and punishing are inflicted [. . .] mean[ing] that it is only from that site of power that resistance can be mobilized in the struggle to liberate human desire" (1990, p. 213). That is to say, it is by our choices of how to occupy physical space that we can empower and deploy ourselves as political actors: this applies equally to the culture and products we consume, and reinforce, by our presence as it does to the decision to join a demonstration. The fact of being a body in physical space has not lost its currency today in spite of movement towards machine-automated physical labour, reserving intellectual work for people. The body is the instrument of resistance. To incite change, an assembly must disrupt the tight web of signs and introduce into it elements for which there is no prepared response in legal, moral, or social codes. But we should be careful not to be too idealistic in our conception of the capacity to incite change. To make such an affirmation, after all, is to remain within the form of a rigid one for one symbolic system.

What's left for counterconduct, then, is to change the very form of discourse from similar unilinear governmental reason. For instance, Levica are doing everything they can to not become a social movement which chose to "enter the temporality of politics and adapt [itself] to the performatives of rational-critical discourse. For many counterpublics, to do so is to cede the original hope of transforming, not just policy, but the space of public life itself" (Warner 2002, p. 89). Yet in their efforts to fight against political discourse, Levica are almost altogether excluded from it as a political party. Applying Warner's logic to this scenario, we could say that too few texts of the Levica-style publics have existed in the political sphere to date for

the party to create a public for it and to be immediately impactful. Time will tell whether enough people will build on radical leftist texts in the Macedonian political sphere to form a public that would vote less conservatively. A further dilemma will be reached if such a party were ever to come to power, as was the example of the appointment of Syriza, and they need to negotiate with leadership from other countries.

This brings us to a number of important questions to close the chapter: Can serious resistance communicate with hegemonic powers? If so, how? What concessions need to be made for a counterpublic to become a dominant public? How far can a position stray from widely acknowledged grammar before it is dismissed? Is breaking away from this grammar only effective in informal political bodies but not formal ones? The variety of demonstrators in Skopje and in Macedonia at large had to ask themselves these questions; each decided for themselves, yet they still gathered around a common aim and not a common identity. This is why we speak of protesting publics in the plural; they exist as complex, contradictory bodies with changing members and space to change one's mind. Although this has been used to disavow them as insignificant or powerless, it is also a testament to their truly democratic nature. We have seen that in the case of Macedonia, they not only succeeded in overthrowing an oppressive, authoritarian government but also developed a tradition of local counterpublics to call upon in the future. The discourse has begun; people are watching.

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Retracing Protest Publics in Portugal: A Generation in Trouble



Cristina Montalvão Sarmento, Patrícia Oliveira, and Patrícia Tomás

1 Introduction

This chapter aims to analyse the 2010s crisis in Portugal and its main outcomes. It draws on the theory on publics and public protest and uses it to examine the what has been called *Geração à Rasca* [*Generation in Trouble*]. The protests led to tensions between publics and the institutionalized forms of politics that the former eventually influenced. Our goal is to map the tensions and political associations of the Portuguese case through employing theoretical insights from the theory of publics, showing how the informal politics had significant consequences for the sphere of institutionalized politics.

Generation in Trouble was a public protest scheduled on March 12, 2011, in Lisbon and Porto. The protest wanted to give voice to unemployed people, "quinhentoseuristas",[1] and other low-wage workers, self-entitled "slaves in disguise". The mobilization claimed to be non-partisan, secular and peaceful and sought to express the dissatisfaction of those who want to have the right to employment, education and better working conditions. Only 7 days after the *Generation in Trouble* protest, another even more ambitious protest took place. It aimed to show indignation at the lack of employment and at "injustices and inequalities" and to defend "policy changes". One million Portuguese citizens flowed out on to the streets. The way they mobilized, without the call of any political party, was pioneering. Social media platforms (new social and free networks) and loosely assembled protest gatherings

This chapter was reviewed by Claudia Favarato, Institute of Social and Political Sciences, University of Lisbon, Lisbon, Portugal.

[1] "Five hundred eurists", young people that earn around 500,00 €.

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N. Belyaeva et al. (eds.), *Protest Publics*, Societies and Political Orders in Transition,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5_6

rather than traditional media and conventional institutionalized politics are what mark these protests out as distinctive.

The link between social network mobilization and its role in the public protest is manifest in several other cases that have emerged in recent years. The 2010 wave that shook the Arab world (Algeria, Libya, Bahrain, Iran, Jordan, Morocco and Yemen) was the first such wave of related cases. Later, similar mobilizing tactics appeared in Europe, particularly in *Southern European countries*. Furthermore, during May 2011, in Spain, thousands of protesters came together to ask for political, economic and social change. The Spanish claims and protest models were epigones of the Portuguese ones. During springtime, they adopted alike patterns of demonstration. The apparent roots of the emergent protest appear to be linked to a mimetic crisis process, which affected several countries and dynamically shaped the correlation of forces in the political system.

The chapter is organized as follows. First, the context for the Portuguese case is provided. We highlight the processes of politicization and depoliticization that have taken place at a national and European level. Then, questioning the collective action as a model of analysis permits us to discard some of the explanatory arguments founded. Those are mainly originated from committed sociological and political action point of view, without considering the outcome on the institutionalized political system. Subsequently, we focus our analysis on protest publics, cast as a model type of new protest behaviour, to search for the features of the protests that figured in the changes on the institutionalized political system.

Finally, a hypothesis is ventured that some institutionalized political effective changes are the result of this new model of political participation made on the streets and can be characterized using the concept of *protest democracy*. To our goal, examining the later formal changes of the system allows the conclusive demonstration. If so, it will remain to explain the sudden end of the financial crisis, where the argument about the politicization and depoliticization possibly helps to enlighten the subject, without further economic explanations.

2 Portuguese and the Crisis Process

When in 2008–2010 the financial crisis reached the European markets, in particular the Southern European ones such as Portugal, it was discursively framed in different ways. As a political discourse, the aggregation of several peripheral countries of the south, *Southern European countries* (Karamouzi et al. 2013), into the same "crisis" raises questions about Europe's north-south division. The sources of this division are much older than the crisis. The common argument about the distinction between the two halves of Europe is the presence, in the North, of a political coalition protecting the autonomy of the bureaucracy. Here civil service is largely perceived as impartial and entrusted with providing continuity to policymaking. Governance failures in Southern Europe are inextricably tied to more or less pervasive forms of clienteles', which bury merit and frustrate reforms. In turn, European institutions have operated on the assumption that reforms are in every country's best interest and, backed by

Northern member states, have imposed austerity measures on the south through a standardizing language of gradual adaptation. Hence the South, historically, is also known as PIGS (Portugal, Italy, Greece, and Spain). It is an acronym, created in the 1990s to designate Portugal, Italy, Greece and Spain, that is intentionally pejorative. This characterization combines geographical and socio-economic dimensions which depict Southern or Mediterranean Europe as chronically economic deficient countries, dependent on the virtuous Northern countries. Since Ireland's bankruptcy in 2008, Italy disappeared from the acronym to be replaced by the former or gave rise the amendment PIIGS to include either Ireland or Italy or even PIIIGS to add Iceland. This pejorative depiction of a set of countries figured in speculations about sovereign debt securities of these countries, as it happened in 2010. Public discourse and opinion, spread through social and conventional media, held that these countries were undergoing a crisis.

From a political perspective, the term "crisis" indicates situations in which political actors undertake and political structures undergo radical changes. In this sense, not only in political science but also in the field of social sciences, the "crisis of representative democracy" (Pierson 2002) or the "crisis of the welfare state" (Strange 1995) sparked an extended debate. As Flinders and Wood might argue (Flinders and Wood 2014), departing from Colin Hay's conceptual work (Hay 2007), a process of depoliticization arose through a depoliticized discourse about the crisis. This can be described as a political strategy, whereby the traditional roles and abilities of the state were delegated to political institutions constrained by the adoption of binding rules. While the literature first embraced a top-down approach, which saw depoliticization as an imposition of political elites to strengthen their own positions, more recent literature moved towards a more conflictual approach in which depoliticization is challenged by different social and political actors; thus re-politicization may occur. One of the greatest advantages of the depoliticization approach is that it pinpoints contingency and contestation of these political strategies while critically challenging deterministic approaches and the discourse of "there is no alternative".

The Portuguese crisis process seems to suffer from these involutions, as it was founded on a "no alternative" discourse grounded on structural and external conditions that were affecting the *Southern European countries*. The general structure of the crisis period was shaped by changing labour dynamics. Special emphasis must be put on power shifts in the processes of reconversion and fragmentation of labour relations and labour rights. The changing relationship between the welfare state and social policies focusing on access to public provision and quality of public services (in health, education, housing and justice areas, among others) and in the deepening social inequalities was another mark of the time under analysis. Last but not least, governance and democracy changed according priority to socio-economic governance and to high-quality policymaking (including democracy, transparency, participation) at the local, national, European and global level. These conditions justified and established the "inevitable" austerity policies enforced in Portugal since 2009, as a result of the 2008 financial crisis.

In Portugal, the austerity policies started off as fiscal policies, which bottlenecked public expenditures, especially in investments and the social functions of the state. Only afterwards did they become active against wage costs and the value of labour. They attacked social rights and protections, in a context of rising unemployment. This led to a stark compression of demand and purchasing power, thus reducing economic growth.

Austerity is therefore adopted as the solution to the economic crisis. Its purpose is to contain or to reverse public expenditure by restricting state budgets and thereby to change redistributive policy and associated costs. Despite the depoliticized rhetoric, they are ideological choices and political options. The discourse about the "certainty" of the crisis, common in all *Southern European countries*, and the inevitability of austerity, was largely used by European ruling class and were a permanent mark of the public sphere after 2010. Currently, almost ten years after the beginning of the crisis and following the end of the austerity programme enforced in Portugal enable us to analyse the chronology of the period. Between 2011 and 2014, several economic measures affected the Portuguese population. Those measures radically affected labour conditions and were perceived as an external imposition by international and European institutions. Despite the resilience of social and political institutions, before and after the *troika,*[2] the intervention of new forms of political protests appeared in the Portuguese political arena, linking directly with the labour conditions and mostly affecting young people.

The term *troika* has been widely used in Greece and Cyprus, Ireland, Portugal and Spain to refer to the presence of the European Commission (EC), the European Central Bank (ECB) and the International Monetary Fund (IMF) in these countries since 2010 and the financial measures that these institutions have taken. *Troika* involvement started on May 17, 2011. The intervention programme for public finances and Portuguese economy was negotiated between the Socialist Party (PS) government, led by José Sócrates, and the European Commission, the European Central Bank and the International Monetary Fund. It provided Portugal a loan of 78 billion €. In coalition with the Centre Democratic Party (CDS), the Social Democratic Party (PSD) won the June legislative elections. The PSD got 38.66% of the votes, while the Socialist Party got 28.05%, and José Sócrates stepped down. On June 21, 2011, the PSD-CDS government, headed by Pedro Passos Coelho, took office.

In October, the prime minister announced the first austerity package to be applied in the state budget for 2012, including cuts to Christmas and Holidays pay checks for state workers, maintaining of 5% salary reduction of the public service employees (introduced by José Sócrates the previous year), and extension to retirement pensions of the application of *Contribuição Extraordinária de Solidariedade* [*Extraordinary*

[2]The European *troika* is the designation of the triumvirate representing foreign/institutes of the EU, concerning in particular its common foreign and security policy (CFSP). Currently, to talk about the *troika* (especially in the media) refers to a decision group formed by the European Commission (EC), the European Central Bank (ECB) and the International Monetary Fund (IMF).

Solidarity Contribution]. Weekly working hours arose from 35 to 40, some bank holidays were erased, and VAT (value added tax) augmented. On September 15, 2012, a second large demonstration, organized around the motto *Que se lixe a troika! Queremos as nossas vidas!* [*To hell with troika! We want our lives!*], became the largest demonstration in Portugal since 1974. Some estimates indicate that more than a million and a half people walked down the streets in protest (Soeiro 2014).

Nevertheless, in October 2012, the Finance Minister Vítor Gaspar announced a "huge increase in taxes", with emphasis on the creation of a 4% surcharge on incomes in 2013 (still in force today) and a reduction from 8 to 5 in the income tax brackets, thus to increase the effective tax revenue. The political arena was thoroughly defenceless and courts interceded. During April 2013, the Constitutional Court ruled over the state budget for 2013; it repealed the suspension of public holiday's payment, the suspension of 90% of the pensioners' vacation pay and a 5% cut in sick pay and 6% in unemployment benefits. Requests for successive audits were made by the President of the Republic and by Socialist (PS) MPs, the Communist Party (PCP), the Left Block (BE) and the Ecologist Party "The Greens" (PEV) and by the Ombudsman.

On July 10, the President of the Republic proposed a "national salvation compromise" between Social Democratic Party (PSD), Socialist Party (PS) and Centre Democratic and Social Party (CDS), so to fully accomplish the *troika* intervention programme till the end term, May 17, 2014. Should the compromise come to fruition, it was temporary, and previsions included elections after June 2014.

A sense of dependency and of disagreement with European orientations was felt all over the country. Analysts and media corporations were unanimous on the potential failure of the most important sources of social stability. It is significant to mention those decisions and the relevant steps of this period, especially because these political measures influenced the various public protests, with consequences in the way traditional institutions of representative democracy work. In sum, we have clearly ideological and political complexities that are obscured by the general crisis framework. First, a discourse about the "inevitability" of the crisis was "shared" by all *Southern European countries*. It was "provoked" by 2008 financial crisis along with ethical values that (wrongly) preside over the administrations of those countries. The latter can be politically deconstructed. Second, a one-for-all solution was to arbitrarily apply "austerity measures", despite the disagreement expressed by economists. Those austerity measures were imposed by external institutions (*troika*) and required certain labour conditions to be changed. Inherently an essentially political choice, the remodelling was a prerequisite to be given any loan. Problems of other orders, such as decreased trust in and identification with European institutions, accountability of EU institutions, worsen social conditions and public protest eruption, were discarded as a national, secondary matter.

3 The Paths of Public Protest

Following the wave of austerity measures, in 2011 the *Geração à Rasca* appeared in Portugal. The name is a peculiar slang term that can be rudimentarily translated as *Generation in Trouble*. As soon as the media conveyed the images and story of *Occupy Wall Street* in the USA and elsewhere, the *Generation in Trouble* blossomed. Demands for more responsive democracy, accountability and quality of democracy were a common feature of public protest in several countries, which can fall under the name of collective action. According to the traditional literature (Della Porta 1996; Tilly 1978), the structure of collective action has a variety of forms—from rituals of manifestation in the public arena (protest actions, concentrations, rallies, strikes) to less direct forms of political intervention (petitions, manifests). Nowadays, much collective action, and thus public protest, identifies under the umbrella of opposing neo-liberalist policies' consequences. The Internet has profoundly changed the strategies of mobilization used in the political arena, creating a "hybrid public space" (Castells 2012), yet a new political space where participation is possible in different new ways. The concept of public protest results from the combination of meanings with the circulation of discourse (Warner 2002): it is a synonym for claim, pressure, contestation, questioning and resistance in a specific temporality. But it is also an expression of participation, of emancipation, and of affirmation of alternatives.

The media projection of public protests brings about a dynamic that requires the redefinition of strategies, the specific logics of recruitment and the application of appropriate discourses and rhetoric to the general public, not only to participants. From small and localized protest action to a large social movement, the logic of action is oriented towards social change, exposing the existing situations and the affirmation of citizens' rights. It represents identities and voices that cannot or do not have access to the saturated space of social communication and, more important, the public sphere. The recently context of crisis revealed an unusual dynamic in the public space. From social movements, citizen forums or civil society organizations to a more spontaneous or improvised manifestations of public protests, many and varied of them are the initiatives that have been challenging the logic of the conventional functioning of the political arena and the traditional institutions of representative democracy and ultimately in the exercise of citizenship.

The renewed role of the streets in public protests constitutes an expression of alternative visions that seems to lay stress upon not only in the new social, political causes and agendas but also in its potential for the operating logic of public protests. The renewal of the public space as a space open to broader participation, more inclusion, is vital for the support of alternative visions to dominant politics. It is a space loosely bonded to exclusionary codifications and constraints; therefore it puts in question the traditional institutions of representative democracy. The emergence of these new forms of protest have been approached and interpreted in different ways by the literature. There are several proposals about the Portuguese protests that

added more than one debate to the explanation of public protest but ignored the possible consequences for institutionalized political process.

Soeiro suggests that the Portuguese generation mobilization is part of a new cycle of collective action (Soeiro 2014) where a cycle effect can emerge (Tarrow 1995). It focuses the characterization of the public protest rather than following its consequences. This mobilization is very distinct from the transnational *activism* as conceptualized by Baumgarten. Targets of Portuguese protest remained mainly on national level, according to her theorization (Baumgarten 2013). The first hypothesis is grounded on a sociological analysis of the 2083 documents on the mobilization collected by the organizers. The second hypothesis is based on a participant observation of the protest activities' preparations. Both provide sociological insights into political phenomena in ways that are clearly shaped by political activism.

Analysis of the claims is another way of reading the dynamics of public protest, such as the case of the global justice movement (Della Porta 2005, 2007). Do they have sufficient common features to enable us to consider a new form of social movement? As Felgueiras largely explored in his recent study, public protest can be a simpler social movement, in accordance with classic explanation to the protest mobilization (Felgueiras 2016). The economic crisis framework is essential for the mobilization. Changes in labour and material issues have gained a new centrality, as Estanque argues (Estanque et al. 2013), thus establishing patterns of a new kind of materialism. Meanwhile, post-materialist values are an inherent part of the protesters' grievance. As the mobilization seems deeply connected with the aesthetic communication of a song that synthesizes and eloquently expresses a reality and the networks of meanings and representations that circulate in a given society and especially among a younger generation.

We can recognize potential strength in those arguments altogether, but none seems to explain successfully the consequences of political protests in the Portuguese political arena.

3.1 The Portuguese Generation in Trouble

The *Generation in Trouble* constitutes an interesting case study of youth involvement in public protest. The protesters share a singular and unusual vision about themselves, as a peculiar category of the political arena and of the social system. This perspective complements the managing of the streets as a public space to protest. Even if the historiography of this public protest is characterized by brief volatility, it is detectable a former background, as the name itself results from the expression *rasca* [*junk*]. The expression "junk generation" was employed in 1994 by a well-known Portuguese journalist (Vicente Jorge Silva) to characterize a student protest against the Minister of Education and the mandatory global examinations at the end of secondary studies.

The public protest that took place on May 5, 1994, was given the name of *Geração Rasca* by the media. This protest was organized by high school students'

associations, merged with university ones, seeking to forestall the payment of fees and seeking support for the neediest students to be provided by social services. The protest was characterized by a culture of excess: the young students walked in the streets, cut off the traffic and defied the police. Therefore, the protest was dubbed *Geração Rasca* [*junk generation*] meaning without principles or values. It became powerless, irrelevant and sparked no consequences.

Despite broad critiques, the expression was transformed into a slang of protest, emphasizing the gap between values of different generations. In 2011, the expression was adjusted to the March 12 demonstration *Geração à Rasca*, thus a pun of the precedent terminology. The *junk generation* became the *generation in trouble* or "desperate", as it has also been translated. The phenomenon of the *Generation in Trouble* manifestly began with two concerts of the musical group *Deolinda*, in the Coliseums of Porto (January 22 and 23) and of Lisbon (on January 28 and 29). *Deolinda*'s song, entitled *Que parva que eu sou* [*I am such a fool*], expresses the untenable situation of young Portuguese graduates. It addressed their jobless status, their forlorn future and the prospect of swinging between an unpaid job and an unpaid internship:

> I'm from a generation without remuneration/(. . .) I'm already lucky that I can work as an intern/(. . .) I'm from a generation still living in "mom and dad's house"/(. . .) Children, husband, I'm always delaying/(. . .) And I think to myself/what a silly world/where to become a slave you need to study. . .[3]

The above written song, which recalls the tradition of protest songs, fostered a process of identification within the public, and it quickly spread through the Internet via YouTube, especially among young people. Furthermore, the Portuguese group *Homens da Luta* [*Men of Struggle*] won the Eurovision Festival, broadcasted on TV, with the song *A Luta é Alegria* [*Rally is Joy*]. The song is a clear reference to the revolutionary ambience of the 25th April (1974) Revolution. *Deolinda* and *Homens da Luta*, followed by other artists and intellectuals, triggered a social wave that problematized the issue of precarious labour in the public and media agenda, unleashing a generalized mobilization that culminated in the so-called protest *Geração à Rasca* [*Generation in Trouble*] on March 12, 2011.

The protest *Generation in Trouble* was organized through the social network Facebook by four young people (Alexandre Carvalho, António Frazão, João Labrincha and Paula Gil). They took advantage of the political opportunities to create awareness about Portuguese young generation precarious labour scenario, as it had been foretold at *Deolinda*'s concerts. The protest took to the streets in several cities of the country, gathering together more than 200,000 people who demonstrated against precarious labour. Although the initiative was launched by young people, demonstrators belonging to other generations were involved, giving voice to the unemployed, "quinhentoseuristas" ("five hundred eurists", people that earns

[3]See the lyric of the song Que parva que eu sou [I am such a fool], of the musical group Deolinda, Retrievable from: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kGS7vAliIjI (Accessed 9 September 2017).

around 500,00 €) and other low-paid citizens,[4] all of them acknowledging that they are *à rasca* [*in trouble*].

The situation of job insecurity and growing unemployment,[5] coupled with lack of hope for the future, was the catalytic elements that caused feelings of discouragement among young people, which are the main factors of demonstrators' mobilization (Melucci 2001). Currently, a high level of education is counterbalanced by higher unemployment rates and increased difficulties in entering the labour market, thus discrediting the belief that school certification, through access to higher education, would provide stable employment. In this sense, the *Generation in Trouble* protest was a milestone in recent Portuguese political history, not only because of the political results achieved but also because of the innovative factors introduced in public protest, such as the use of social networks and the Internet. Nevertheless, the innovation factor also resulted in the subsequent intensification of several protests using methodologies and practices.

Another even more ambitious protest, scheduled through Facebook by a group called *1 Milhão na Avenida da Liberdade* [*1 Million in Liberty Avenue*], wanted to join one million of Portuguese in the centre of Lisbon City on March 19. Seven days after *Generation in Trouble*, the Facebook group intended to show indignation at the lack of employment, injustices and inequalities while demanding policy changes. Therefore, these two groups mobilized through social media and grew out of decentralized self-organized groups that were separated from political parties and unions. Just after the *Generation in Trouble*, several other groups had emerged in social media under other names. They all represented groups that had a precarious situation in labour market, low wages and in particular a lack of social welfare guarantees. Groups such as *Quinhenteuristas* (who earns less than 500,00€); *Precários unidos* [*United Temporary Workers*]; O*s Intermitentes do Espectáculo e do Audiovisual* [*labor workers on shows/visual arts without guaranties of stability or short-terms contracts*]; *The FERVE*, *os Fartos/as D'Estes Recibos Verdes* [*The Tired Workers of Green Receipts*] or even the *ABIC*, *Associação dos Bolseiros de Investigação Científica* [*Association of Scientific Research Grants*] showed up.

These seemingly spontaneous public events—more or less ephemeral public demonstrations of discontent—of several small groups of citizens brought new agendas to both the state and the society. They have been classified as "classic groups" (Baumgarten 2013), by opposition to the PPA (participation, public debate and alternatives beyond the state), which is closer to transnational protest commitment. Those waves of public protest represented a complex interplay that eventually causes democratic changes or, instead, produces instability in the political systems. In a country where protest tradition is tightly linked to political

[4]See the manifest of Geração à Rasca [Generation in Trouble] protest. Retrievable from: https://geracaoenrascada.wordpress.com/manifesto/english/ (accessed 9 September 2017).

[5]Since 2008 there has been a rise in the unemployment rate, particularly in the case of young people under 25 years of age, exceeding 25% from 2009. From 2009, the youth unemployment rate has hit successive records, reaching more than 35% in 2011, which means that in every three young people, one was unemployed.

parties, thus to institutionalized protest, the idea of a "non-partisan, secular and peaceful" protest constitutes a singular aspect of *Generation in Trouble*. This argument frames the analysis of this protest in the context of social construction of the non-institutionalized political protest.

The simultaneous events that occurred in Greece or Spain enable us to detect links between the protests, with special regard to new agendas, namely, about corruption, which contrasted mainstream political discourse. As in Portugal, Spain implemented austerity measures and the public protests mobilized through social media platforms, with even more radical demands. The neighbouring protests influenced the dynamics of public protest in Portugal. After the Spanish public protest, an unpredictable major trial on corruption started in Portugal, involving the former prime minister. In November 2014, Miguel Macedo, Minister of Internal Affairs, resigned, following the arrests of his ministry's officials in the case known as "Golden Visa". Right after, José Sócrates is seized at Lisbon airport and held in custody under suspicion of tax evasion, money laundering and corruption. This unprecedented suspicion of political class accountability is the milestone consequence of the wave of national and regional protests.

Five years after the *Generation in Trouble* demonstration, protest organizers say that young people are still "more in trouble" due to worsening job insecurity, yet they are confident that the current government will be able to change the situation. When asked by Lusa, the national news agency,[6] whether 5 years after the demonstration there is still a *generation in trouble*, Paula Gil, one of the four young people who organized the protest and who continues to have a precarious job, replied:

> Of course, and more and more. The last 4 years of government have shown that the only form of hiring in the country is precarious. If it were not for this precariousness, we would be forced into unemployment or to emigrate.

The activist said also that:

> labour precariousness intensified due to a strategy of devaluing work. Nowadays people work for much less money, with far fewer conditions, with far fewer rights, precisely because unemployment is so high.

Despite the fact that worsened, Paula Gil said the demonstration was "worth it" as it showed that:

> it was possible to bring people together, regardless of the value that trade unions and parties have for our democracy. Even so, I think it was worthy organizing that demonstration for the sake of popular organization, to acknowledge that it is possible to make democracy outside the organized structures and the framework that people felt when they took to the streets to defend their work and their rights, but mainly because, at the time, it brought precariousness onto the political agenda, which was something that hadn't happened before.

The activist stressed that the issue of precarious work is currently on the political agenda and there is "a constant concern to mention it". In this sense, Paula Gil

[6]Retrievable from: http://www.tvi24.iol.pt/sociedade/11-03-2016/cinco-anos-apos-a-manifestacao-ainda-existe-uma-geracao-a-rasca (accessed 9 September 2017).

expressed hope in the current government and for the parliamentary agreement with the left parties to "bring some changes" to workers' rights. The activist thinks that "the level of expectation surrounding this government is enough... It is a government that has the support of BE and PCP", adding that fighting job insecurity is "a matter of political will". This interview is the real expression of beliefs that the activists nourish after the public protest. It shows also the conviction that the change of government will meet the quests. More important, it manifests the certainties that it will be possible to realize other demonstrations, through the same successful method.

The Portuguese mobilization of claims expressed in *Generation in Trouble* figured importantly in several international events. The import of ideas from foreign movements, specifically from neighbouring Spain, should be regarded as part of a bigger picture of worldwide mobilizations, against austerity measures, unjust labour markets and for a participatory, deliberative democracy.

4 From Public Dissents to "Protest Democracy"

With the emergence of these new waves of protest, it is clear that the participation of the ordinary citizen today is far from the democratic ideals proclaiming that the citizen should be interested in politics and should actively participate through political parties (Milbrath 1965). The individualisation of values and lifestyles of young people (the extension of compulsory education, the late entry into the labour market, the union and constitution of family in older age), coupled with the perception of generalized crisis in the last decade, has led to a growing interest by young people in personally meaningful causes (youth unemployment, the increasing costs of higher education, political corruption). Those, in turn, directly influence their everyday lives and is reflected in non-electoral, non-institutional participation (Dalton 2008; Inglehart and Welzel 2005) to the detriment of electoral and institutional participation.

Political parties are central institutions of representative democracies; they are the main means of political representation of citizens in political systems. The discussion above leads us to the debate on the "crisis of political parties" in democracies, currently a central theme in political party studies (Lisi 2011; Costa Pinto et al. 2013; Teixeira 2011), underpinned in party organizations growing inability to mobilize and to encourage voters to take part. The increasing decline of party membership (Seyd and Whiteley 2004; Webb et al. 2002; Mair and van Biezen 2001; Scarrow 2000; Katz et al. 1992), the low voter turnout and the decrease in party identification (Costa Lobo et al. 2015; Magalhães and Moral 2008; Freire 2006) confirm the ever-growing gap between citizens and political parties (Dalton 2000). These indicators of political participation attest to a decrease in citizens' political engagement through traditional forms of participation. Facing this new reality, we can assert the inability of traditional organizations to provide adequate answers to the set of current challenges. The new extremist movements that are springing throughout Europe (Freire 2006),

occupying more and more space in the political arena and gaining ground among younger sections of society correspond to a greater capacity of individual action.

The current reality is, to a large extent, the outcome of the emergence and the consolidation of the media as the main mediating institution accomplishing the tasks of articulating interests and political communication that are traditionally reserved to parties (Dalton 2000). The media are tending to gradually replace parties as the privileged sources of information, resulting in an increasing decline of their importance in the framework of advanced representative democracies. In addition, the emergence of waves of public protest provides means to map new forms of communication that reinforce the finding that non-institutionalized protest is capable of producing real inputs into the political system.

5 Political Change in Portugal

Specifically regarding the Portuguese case, we face some significant changes in the democratic system, for example, the current composition of the government based on a left-wing parliamentary coalition, known as *geringonça* (which in English roughly translates to *contraption*). This unusual political coalition ultimately has consequences on how we will perceive democracy and its institutions in the future (Freire 2017). As a matter of fact, the former President Cavaco Silva was doubly unable to convene early legislative elections, since he was serving the last 6 months of his term. The Assembly of the Republic, in accordance with the Constitution of the Portuguese Republic, cannot be dissolved by a president either in the last 6 months of the term or in the first 6 months after legislative elections. After hearings with seven parties having parliamentary representation, the President of the Republic appointed the leader of socialist party, António Costa, prime minister.

Most media refer to the XXI Government as the "Leftist Government" or "Government of the Left Parties" or, simply, "Leftist Majority" or "Leftist Front" due to the parliamentary support provided by left-wing parties, who ensured that the executive took office. The "never-before-seen" situation of Portuguese political arena earned the derogatory epithet *geringonça* [*contraption*]. The nickname was given by the centrist leader Paulo Portas who during a parliamentary session referred to the alternative left-wing government as "not a government, a *contraption*". Paulo Portas called it *geringonça* in November 2015, after the Socialist Party had signed agreements with the Portuguese Communist Party, Left Block and PEV to guarantee support to the socialist government. Called "loose" and "illegitimate" by the opposition, the left-wing parliamentary majority has nevertheless been able to approve two state budgets and has now the support of the President of the Republic.

On May 22, 2017, Portugal closed the Excessive Deficit Procedure, thanks to the confirmation of the lowest deficit since the Carnation Revolution. At the European level, this was applauded in addition to calls to redouble the work necessary to escape further attention from Brussels.

Portugal and Europe sung in a single voice the victory achieved in the European Commission: The Excessive Deficit Procedure was about to be closed due to a financial consolidation that seemed to be in doubt but which was finally achieved, thanks to a new economic strategy applied during the transition from centre/right coalition government to the famous *geringonça* formed by left parties. On the morning of the announcement, when good news was already expected, the first salute was "fired" by the European Commission, which recommended to close as soon as possible the Excessive Deficit Procedure opened in Portugal in 2009.

Speaking to journalists about the decision,[7] the European Commissioners Pierre Moscovici and Valdis Dombrovskis spoke of "excellent news for Portugal, for the Portuguese economy and for the Portuguese people" and "a fine recognition of the effort to get out of a crisis that had an important social impact". The government felt victorious at several times in various realms. The Economy Minister spoke of a long-awaited "fair decision", anticipating Mario Centeno's victory, current Minister of Finance. Replying to reporters in Brussels, who align the Euro group meeting's decisions, he stated: "This is good news because it shows that public accounts in Portugal go towards sustainable and lasting consolidation". At the time of the European recognition, the Portuguese Minister of Finance[8] said: "This decision is a turning point insofar it expresses the Commission's assessment that Portugal's excessive budget deficit has been corrected in a sustainable and lasting manner".

The "unlikely" success of the so-called contraption is due, according to the several analysts, as by Victor Bento,[9] to a mixture of talent, luck and complicity of the media. Regarding talent, he mentions the promotion of a never-before-tried government solution and "the realization that in economics everything that goes down eventually goes up, and that, after adjustment [by the previous government], the turning of the tide would not fail to bring usable dividends". Under closer examination, this fallacious compliment does not explain how the unprecedented government solution emerged (Costa's eventual talent does not clarify the essential, which was the entire left-wing rejection of Coelho's government), and it leaves out the concrete policies of this government. While pointing out the opportunism of the confiscation of the dividends of the previous government's policy (the current dominating trick of the right), he refers to an economic "tidal turn" that he considers a stroke of luck.

When it comes to luck, the columnist mentions a hodgepodge of things, from the unexpected good international economic situation and the unexpected tourist boom to the never-before-seen (or so he says) complicity of the Portuguese President of the Republic with the government (which also benefitted from luck). He doesn't refrain

[7]Retrieved from: https://www.publico.pt/2017/05/22/economia/noticia/comissao-recomenda-saida-de-portugal-do-procedimento-por-defice-excessivo-1773012 (accessed 9 September 2017).

[8]Retrieved from: http://www.jornaldenegocios.pt/economia/detalhe/centeno-portugal-saira-do-procedimento-por-defices-excessivos (accessed 9 September 2017).

[9]Retrieved from: https://www.rtp.pt/programa/tv/p32609/e36 (accessed 9 September 2017).

from mentioning the "incidents that are favourable to the country's self-esteem", namely, the successes of football and Eurovision, not to mention the Pope's visit in 13 May 2017. Among all this, he mentions a "softening of the obstinacy of Brussels' hawks", which would have been due merely to the international political situation and not to any change of attitude on the part of the Portuguese government. Finally, under media complicity, he exposes a light version of the old theory of "democratic suffocation". According to Vitor Bento, there is today in Portugal a "control of the political effect of social communication", which "materializes much more in what it omits rather than in what it declares". In other words, the Portuguese media "reproduces and amplifies news or opinions that are convenient to the government, multiplying their social impact" and "ignores or cushions the inconveniences, stifling their impact". The successes of the *contraption* are making the right-wing parties desperate and distrustful.

Whatever the explanation, either given by media, by political actors or by participants in the political arena, after the settlement of the economic crisis and the end of austerity measures, the consequence seems to point to a new political outcome. The left coalition used the public protest claims as its main political discourse and the narrative which re-politicized the meaning of the crisis, even if the economic conditions did not change substantially. In this sense, the expression of "protest democracy" first used by Mathieu (2011) continues to have relevance.

In this context, the use of unconventional forms of participation is explained by the emergence of new protest publics, a variety of cultural and social minorities that integrate ethnic, religious, racial and sexual groups, which often resort to direct political action (strikes, boycotts, occupations, petitions, blocking public roads, civil disobedience and the use of violence). Recruitment through the use of Internet information networks and the creation of new forms of participation blossom in a new "hybrid public space" (Castells 2012) and a political culture marked by individualism, self-expression and diversity, based on post-materialistic values (Inglehart 1990) and new materialist ones (Soeiro 2014) provoked by the subordinate position of young people in the labour market. This generational group was given false expectations over the proportional relationship between an increase of investment skills and possible recruitment.

Attitudes and behaviours that influence young people's political engagement should be understood, not only through economic factors, which are not enough to explain political conduct, but also through cultural factors. Albeit varying in degrees, societies are characterized by a relatively stable set of political and cultural attitudes, which have implications for the viability of democratic institutions (Inglehart 1990). However, even in its alternative and emancipatory sense, democracy is not a simple political method, a system of government or a static reality. It is an unfinished, open, dynamic, contradictory, multidimensional and long-lasting process that consists in transforming unequal relations of power into relations of shared authority in all spheres of life (work, family, economic, educational, religious, culture, etc.). So conceived, far from being an ally of dominant ideologies, democracy is the overall social and political struggle that creates the conditions for the exercise of equality in diversity or, in other words, that provides the basis for the development of skills,

knowledge and values that create and reproduce practices of solidarity, participation and effective pursuit of equality—in this case, through public protest.

According to the aim of this chapter on the Portuguese case, it is possible that democracy provided the opportunity to interiorize the claims and demands of a young public protest, into a new discursive approach which resulted in a new political coalition, forming an original and unprecedented agreement between different political parties. Meanwhile, the political elite was faced with other internal challenges, such as the "Brexit" issue, which jeopardized the existence of the Union. *Southern European countries'* affairs were left off the political agenda.

6 Final Remarks

The goal of this chapter was to examine the framework of the crisis and the forms of political protest called *Geração à Rasca* [*Generation in Trouble*] in Portugal. Framing the Portuguese case into the more general wave of 2010 protests, the text aimed to emphasize the similarities between Portuguese and other countries protests, such as those in Spain. The pioneering Portuguese case is part of the wave of rebellions that the world has witnessed since 2010. The similarities in claims, temporal sequencing and form of mobilization enable us to locate the Portuguese within a broader wave of public protest. Furthermore, this insertion is underpinned in social and political scientific theoretical developments.

The sociological approaches to the subject, based on limited data, on one hand intend to demonstrate a *new global cycle of protest* and *the return of materialism.* On the other hand, the view/standpoint is an ideologically supported *transnational activism*. Other alternative is to constrain the analysis within sociological classic terms. Several concepts, such as crisis, and classical theory approaches to young participation in current democracies were revisited, in order to clarify the argument of a "protest democracy" as a new political absorption of the demands and language of the protest public that emerged at the beginning of the 2010s.

The essay sought to reveal how the protests influenced the emergence of a left coalition that currently rules Portugal, the so-called *geringonça*, a coalition among all Portuguese left parties represented in the national parliament. The political consequence was a radical transformation since the democratization of the country, which resulted not only in austerity measures but also in decreasing of European integration. The latter caused no real economic change but a mere virtual adjustment of the political discourse.

Whether to introduce the European political level at the end of the analytic demonstration might seem like adding a complementary element to the analysis, it is nevertheless necessary to understand the Portuguese case. The evolution of the political context in the European institutions, through the period of time in analysis, strengthens the argument. When facing the troubling multiplicity of discourses generated by the crisis, it becomes a priority to critically reflect on the causes and conditions of the crisis, in order to understand public debate and the circulation of discourse. Whether the main

goal is to reinforce and improve social knowledge, an exhaustive and plural dialogue on the ways out of the crisis is desirable. The access to a myriad of new social forms of interactions and networks, such as the Internet, and free platforms for communication and exchange has transformed the nature of power relations. Marked by waves of transnational claims and activism, the 2010s were years of political transformation. In Portugal, the mobilization of *Generation in Trouble* was pioneered and contributed to produce straightforward political outcomes in the national political arena.[10]

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[10]A draft paper (not for quotation) on the protest waves of 2010s was prepared, presented and discussed on the XXII World Congress of Political Science (IPSA, Madrid, July, 2012) RC37. The main focus on "crisis" was explored by the authors, on the book in Cambridge Scholars Publishing: *Plunging in Turmoil in the Aftermath of Crisis*. Here the main goal of this chapter is to focus on the outcome of the *Geração à Rasca* mobilization in 2011.

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Justification in Protest Publics: The Homeless Workers' Movement in Brazil's Crisis



Victor Albert

1 Introduction

At the end of the 2000s, the prognoses of Brazil's future were optimistic. This was, it was thought, a 'New Brazil' (Roett 2011), one which was no longer merely a 'country of the future', a land of perennially unrealised potential, but which had stabilised politically, was experiencing strong economic growth and had taken its place on the global stage (see Eakin 2013). Even inequality, arguably the most steadfast of Brazil's problems, had notably diminished, with a group of economists charting the emergence of a 'new middle class' that had risen out of the most disenfranchised sectors of Brazilian society due to an improving labour market and government social programmes (Neri 2010, 2011; Neri et al. 2010; however see Pochmann 2014; Arretche 2015). Such expectant analyses helped to form a narrative of progress that chimed well with the media frames as they first developed around the World Cup and Olympic Games, which Brazil was soon to host. The narrative did not last, however, as a grave political and economic crisis began to take shape over the first 5 years of the following decade.

The unfolding crisis has been principally interpreted according to macro-political and economic frames. In this chapter I add a qualitative dimension to the study of the crisis and do so through an examination of the politics and activities of one of the most important collective actors to emerge therein: the Homeless Workers' Movement (Movimento de Trabalhadores Sem-Teto, MTST). The MTST separated from the Landless Peasants Movement (Movimento de Trabalhadores Rurais Sem-Teto, MST), Brazil's large agrarian movement, in 1997, with the aim of applying the land occupation strategies of its agrarian progenitor to urban regions, initially in Campinas—the state of São Paulo's third-largest city—and then in the city of São Paulo itself (Rosa 2015; Tedesco 2013, p. 97). During its first decade and a half of existence, the MTST maintained a low public profile, despite engaging in a number of

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N. Belyaeva et al. (eds.), *Protest Publics*, Societies and Political Orders in Transition,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5_7

land occupations in São Paulo. This changed as the movement evolved and grew as the crisis developed, through combining combative direct-action tactics, the use of a government housing programme and a strong media presence that complemented other, more spontaneously organised protest publics that emerged in the crisis.

This chapter has two aims. First, it fills in an important gap in existing analyses of and commentary on the crisis by examining the MTST, one of the foremost social actors to contest first the impeachment of the centre-left Workers' Party President, Dilma Rousseff, and then the new government led by former Vice President Michel Temer. Second, I use this case study to examine how the sociology of critical capacity might contribute to an understanding of how social movements can work as public mediators for individual action plans, thus contributing to the theorisation of protest publics. The sociology of critical capacity is a field of inquiry that emerged out of the Political and Moral Sociology Research Group in Paris and which foregrounds the political-moral dimensions of social life (Blokker 2011). While the sociology of critical capacity shares much in common with studies of political protest—and in particular a substantive interest in dispute, contestation and cooperation—it has not been comprehensively applied to the study of this phenomenon (Jasper 2007, p. 88; see Clément 2015). Drawing on the case of the MTST, I argue that the sociology of critical capacity contains a latent theorisation of key elements of the different kinds of 'justification work' (Jagd 2011) which allow individuals to make claims in the public sphere. This enables, we argue, a deeper understanding of the discursive and legitimising tactics through which private aims and plans are made public (Mahony and Clarke 2013; Newman and Clarke 2009; Warner 2002).

The chapter proceeds as follows. In the opening sections, I review the sociology of critical capacity and examine its potential to contribute to the study of how contentious actors negotiate publicness—and thus contribute to the theorisation of protest publics—before providing a history of the crisis in Brazil and the MTST. In the substantive sections of the chapter, I examine the justification work of the movement in different presentational forms and social spaces. First, I analyse the broad, publicly available justifications of the MTST based on written texts, which draw on principles of justice and develop a social critique of property relations in Brazil. Second, I examine the way that MTST members test commitment to the movement through evaluations of its moral character and support of their own personal plans. In the concluding sections, I critically evaluate the possible contribution of the sociology of critical capacity to the study of contentious actors like social movements and associated protest publics.

2 The Sociology of Critical Capacity and Social Contention

The research programme initiated by Luc Boltanski and Laurent Thévenot three decades ago has gone by various appellations, but the most promising and relevant for my analysis is the 'sociology of critical capacity' (Boltanski and Thévenot 1999). This attention to 'critical capacity' is often contrasted with the tendency in critical

theory to downplay the critical ability of agents to make judgements, evaluate alternatives and cooperate with others. The sociology of critical capacity thus sought to theorise the rationalisation of judgements, the means by which agreement is reached between disputants and the moral dimensions of cooperation. In *On Justification*, the founding text of the approach, Boltanski and Thévenot develop a flexible framework for the analysis of disputes and agreements, by elaborating 'economies of worth' (Boltanski and Thévenot 2006). Though often described as 'ideal types' (e.g. Jagd 2011), these 'economies of worth' are perhaps more productively considered here as moral-cultural repertoires (Silber 2003) or 'forms of argumentation' (Ricoeur 2000, p. 83) from which actors may draw in the evaluation of everyday events, actions and relationships.

A central premise of the economies of worth approach is that in order to be considered socially legitimate, actors justify actions through drawing on a notion of the good that extends beyond the self, requiring a 'rise in generality'. Boltanski and Thévenot derive six orders of worth (or 'polities') from key texts of political philosophy (2006, p. 67) which specify a plurality of public goods. These include the market polity (whose key theoretician is Adam Smith), the inspired polity (St. Augustine), the polity of renown (Hobbes), the civic polity (Rousseau) and the industrial polity (Saint-Simon). Subsequent research has also expanded these to include the networked order of worth (Boltanski and Chiapello 2005) and a green order of worth, which has accompanied the spread of environmentalism (Thévenot et al. 2000).

The sociology of critical capacity is not only concerned with discursive legitimacy, however. Orders of worth have common requirements for inclusion (Thévenot 2011, p. 44) and correspond to different sets of 'qualified objects', which are used in the course of evaluation and the pursuit of public legitimacy. Boltanski and Thévenot use the term 'worlds' for the combination of the orders of worth and their qualified objects and conventions. The industrial world is composed of factories and manpower (objects), for instance, whose products may be compared according to accepted criteria. There may also be compromises between the orders in any particular evaluation. A product made in a factory, to take one example, may function excellently but be energy inefficient and thus susceptible to criticism according to green evaluative criteria. Further, any evaluation is impermanent, for instance, when the product breaks down, revealing a hitherto unacknowledged flaw in the industrial quality of the machine (e.g. Thévenot 2002, p. 61). There thus may be compromises and uncertainties revealed in the process of evaluation which unfold over time.

Publics may allow groups to stake claims in terms of collective goods that correspond to the orders of worth, perhaps most commonly the egalitarianism of the civic order. But the contestations in which they are engaged may only be partially captured by a framework that is, for my purposes, too narrowly focused on 'the critical practices evident in everyday life' (Boltanski 2013, p. 47). Boltanski and Thévenot have pursued independent research programmes following the publication of *On Justification*, however, that extend the scope for theorising the relationship between the private and the public (Warner 2002) in quite different ways.

Boltanski's interest in the situated ideologies and characteristic critiques of capitalism is particularly relevant for the left-wing actor analysed here (Boltanski 2011, 2013; Boltanski and Chiapello 2005; see also Chiapello 2013). This is so because protestors' claims may be justified through critiques of capitalist relations, the inequalities they generate or the unjust behaviour of elites, rather than in terms of explicitly articulated public goods. Or rather, the public goods which they pursue may only be implicit in their critiques of injustice, particularly as principled demands become embedded in more polarised forms of political contestation. Boltanski and Chiapello identify two principal critiques of capitalism as it has developed since the nineteenth century (2005). The first is a social critique that denounces the material inequalities that are generated through capital accumulation, while the second is an artistic critique that takes aim at the alienation and inauthenticity created through the commoditisation of human labour. Boltanski and Chiapello then historicise the social and historical critiques, arguing that both the artistic and the social critiques lost relevance as capitalism entered a new phase of development after the 1970s.

While Boltanski and Chiapello argue that a new critique of capitalism has been observable from the 1990s on—an argument further elaborated by Paul Blokker (2014)—it is important to recognise the plurality of modern capitalisms (Bruff et al. 2015) and acknowledge that locally developed critiques, social or otherwise, are often historically specific. In this respect Brazil's history of colonialism and elite rule is especially relevant. The elitist and exclusionary nature of Brazilian capitalism is prosaically recognised in much sociological work and forms a core ingredient of political discourse on the left. While there may be debate over the imprint of colonialism on the current moment, it will suffice here to note that actors like the MTST combine elements of colonialism in their critiques of actually existing capitalism and in particular imagery that derives from the old slavocracy (such as the slave-owner's mansion 'a casa grande'). Using elements of this legacy, the MTST articulates a social critique of Brazilian capitalism that urges practical welfare reforms while also underscoring the foundational injustice of Brazilian society.

While Boltanski pursued a broader engagement with capitalism and social critique, Thévenot theorised pragmatic engagements that obtain below the level of public justification and the tensions that emerge as individual actors justify their own actions to others. This quite different line of theorising enables a nuanced analysis of the more intimate and personal dimensions of participation in the MTST than is possible by exclusively focusing on public contestation and critique. I thus complement the orders of worth approach and Boltanski's analysis of critiques with Thévenot's theorisation of 'regimes of engagement', which is a tripartite formulation of agency that broaches the intimate and publicly legitimate forms of pragmatic engagement. This is an important complement to the orders of worth approach, since it allows us to theorise the role of the MTST in rendering individual action plans publicly justifiable—or rather, in moving from 'engagement in a plan' to 'engagement in a justifiable action' (Thévenot 2006).

This bridging between the personal and intimate and the publicly legitimate is important for setting out my use of 'tests', another key element of the approach developed by Boltanski and Thévenot (see Boltanski and Thévenot 2006, p. 40).

Though there are many potential applications to this study, two examples became salient and concern the tests that are employed by activists to critically evaluate the worth of the MTST as they reflect on their motivations for joining and remaining active in it. The first refers to the evaluations of actors concerning their participation in the organisation—that is, interrogations concerning whether it belongs to the world of civic solidarity. The second is a test that concerns the individual action plans of the actors—their 'engagement in a plan'—that arises in moments of doubt over whether the movement complements the actor's own plans. This is a quite different form of test, insofar as it concerns a regime of engagement that is less public than the order of worth (Thévenot 2012, p. 249). The results of both tests, rather than occurring at 'peak moments', were revealed over time, mediating the strengthening of bonds of solidarity and influencing the recruitment and retention of activists.

3 Methods

This chapter draws on 8 months of ethnographic research from December 2015 to August 2016, which included participant observation of social movement meetings at the MTST's headquarters, participation in public protests and site visits to land occupations (Esperença Vermelha and Rosa Luxemburgo in São Paulo and the Glória Occupation in Uberlândia, Minas Gerais). However, the interviews for this chapter were selected from among residents in João Candido, a housing complex in Taboão da Serra, on the outskirts of São Paulo and the first formal settlement that had been constructed by the MTST through a government programme called My House My Life (Minha Casa Minha Vida). These were chosen to show how experienced participants in the movement thought and felt about the MTST even after achieving their goal of permanent housing (many of the other interviewees, that is, those in the new land occupations, were new to the movement). The text also draws on the writings of the movement leader Guilherme Boulos and 25 in-depth interviews with movement activists, coordinators and ethnographic field notes. In the section below, I provide some historical background to the crisis and the MTST before turning to the critiques developed by Guilherme Boulos.

4 Sources of the Crisis

The crisis is partly the result of shifts in the country's political economy over the past decade. Over a period of three terms in office—Luis Ignacio "Lula" da Silva from 2002 to 2006 and 2006 to 2010 and Dilma Rousseff from 2011 to 2014—Presidents of the centre-left Workers' Party led efforts to marry a neo-developmentalist agenda and progressive policies with the neoliberal policy settings inherited from previous administrations. The result, particularly in Lula's second term, was impressive: a

commodities boom helped to fund distributive policies such as Bolsa Família (Family Grant), a conditional cash transfer scheme that provides financial support for low-income families. The minimum wage was increased, and the labour market became more formalised, delivering important benefits for workers such as domestic labourers. Affirmative action policies were also pursued, such as quotas which were introduced for the admission of black students to federal universities. But even though Brazil initially rode out the global financial crisis well (Fernandes and Novy 2010), Dilma's plans to improve domestic, rather than export-based, investment and development failed as the broader global economic downturn that followed it began to bite (Saad-Filho and Boito 2016, pp. 217–219). Brazil's external accounts suffered because of the ongoing commodity crisis and in particular falling demand for soy, iron ore and oil, in part due to China's cooling economy. Further, quantitative easing in the Eurozone, the UK and the USA provoked capital outflows and contributed to the falling value of the real (Saad-Filho 2013, p. 663).

If the country's economic woes provided the tinder, a corruption investigation dubbed Lava Jato (or 'Car Wash' investigation) helped to set it alight. Lava Jato is an ongoing investigation into Brazil's state-owned oil and gas giant, Petrobras, which awarded overvalued contracts to a cartel of companies and redistributed the kickbacks into politicians' campaign finances and personal accounts. Though Rousseff herself was not named in the scandal, she was the chairwoman of Petrobras from 2003 to 2010, leading to widespread media speculation on her complicity in the scheme. Economic downturn, a corruption scandal that directly implicated many of her close allies, and low public approval ratings provided propitious conditions for her political enemies. Thus, the fact that Dilma had window-dressed the public accounts in the lead-up to her successful 2014 presidential election campaign allowed for impeachment proceedings to be launched by the President of the Lower House, Eduardo Cunha, who was in fact named in the Lava Jato investigation. Cunha's push for impeachment was ultimately successful, as Rousseff was suspended from office on 12 May 2016.

The MTST has been a key factor in the political opposition to the impeachment of Dilma Rousseff and the policies pursued by her successor, Michel Temer. I outline its emergence below.

4.1 The Homeless Workers' Movement and My House My Life

From 1997 to 2011, the MTST pursued a practice similar to the Landless Peasants Movement (Movimento de Trabalhadores Rurais Sem-Teto, MST) from which it emerged: it would mobilise a group of movement affiliates and occupy unused land, generally on the periphery of São Paulo, on which it would construct temporary accommodation, with the aim of making more permanent settlements once land ownership had been awarded. This changed in 2011 when the movement decided to

no longer advocate for the construction of informal housing but rather use the land occupation as a symbolic act and political lever which would help in negotiations with government to construct formal housing using a federal housing programme, My House My Life (Minha Casa Minha Vida, MCMV). Temporary plastic and canvas shacks would be erected on the occupied land, but these served only to formalise the occupation, while negotiations would take place with public authorities. This strategy achieved renown when in 2014 the MTST occupied land near São Paulo's World Cup stadium amidst a wave of discontent with preparations for a sporting event that was widely held to be the reserve of the middle/upper classes and claimed it for development via MCMV. The occupation—called 'World Cup of the People'—was accompanied by a strong media campaign, which bolstered the MTST's public profile (see Magnani 2015).

MCMV is a large federal housing programme that incurs high public debt (see Dias 2015) but that works through market actors—effecting a compromise between the market and civic world (e.g. Thévenot 2014, p. 17). This put a high value on land in peripheral areas of the city that would be suitable for MCMV developments, which predictably led to increased speculation and an inflation of land prices, as developers could be virtually guaranteed strong returns on cheap housing produced in dormitory zones on the periphery. MCMV Entities (Minha Casa Minha Vida, Entidades) is a branch of the MCMV programme and applies uniquely to the lowest income bracket applicable (up to 1600 BRL per family per month). The 'entity', be it a social movement, civic association or cooperative, would take on broad-ranging responsibilities: everything from selecting possible building sites, negotiating with developers, managing possible residents and delivering the keys to the new occupiers (Rizek et al. 2014, p. 532). While the 'Entities' branch of MCMW has in general produced better-quality developments than when the coordinating role is provided by real-estate developers—a point that allows for claims of industrial worth—the broader pattern for low-income housing that is produced is easy to make out: almost all of the low-income housing settlements occur on the periphery of the city (Hirata and Oliveira 2012; Marques and Rodrigues 2015; Rolnik 2015, p. 313).

In the following section, I examine some of the key texts that justify the movement's occupation of underutilised land.

4.2 Justifying Land Occupations

As the principal tactic of the movement is the occupation of unused land, the MTST must challenge dominant norms concerning property acquisition. In the preface to his short text *Why We Occupy* (Boulos 2014), Boulos acknowledges the popular expectation that since the property owners of unused land were likely to have legally purchased the land, then so too ought MTST. This is the 'principle of equivalence' on which property relations are founded in the market world: that the same processes for the exchange of ownership should apply to all parties. The capacity of the movement to legitimate its own claims and tactics rests on an ability to demonstrate

that these same rules should not apply to the poor and that equivalent rules for property acquisition reinforce inequalities and the disenfranchisement of the homeless.

The move throughout the text is to reveal the housing deficiencies in the country and the sources of socio-economic inequality that gave rise to them. Boulos often references the right to dignified housing which is specified in Article 6 of the 1988 Federal Constitution and critiques the realisation of this right through the real-estate market. The MCMV programme is, Boulos recognises through quoting ex-President Lula, an attempt to reconcile the right to housing and the jobs provided through the construction industry (Boulos 2014, p. 22). But it is a failed reconciliation because the programme deepens dependence on the market, which has led to the overvaluation of land, and encourages the construction of housing far from places of work and basic public amenities (Marques and Rodrigues 2015).

Boulos analyses the strategies of property speculators, who have in some cases obtained the land through falsely claiming land ownership via manufactured legal claims, a practice called 'grilhagem' (see Holston 1991, 2008, pp. 139–142); who strategically purchase land around new commercial developments in anticipation of increasing demand; and who, through demolishing and rebuilding in central areas of the city, have raised rents and thrust the poor onto the periphery (Boulos 2014, pp. 27–28). In so doing, Boulos advances theories that are common in studies of Brazilian inequality and indeed in other critiques of capitalism (Boltanski and Chiapello 2005, pp. 36–37; Boltanski 2011, p. 11), by unearthing how the formally egalitarian instruments of the Brazilian state are used for private ends. Another recurrent theme is the association of the state and large capital. This is another important trope in left politics in Brazil as elsewhere, just as it is quite inevitable. The MCMV programme, for instance, was specifically designed to jumpstart the economy through providing jobs, many of which, at least in the initial phase of the programme, have gone to large- and medium-size construction companies (Hirata 2009; Dias 2015, p. 771; Rolnik 2015, p. 305).

The direct-action tactics of the MTST, however, are often criticised by those who draw on their own experiences to argue that land acquisition should be mediated exclusively via market exchanges. For example, Boulos gives one example where a neighbour of an occupation asks how, after working his whole life to pay for his home, a social movement can come and occupy land without having to work for it: 'Do you think that it is just to invade this land and take me off it? It is the same thing' (my translation, Boulos 2014, p. 42). The justificatory response is a historical one. The original land invaders were the Portuguese who divided Brazil into 'capitanias', which were then distributed to aristocrats with the aim of channelling profits made therein back to Portugal. The tactics pursued by the elites in urban regions was, for Boulos, quite similar: powerful families seized lands via 'grilhagem', which then became the source of profits which prejudiced the interests of workers. Landownership, according to this analysis, has routinely been based on occupation, but through its alliance with the state, the landowning elite has acquired the legitimising seal of legality.

This land invasion could not be justified through reference to the individual neighbour who had worked hard to purchase neighbouring land and construct his home. It needed to be cast in a 'higher level of generality' (Boltanski and Thévenot 2006, p. 33), if there was to be no awkward recognition that the neighbour life's work had helped to prop up an inherently unjust regime of property relations and socio-spatial inequality. The corresponding text thus makes no mention of the neighbour's life choices, or his complicity in this regime, and only mentions the ideological effect of mass media, which demonises the organisation of the poor and those who resist the political status quo (Boulos 2014, pp. 42–44). However, this 'rise in generality' does not draw on principles of justice but rather gives an historical account that undermines the claims of the market order, as it generally applies to Brazilian society, in addition to advancing a metacritique of mainstream media.

The regime of private property rights is further critiqued through showing how it is only variably upheld by the legal establishment (see Nash 2014, p. 356). For example, in an article entitled 'Who are the invaders?', Boulos identifies several instances where companies, private clubs, shopping centres, banks and supermarkets have been established through the 'irregular use of land' (Boulos 2015, pp. 34–35). Citing a Parliamentary Commission into the irregular use of public land, Boulos mentions the Continental, Eldorado and Centre North Shopping Centres, which all irregularly occupied public land and which were legitimised by judges after the fact, occasionally to the shock of other legal observers. Major bank agencies in prime locations in the west of São Paulo were also constructed on lots which illegally extended into public lands. Even the headquarters of the State Association of Magistrates was constructed with 'irregularities in the concession of use', prompting Boulos to ask whether 'rubber bullets will be fired on the illustrious judges' (my translation, Boulos 2015, p. 35). Here the justificatory tactic is to challenge the universalism of the law through satirically drawing on examples that liken the transgressive moves of the MTST with the actions of other major commercial and professional actors.

Such writings and their iterations in other presentational forms seek to publicly legitimise land occupations by building on established social critiques of inequality in Brazil. These serve to break down the 'principle of equivalence' on which market exchanges are based, through outlining the long history of land seizures by elites and by showing how differently the privileged are treated for similar legal infractions. The activities of the MTST are thus justified both through intermittently employing principles of justice and by undermining the universal claims of the market order, as part of a larger metacritique of Brazilian property relations. In this way the movement enables the mediation between individual participants and the expectations that obtain in the public sphere (Warner 2002).

Next I examine some of the more personal ways by which activists interrogate the worth of the movement and give their own, more intimate justifications of continued participation in the MTST.

4.3 Nested Plans and Tests

The broad, publicly available frames of the MTST are articulated by its leadership, who are active on social media and in constant touch with political events on the national and international scene. Boulos' analysis is one which, despite the odd rhetorical flourish, would be at home in historical analyses of Brazilian inequality (see Abreu 2014; Secco 2014), anchoring the MTST's claims in shared understandings with some public legitimacy. But how are such framings of the MTST's goals, and justifications of its transgressive nature, shared by rank-and-file members, who must negotiate between their own individual action plans and the justificatory frames elaborated by the leaders? In this section, activists give their own justifications of continued association with the MTST, even after they have acquired apartments through MCMV.

Many of the participants had had little prior experience in social activism. Luciano, for instance, gives a narrative of initiation into the MTST that was typical in its apolitical nature:

> I had never heard of the MTST and not even of this kind of movement. My intention was just to invade [vacant land] and construct an informal shack, and go there to live. This was my intention. One day I was leaving work and I passed an area that the MTST had invaded, on which it had constructed a camp. I saw a lot of people there, camped out, and didn't understand what it was about.

Participation in the MTST complemented Luciano's existing plan of making a home for himself. While he had never heard of the movement before becoming involved, he remained active in the movement even after obtaining an apartment in João Candido, for the shared sense of purpose with others involved in the MTST and also because his brothers were now involved but had not yet secured housing.

> I was able to get housing and I want others to get it as well. My brothers are involved as well and they participate. So when there is a protest I go because I want them to get it as well. Many still have not got an apartment because there weren't opportunities for everyone, and others didn't get it because they didn't believe in it. Then when they see that the movement really is *honest* and *functions*, everyone wants to return [my emphasis].

Faith in the 'honesty' of the MTST was not something, for Luciano, which was granted spontaneously. Rather, Luciano reflects elsewhere in the interview that he initially doubted the intentions of the organisers and only after proof of its moral character was provided did he begin to believe, and a more trusting relationship ensued. However, faith in the movement did not mean that Luciano explicitly espoused the Marxist aims of the MTST, that is, its critique of unequal property relations and capitalism in Brazil more broadly—something he suggested should be left to 'great men and women' (grandões). His involvement was thus linked to faith in the integrity of the movement and its ability to secure housing rather than the larger anticapitalist ideology espoused by the leaders. But what might this 'honesty' mean, more specifically?

Eduardo speaks much more directly about his doubts concerning the moral character of the movement when he observes:

> So when I stayed in the camp, I began to think that the movement will want to swallow our money [of the people camped out]; but Guilherme came to us and said 'We don't want one *real* from you; we don't want money from anyone,' and from then until now no-one ever asked for one cent from anyone. Then I started to believe in the movement, which is not interested in money, only in the struggle... And I stayed and believed. The movement never took one cent from my wallet; the ideal is only to struggle.

While the same idea was implied by Luciano, Eduardo more directly states his concern that the leaders may have merely been seeking to advance their own monetary interests. In Eduardo's comment, 'money' is in clear opposition to 'struggle'. That is, the test that the movement must pass requires the separation of values that belong to the two different orders of worth—the profiteering of the market world and the egalitarian solidarity of the civic world. The test was not a kind of 'peak moment' when insight into the character of the movement could be gleaned; rather it was a test over time, in ongoing engagements in which the moral character of the movement was revealed in practice.

The pecuniary interests of the leaders were not the only, or indeed the main, concern of the participants. Eduardo, for example, had grave doubts about his continued participation in the movement, which arose through the hardships he experienced in the camp and the length of time it took to secure housing.

> I thought more than once about quitting because I lost my job, I was unemployed, I was struggling. Have you ever thought about going two or three days without taking a shower, in the bush, with that kind of difficulty? You have to have a lot of determination. It is not easy. You need to have courage and to be really needy... It was not only I [who thought about quitting]; everyone thought about it.

Here Eduardo reveals some of the hardships he endured and the doubts that he had over the movement's ability to make good on its (and his) plan to provide formal housing. This is another form of test, one that concerns the pursuit of 'individual plans of engagement', aggregated through movement activity, which were also revealed over time. Eduardo's account underscores the temporal dimension of personal justifications, and the constant interplay among evaluations of everyday experiences, faith that objectives will be attained and the diffusion of discursive justifications by the movement coordinators (see Green 2004, p. 658).

Since the movement explicitly seeks to provide housing for its members, it is of little surprise that questions about its ability to deliver were constantly raised by participants of this study. But there were also interrogations about its moral character, whether it did indeed belong to the world of civic solidarity or whether it constituted a source of profit for the leaders. The successful responses to both of these questions among many of the residents of João Candido ensured their continued participation in the movement even after they had achieved their own apartment. They did not necessarily espouse the formal aims of the movement, or its broader critique of inequality, but rather rationalised their own involvement in the movement in ways that were compatible with these broader aims by identifying it as part of the civic world. In this way, the MTST helped to broker individual action plans on the public stage, forming a key intermediary between different sociopolitical worlds.

5 Justification Work and the Sociology of Critical Capacity

In the previous sections, I showed how the MTST combined principles of justice and equal treatment with a broader social critique of property relations in Brazil. However, it did not weave these critiques into a larger conception of justice based around rights to property, which would require a thorough elaboration of the tests necessary for the maintenance of property rights. In this regard Kate Nash's critique of the absence of a treatment of human rights and the state in Boltanski and Thévenot's work is relevant (Nash 2014). Nash holds that human rights constitute a vital polity in modern life and that they meet important criteria for orders of worth set out in *On Justification*. Human rights discourse meets the criterion of applying to humanity in general, with 'no human being left out', but it does not meet the criterion of having gradations of eligibility. However, where human rights posit a set of fundamental expectations that govern one's treatment by the state and should not be subject to qualification, social rights *are* often subject to gradations, or criteria of eligibility, based on the common good, such as geographic location, means testing of income and so on. This kind of qualified specification may be advocated by more institutionalised social movements or political actors. But the MTST does not specifically advocate for other standardised tests for property use, other than that they be in productive use. Rather, the MTST identifies unused land as symptomatic of broader structures of sociopolitical injustice—taking aim at the 'totality of the existing order' (Blokker and Brighenti 2011, p. 294)—which can be locally alleviated through land occupation and the construction of housing. The justifications employed by MTST organisers are thus not easily captured by the orders of worth approach.

Paul Blokker and Andrea Brighenti (2011) have provided a relevant addition to Boltanski and Thévenot's project in two ways: first, by bringing it into greater dialogue with political institutionalisation or politics-as-constitution and second, by positing dissent and resistance as contributions to Boltanski's work, as 'dimensions of critique'. Dissent refers to a critical posture towards institutionalised politics, as it critiques existing 'narratives of foundation' or other attempts at achieving semantic closure or the casting of the liberal-democratic project as the finished product. Dissent works towards the correction not merely of existing democratic procedures but also 'structural problems' that may not be compatible with dominant legal discourses and associated forms of control. Resistance, Blokker and Brighenti hold, can be considered the work of hampering and resisting what others accept. Further, resistance is associated with violence and violent acts, since they involve transgressions of social and possibly legal norms (Blokker and Brighenti 2011, pp. 294–296).

In this way resistance and dissent do not accord with the economies of worth and thus suggest alternate counter-narratives and practices that enable some collective actors to contest elements of the dominant order, at times in co-operation with others. This was indeed the case with the MTST during the crisis in Brazil that has been ongoing since 2013. While it has been a key protagonist on the political stage, it has formed part of a larger coalition of actors, some institutionalised, such as the People

Without Fear ('Povo Sem Medo') front of social actors, while others were less institutionalised and rely on more spontaneous protests around issues of common concern, such as the impeachment of Dilma Rousseff or PEC 181, a constitutional amendment to cap government spending. As a part of these protest publics, the MTST that is works at the interstices of resistance and dissent, through a confrontational kind of politics that changes conditions on the ground but then can also seek peaceful resolution through negotiation and the use of government programmes.

6 Justifying Movements and Protests

This case study of the MTST has considered the potential for the sociology of critical capacity to account for the justification work of movements and associated protest publics, through theorising the negotiations between private and public realms. A key contribution of the approach to scholarship on political contestation is the range and scale of justifications that are theorised across diverse social spaces. Operating below the level of public justification, Thévenot accounts for how individual actors act and organise life in their familiar milieu (or regime) away from the scrutiny of others and how they pursue plans, which are future-oriented and which involve coordination with others and with oneself. This theorisation of planning as a kind of strategic investment expands the notion of instrumental rationality that has currency in social movement studies (e.g. Klandermans 2005). It also enables us to examine how people's action plans become entangled with social collectivities that may espouse quite different aims, providing the 'imperative for justification' required of public discourse. The sociology of critical capacity thus allows for a complex account of how demands that emerge in private life and social collectives come to be expressed on the public stage (see Alexander 1996).

And yet I believe that much of the analysis of public disputes inspired by this tradition would rankle scholars of protest and contentious politics. In part this is due to the developed framework found in *On Justification*, the use of which implies a sacrifice, directing attention away from the emergent to the established and inviting interpretations of protest actors according to existing moral-political repertoires. This kind of moral-political modelling enables comparison, but it may have limited relevance to subaltern actors who critique and undermine—rather than invoke—conventional forms of justification. The rise in generality required by justification may draw on histories and experiences of inequity and exclusion rather than principles of justice, narrowly defined. Rather than the invocation of existing moral principles, such 'agitational campaigns' (Fraser 1990, p. 157)—particularly in the times of crisis examined here—consist in an ongoing struggle in which actors dynamically employ an array of tactics and discourses that justify their own positions (see Jaspers 1997). These may have established components, such as denunciations of the injustices produced by the market world, while also creatively engaging with events as they unfold and revealing inconsistencies in the pronouncements of opponents.

Acknowledgments The chapter was prepared within the framework of the Academic Fund Program at the National Research University Higher School of Economics (HSE) in 2016–2017 (grant № 17-05-0018) and by the Russian Academic Excellence Project "5-100". Victor received funding via the São Paulo Research Foundation (grant no. 15/14474-0). This chapter is a revised version of a paper that appeared in *European Journal of Cultural and Political Sociology*, 2018, 5(1–2), pp. 194–217.

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So Strong, yet So Weak: The Emergence of Protest Publics in Iceland in the Wake of the Financial Crisis



Jón Ólafsson

1 Introduction: It's About Trust

In his classical piece on civil disobedience, Henry David Thoreau argues that civic duties go beyond simply expressing or affirming one's opinion in a system which will then either select or reject that opinion. He writes: "I cast my vote perchance, as I think right; but I am not vitally concerned that the right will prevail. I am willing to leave it to the majority. . . . Even voting for the right thing is doing nothing for it" (Thoreau 1970, p. 460). Moreover, once the majority has finally come to vote for the right cause, it most probably shows that the issue itself has become irrelevant for some reason of "expediency." Thoreau remains convinced that majority opinion, even if right, may just as well be for the wrong reason.

Thoreau's moral stance places civic duty above democratic procedure—even if not above democracy itself. A democratic government has limited power, and one of the limitations on its power is the demands of justice and morality. Citizens have limited means to control government, yet a duty exists to make every effort to prevent government from committing "enormous injustice." Thoreau's thinking was fueled by moral outrage over both the US war efforts at the time against Mexico and institutional slavery. It is in his view inconceivable that any citizen could be satisfied with simply being in a minority on such fundamental issues. The citizen's duty in the face of such "enormous injustice" is to do what is possible to prevent it without regard to consequences for himself or herself.

Trust is at the heart of Thoreau's concern. The majority rule based on procedural integrity is meant to provide a system of decision-making where the citizen has a well-defined role in influencing choice but must also recognize the limits of this role and trust government. But to trust is not to acquiesce in immoral policies—it rather

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N. Belyaeva et al. (eds.), *Protest Publics*, Societies and Political Orders in Transition,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5_8

implies a civic duty to refuse to go along with such policies regardless of majority opinion.

Thoreau's moral outrage provides an interesting analogy with the public outrage in Iceland after the financial collapse of 2008. Differences about policy issues were perceived at a much deeper level than previously and elites seen as having betrayed public trust. Now a decade later, it may seem a little difficult to fully grasp the magnitude and depth of the outrage, which spurred months of grassroots activity and permanently changed the Icelandic political landscape after the crisis. Countries go through economic crises without revolutions—what was so special in Iceland? Trust is central: the financial collapse showed how badly trust had been misplaced—and that created a moral outrage. In a Thoreauean fashion, protesters seemed spontaneously to find a common ground in protesting the "enormous injustice" done by technically bankrupting the country and leaving a large part of the population exposed to the caprice of financial institutions (see Sveinsson 2013, p. 223).

In street protests, a full moral reversal was loudly demanded as well as an open acknowledgment of guilt. Thus, the financial crash, which almost led to a national bankruptcy, caused a crisis, much deeper than any previous economic crisis in Iceland. It was not the economic crisis as such that led to prolonged protest action (Bernburg 2016, p. 11). The danger of national bankruptcy—quite real for some time—was averted, and economic recovery came relatively quickly. But trust did not return, and criticism of government, expressed so vocally when the crisis hit, was transformed into—as it seems—a permanently cynical view of party politics and government policies (Johnsen and Sigurgeirsdóttir 2018). Therefore, I will argue that the collapse of trust in government experienced by a previously rather acquiescent public in Iceland transformed the political environment by the emergence of an easily mobilized "protest public," i.e., a public unsuppressed by the elite structure of representative politics and able to self-organize when confronted with oppressive or corrupt policies and practices. I will also show, however, that even if authorities have had to reckon with this new reality, it has not—so far—led to a deeper change in democratic politics.

I will first explain how moral outrage appears as an underlying issue in protest action and political demands by groups that were activated by the crisis. Next, I will discuss expectations and subsequent disappointment of a reform-minded public. I will then give an overview of democratic innovations as well as activist groups and postcrisis parties, whose success strongly indicates an erosion of established political structures with the emergence of protest publics, and finally I will show how the political establishment remains unbroken, although the constantly open possibility of mass mobilization has left its mark on democratic politics and has certainly created a political role for a new kind of publics—being empowered by a series of successful protest, where government policy has actually been shifted as a result of protest action and clearly expressed, yet spontaneous, public unity. January 2009 was only the beginning. The Icesave referenda in 2010 and 2011 are also among these cases, and so is action spurred by EU membership application disputes in 2014 and the Panama Papers scandal in 2016.

2 Moral Mobilization

Surveys made during the crisis suggested that it had caused family life and social justice to be valued more and money and material goods less than had been the case during the years of economic boom. Some public commentators even argued that the crisis had led to a reflective engagement about values of life, which suggested that in some sense the crisis also had positive effects (Jóhannesson 2009, p. 359). The importance of common values was frequently the topic of public debates, and some groups even argued that Icelanders should find a way to commonly articulate some fundamental values of Icelandic society, in an effort to restore the "social contract" (see Mauraþúfan 2009).

Before the crisis political and media discourse was bristling with self-congratulatory rhetoric, where for some the main task was to explain why the Icelandic nation had turned out to be so great and successful (see, e.g., Forsætisráðuneyti 2008; Winterman 2006). After the crisis of 2008, however, a more realistic self-image appeared. Icelanders now saw themselves as victims of greed, corruption, and incompetence. Monitoring agencies were paralyzed and the authorities both unable and unwilling to deal with that situation (Sigurgeirsdottir and Wade 2012; Gylfason 2013a).

The attention to basic moral and social values—moral condemnation of the government, which had not only failed to avert the crisis (no one argued that it could have) but failed both to honestly acknowledge the danger and to prepare the country institutionally and politically—created a situation where moral improvement was loudly demanded as a necessary step in renewing the democratic system (Boyes 2009). Community trust became the opposite of trust in government: trust in fellow citizens seemed to grow as trust in government collapsed. Thus, it would seem that serious and detailed reform plans, even if radical, could have been successfully proposed by activist groups (Jeffrey et al. 2015, pp. 6–8).

The series of events that since have been referred to as the "pots and pans revolution" can be seen as the direct consequence of this double reversal of trust where the citizens turned away from the government and to each other. Facing public distrust on an unprecedented scale, the government resigned in early 2009 (Bergmann 2014, pp. 145–146). The nature of these events was quite different from the kind of protest seen in other European countries at the same time. While street action never degenerated into violence and the political changes were all within the constitutional order, public action from October 2008, when the crisis hit, to February 2009, when the government collapsed, was widely perceived to be revolutionary, a collapse—at least temporary—of political order (see Sveinsson 2013; Magnússon 2013).

Widespread and deep distrust of institutions and administrative and political practices fundamentally changed the relations between the government and public (Vilhelmsdóttir and Kristinsson 2018). Between 1991 and 2008, Iceland had a stable center-right government led by the liberal conservative Independence Party. During this time the opposition was unorganized and without much influence on policy-making. As the Independence Party changed its coalition partner in 2007 from the

rural-based Progressive Party to the Social Democrats, a certain shift toward more socially oriented politics was expected by some, but the change was largely cosmetic—with the Social Democrats filling a vacuum left by the Progressives (Pálsson 2007). When three Icelandic banks—with huge international portfolios—went bankrupt just a year later and had to be taken over by the government, the policies shaped by the Independence Party, which in previous years had been seen as successful, were exposed: policies of the government in the years of the economic boom preceding the crisis including the privatization of banks were now seen as faulty or—worse—as fraudulent (Gylfason 2013a; Johnsen 2016).

The debates in the media, on the streets, and on the emerging social media were dominated by grassroots activists who called for a radical revision of Iceland's political culture, but participation was steadily growing (Bernburg 2016, p. 49). Public discussion was transformed. It reached the level of the political: instead of ordinary (ontic) debate about policies, values were discussed at a deeper (ontological) level (Mouffe 2005, p. 9). Abstract concepts became the common currency: public discussion frequently made explicit reference to a (now broken) "social contract" (Júlíusson and Helgason 2013). It was asked what fundamental reforms were necessary to renew such a contract, and it was not seen as extreme or marginal to demand total social and political renewal even to the extent of founding a "new republic" (Njarðvík 2009, 2010). The mood was hostile to the government in general—it was not an expression of a desire for dialogue or a more deliberative discursive environment but rather about other forms of control: about ways to engage the public directly in decision-making (Rushton 2014).

This—partly—presented a populist appeal to the "public will," but interestingly many activists referred more to the epistemic justification of participatory approaches than to a necessity to subject policies to direct populist control (Ólafsson 2016).

The goal at first was therefore not to reach an "ideal deliberative consensus" but to establish a new hegemony through which corrupt and incompetent public institutions could be overtaken and subjected to decision-making truly committed to the common good. Therefore, the moral outrage was directed not toward the moral discourse underlying deliberative aspects of representative democracy but rather toward political discourse as such, seeking to transform it and break the dominance of elites empowered by the party system. So here we have the revolutionary element—a total transformation of political discourse—which would submit decision-making to public control thereby ensuring a corresponding moral transformation (Guðmundsson 2009). This also made the symbolic power of pots and pans so strong: the presentation of pragmatism and common sense—kitchen logic.

The financial collapse radicalized grassroots movements in Iceland to an extent that had hardly been seen in Northern Europe since the interwar years. They also changed the political dialogue since their aim was to change the rules and culture of democratic politics—not only to create a civic/government forum for public engagement. The public mood was—to use Chantal Mouffe's term—antagonistic (Mouffe 2000). Activist groups and the emerging protest publics aimed at shattering elite solidarity—to replace the elites. This is what made the situation in Iceland—for a

while—similar to the situation in some Eastern European countries during the fall of Communism. Nothing less than wholesale revision of social and political values was demanded. The first part of this transformative enterprise was successful. Overnight protest became a part of the political vocabulary, i.e., if previously protest action had been limited to social movements, it was now a part of a much more general public engagement. The second part however, as I will argue, was less successful than the first.

3 Expectations of a Newly Emerged Protest Public

One of the most visible events expressing civic outrage in the wake of the 2008 crisis was a "citizens' meeting" in the largest cinema theatre in Reykjavík where a newly founded citizens' association invited all MPs, including government ministers, to participate in a discussion about the crisis and its causes. The hall was packed and large crowds also gathered outside where it was possible to see on a big screen what was going on in the hall itself. The meeting was also broadcast directly by national TV. First some invited speakers gave short talks on which the politicians were then invited to comment. They and speakers then took questions from the audience.[1]

Most of the MPs who belonged to the coalition parties came only reluctantly to the meeting. Some of them however saw it as something they simply could not ignore—even though they were skeptical about the new grassroots movements. These encounters and the discussion that evolved between the politicians, the activist speakers, and the people in the audience were rather awkward and in some cases involved mockery and cynicism rather than respectful exchange of views (Fréttablaðið 2008).

The audience eventually got quite upset when the foreign minister, who was also the leader of one of the coalition parties—the Social Democrats—suggested that the audience could not claim to represent "the people," rather it represented simply themselves.[2] The reaction to this comment was quite hostile at the meeting itself and in the days that followed it also was widely ridiculed on social media and elsewhere. Activists and civic groups saw it as illustrating the gap between the government and the public. It can also be seen as the classic example of a politician failing to understand changes as they happen. The ministers were faced with a new kind of public, not the somewhat irritable and argumentative groups they were used to

[1]The meeting was a part of a series of meetings organized by a new organization, the Civic Action Association. The meetings were well documented, and considerable material about them can be found on the group's website, borgarafundur.info. See http://www.borgarafundur.info/?page_id=51 for recordings of the meeting discussed here, which was held on 24 November 2008.

[2]An amateur recording of the remarks is available on youtube.com, "Púað á Ingibjörgu Sólrúnu." Her exact words were (my translation): "I am not sure that those in the audience can necessarily claim to be talking on behalf of the nation, or have the right to... [booing and shouting from the audience] ... that's it."

dealing with, but with activists who had not necessarily engaged in any political activity before the crisis and who saw themselves as representing not the public in some numerical sense but the moral indignation caused by the government's betrayal. Eventually the unrest on the streets, constant criticism of the government, and increasing distrust toward the public administration created insecurity within the coalition parties themselves. Finally, the Social Democrats pulled out and the government collapsed.

All put together it seems fair to say that public criticism of the government, both of its pre-crisis policies and its reaction to the crisis which came from grassroots movements and directly from the public in citizen meetings and demonstrations and on social media, was sharp, focused, and widely shared. The crisis was of course understood to be caused by the international situation through which the Icelandic banks had become insolvent. But it was not an international financial crisis that caused the unrest in Iceland, but rather two characteristics of Icelandic politics and public service: incompetence and corruption. These two explanations of how badly Iceland had handled the crisis were frequently expressed:

1. The public administration had failed because of incompetence caused partly by a long tradition of corrupt hiring practices. Governing parties had consistently politicized key appointments—ranked loyalty and support over professional ability, education, and experience (WGE 2010, pp. 141–143; Gylfason 2013a, p. 402).
2. Deep and long-standing corruption among top members of the political elite meant that some of the privatizations (including the banks') for which Iceland had been lauded internationally had in fact been a handing out of public property to favored individuals and groups (Bernburg and Víkingsdóttir 2016, pp. 88–89).

As the crisis evolved, incompetence and corruption were more and more seen to necessitate a complete overhaul of the political system. New practices would have to be created within the government and in the public sector in general. A new government should be committed to improving politics through systemic reforms, both political and administrative (Boyes 2009, pp. 192–195).

The expectations that these goals were possible came from the new grassroots and activist groups. Yet it was not obvious to everyone that the economic crisis should be seen as necessitating such change, even given the loudly expressed moral outrage. In the months after the collapse of the banks, many had argued to the contrary claiming that it was both for the best of the country and the responsibility of the sitting government that it should deal with the crisis, not run away from it. As grassroots activity increased and more became public about how the government had failed to do what it could have done to reduce the risk that the banks would bring down the Icelandic economy, the less convincing was the argument that the same government should continue (Jóhannesson 2009, pp. 288–289). But protesters and activists did not follow up on this—the transition to a new minority government followed not only constitutional norms but was fully according to established political tradition. That was also the end of the revolution. One argument frequently made during this period was based on the observation that the financial sector was heavily male

dominated in Iceland as elsewhere and that in fact men were to blame for the financial collapse. This leads to a demand that women's leadership should be sought in the restoration of the Icelandic economy and female values emphasized. A movement named "Women's Emergency Government" was founded to strengthen this platform, but its effects were minor (Pálsdóttir 2008).

The pots and pans revolution was eventually contained by the political elites—without much effort as it seemed, after the change of government, when the parties of the left, the Left-Green Movement and the Social Democrats, came to power. The relative ease with which the two leftist parties took over spurred suspicions on the right wing that the demonstrations in the weeks before had been stage directed by leading figures of the Left-Green party, which had not been part of government before (Bragason 2015, p. 62). These suspicions were unfounded but understandable given the conspiratorial atmosphere and the humiliating downfall of the Independence Party. Leftist MPs were often accused of inappropriate liaison with protesters (Sveinsson 2013, p. 225). Later on, frustration also emerged among the activist public where the feeling became widespread that the pots and pans revolution was unfinished—a revolution cut short by a political system which remained stable (Sveinsson 2013, pp. 72–73). After a brief period of a left-wing minority government, the parties forming it got a slim majority in fresh parliamentary elections. Although activist leaders continued to insist on the need for a revolution and revolutionary change and various scenarios of renewal were suggested, no plans seem to have been harbored by any group about some kind of nonconstitutional paths to such renewal (Þorsteinsson 2016).

Given the circumstances which brought the leftist government to power, its task was fairly complicated—if not impossible. Not only were there a collapsed economy to bring on its feet again and an international reputation in shambles—which meant, e.g., low credit rating and therefore extremely difficult loan conditions. The grassroots movements continued to be highly active pressing for political renewal including serious efforts to create participatory mechanisms, seen by many as the way to rebuild trust and prevent the formation of a new government-business coalition against public interest. The new left-wing government also showed all indications in its rhetoric of wanting to institute major political reforms, bringing the government closer to the people: first hiring policies would be changed to ensure that the most competent (rather than the most loyal) people would be recruited. Then decisions would be made more transparent to ensure integrity (Fréttablaðið 2009).

The new government also pledged to work on changing the culture of debate and policy-making within government and legislature and to increase public consultation. In short, the government promised to make democracy more deliberative in an effort to create a national unity around an economic renewal (Stjórnarráðið 2009a). A deliberative model is based on consensus on certain basic issues where parties to public debate refrain from polemics and useless antagonisms. Such a model thus requires not only that the participants see themselves as having a common goal and sincerely wanting to work toward it. They also must interpret the goal, their interests, views, and values in a similar way and have the same or at least very similar measure of success (Gutmann and Thompson 2004).

The new government thus wanted to show itself to be committed to working with the groups that had created political atmosphere in which its taking power looked like the conclusion of a successful revolution. The goals outlined in the first coalition agreement between the Social Democratic Alliance and the Left-Green Movement were described in more detail in a second agreement, made after these two parties were able to form a majority government after elections were held in April 2009. The coalition agreements therefore seemed to begin with to concur with the demands from the street although made in a language that lacked revolutionary undertones except insofar as leftist policies were announced and a commitment to fostering a Nordic welfare society (Stjórnarráðið 2009b).

The government however clearly underestimated the distrust toward the political establishment caused by the crisis. Its declared goals may have been too lofty and too ambitious. While they spoke to the demands of the street protest, they did not suffice to bridge the gap between grassroots and government. The lack of a clear political agenda does not mean that there were no clear expectations. Activists, fueled by moral outrage, also had moral goals, and the expectation was that the new government would fulfill some (or all) of those goals. Moreover, the leftist government was not averse to these goals. But to ensure success, activists and public organizations needed to work together—the government needed to recognize the "new" public—and from their side, activists needed to transit from antagonism to agonism. This however did not happen, and, arguably, the government lost the opportunity to win over the public. That could in part explain its unpopularity, which had become considerable already within the first year after its formation.

If the pre-crisis, acquiescent (dominated) public is seen as a counter-public transformed by the crisis (the pots-and-pans-wielding ordinary people become a dominant public), the government seems severely limited by its inability to face this new reality. It continues the suspicion expressed by the foreign minister at the citizens' meeting. As a result, the deliberative moment is lost, and the protest public remains stuck in its role of reacting to government proposals (Peshkopia 2008, p. 33; Dewey 2008, pp. 233–234).

4 The Special Investigation Commission and a Constituent Assembly

So far, I have tried to show how what was seen as the particular Icelandic failure in responding to the international crisis caused widespread moral outrage, which led to spontaneous grassroots activity, and group formation that transformed political engagement. The central parliament square in Reykjavík served as a regular gathering spot, and when action was at its height, the whole city center was bustling with activity.

The government responded in two ways to the strong demand for a moral renewal: first by appointing a committee—sometimes compared to South Africa's

Truth and Reconciliation Commission—to investigate what had gone wrong before the crisis and second (this happened after the change of government) by passing a law on the election of a Constituent Assembly to revise the Icelandic constitution.

The so-called Special Investigation Commission was formed in December 2008 to investigate how Iceland's government and public administration had failed and what could explain that the Icelandic government was neither prepared for the acute crisis of the banking system nor for the aftermath, although the Icelandic leadership had received sufficient information at home and abroad to show clearly that such preparations were needed. The report subsequently published, detailed the faults in how the Icelandic governmental practice had developed over the years. A specially appointed Working Group on Ethics worked with the Commission to provide an ethical analysis in addition to the report itself (SIC 2010a; Johnsen 2014; Árnason 2010).

The WGE report concluded, among other things, that Icelandic politics had been immature and Icelandic politicians had failed to develop the discursive culture of democracy where its debates present attempts to reach the best solution rather than an attempt to convince the audience and defeat the opponent. Various characteristics of Icelandic political and administrative traditions are then detailed to reveal practices that either reflected incompetence, corruption, or both (WGE 2010, pp. 179–180).

The findings of the investigative commission largely concurred with the demands from grassroots activists. One obvious conclusion from reading the report concerned democracy itself. It was clear that the government had failed both because of a lack of democratic as well as administrative competence but also that it had become a victim of systemic corruption since it had in fact more and more come to see itself in the role of serving the interests of Iceland's international companies, rather than being accountable to the public directly.

The Special Investigation Commission saw it as one of the main tasks of an Icelandic postcrisis government to professionalize public administration. But it did not see increased democratic participation or direct public engagement in policy- and decision-making as an important goal. It therefore in fact failed to address the deep democratic discontent that the crisis had created and grassroots movements most strongly expressed. The Commission, whose members were two senior legal specialists and a professor of economics, recommended some legal and economic action. The Working Group on Ethics—composed of the specialists on ethics and one historian—emphasized that institutional structures needed to be strengthened (SIC 2010b; Árnason 2010, p. 119; WGE 2010, pp. 242–243). Neither the commission nor the working group emphasized public engagement or recommended that the government should reach out to different groups that had been instrumental in creating an atmosphere that made governmental change inescapable.

Therefore, even though regular protest action died down once a new government had been formed, the dissonance between democratic rhetoric and democratic demands on the one hand, evolving governmental policy on the other, steadily grew. The government however made one move which appealed strongly to activists: it announced that it would convene a Constituent Assembly to revise the Icelandic constitution. While such a revision was long overdue, the Icelandic

constitution adopted in 1944 was considered too close to its predecessor, the Danish constitution, as well as dated in many respects (Sigurðardóttir 1996).

It was a generally accepted view that considerable rewriting was necessary, since the text of the constitution was to a considerable extent a nineteenth-century relic. The text contains formulations, articles, and provisions whose meaning is obscure without historical commentary (Stjórnarráðið 2009b, p. 14). The Constitutional Assembly was elected in 2010, but due to technical flaws in how the elections were conducted, the Supreme Court invalidated the elections (Hæstiréttur 2011). The parliament then reappointed the candidates who had been elected to the Constitutional Assembly to form the Constitutional Council. The Council was given the official task of preparing a bill with a revised constitution and asked to consider a number of issues in particular, including the organization of the legislative and executive powers, the role and position of the president, the independence of the courts and provisions about elections, and the constituency system (Stjórnlagaráð 2011). The council submitted a constitutional bill to the parliament in 2011, but the parliament failed to pass the new constitution before its term ended in April 2013 (Gylfason 2013b; Ólafsson 2016).

The Special Investigative Committee and the Constituent Assembly were attempts to regain trust and respond to the powerful public demand for moral reckoning. The SIC report was seen as a successful—if limited—investigation of what had gone wrong. The Constitutional effort on the other hand failed. Neither project substantively contributed to reestablishing trust in government (Johnsen and Sigurgeirsdóttir 2018).

5 Democratic Experiments and Innovations

If the Special Investigation Commission and the Constituent Assembly were the exercises in deliberative democracy that the public had demanded, the results were disappointing. The SIC produced a huge report which to some extent exposed the fraudulent activities of the banks before the crisis, but it did not in any obvious way suggest reforms in the way protesting publics seemed to be calling for—let alone recognize the transformed moral-political discourse of the Icelandic postcrisis society. Vilhjálmur Árnason who led the Working Group on Ethics has in numerous subsequent papers expressed serious doubts about the postcrisis grassroots movements, arguing that the emphasis on direct democracy have been counterproductive and, in many ways, served to spoil efforts to strengthen the institutional basis of democracy in Iceland (Árnason 2013, 2016, 2018). So already with the submission of its report, the gap seemed to be widening between postcrisis protest publics and the postcrisis government.

Many political projects were generated directly and indirectly by postcrisis public engagement. These projects were quite diverse, but they all shared the morally loaded vision of reform. Success varied, but the postcrisis discourse that gradually took shape was based on the same premise of moral failure. I will now give a brief overview and assessment of these projects (see also Ólafsson 2014).

5.1 The Citizens' Movement

Already in 2008, a group of people most of whom had not previously been associated with political parties formed a movement which came to be called Borgarahreyfingin (The Citizens' Movement). The name was inspired by the Czech Civic Forum, which had played a key role in bringing down the Communist government in Czechoslovakia some 19 years earlier. In their rhetoric some of the early participants in the movement also made a found there to be a connection between the collapse of communism in Eastern Europe in 1989 and the crisis in Iceland.

The Citizens' Movement registered as a political party and subsequently won four seats in the parliamentary elections of 2009. The movement however was soon consumed by internal strife. Contradictions between the practice of parliamentary politics and militant radicalism led to various splits within the group and eventually to its collapse. A few months after the elections, three of its MPs had split from the rest of the group and formed a new party—The Movement. One had joined the Left-Green Movement and thus become a part of the governmental majority (Tryggvadóttir 2014).

The Citizens' Movement displayed all the weaknesses of a spontaneous grassroots activism. Coordination was mostly absent and the expectations of members so diversified that the task of forming policies and working within preexisting structures was simply too complicated and oppressive. After the parliamentary group had left the Citizens' Movement and created the Movement, it was able to maintain a strong presence within the parliament during its tenure from 2009 to 2013 (Tryggvadóttir 2014, pp. 125–132).

The Pirate Party, which gradually took over as the movement that united many of the grassroots activists and continued the strong and sometimes moralistic pro-reform discourse, put up candidates for the elections in 2013 and just made the 5% barrier, getting three MPs elected. The Pirates unlike the Citizens' Movement based their work on clear political principles and maintained an organizational structure robust enough to keep the movement from disintegrating. Their strength has grown. In 2016 they got 10 MPs elected and in 2017 retained 6 (out of a total number of 63) (Píratar 2018).

5.2 The National Forums

In early 2009 a group of people mainly from business and industry formed a movement—the so-called anthill movement—to promote alternative means for policy-making based on the general idea, adapted from the bestselling book *The Wisdom of Crowds,* that harnessing the "wisdom of the many" could help articulate the common good beyond what traditional politicians were capable of (Maurabúfan 2009).

The anthill movement convened the first National Forum in November of 2009. Its task was to express and rank the core values of Icelandic society. The methodology came mainly from goal- and value-setting strategies used in the private sector,

when employees of a company, or employees and stakeholders, are invited to participate in the choice of values, main goals, and priorities of a company or corporation. The government emulated the anthill method in a second National Forum in 2010 whose task was to articulate basic values that should guide the revision of the constitution. In both forums it was strongly suggested that only a randomly selected assembly would be able to part with political discourse of the past to think about the future from an entirely new perspective (Þjóðfundur 2010). During the next few years, this form of citizen meetings became the standard way for government to consult with the public (Forsætisráðuneyti 2010).

5.3 The Icesave Referenda

According to the current Icelandic constitution, the president has a partial veto power over legislation passed by the parliament. If the president refuses to sign the legislation, it takes effect only temporarily but is to be put to a national referendum. In 2010 and 2011 the Icelandic parliament passed controversial bills ratifying agreements with the United Kingdom and Holland in which Iceland admitted responsibility for partially covering losses of individual owners of savings accounts in the British and Dutch branches of the collapsed bank Landsbankinn. The president, having received petitions from a considerable part of Icelandic voters, decided in both cases to refuse signing the bill (Grímsson 2010, 2011). The latter refusal surprised many observers since in the meantime a greatly improved agreement had been reached and most specialists thought that Icelanders could hardly get a better deal. Both referenda resulted in a rejection of the proposed legislation. Many of those who opposed the presidential veto argued that the case was unsuitable for a referendum, since the content of the agreement and the economic consequences were too complicated for most people to understand fully. But when, after having twice had an agreement rejected by the public, the Icelandic government won its case against the British and the Dutch governments in the EFTA court and turned out not to be liable to pay a deposit guarantee to individual account holders, for some, it became less obvious that the public should not be consulted about complicated financial issues (Finnbogason 2015).

5.4 The International Modern Media Initiative

In the wake of the sensational publications of secret governmental documents by WikiLeaks, a group of Icelanders who had been involved in various ways with the organization started lobbying in the Icelandic parliament that Iceland should take a step toward revolutionary legislation that would secure an unprecedented level of free speech protection for media and individuals. The initiative led to interesting developments in the parliament, which at first passed a resolution on special steps

toward a new legislation on media freedom and freedom of expression stating that Iceland would aim at leading the way for other countries in this respect. The resolution was passed with a broad support in the parliament. Subsequent discussion about the consequences of the WikiLeaks revelations created doubts among parliamentarians who eventually were unwilling to face the risk involved in taking the lead internationally in promoting freedom of speech (Alþingi 2010). IMMI has not been a strong presence in subsequent discussion on issues related to freedom of information. Yet it has to some extent been a part of the ongoing discussion about legislation to protect freedom of information and the right to disclosure of information for the public good. A working group appointed in early 2018 to make proposals on such legislation is an indirect result of the initiative (Stjórnarráðið 2018).

5.5 Participatory Budgeting: Better Reykjavík

In 2010, the City of Reykjavík began to collaborate with a group of web designers on creating web-based tools to enable individuals to have a direct say in policy matters within the city council. A special web was opened called Better Reykjavík where people could comment on planned projects, start initiatives, and offer project ideas and solutions which city officials were obligated to consider. Citizens were also asked to vote on proposed projects and rank them within certain budgetary restraints. Thus, Better Reykjavík has led to a miniature version of participatory budgeting. It has grown over the years both in terms of budget and participation. The platform has also been used for other participatory projects at local and national level. It will most probably also be used in a renewed participatory effort to revise the Icelandic constitution (Reykjavíkurborg 2018).

5.6 Political Transformation: The Best Party

In the municipal elections of 2010, Jón Gnarr, until then first and foremost a well-known actor and stand-up comedian, led a new party, called the Best Party, which aimed at proposing well-sounding goals, be popular, say what people liked to hear, have fun, and secure Jón and his friend's stable well-paying jobs. To begin with, the Best Party seemed like the ordinary political parody of Icelandic politics, but there was something more in it: in addition to all the fun, there was a core element of sharp political criticism, which caught on (Hafsteinsdóttir 2011). The "immoral" message that the party delivered during the election campaign subverted the seriousness of the solemn moral message that had characterized Iceland's postcrisis publics in the preceding years. The Party got a plurality of votes and formed the biggest faction in the city council. Jón Gnarr became mayor of Reykjavík. One could say that of all attempts at political reform in postcrisis Iceland, the Best Party is the most obvious short-term success. The party has to some extent become normalized as just one of

the political parties competing at the municipal level (Boyer 2013, pp. 284–285). Together with the Social Democrats, it managed to create a stable city government and according to opinion polls in the fall of 2013 would still have been the largest party in the municipal council. Jón Gnarr announced at the end of October that year that he would not be running for reelection. The Best Party would not prolong its existence beyond its initial 4-year term. Members of the party who had been active in the city government and wished to continue would do so on the platform of another party, Bright future, founded in 2012. Bright future got six seats in Althingi in the 2013 parliament elections, retained three in 2016 but lost all seats in 2017. The party withdrew from participation in the municipal elections of 2018 (Andersen 2013).

6 Results

Scholarly discussion in Iceland about grassroots activism and democratic initiatives has been critical and sometimes dismissive—intellectuals have to some extent found it difficult to see public interference with policy programs as entirely helpful. It has been argued, e.g., that the National Forums simply adopted a corporate methodology for a public forum instead of creating real deliberative opportunities (Ólafsson 2011). It has also been argued that participants in the National Forums were deceived since they participated in the belief that their input would actually be used for further policy-making (Árnason 2013). Some critics of the Constitutional Council complained that its legitimacy was questionable, since instead of the elected Constitutional Assembly the Constitutional Council had simply been appointed by the parliament (Árnason 2011, p. 350). When it submitted its draft constitution to the parliament as a legislative bill, the reaction among experts and scholars of law and politics was rather negative and during the most intensive discussion of the draft in the fall of 2012 became outright hostile when prominent academics declared that the project must be given "a failing grade" (see, e.g., Arnarson 2012). It was complained that the proposed constitution lacked the terminological precision necessary for such an important document and that some of its articles could even create constitutional uncertainty since they were unclear and internally contradictory (Árnason and Magnússon 2012).

In general, one might say that these projects were evaluated much more harshly within Iceland than abroad where most of them, especially the writing of the new constitution, evoked considerable political and scholarly interest. The appearance of the Best Party before the municipal elections in 2010 was also highly controversial. While the party appealed to voters very broadly and seemed to take voters from all other parties, commentators had mixed and—to a great extent—dismissive reactions to it since the party was considered nonserious and its supporters therefore irresponsible (Boyer 2013, p. 285). The Best Party probably had the best opportunity to make changes within the public administration since it effectively controlled the government of the city of Reykjavík for 4 years, but it can hardly be said that it did so. There was a certain symbolic aspect of Jón Gnarr's taking over as mayor—a social outcast

turned comedian actually playing the role of a mayor for a whole term—but neither he nor his supporters were able to use that symbolic force for systemic transformation.

It is important to re-evaluate actions, initiatives, and reactions meant to either address an unsatisfactory political situation or create a venue for democratic renewal. One way of doing so is simply to ask whether the quality of discussion and decision-making tends to increase with such participatory approaches or not. The criticism sustained by proponents of democratic initiatives has in most cases been focused on the quality of decision-making and on the quality of deliberation. Some critics, such as Vilhjálmur Árnason (a philosopher), have argued that deliberation was seriously flawed at the National Forums, in the Constitutional Council, and in connection with the Icesave referenda (Árnason 2013). Others, such as Gunnar Helgi Kristinsson (political scientist), have argued that in the case of the constitution (at least), the process was badly designed and therefore both the quality and the legitimacy of the project were compromised (Kristinsson 2012). Still others maintain that the products of participatory exercises such as the Constitutional Council are simply fraught with mistakes that seriously compromise their helpfulness (Árnason and Magnússon 2012). Such assessments are based on a very narrow view of how decisions and policy-making should proceed and will tend to treat public engagement as a secondary issue, arguing that it is more important to ensure quality through the involvement of experts.

The Icesave referenda, which twice served to invalidate agreements that the government had reached with British and Dutch authorities, are quite important in such an assessment. The Icesave referenda are a case of a very controversial exploitation of the tool of national referendum. One of the main arguments of those opposed to the referendum was based on the claim that the issue was too complicated for the average voter to understand and that public opinion was "cynically manipulated" (Hallgrímsdóttir and Brunet-Jailly 2016, p. 111). A deeper analysis of the first and second referenda might challenge that assumption on several grounds. Although the referendum was certainly flawed in many respects, nothing suggests that the public's lack of understanding of the issues was the decisive factor in determining the outcome of the vote. A group of informed people who truly understood what was at stake could have been split along the same lines.

Elections in 2013 seemed to turn the tide back: the two parties that for 12 years before the crisis had controlled government, and were to blame for the policies that left Iceland so vulnerable to an international financial crisis, were reinstated. Events showed however that the Icelandic public could still be mobilized and controversial decisions made by the new government continued to bring people to the streets. In 2014 large crowds protested the government's decision to formally end membership negotiations with the European Union, which the new government had put on hold, promising a referendum on whether they should be continued (Kjartansdóttir 2015).

The publication of the Panama Papers in 2016 created an even greater outrage as the public discovered not only that 600 Icelanders had over 800 offshore accounts through the company Mossack Fonseca, one of them being the Prime Minister's wife, whose funds had actually been co-owned with her husband until a new law made it necessary for MPs to declare such assets. Before the law took effect, he

handed his share over to her. The revelations led to the resignation of the Prime Minister and fresh elections (Fontaine 2016).

After the elections in the fall of 2016, parties that had been created after the 2008 crisis and as a response to the crisis held 21 out 63 seats in Iceland's Parliament. Two of these parties then entered the government with the right-wing Independence Party. Surprisingly the coalition agreement had few elements of the transformative spirit that so strongly characterized the grassroots movements—but this government was short-lived. After one still another round of elections, a coalition was formed with three of the four established Icelandic parties, across the political spectrum with a Left-Green Prime Minister and a Finance Minister from the Conservative Independence Party. This government has made some commitments toward bringing to conclusion some of the reform projects initiated after 2008 including a revision of the Icelandic constitution (Stjórnarráðið 2017). All in all, however, the actual changes brought about through the great social upheavals of the crisis and postcrisis years are relatively modest. It might be argued that greater changes have been achieved with less fanfare in countries that were less radicalized than Iceland was in the wake of the 2008 crisis. Perhaps the Pirate Party reflects some degree of permanent success having brought people from the margins of political activism into parliament for three successive elections. But that has, arguably, also led to some normalization of their platform and even rhetoric. In parliament, however, the party continues to press the government to increase transparency by publishing government data and making the work of the public service and government organizations more open for the public (Burgess and Clark 2016).

I emphasized the moral nature of the public protest action in Iceland in the wake of the 2008 crisis. This character of the protests made many of the demands, arguments, and claims voiced during protest by activist groups, the political groups, and parties that formed around various projects, appealing to the common sense of the average Icelander left deeply frustrated with the lack of accountability displayed by government officials, as well as shellshocked by the days of chaos in October 2008. But it is possible to conclude that the moral outrage somewhat derailed the political goals and objectives that the demand for political renewal needed. Moral outrage eroded the general acquiescent support of the political system—it certainly contributed to a situation where a protest public was formed. But it failed to empower the public to an extent that could break the domination of the political elites. The economy has certainly bounced back, but the moral outrage is still there (Vilhelmsdóttir and Kristinsson 2018).

The conclusion that we can draw from my brief excursion into protest publics that emerged in Iceland in the wake of the 2008 financial crisis, especially the Icelandic economic and political collapse, is that public-elite interaction was transformed: the ways in which the public reacts to government action (or inaction) is more forceful and (as examples have shown) more decisive than was previously the case. Furthermore, there is a moral approach to activism which provides common discourse to diverse publics, and there seems to be a strong tendency to translate dissatisfaction with policy performance into democratic dissent (Önnudóttir and Harðarson 2011).

Mobilization can be swift: in a small country, seeing 20% of the population take to the streets is a powerful reminder of democratic accountability.

I have argued however that the Icelandic case is still no great success in the sense of new practices, approaches, or public engagement. Neither government nor legislature has in any substantive way created deliberative forums for public participation, engagement, or co-creation. The worries expressed by the foreign minister at the citizens' meeting described above have become a spell which elites seem unable to break. Instead of seeking to channel dissent into deliberative and consultative processes, the problem of numerical representation has prevailed. It follows that even listening to the "crowd" may be seen as an undemocratic approach, since we cannot simply decide to let someone speak for the public (Önnudóttir 2016; Mahony and Clarke 2013, p. 950). This suggests in my view that unless protesting publics, which emerge as a result of a deep political crisis, transform into civic movements with time, capable of working with political elites, they will hardly achieve the necessary political reform through which democratic systems open up for public deliberation and participation that goes right into the policy- and decision-making itself.

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Five Stars of Change: The Transformation of Italian Protest Publics Through Grillo's Blog



Giuseppe Mastruzzo

1 Introduction

The rise of the Five Star Movement after the great success from 2005 of the "Blog di Beppe Grillo", which soon became "one of the most widely read blogs in Italy" (Dittrich 2017, p. 7), challenged old notions of democratic participation and social dissent. Indeed, Grillo's extremely popular blog introduced horizontal forms of democracy both through Internet discussion and in-person meetings, though partly keeping to a vertically hierarchical model in the actual taking of political decisions.

The movement that gathered around Grillo's blog presented many characteristics of protest publics as defined by Belyaeva and Zaytsev in their introductory essays to this volume. In point of fact, the blog:

1. Was a virtual space that called for collective action (Vignati 2015, p. 18).
2. Was organised in the form of a network (Campante et al. 2017, pp. 25–27).
3. Called for civil participation (Pepe and di Gennaro 2009, p. 4).
4. Addressed diverse issues, being "like a 'catch all' phenomenon" (Lanzone and Woods 2015, p. 57).
5. Its level of institutionalisation was low (Lanzone 2014, pp. 67–69).

Grillo's blog would also use what is widely understood as the typical vocabulary of populism. Just to mention here a recent example of how populism is generally defined in literature, "populism obtains when a certain political entrepreneur is able to polarize politics by creating a cleavage based on the interaction between 'the people' versus some establishment, thus forging a mass political movement" (Pappas 2012, p. 2). Here, our "political entrepreneur" was Grillo. Like other "populist" movements all over the world, his Five Star Movement would shed twentieth-century ideologies to reach a post-ideological language that appeals to

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N. Belyaeva et al. (eds.), *Protest Publics*, Societies and Political Orders in Transition,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5_9

different social layers and different personal histories. In doing so, the MoVimento would successfully answer both the traditional Italian anti-establishment distrust (Bouillaud 2016, p. 16) and the more recent drive to protest against austerity policies of that significant part of Italian society hit hard by the financial crisis (Biorcio and Natale 2013, pp. 108–109). Drawing both on a new conception of direct democracy through online participation and on the old widespread popular aversion to the political system, Grillo and his Five Star Movement managed to galvanise and give expression to several latent elements of remonstration in Italian society (Conti and Memoli 2015, p. 529).

Who were these people that spent their time and emotions on Grillo's blog and later followed him in his first street protests? A 2007 national survey describes Grillo's followers as mainly from Centre-North Italy, in prevalence males, "young, well-educated, living in medium or large cities, and, naturally, with a higher than average rate of internet use" (Bordignon and Ceccarini 2013, pp. 442–443). In the following pages, I will show how these characteristics change with the transformation of the 2007 local protest publics into the 2013 Five Star national political force.

More in detail, I will investigate the idea of direct democracy on which the MoVimento grows and observe the MoVimento's belief that a novel potential for democratic participation is technologically determined by universal access to the Internet. I will then give a definition of what a movement party is and show the gradual change of Grillo's followers from protest publics into a movement party. I will go back to examine Grillo's political enterprise from the early 2005 days to the first significant electoral victory in 2009 and list the "five stars" (the five political issues on which the MoVimento was founded). I will try to understand why a certain reduction of "horizontality" takes place in the MoVimento's decision-making after 2009 and note how this reduction is attained through the very same technology that should guarantee horizontality and expand it. In parallel, I will discuss the undiminished Five Star polarisation between "elite" and "people", and its great electoral appeal, while exposing the limitations of the notion of "populism" and its partial ineffectiveness in describing the MoVimento's characteristics. I will draw a comparative sketch of the average Five Star voters in 2013 and 2018 and discuss their increasingly wider social and political heterogeneity and the establishment of a stronger internal control in the movement party to face that heterogeneity. Then, I will shortly present the case of the 2011 Italian national referendum against the forced privatisation of all local public services and on water as a commons, considering the actual policy on the management of the water systems in the metropolitan areas with Five Star mayoralties. Taking as an example the case of water, the first "star" at the MoVimento's foundation in October 2009, I will show how the MoVimento's former participation in a protest results only incompletely in a radical political action on the issue once the movement party is in power. Finally, in my conclusions, I will briefly argue that protest publics are common spaces created by popular cooperation whose openness and radicalness are today threatened with being enclosed and privatised by platform monopolies.

2 Online Agora and Direct Democracy

Before the birth of the MoVimento, in Italy the idea of direct participatory democracy had developed in parallel with the idea of cognitive democracy. By this viewpoint, ordinary citizens are in principle capable of exercising functions of government, since these functions are not impossibly complex and only require proper information and discussion. Governors and representatives then are in office only to satisfy their people's will, without any personal political autonomy. In a sense, the representatives are just individual embodiments of the cohesive collective subject they represent, whose interests and opinions are more transparently similar than less obviously plural. The representatives are just the people's spokespersons, and their prolonged possession of power is not desirable and must be prevented by their rotation in office and their revocability through online referendum. As a result, leaders are selected less on the basis of an evaluation of their ideas and political views than for their personal qualities of honesty and competence. In this (post) ideological framework, history is driven by relentless in-real-time deliberative democracy helped by technological change, while the notion itself of non-instant democracy is now irreversibly associated with lack of transparency and the hidden interests of powerful lobbies.

Accordingly, the rise of the Five Star Movement significantly contributed to reclassify and extend on different grounds the notion of political debate in Italy. With the advent of the Internet, more traditional political organisations kept to a unilateral dimension of the new medium, unidirectionally inflicting the positions of their leaders on ordinary people as they had done for decades with their paper press releases and TV public declarations. Instead, the MoVimento's platform provided a powerfully modern "agora"—a space dedicated to public speech—to thousands of people transforming them from passive public audience into political activists (Giansante 2016, pp. 19–20). In fact, "in 2010 there were about 200,000 visitors every day and several thousand comments for each post" (De Rosa 2013, p. 130); this massive, constant expression of popular opinion established the framework for the growth of the largest protest public in Europe at that point.

Supported by the idea that democracy does not really need the mediation of representation, the notion of a direct-democracy assembly was reformulated in the light of the potential of new information technologies and communication. Hence, the Internet was seen as a major step forward to the true expression of the people's will and of the achievement of a full participatory democracy against the concealed motives of influential private groups and political parties.

Accordingly, the MoVimento constantly called for a re-publicisation of services and spaces of general interest. Re-publicising also implied expanding on the category of the "commons" as the right of local, national, continental and global publics and communities to access both private and public goods and resources of general interest that were traditionally not accessible since they were managed by members of the establishment or private owners in terms of exclusion of the community/people (Capra and Mattei 2015, pp. 160, 164–165). Yet, this call by the MoVimento

for the protection and promotion of the commons and a re-publicisation of goods, services and spaces of general interest found later a problematic practical recognition in those local situations where the MoVimento gained mayoralties and positions of government (Movarelli 2016, p. 217).

3 The Transformation of Italian Protest Publics into a Movement Party

In a recent analysis, protest publics are acknowledged as successful when they have "three crucial capabilities": "narrative capacity, disruptive capacity, and electoral and/or institutional capacity" (Tufekci 2017, p. 192). In brief, narrative capacity is the ability of publics to form and disseminate their own world view (Weltanschauung!); disruptive capacity is their ability to disturb the orderly processes of organised authorities; electoral or institutional capacity defines their ability to attack the political system in its core business by preventing traditional politicians from being re-elected and imposing "changes in institutions through both insider and outsider strategies" (Tufekci 2017, pp. 192–193). We shall see how these three dimensions have unfolded in the MoVimento's venture.

Certainly, like the MoVimento's action, the efforts of several other organisations and movements in different parts of Europe were similarly informed by an immediate association of the notions of "protest" and "people"—think of the Greek Aganaktismenoi or the Spanish Indignados, which apart from Grillo's Italian friends were the two largest protest publics in the European Union in those years. While it is a shared view that the powerful rise of those movements contributed to bring to the level of European institutions the need for a broader public access to political decision-making, it must be pointed out that these three protest publics all eventually transformed themselves into movement parties seeking electoral success: in Italy the Five Star Movement, in Spain Podemos and in Greece Syriza (della Porta et al. 2017, passim).

Today, it must be admitted that in their three countries, these newly structured forces massively occupy the rhetorical space for the politically antagonistic use of words such as "elite", "caste" or "system", with the eventual result of limiting the possibility of birth of new antagonism outside them. Also, it must be recognised that once in power not always have these political forces managed to establish local or national governments in political discontinuity with the approach of previous administrations, challenging only to some extent the traditional centres of political influence and the usual ways of doing business in the public arena.

In effect, at least in the Italian case, the well-known definition of a movement party given by Kitschelt (2006) describes very closely the actual development of the Five Star Movement. In Kitschelt's view, a movement party is a coalition "of political activists who emanate from social movements and try to apply the organizational and strategic practices of social movements in the arena of party

competition" (p. 280), which is still true of the MoVimento. Like a movement party, additionally, the MoVimento would make "little investment in a formal organizational party structure". It had "no formal definition of the membership role" (p. 280), and anyone who came "to a meeting or activity of the party [was] considered a 'member' in the sense of entitlement to participation" (p. 280). Last but not least, like a movement party, initially the Five Star Movement was "led by a charismatic leader with a patrimonial staff and personal following over which s/he exercises unconditional and unquestioned control" (p. 280).

4 Blog Visitors, Online Activists and Effective Protest Publics

In Italy, the rise of the Five Star Movement took place following the growth of criticism of the new forms of global "plutocracy" and bureaucracy (WTO, WB, EU, hypertrophic financial markets) supported by technostructures in the 1990s and early 2000s. This all-controlling novel technocracy was seen as challenging the old institutes of sovereignty and democratic participation and representation and defying any process of democratic accountability. To that appearance, and to a more generally perceived crisis of representative democracy, the MoVimento opposed the necessity of a recuperated and renewed popular sovereignty.

Before the birth of Grillo's blog, in the view of web consultant Gianroberto Casaleggio, direct democracy is already made possible by the wide diffusion of the Internet. The Internet's inclusive availability altogether cancels the traditional instances of political mediation to bring about a new centrality of the citizen (Casaleggio 2004, pp. 23–25). The result, as we shall see, is a model of "participatory" governance that removes the difficulties in governability shown by previous democratic models through a shortcut to deliberation that makes mediation and compromise somewhat hard to achieve.

As already noted, the initial development of a civic movement was pivoted around comedian Beppe Grillo's blog ("Il Blog di Beppe Grillo"). Before its creation, Grillo would be critical of the use of modern technologies (Bordignon and Ceccarini 2013, p. 429), and it was only in January 2005 on Casaleggio's suggestion that Grillo created his blog. The blog soon involved regular followers in their hundreds of thousands, with their frequent feedback and comments. Later in 2005, an online "MeetUp" platform was created in order to promote forms of autonomous self-organisation at a local level and allow the blog's followers to interact (Grillo 2005). Cutting-edge technology and creativity characterised the novel national platform, which encouraged many to grow from active blog participants to offline activists, thus establishing in time local instances of political grassroots initiative. Together with already present local protest publics, new ones were born, all maintaining a strong connection with the central MeetUp platform and Grillo's blog (Campante et al. 2017, pp. 10–11). On the platform, the language

would increasingly move from nonspecific remarks on global consumerism and incorrect habits to unforgiving condemnation of Italian politics (Santoro 2012, p. 41).

Initially, therefore, Grillo's blog took advantage of the countless disputes and struggles throughout the Italian Peninsula by accusing regional politicians and members of the parliament to be the main obstacle to the solution of local and national evils. The variety of local conditions and groups that welcomed Grillo's contentious language and structured themselves according to his charismatic vision(s) produced diverse forms of aggregation in dissimilar local situations, and this native peculiarity is still true of today's MoVimento (Biancalana 2017, p. 331). Sometimes, collective action would be triggered by Grillo himself, immediately supported by his blog's enthusiastic followers. More frequently, Grillo would be the one to offer national prominence to actions independently taken by local protest publics.

In the autumn of 2007, Grillo permitted the use of the logo "Amici di Beppe Grillo" ("Friends of Beppe Grillo") by those MeetUp groups that wished to run in local elections, thus adding a more immediate political trait to his civic movement (Grillo 2007). At the same time, Grillo's Amici moved from the web to the streets with a series of national "Vaffanculo Days" against the "caste" of politicians and journalists (Bordignon and Ceccarini 2013, p. 433). The term "casta" had become popular in Italy some months before through the best seller *La Casta* (Rizzo and Stella 2007). In doing so, Grillo and his Amici advocated a total ban of convicted representatives from parliament and local bodies and a two-term personal limit of political representation for everybody in order to avoid the calamity of professional politics and politicians. Also, they called for "the complete suppression of any kind of public finance for political parties, and the strong limitation of the level of pay to elected politicians at any level" while claiming as a political organisation "to function at a minimal cost to the citizens using the tools of Internet to coordinate its actions" (Bouillaud 2016, p. 5).

The triumph of the Vaffanculo Days (Pepe and di Gennaro 2009, pp. 5–8) completed the conversion of the MeetUp from online platforms into cells of political activists. As late as 2008, a significant part of those activists was explicitly against any participation in the elections and wanted to preserve the characteristics of the initial movements (Biancalana 2017, p. 339). However, electoral lists were approved which ran under the Five Star symbol in the June 2009 municipal elections.

Then, on October 4, 2009 in Milan, a far-reaching political programme grounded on "five stars" was launched:

1. Water—public management of local water systems.
2. Environment—environmental protection of local territory.
3. Transport—promotion of public transport against private mobility.
4. (De-)growth and connectivity—long-term conception of social and economic development open to the notion of de-growth and with free Internet connectivity for all citizens.
5. Energy—renewable sources of energy and wide-ranging rubbish recycling (Le 5 n.d.).

Thus, in the autumn of 2009, having managed to elect some 36 local representatives throughout the Peninsula, the MoVimento was explicitly constituted as a political entity (Grillo 2009).

5 From Horizontal Network to a More Hierarchical Structure: The MoVimento's Journey to the 2013 Elections

Initially, therefore, the Five Star Movement established itself by promoting and drawing on local protest publics and networks of civic activism. These publics were gathering around the protest against the forced privatisation of all local public services and the notion of "water as a commons" in the 2010–2011 national referendum campaign, or the protest against a major high-speed rail project between Turin and Lyon or large waste treatment plants, or had developed around a critical approach to consumerism and its social and cultural effects. Many of these protest publics, which very often explicitly demanded direct democracy and participation in administrative decisions, found through the MoVimento an opportunity of interconnection and further mobilisation beyond the local level.

From the beginning, thus, a specific trait of the Five Star Movement was the confidence in pervasive horizontal and anti-hierarchical processes of social change driven by new communication technologies, which were understood as tools that allowed ordinary people to take political power back in their hands (Bordignon and Ceccarini 2013, p. 434). In this view, people are able to decide through the acquisition of basic information on more or less complex issues of governance previously seen as the prerogative of technocratic, academic and administrative elites whose honesty, functions and existence are now overtly challenged.

This foundational trait of the MoVimento is confirmed as late as 2017 by a national survey that shows how 85% of its electors still think that it is the citizens, not the politicians, who should take the most important political decisions for Italy (Comodo and Forni 2017, p. 147). Consequently, it would seem that the definitions of populism by Jagers and Walgrave (2007), and again by Pappas (2012), well depict the main traits of the Five Star Movement in the different stages of its evolution. Yet, perhaps a verification of the notion of populism and of its efficacy in the analysis of the MoVimento is here required.

As Jagers and Walgrave (2007) state, "populism (1) always refers to the people and justifies its actions by appealing to and identifying with the people; (2) it is rooted in anti-elite feelings; and (3) it considers the people as a monolithic group without internal differences except for some very specific categories who are subject to an exclusion strategy" (p. 322). Similarly, for Pappas (2012), "three distinct and yet interrelated causal mechanisms ... are instrumental for generating populism: the politicization of resentment; the creation of a new cleavage between 'the people' and some establishment; and intense political polarization" (p. 8).

Accordingly, a vision of politics and society was being produced by the MoVimento where on the one side one finds unjustified elites, all with the same purpose of maintaining their unfair privileges and benefits, and on the other side one finds the people, all with the same interests and eventually the same opinions (Bordignon and Ceccarini 2013, p. 435).

This "polarised relationship" between citizens and establishment is well shown by an analysis of selected recurrent words in Grillo's blog that consistently depict the establishment as "a negative force upon society" and citizens "as good and honest" (Aragrande and Nardone 2017, p. 2). This polarisation is again typical of the populist structuring of that "us-them" antagonism that produces a simplification of political signification (Laclau and Mouffe 1985, p. 130).

In Italy, however, the term "populism" has recently been challenged by different authors as a category that is unhelpful to make us understand the traits of the novel political scenario and the novelties in the language of the emerging political forces in the country and in Europe.

Immediately after the March 2018 national elections, Gustavo Zagrebelsky, an emeritus president of the Italian Constitutional Court, in an interview on a national newspaper (Truzzi and Zagrebelsky 2018) states that those who speak of populism make an uncritical use of a decaying notion in order to exonerate themselves from looking into the complexity of things and proposes to abandon the word among the dregs of the political lexicon. More in detail, Zagrebelsky holds that the word populism has nothing to do with the conflict between political ideas—one can well be a right-wing or left-wing populist or anti-populist—but it has to do with sheer power competition. Those who more frequently pronounce it belong (and by pronouncing it, they reveal that they do belong) to the circle of the elect that "impersonate 'good governance', the few who know against the many who do not know: oligarchy, precisely" (Truzzi and Zagrebelsky 2018).

Also, it must be noted that throughout all its history, the MoVimento—unlike other "populist" forces—has frequently asked for the support of prominent "experts" in order to endorse its proposals. In effect, finally and logically, this attitude resulted in the recent inclusion of a significant number of "supercompetent" figures in the lists of the MoVimento's candidates for the 2018 national elections (Di Maio 2018).

Making a step back, before the birth of the MoVimento, the loss of prestige and authority of the political "caste" because of the many instances of corruption of representatives of traditional political parties in Italy had already persuaded many voters that the whole system of political and electoral representation was flawed. This feeling was reinforced by the financial scandals that in 2012 involved high figures of Lega Nord and Italia dei Valori, two political parties that had successfully used a populist and anti-system vocabulary to their electoral advantage (Mejstrik 2016, p. 6).

Here, it will come as no surprise that Gianroberto Casaleggio was a Lega Nord sympathiser in the early 2000s and later for years and as late as 2009 a political communication and party strategy advisor for Italia dei Valori (Salvatori 2013, Chap. 6). As an effect of those scandals, the number of regular followers of Grillo kept growing at an exponential rate, nurtured both by the new discontent with the

more traditional populist parties and a renewed distrust in the traditional media (newspapers, TVs)—especially, as we shall see, after their outrageous coverage of the 2011 national referendum campaign against the privatisation of local water systems and public utilities. In November 2012, Grillo's Twitter followers surpassed the number of 700,000, while Twitter followers of the leader of the powerful Democratic Party—at that time, Luigi Bersani—were less than 150,000 (Bartlett et al. 2013, pp. 13–14).

After a further success in the 2012 municipal elections, when the Five Star Movement won the mayoralty in Parma and more than 150 local representatives nationally, the landslide in the general elections in February 2013 brought to the MoVimento a considerable number of seats in both chambers of parliament, also making it the political force most evenly supported throughout the Peninsula (Biorcio and Natale 2013, pp. 100–101).

The average Grillo's supporter was now different from the protest public member of the Vaffanculo Days (a translation of "vaffanculo" shall not be given here). While a prevalence of males was still the case, now the average age was higher, though Five Star electors were still younger than those of the other political groups. Their formerly predominant urban dimension was now forgotten, together with their higher level of education, as they were now more evenly distributed throughout the country, between cities and countryside, and throughout all social classes. Their former sympathy for centre-left politics had now given way to a much wider "political heterogeneity" (Bordignon and Ceccarini 2013, pp. 443–444).

To complete the picture, in February 2018, a national pre-electoral survey by the Italian Centre for Electoral Studies (CISE) offers a renewed image of Five Star voters. By now, they essentially constitute a mainstream electorate that on all themes has the very same opinion that all Italians share. More in detail, Five Star electors have a mainly progressive orientation, since they reply with a progressive sign to 15 out of 19 thematic questions. There are, nevertheless, four themes on which a conservative orientation prevails in the Five Star electorate: decriminalising the excess of right to self-defence, limiting refugees' access to the Italian Peninsula, reducing access to social services for immigrants, and impeding the introduction of the right of the soil (*ius soli*) in birthright citizenship. In this sense, Five Star voters (in line with the entire sample, even if with slightly higher percentages) represent a case of a phenomenon already known in other European countries: they are the "left-authoritarians", i.e. citizens who have left-wing opinions on economic issues (such as the reform of the labour market, for instance), but are conservative on cultural issues, especially when immigration is concerned (CISE 2018).

In 2013, this newly amplified political heterogeneity found a difficult answer in the MoVimento's leadership. Indeed, the 2013 electoral triumph further proposed the issue of institutionalisation, to which the leadership replied by inhibiting some of the previous fluidity and freedom of the internal debate. A stronger internal control was established not only on dissenting opinions but altogether on the democratic mechanism of formation of opinions while publicly persevering in the use of an anti-institutional rhetoric.

The result of this attitude, as Coppini (2013) shows, was "a low level of criticism towards the leader's opinions, a high uncivil tone, a tendency to avoid policy discussion, a low level of justifications for claims expressed and, lastly, very few diverse points of views presented" (p. 1). The periods of the political discourse shortened online, together with the time necessary to agree on a political position. A click democracy was established that sometimes lead to plebiscites. In fact, while always speaking of a direct-democracy revolution made possible by the web, the Five Star leadership did not seem to encourage autonomous opinions (Deseriis 2017, p. 453).

Together with the independence of structured views, actual debate was hampered even at the cost of obstructing political initiative at a local and at a parliamentarian level. Now, an online plebiscite scenario is presented in some crucial decisions proposed by the MoVimento's leadership to its web recipients, among whom the number of participants with actual voting rights is low, hence further "downsising" the democratic process (De Rosa 2013, p. 132).

This lack of real room for deliberation (Bordignon and Ceccarini 2015, p. 464) was justified by Grillo and Casaleggio with the need to fight against organised factions in the MoVimento. Accordingly, the nonconforming positions in parliament and in the local territories were stigmatised as the result of contemptible personal ambitions, until Grillo prohibited his elected representatives from publicly speaking altogether in the wake of the February 2013 national elections. This prohibition was enforced not only on TV and on the other media but also in parliament—surely a revolution, since "parliament" is etymologically the "place for speaking". As a result, 17 out of 54 Five Star senators and 9 out of 109 MPs were expelled or defected in the first months of their mandate (I parlamentari 2014). At the same time, all communication was assigned to Gianroberto Casaleggio's private company.

Evidently, by early 2013 the Five Star Movement had shed part of the characteristic horizontality of a protest public, somehow hardening into a movement party lead by Casaleggio and Grillo. Meanwhile, its institutionalisation and the organisation of a more suitable political structure were being addressed. Nonetheless, at a local level, many elements of horizontality and self-organised autonomy would stay unchanged (Biancalana 2017, pp. 333–334).

In fact, in November 2014 Grillo decided to form a directorate composed of five parliamentarians personally appointed by him and confirmed online by the activists. These five members became the official Five Star spokespersons and were allowed to give interviews to journalists and even take part in TV shows. In order to deal with the elected representatives at a national and local level, in an attempt to contain their increasing defections from the MoVimento, the directorate produced a framework of internal procedures. Also, in January 2015 an appeals commission was established in order to judge the behaviour of dissenting representatives (Franzosi et al. 2015, p. 111).

At this point, to everybody a logic conflict was evident between the verbal rejection of elite and authority and the way in which the MoVimento was actually guided by a hierarchical pyramid. Indeed, the "guarantor", as Grillo would define himself, was even able to eventually subvert the web verdicts that he did not approve, as, for example, in the case of the 2017 online consultation to decide the

Five Star candidature to the mayoralty of Genoa. Having clearly obtained the majority in the online vote, Marika Cassimatis was excluded by Grillo with no further explanation for the voters than "I'm asking you to trust me on this" (Grillo 2017).

6 Challenging the Five Stars: After the Protest, a Difficult Policy

The first of the MoVimento's five founding stars in October 2009 was "water", i.e. the public management of local water systems. A month earlier, in September 2009, the Italian government issued a decree law (Decreto Ronchi 2009), with the alleged goal to comply urgently with EU obligations and some recent judgements of the European Court of Justice. The decree law—Decreto-Legge 25 Settembre 2009 n. 135 or "Decreto Ronchi", in its shorter (un)popular form—was implemented 2 months later, enacting the forced privatisation of all the companies of local services still publicly owned. This implied the compulsory privatisation (or, perhaps, the clearance sale to private subjects) by the end of 2011 of all local public utilities, worth hundreds of billion euros.

The outrage provoked by the decree law and its successive implementation was immediate. A team of high-profile jurists started writing the referendum questions necessary to abrogate the crucial passages of the law by direct-democracy vote. Among them, there was Stefano Rodotà, later indicated by the Five Star Movement as its candidate to the presidency of the Italian Republic in 2013. Less than 2 years before the Decreto Ronchi, in 2007–2008, Rodotà had chaired a ground-breaking ministerial commission (popularly known as "Commissione Rodotà") to provide a comprehensive definition of the "commons" for the Italian Civil Code. Pioneeringly, the commons were defined as all those services, spaces and resources, either publicly or privately owned, whose access should be guaranteed to everybody in a (global or local) community since they are fundamental for the full development of the community members as human personae (Commissione Rodotà 2007).

A whole network of activists and ordinary people—and among them all Five Star militants—developed to gather the certified signatures of citizens necessary to validly ask the Italian Constitutional Court for the implementation of the abrogative referendum and the protection of fundamental commons. After having collected at a local level some one and a half million certified signatures (three times what was needed), the most powerful protest public in the history of Italy rose to create national awareness on the referendum issues. In particular, the aspect was successfully stressed that a primary resource like water would be managed for private profit and out of public control in case the law was not abrogated.

As a matter of fact, after the acceptance of the referendum questions by the Constitutional Court, the traditional media in Italy—TV channels and newspapers—instead of starting a public discussion of the referendum issues, utterly ignored them

to everyone's disbelief. This piloted behaviour of the Italian media should have been less of a surprise, though, since Italy is the only Western European country whose freedom of press is consistently classified as "with a noticeable problem" in the World Press Freedom Index compiled by Reporters Without Borders (World Press Freedom Index 2017).

To counteract this patent attempt at organised disinformation, which was perhaps supervised by political and financial lobbies, a capillary popular campaign started in the Italian piazzas and on the Internet. The referendum campaign saw, among many other protesters, all the MoVimento local supporters and Grillo himself actively commit themselves in defence of the people's commons and of public water against the theft perpetrated by the elites and their accomplices, TV and the press (Grillo 2011).

In June 2011, the referendum was won with over 95% of votes in favour of the abrogation of the outrageous law, becoming one of the most important events of direct democracy and participation in Italian history (Referendum Popolare 2011).

After 2011 to date, Grillo's MoVimento has gained the mayoralty of various main Italian cities—Parma, Livorno, Turin and Rome. In none of them, however, it has succeeded in carrying out a clear policy of re-publicisation of the water service (or of other local public services).

A short parenthesis is essential here. Under Italian law, a "Società per azioni" (acronym, SpA) is a limited-liability company whose capital is allocated as "azioni" (shares) and whose shareholders are liable for its debts only within their equity and the perimeter of the capital stock. "Azioni" can be offered to the general public and exchanged on the stock exchange for those SpAs there listed. An SpA, therefore, is a typical Italian example of a globally usual corporate vehicle whose goal is to provide its shareholders with the highest possible equity dividend, at no risk for their other personal assets and property.

Everybody would concur here that the shareholders' interest is most probably different from the general interest. In actuality, the main goal of their limited company is somewhat different from—and sometimes antagonistic to—the protection and development of resources in a community. There is also another critical aspect to be pointed out: while shareholders participate in a limited company in a limited way, only within the limits of their equity, with no further personal involvement, to satisfactorily develop as twenty-first-century human beings, people need that their community guarantees full access to a whole range of basic services and resources (e.g. education, water, etc.).

One would perhaps agree that from the above considerations, it follows that an SpA is not necessarily the best vehicle to cope with common resources that are crucial to the well-being of a community.

Now, in Parma, where the Five Star Movement got the mayoralty as early as 2012, just 1 year after the national referendum, IREN SpA is still in charge of the provision of water and still manages this primary commons with a market approach. The mayoralty in Livorno was won in 2014, where ASA SpA is still managing the water system. In Rome and Turin, where the MoVimento won the mayoralty in 2016, ACEA SpA's management is unchallenged, which is true of Turin with SMAT SpA.

While innovative statutes in defence of the commons have been approved in many Five Star-governed cities, in all of them, the MoVimento's first star, public water, is still managed by market-oriented corporations, as it used to be with previous administrations.

In the meantime, the City of Naples has experienced a full re-publicisation of its water provider. Naples is the only case where the strong local protest public that lead the 2011 referendum campaign has produced a non-Five Star mayor. Elected mayor of Naples in 2011, Luigi De Magistris, entrusted Professor Ugo Mattei with the presidency of the local water provider; Arin SpA Mattei, the vice president of the Commissione Rodotà and a major inspirer of the national water referendum, immediately proceeded to transform what was legally a corporation with a market approach, though publicly owned, into a legal public subject with general interest goals. Even the name of the new provider, "Acqua Bene Comune" (Water as a Commons), bears the memory of the protest that eventually gave birth to it.

7 A Future for Italian Protest Publics?

In Obama's May 2011 *International Strategy for Cyberspace: Prosperity, Security, and Openness in a Networked World* (Obama 2011), the Internet is seen as a self-governing community in which, in spite of "the challenges posed by malevolent actors' entry into cyberspace" (p. 3), the "future promises not just greater prosperity and more reliable networks, but enhanced international security and a more sustainable peace" (p. 7).

Today, just a few years after Obama's confident hopes, it appears that the Internet's initial potential of freedom and sharing has resulted in a system dominated by a small number of large global groups that pursue their interests at the expense of citizens and communities, having in a few years colonised and monopolised a gigantic market, and obtained the power to establish the rules and laws they like, and even to fix the amount of tax they want to pay (Stephens 2017).

At the beginning of the new millennium, some political analysts and web experts insisted on how the universality and rapidity of the novel agora offered by the Internet would empower worldwide democratic protest and popular resilience while challenging the essence of traditional political parties and crystallised power structures. The new movements would unfold outside the enclosures of that tradition and those structures. Indeed, Gianroberto Casaleggio was one of those web pundits who first believed that the Internet would defy an outdated order of political mediation and produce a novel view of citizenship (Casaleggio 2004, pp. 23–25).

In fact, the very notion of protest publics was developed in those days. The democratic novelty of those publics was found first of all in their being informed by the universality and rapidity of the web's shared space and of its cooperative use. The timely rise of a whole series of new movements, in Turkey, the Arabic world, Greece, Brazil, Spain, the USA, Italy and many other countries, came to support that view. Those protest publics, one might argue, were like commons: indeed, they

created common spaces of web discussion where political communities were formed. However, those web spaces based on cooperation appear today to be meticulously controlled by the new platform monopolies. The very same technology that created the arena for protest publics seems now to be dispossessing them.

Therefore, the supposed openness of the web gradually resulted in phenomena of monopoly and enclosure of the main communicative space, now privately owned and managed by corporations. These privately enclosed web structures are making in their turn new concealed challenges to freedom of expression and democratic participation in regional situations and at a global level, as flagrantly shown in the last US presidential election and more recently by the Cambridge Analytica scandal (Cadwalladr 2018).

In effect, the MoVimento's purported references to Rousseau's conception of direct democracy culminated in 2015 with the beta version of the "Rousseau" platform. The new platform was definitively launched in 2016, immediately after Gianroberto Casaleggio's premature death, and now somewhat controls and guides the Five Star Movement's political debate. Actually, through a non-profit association, Rousseau is managed by Casaleggio's son, Davide, who has never been elected by anyone through any democratic procedure. Furthermore, the platform does not allow for direct exchanges and discussions among activists, but only for individual comments (Passarelli et al. 2017, p. 187). It is true, however, that the Rousseau platform offers a wide possibility to the activists to propose bills and laws, and some of these proposals were included in the MoVimento's 2018 national electoral programme. Besides, horizontality and autonomy are still substantial at a local level in the MoVimento (Biancalana 2017, p. 343, 351, passim).

Now, the transformation of speed in communication and in political exchange provided in the last two decades by the Internet and its tools (blogs, platforms, WhatsApp, Facebook, Twitter and the like) has unquestionably had a far-reaching effect on the way all organised parties and "fluid" movements act and develop. Undoubtedly, the Five Star Movement has consistently used those tools to better effect than other organised movements. Yet, the impression is that the MoVimento also risks being used by those tools.

Grillo's blog has been by far the most successful receptor of political protest in Italy in recent years. Already in 2008, *The Observer* would list it as the ninth most powerful blog in the world (The world's 2008), and still in today's Italy, the space for political protest appears to be mainly occupied by Grillo's MoVimento. In point of fact, while Luigi Di Maio's Rimini speech in September 2017, when he accepted to be the Five Star candidate as the future Italian prime minister, omits to mention the five protest issues ("five stars") on which the MoVimento was founded in 2009 in order to allow for a new programme that advocates government for the Movement, the underlying motif of the new programme is still change to the advantage of ordinary citizens against the interests of the powerful (Di Maio 2017).

It is probable, therefore, that the birth of new protest publics will be also triggered by and take place within the MoVimento, whose massive presence in my opinion is still a likely context for the inception of antagonistic publics. To allow for it, however, the Five Star Movement will have to maintain and even to encourage the

local diversity of self-organised forms and autonomous groups that has consistently been its peculiarity from its beginning to its present days.

In the current, evident crisis of representative democracy in Europe, new protest publics and new phenomena of antagonistic politics are needed to support participation, real democracy and the resilience of communities against the interests of organised economic lobbies and powerful financial groups. It appears that those publics will have to challenge old and new enclosures of the political discourse and their old and new greedy proprietors and monopolists at a global and regional level. It is also evident that those publics will have to recuperate in their political discourse a dimension of time and physical presence that goes beyond virtual space, instant approvals, keyboard clicks and online plebiscites. Practising the physical space of contentious politics will be crucial for the future of protest publics, in Europe and beyond, in order to protect that virtual space of democracy provided by the Internet that allowed their birth in the first place.

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Part II
Protest Publics and Political Change in Different Political Regimes

Cross-National Comparison of Protest Publics' Roles as Drivers of Change: From Clusters to Models



Dmitry G. Zaytsev, Anastasia I. Galina, and Anna A. Sokol

1 Introduction

The Armenian revolution of May 2018, currently known as the Velvet Revolution (not to be confused with Czechoslovak Velvet Revolution of 1989), is one of the most recent cases of nonviolent protests. It showcases the success of social movement—the achievement of goals postulated by the protest participants. However, over the past few decades, there were many protests, the success of which cannot be that easily assessed, and these cases pose a special interest for the authors of this book.

2 Mechanism of Social Change: General Modeling Framework of Protest Publics' Participation

Modern political science has developed multiple frameworks for studying macrosocial changes to governments and society, such as the theory of modernization and Wallerstein's world-systems theory (Wallerstein 2004), and for studying political system and regimes, such as the theory of democratization and the theory of revolution (Acemoglu and Robinson 2001). Microsocial changes to behavior and

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N. Belyaeva et al. (eds.), *Protest Publics*, Societies and Political Orders in Transition,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5_10

identity have also been of growing interest for researchers around the world (Branton et al. 2015; Lee 2012). However, the sole focus on either the macro-level analysis of countries and their groups or the microlevel studies of individuals and their attitudes may miss the importance of collective actors in social change. The combination of macro- and microlevels of analysis has been employed by scholars who pay close attention to institutional changes and transformation of political institutions. Such concepts as "punctuated equilibrium" by Stephen Krasner (Krasner 1984), "critical junctures" by Ruth Berins Collier and David Collier (Collier and Collier 2002), and "path dependency" by Paul Pierson (Pierson 2000) were developed in an attempt to explain the process of change and its limits. In the literature review on institutional changes, Leonardo Morlino (2011) noted that although important, the research made by Robert E. Goodin, Stephen Krasner, R.B. Collier and D. Collier, Paul Pierson, Kathleen Thelen and Sven Steinmo, and James and R.D. Kelemen could not become a part of democratization and political change theory because of a high level of abstraction. These works focused on types, stages, reasons and causes, limitations, factors, and actors of political change. However, the conceptualization of "political change" was studied in isolation from the role of collective actors in these processes.

Nevertheless, collective actors had been the focus of applied analysis of the current political situations, policy implementation, and policy expert evaluation research for a long time (Polletta and Jasper 2001). However, when public policy became a distinct part of social sciences, studying the role of collective actors in policy change became its primary research focus (Béland et al. 2018; Moyson et al. 2017; Schmitt 2012; Takács et al. 2008). Meanwhile, the "traditional" research agenda academics predominantly analyzed the "old" actors of policymaking (e.g., interest groups, big corporations, political parties and politicians, civil society associations, and NGOs) and "traditional" political institutions (party system, political culture, civil society, and "stateness"). Recently, we witness a growing actorness capacity of the "new" political actors, such as protest publics, social and new media, think tanks, discourse coalitions, invisible colleges, thought communities, public intellectuals, advocacy coalitions, policy entrepreneurs, and epistemic communities (Karanasiou 2014; Tremayne 2014). Also, these new actors create new institutions and frames like participatory democracy, interactive governance, network civil society, policy advisory systems, soft law and soft power, policy styles, and regimes (Tufekci 2017).

This book is focused on a new actor of change—protest publics—because mass protests of the recent years may have become a significant factor of social change. Ranging from the events of the *Occupy Movement* and the *Arab Spring*, the mass protests in the 2010s happened in the majority countries and covered almost all the continents (Ortiz et al. 2013). Having occurred once, mass protests led to the creation of a newly emerging actor, protest publics, resulting in social change. Compared to the "old" social movements (e.g., movements against slavery in the nineteenth century in the USA, suffragette movement in the USA and the UK on the eve of the twentieth century, civil rights movement in the USA in the twentieth century, protests against the war in Vietnam in the USA in the 1970s, and other anti-war or "youth" movements in Europe in 1970s and national liberation movements in postcolonial and postimperial countries), mass protests of the 2010s spread much faster across the world (such as the Occupy Movement and Arab Spring). They have

several unique features that make them the "new" phenomena and the "new" actor of change (Table 1).

These features include public assembly around specific discourses as a model for collective actions, low level of institutionalization of collective actions, diversity of forms of public self-representation based on diversity of discourses, complex multilayered identity, and focus on the social changes despite the current status quo.

Integrating theories of political change and the theory of publics provides a new focus to the study of mass protests of the 2010. However, the relationship between the civil participation and social change is usually studied within the framework of social movement theory.

The proponents of this theory studied the specific instances when social movement has had an impact in policy change in an attempt to identify the patterns of its influence manifested in a variety of forms. For example, Kenneth T. Andrews (Andrews 2001) looked at disruption, persuasion, and negotiation; Felix Kolb (Kolb 2007) at disruption, public preference, political access, judicial, and international politics mechanism; Edwin Amenta, Neal Caren, Elizabeth Chiarello, and Yang Su at economic models, social movement models, political opportunity models, and political mediation models (Amenta et al. 2010); and Marco Giugni (2007) at the direct-effect, indirect-effect, and joint-effect models of social movement influence on public policy. Authors of the book *The Consequences of Social Movements* noted the dependence of the social movement impact efficiency on the context and the institutional environment and identified possible new areas of research (Bosi et al. 2016). They recommended that first, it was necessary to go beyond the study of exclusively "Western" countries and to learn from "non-Western societies." Second, they proposed to study not only the nature of social movements but also the long-term effect on their activity. Third, it was important to study not only the conditions but also the mechanisms and processes underlying the influence of social movements on public policy. Fourth, it was necessary to combine quantitative and qualitative methods of analysis, to move from short-term to a long-term analysis of social movements, and to create experimental models to go from the search of simple correlations to identify the causal mechanisms of the underlying relationships.

Social movements have been shown to have an impact on the institutional changes, especially on the power relations, changes in formal and informal institutions, and standards (Mahoney and Thelen 2009). Others explored the sudden transformation of the political organizations, the regime change, and the impact on revolution-invoking, significant changes in specific policies at the time of crisis (Greenwood and Hinings 1996; Goldstone 1998, 2001, 2009, 2011). Overall, the frontline research agenda for social movements' impact on institutional change was formulated along several distinct dimensions. First was the analysis of the reasons why some areas of social movements' activity become institutionalized while others were not. Second was the understanding of the reasons, motives, and patterns that determine the level of government officials and politicians' responsiveness to the demands of social movements. At the heart of this dimension is the co-optation and institutionalization of social movements as two different models of their interaction

Table 1 Distinguishing features of social movements and publics

Criteria	Theories	
	Theory of social movements	Theory of publics
Definition	Sustainable practices of collective citizen action, expressed in campaigns based on various forms of association of citizens and their public self-representation (Tarrow and Tilly 2009)	Self-organized body of strangers united through the circulation of their discourse (Warner 2002)
The model of collective action	"A *campaign* is a sustained, organized public effort making collective claims on targeted authorities" (Tarrow and Tilly 2009)	*Public assembly*, gathering around a certain discourse about the problem or event—"troubled message"; *public summoning*, organizing by public spaces of reflexive circulation of discourse, creating and representing of punctual rhythm of "poetic message" circulation about the alternative "world-making"
The level of institutionalization of collective action	*High*. Institutionalized and organized in specific forms (structures, organizations, policy programs) before or after the events (protests). Organizational structures are the basis for collective actions	*Low*. Can appear and exist for a long time without any institutionalization and organizational structures. Structures, organizations, and associations can exist in parallel to the main collective activity
Public self-representation	Importance of public self-representation: *worthiness*, *unity*, *numbers*, *commitment*	Also important, but not a special concern of the public. *Diversity* of public self-representation. Self-representation through different *discourses*
Identity	*Common interests, goals, values—identity* "The special-purpose association brought people together around concrete, often contingent aims and produced its own repertoire (Associational repertoires) of organizational routines—the lockbox holding both funds and dues; the membership card, the trade union branch" (Tarrow and Tilly 2009)	*Diversity* of interests, goals, and values. *Common* identity is built up on the base of imaginary *alternative future world*, which was discursive constructed by public, and democratic values of *civil participation and responsiveness*
Context	*Political opportunity structure*—"features of regimes and institutions that *facilitate or inhibit* a political actor's collective action and to changes in those features;" "the multiplicity of independent centers of power within the regime; its relative closure or openness to new actors; the instability or stability of current political alignments; the availability of influential allies or	Act despite "political opportunity structure" and act outside frameworks. Public is focused on changing regimes and institutions; developing alternative trend to the existent current "political opportunity structure"

(continued)

Table 1 (continued)

Criteria	Theories	
	Theory of social movements	Theory of publics
	supporters; the extent to which the regime represses or facilitates collective claim making; decisive changes in these properties" (Tarrow and Tilly 2009)	
Examples	Anti-Vietnam war movement, civil rights movement	"Arab Spring" in the Middle East and North Africa region, protests of 2010 in Russia, Turkey, Ukraine, India, etc.

with the state and the quality of social movement claims (to what extent are they capable of formulating policy problems, solutions, and alternatives). Third was the study of the institutionalization of social movements in nondemocratic societies or outside the election process (why politicians respond to social movement claims beyond the motive to be elected). Fourth was the analysis of social movements in diverse space and time (comparison of them across nations, including "non-Western" societies, and dynamically over time). Following one or several of these dimensions may provide an opportunity to identify patterns of the social movement effectiveness from the standpoint of their impact on institutional change, depending on the spatial and temporal contexts, and the actual dynamics of the social movements themselves (Bosi et al. 2016).

There were only a few attempts to study protests as social movements, taking into account the aforementioned new research agenda. For example, Donatella Della Porta and her co-authors compared Western and "non-Western" societies, looked at long-term effects of social movements on social change, and studied the causal mechanisms of social movements' success or failure (Della Porta and Diani 2006, 2011, 2015; Della Porta 2014). Despite these attempts, a lot in the research area remains understudied, such as the causal mechanisms that lead to different forms of protest movements' institutionalization, from inclusion in the policy process as an autonomous actor of change and direct participation to co-optation when the autonomy of protesters could be lost. Such dynamics would of interest to compare in "democratic" and "nondemocratic" environment, spatial and temporal contexts.

Democratization theories paid little attention to the impact of protests on political change. In modernization theory, democratization is seen as just one of the processes along with secularization, urbanization, industrialization, and national and industrial revolutions without the specific role of civil actors. There is a particular focus on the way that social structures and institutions affect democratization (market economy, universal education, middle class, organized working class, etc.). Transitology defined democratization as a process of political actors' interaction for regime change, criticizing the structuralism approach for undue emphasis on macro-processes and structures affecting the process of democratization. However, even this framework saw

protest groups as marginal, having little influence on democratization, and as an amorphous social phenomenon—masses or crowds (Della Porta 2014).

The reason the roles of some actors are being underestimated lies within the fact that transitology considers democratization as a linear process of subsequent changes from one stage to the other, from liberalization to democratization to consolidation (Schmitter and Santiso 1998). While a large number of examples contradict the notion of linear or stage-by-stage nature of democratization, overcoming this assumption in research was an essential step in democracy studies, which allowed researchers to ponder the role of different actors in the process of democratization (Carothers 2002). For example, Leonardo Morlino (2011) examined the main driving forces behind democratic changes. He separated changes for democracy into six discrete and complex processes toward the democracy (transition to democracy and democratic installation, democratic consolidation, and democratic qualities' deepening) and away from democracy (transition from democracy to authoritarianism or another regime, democratic crisis, and democratic qualities' worsening). While doing so, he noted that each process required "its own empirical analysis with different possible theoretical results" (Morlino 2011). With such an approach, actors are considered having the central position and role in the processes of change, but with some reservation that while studying democratization in countries of consolidated democracies, special attention should also be paid to structures (Morlino 2011). Also, an important role in the democratization of countries with authoritarian or hybrid regimes is given to external actors such as the European Union (Morlino 2011).

While analyzing mass protests within the framework of the democratization theories and the concept of social movements, Donatella Della Porta posed the research question toward the role of the protest movements in the process of democratization: "As the relationship between social movements and democratization is not simple, a systematic cross-national comparison is needed to single out the conditions and mechanisms through which democratization is moved from below" (Porta 2014). In this volume we intend to refine this question with a reference to the emerging new type of civil collective actor—protest publics—to single out the conditions and mechanisms through which they can impact social change. Bridging together the limitations and useful insights arising from social change theories, and existing research on social movements with those developed within the theory of publics and in democratization literature, we will focus on defining the models of protest publics' participation in social change. These clarifications are necessary for several reasons.

First, many of the studies attempt to describe and analyze mass protests of the new millennium as a newly emerging phenomenon (Bozzoli and Bruck 2010; Durac 2012, 2013; Khmelko and Pereguda 2014; Madestam et al. 2013). We argue that mass protests of the 2010s indicated the appearance of a new civil collective actor that, when compared with social movements, has unique features that can be better analyzed within the theory of publics framework. The first part of this volume attempts to demonstrate that this emerging civil actor can be called protest public, because protest groups of the 2010s have more features of the "active public" developed within the theory of publics (Warner 2002) than of social movement (see Table 1).

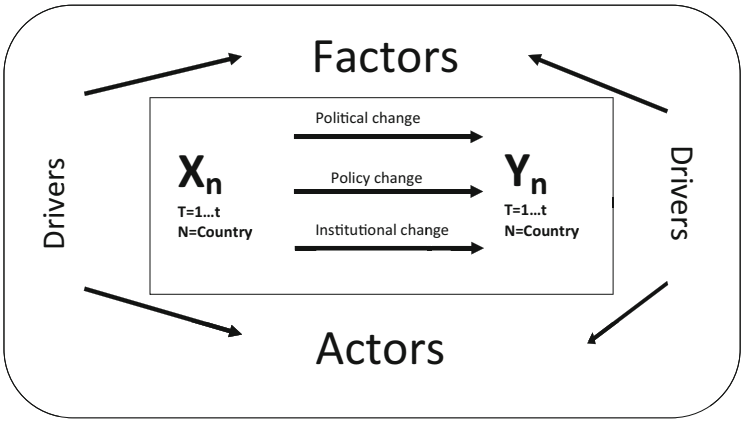
Second, the theory of publics provides an insight that protest publics can impact social change despite "political opportunity structure" and act as an agent of change (Table 1). In social sciences, the study of the interaction between the protestors and social change is usually reduced to an explanation of a successful or, which is more common, unsuccessful cases of changes. In general, the main conclusions are circling around the crisis of traditional democratic institutions of representative democracy thesis, of the "liberal model" of democracy, and the need to develop new forms of participatory democracy (Arbatli and Rosenberg 2017). In practice, protests do not necessarily lead toward or away from democratization; the reality is much more complex and consists of "nonlinear," multidimensional processes. For example, it is a common knowledge that the waves of protests in Russia led to tightening of the political regime, which became more authoritarian. However, they also boosted and transformed into the numerous civil initiatives and democratic practices that allow us to call this model of protest publics' participation the "democratic innovators in authoritarian environment" (see chapter "Protest Publics as Democratic Innovators in Authoritarian Environments"). It is usually reported that the protests in Egypt first led to Islamization during the President Morsi period and then to "coup d'état" when Abdel Fattah el-Sisi, a military figure who led the coup against Morsi, won the general elections. But democratization processes and other social changes are not so linear in Egypt, where we can see some progress because the government had to take into account the protest publics as triggers of majority of the changes in economy and social sphere (see chapter "Protest Publics as the 'Triggers' of Political Changes in Hybrid Regimes: The Cases of Tunisia, Morocco and Egypt"). The examples provided here reaffirm the conclusion of nonlinear nature of changes and the importance of monitoring their trajectories. It is important to note that protest publics can move those trajectories in certain directions (not necessarily just toward or away from democratization), which should also be examined and studied. The trajectories of changes and their corresponding factors and actors encompass a broader mechanism of social change.

Modeling the protest publics' participation in social change required a reconceptualization of the idea of "social change" itself and reevaluation of the research tools used for the analysis. In this book, we focused on social change on the national level. This focus allowed conducting of cross-national research to identify the functions of collective actors in social change. Particular attention was paid to the mechanisms of political change in the examined polities. In order to do so, there was a need to combine actor-centered and institutional theoretical approaches to the analysis of social change. This allowed identifying three types of social change: political change, policy change, and institutional change. Political change should be considered within the sphere of politics (struggle for power) and include change of political leadership, change of balance of power, elite change, and regime change. Policy change happens in public policy sphere and covers dynamics in diverse policy fields such as the economy, delivery of social services, sport, migration, education, and healthcare (Bardach 2011). Institutional change refers to the change of architecture of existing polity and contains evolution, devolution, and collapse of "old" political institutions and emergence and development of "new" one (Roland 2004).

The suggested approach focuses on actions of collective actors and protest publics, in particular, which helps limit social changes to a timeline when the protests were the strongest and protest publics were the most active. We assume that the actions of a collective actor in a short period of time could trigger mechanism of social change and result in long-term consequences. This assumption allows us to trace the impact of protest publics on social change of all three types. Mechanism of social change is a "concatenation of generative events linking macro causes (such as contextual transformation) to aggregated effects (for example, cycles of protest) through individual and/or organizational agents" (Della Porta 2014; Roland 2004). Given that focus, we move to the appropriate level of analysis of the role of collective actors, protest publics in particular, in social change. Also, this approach helps us to avoid a simplified "linear" understanding of an actor's influence on the social change, usually modeled as a direct relationship between actions of actors and factors, on the one hand, and social change, on the other, as it is often the case in quantitative research, i.e., when modeling a regression. At the same time, it also allows us to evaluate the actor's influence, taking into account the interdependence of the variables and avoiding the simplification of the mechanism of social change and not ignoring its multidimensional and multivariate nature.

In order to conceptualize and operationalize collective actors' impact and role in social change, we propose the following scheme (Picture 1). For analysis, it is important to identify the starting (Xn) and the ending point (Yn) in the timeline to trace social change in the country (N). Theoretically, there could be as many trajectories of social change as there are countries in the world. However, we assume that these trajectories could be grouped or clustered into a smaller number (T), far less than the number of countries in the world (N).

Basic concepts used in the analysis include the types of change defined above and the drivers of change. Drivers of social change are divided into actors and factors. Factors are all the possible phenomena, external to social change, which can influence



Picture 1 Conceptualization scheme to assess the impact and role of a collective actor in the mechanism of social change

any type of change: economy, politics, culture, demography, and society. Actors are all possible structures, individuals, and groups that can impact the changes: governmental and nongovernmental actors, politicians, political parties, interest groups, social movements, NGOs, business associations and corporations, intellectuals, and protest publics. If the protest publics act as the drivers of social change, they could be considered as actors of change and mass protests as factors of change.

Consequently, the assessment of protest publics' impact on social change might be achieved by comparing the mass protests to other factors of political change, be they economic (such as GDP and production), political (e.g., the level of trust to government, electoral preference changes), cultural (value shifts in society, changes of political culture), social (environmental problems, migration, poverty), and demographic (population change, mortality rate). For example, mass protests appear to be an important factor of social change in nearly every country that experienced mass protests in the 2010s. Protests in Russia (mass opposition protests of 2011–2014) and Brazil (protests due to numerous allegations of corruption and embezzlement in the government and discontent over World Cup 2014 budgetary expenditure in times of austerity) were linked to decelerating growth rates of the economy preceded by significant economic growth in both countries. In addition, both Russia and Brazil had experienced an increase of proportion of population who shared post-materialist values at the time of protests. As a result, the new middle class comprised the base of the protest publics in both countries. Despite these similarities, protestors in Brazil were more successful than their Russian counterparts (demands of Brazilian protestors were partially satisfied by the authorities), because protest publics in Brazil acted in democratic environment and societal consensus that economic modernization is a key to solving social problems as an alternative to authoritative modernization (Zaytsev 2017). Russia had very different external environments: growth of the authoritarian tendencies in political regime accompanied by dependence on extensive economic growth, which later turned into recession and further economic problems. These led to a very different outcome: protestors' demands were left unsatisfied. On the contrary, political elites tried to marginalize the protest publics. Citizens became extremely polarized with a pro-Putin passive majority and an active minority in opposition to the current political status quo (see chapter "Protest Publics as Democratic Innovators in Authoritarian Environments").

Also, in this case another outcome is possible; that is, protest publics might be the actor of change. That means that their influence on social change is strong enough for them to be only a background or a factor of change, but also as a valuable player in the game. Consequently, it is very important to evaluate the capacity of protest publics to influence social change and compare their actions with actions of other possible actors of change. It is clear that the changes cannot be driven by a single actor, even a collective one; it is always the outcome of some activity of a coalition of actors. In addition, different coalitions compete to realize their own scenarios of change. Therefore, studying the mechanism of social change may allow analyzing the activity of the actors' coalitions, their game, and its results. However, before this analysis can be performed, we have to be sure that protest publics are the truly autonomous actors, with their own identity, who do not depend on "third parties,"

agents, or clients in patron-client relations. In the literature, this capacity is also called "actorness" (Belyaeva and Dzhibladze 2014).

To consider whether protest publics have any degree of "actorness," we need to test their degrees of political consolidation and political autonomy. The assumption is that only sufficiently consolidated (with integrated interests, goals, and values, connected with its members through regular communication) and autonomous (self-organized, self-governed, self-sufficient, able to set goals independently from "third parties," with more or less clear identity) political actors can influence political change.

The next five chapters in this volume describe the studies of protest publics as drivers of social change using the methodological framework described above in a way that each chapter reflects the following considerations in countries under study: the significance of mass protests ("factorness"), the degree of protest publics' consolidation and autonomy ("actorness"), social changes, and factors and actors of social changes. Such a framework allowed the authors to make inferences about mass protests as the factors of change in their interaction with other factors, about protest publics as actors of change compared with other actors, and, finally, to justify the role that the protest publics play in social change.

For such a justification, we assume grouping of countries under the analysis into four models, where protest publics have similar function in social change. First model is represented by such embedded democracies as Iceland, the UK, and the USA, because we suppose that in these countries, the protest publics have been trying to challenge the centuries-old "status quo" (chapter "Protesters as the "Challengers of the Status-Quo" in Embedded Democracies: The Cases of Iceland, the United Kingdom, and the United States of America"). In relatively earlier polyarchies of the Global South (Brazil, India, and South Africa) and Southern Europe (Italy, Spain, and Greece), protest publics entrenched the role of "watch-dogs," raising concerns about the quality of democracy (Chapters "Protest Publics as the 'Watchdogs' of the Quality of Democracy in the Polyarchies of the Global South" and "The Transforming Role of Protest Publics in Processes of Socio-political Change in the Global South and Southern Europe: From Occasional Challengers to Institutionalised Watchdogs"). In hybrid regimes protests led to different changes, but protest publics became the "triggers" for such changes, which allows us to consider cases of Tunisia, Morocco, and Egypt together in chapter "Protest Publics as the 'Triggers' of Political Changes in Hybrid Regimes: The Cases of Tunisia, Morocco and Egypt". Finally, there is a model of protest publics in authoritarian environments, where they can establish the function of "democratic innovators" (Chapter "Protest Publics as Democratic Innovators in Authoritarian Environments"). The reasoning behind the selection of the abovementioned countries is based on both quantitative and qualitative traditions of comparative research.

Table 2 Social change in different regimes: from clusters to models

Clusters	2008	Clusters	2015	Models	Final models
I	Iceland, UK, and USA	I	Iceland, UK, and USA	I	Iceland, UK, and USA
II	Italy, Spain, and Greece	II	Italy, Spain, and Greece	II	Italy, Spain, and Greece
III	Brazil, South Africa	III	Brazil, India, South Africa, and Tunisia	III	Brazil, India, and South Africa
IV	India				
V	Tunisia, Egypt	IV	Egypt, Morocco, Russia, and Turkey	IV	Tunisia, Morocco, and Egypt
VI	Morocco				
VII	Russia, Turkey			V	Russia, Turkey, and China
VIII	China	V	China		

3 Research Design: Case Selection and Clusterization

From the 84 countries (Ortiz et al. 2013), where the mass protests happened between 2006 and 2013, we choose 15 countries for further qualitative analysis using small-N comparative case study method. The main selection criteria were geography, total number of years over which the mass protests happened, and number of protest episodes. For each geographical region, in accordance with the Economist Intelligence Unit classification of geographical regions (North America, Western Europe, Eastern Europe, Latin America and the Caribbean, Asia and Australasia, Middle East and North Africa, sub-Saharan Africa), we chose several countries, maximizing the total number of years when mass protests happened and the number of protest episodes. In addition, we took into consideration the changes in democracy ranking between 2006 and 2016, selecting such countries where the difference in rankings was the highest. As a result, we ended up with the list of 15 within the framework of most-different comparative research design, where the cases are the most different countries by their inputs (social context and conditions) and outcomes (social changes), but have one important similarity: in all these countries, mass protests were a significant factor of change.

The next step was to find more similarities between these 15 countries and group them by comparable clusters. To do this we used both the quantitative and qualitative methods. First, we performed the hierarchical cluster analysis using Ward's method to define similarities between countries. Clusters were calculated for 164 countries by 153 variables that operationalize political, policy, and institutional changes according to Picture 1 (the full list of variables is available in the Appendix). The data were collected and analyzed for the years 2008 and 2015. First period was chosen as the starting point before the main waves of protests, and the year 2015 is the latest period available for data analysis when the majority of variables are still available. The results are shown in Table 2.

The grouping of cases that comprise the final models was based on both the quantitative and qualitative reasoning. There are two most stable clusters of

countries: Iceland, the UK, and the USA (first cluster) and Italy, Spain, and Greece (second cluster). We can assume the similarities in the dynamics of social changes in these clusters and the comparable roles of protest publics in these changes. This is why these countries were combined into the first two models.

The grouping of the next countries into the models did not have a strong supporting evidence in the results of cluster analysis. To support this grouping, we used the results of expert assessments (conducted during the research project, results are presented in the second part of the book) and previous empirical research. As a result, the cluster composition for the final models was the corrected results of cluster analysis based on the evidence from expert interviews and literature. Hence, India in 2008 was in a separate cluster, but in 2015 was in a joined cluster with Brazil and South Africa. An additional justification from experts and literature supports the idea that these were the developing states of Global South, with many similarities in recent democratic development (Keukeleire and Hooijmaaijers 2014; Mohanty et al. 2011; Scoones 2008); it gave us the opportunity to analyze them together in chapter "Protest Publics as the 'Watchdogs' of the Quality of Democracy in the Polyarchies of the Global South".

Tunisia, Egypt, and Morocco have similar change trajectories during the peak of mass protests (Hinnebusch 2015; Ottaway and Hamzawy 2011), but they appear to be in different clusters before and after the protests. In 2008, Tunisia and Egypt have very similar authoritarian regimes (Battera 2014). In 2015 Tunisia, triggered by the protests, has significantly improved on the democratization scale and joined the cluster of polyarchies of Global South. Egypt and Morocco, located in separate clusters in 2008, in 2015 joined the cluster with Russia and Turkey. These results demonstrate the change of trajectory for both Egypt and Morocco from democracy as a goal of change to a decline toward the more autocratic regime. Russia and Turkey in recent decades are always documented together in one cluster. China appears to remain alone and does not belong to any group of countries. It is usually recognized by the experts as an example of a successful authoritarian economic modernization (Suisheng 2010; Wallace 2011; Wang and Tan 2013). That is why we put China into one model with Russia and Turkey. In each model, we have such referent countries. For example, Iceland, after the peak of mass protests, practiced much more democratic innovations than the UK and the USA, demonstrating the possible path for further development, deepening the quality of democracy. Spain and Brazil are also such example countries in their clusters. Tunisia showed the path for other Arab states with hybrid regimes, providing evidence that successful democratic transit and development of institutions of polyarchy in this region is possible.

Therefore, even within the models where the difference between the countries existed, we argue that protest publics had similar functions as they were able to boost similar effects on social change at least during the peak of protests, and sometimes those changes remained stable trajectories demonstrating similar trends. In the next section of the chapter, we used the method of agreement (Mill and Nagel 1950) to figure out the similar causes of the similar trends within the model countries.

4 Models of Protest Publics' Participation in Social Change: An Overview

The results of our research on the role of protest publics in the social changes have served as the grounds for the hypothetical modeling of possible patterns for the civic participation in social dynamics observed in the world. We describe and test these models in the next five chapters of this volume.

First, protest publics were examined as the challengers of the status quo in embedded democracies (Iceland, the UK, and the USA). In the countries with established democratic institutions that functioned for centuries, the protest publics contest and question their efficiency, promoting new agenda for deepening the quality of democracy and change toward more civil participation, more equal citizens' inclusion, and higher responsiveness of political elites.

Second, protest publics serve as the watchdogs raising concerns about the quality of democracy in consolidated democracies (Brazil, India, and SAR; Spain, Italy, and Greece). The function of protester in these countries was institutionalized as permanent control over the government, with continuous monitoring of the authorities' decisions. Overall, the common interest of protest publics and other related actors lies in the further development of polyarchies and democratic consolidation.

Third, protest publics act as the triggers of democratic development in hybrid regimes (Tunisia, Egypt, and Morocco). In the beginning of mass uprising in Tunisia, Egypt, and Morocco, protest publics boosted the democratic development, but the following changes tended to go by different trajectories. Examining the differences in light of many similarities in these Arab countries of North Africa is an objective of our analysis.

Finally, protest publics appear as democratic innovators in authoritarian environments (Russia, Turkey, and China). The main assumption of this cluster is that being placed in the authoritarian environment, the protest publics take on a function of the establishment and institutionalization of democratic practices. Protesters established a trend contrary to the dominant one—the rise of authoritarianism. They created the alternative agenda with the focus on development of bottom-up and grassroot practices such as volunteering, election observers, independent media, and information exchange exposing propaganda, pro bono legal education, and support of civil activists.

Protest publics boost the similar trends of social change within the model countries. The social change goes through several trajectories that are examined through the three types of change: political, policy, and institutional change. Table 3 represents how four hypothesized models are characterized by each type of change.

Political polarization is the common trend across the examined countries. However, it materializes differently in different model countries. In embedded democracies the existing political spectrum becomes more polarized because of the appearance of the radical "left" and the radical "right" new political parties and opposing wings of traditional parties. Such polarization is accompanied by the rise of political populism. However, new parties and wings cannot break down the existing

Table 3 Trajectories of social change

Parameters (main features and trends)		Challengers of the status quo in embedded democracies	Watchdogs raising concerns about the quality of democracy in consolidated democracies		Triggers of democratic development in hybrid regimes	Democratic innovators in authoritarian environments
Type of social change	Political	Polarization of existing political spectrum (appearance of radical "left" and "right" parties and wings), rise of political populism	Polarization of political spectrum (appearance of new political parties that won elections)		Polarization of elites, activation of "veto players" (army, the King, civil society) as "peace-makers" and "peacekeepers"	Polarization of elites and society (conformist "majority" and active "progressive" "minority")
	Policy	Raising new issues in the policy agenda	Anti-corruption and redistribution policy measures		Economic development policy measures	Restrictions in media, security, anti-extremism, civil society policies; identity politics as a new political arena
	Institutional	Raising the question about the quality of democracy (equality)	Raising the question about the quality of democracy (participation and responsiveness)		"Eventful democratization"	Raising of authoritarianism vs "underground" development of civil society and accumulation of collective actions and democratic practices
Countries (examples)		USA, UK, Iceland	Spain, Greece, Italy	Brazil, India, South Africa	Egypt, Morocco, Tunisia	Russia, China, Turkey

political status quo. In the contrary, in consolidated democracies of Global South and European South, new political parties, which appeared on the wave of mass protests, have managed to grab significant election counts; they sometimes won the elections and established new governments as the result. In hybrid regimes of Arab countries, the polarization affected political elites and key actors first and then the established party institutions because they were weaker than in polyarchies. If in the polyarchies the polarization reproduced the traditional left-right party system division, the split of Arab countries represented the divergent poles of modernist and Islamist parts of society (Anufriev and Zaytsev 2016). To prevent violent clashes and confrontations that threaten to develop into civil wars, the veto players (Morlino 2011) become active in order to turn away from the destructive scenarios of political development. In the case of Egypt, it was the army and military elites; Morocco, the King; and Tunisia, the coalition of civil society actors. In autocracies, both the elites and the society were divided into the conformist majority (political elites of power-holders around the authoritarian national leader whose support is legitimized by the conformists and absentee groups of the society) and active progressive minority (political contra-elites and opposition, autonomous from the government interest groups, and active parts of society).

Policy changes differ more and range from raising new issues in the policy agenda in embedded democracies (mostly around the problem of inequality in diverse aspects) to restrictions in media, security, anti-extremism, and civil society policies in authoritarian states. The goal of such restrictions is to override protest publics and opposition and to preserve political dominance by political elites. Interesting is the fact that such policy goals are also achieved by special identity politics that become the new political agenda. Here, a political campaign to impose a conservative ideology by the power-holders is expanding through persecution of any alternative political, civil, or even cultural identities. Cultural identity representation is also under risk of being oppressed because imposed identity is mixed with traditional values (patriotic and Orthodox in Russia, Islamist and Pan-Turkism in Turkey, and communist in China). In polyarchies of Global South and European South, the policy change agenda is more focused on solving the problems with corruption and proper redistribution of national income (more to the social issues and less to policies supporting reputation of the state such as sport policy), which were of special concern and the subject of demands of protest publics. Economic development became the primary goal for the new governments in Arab countries because mass protests were closely associated with economic problems such as unemployment and poverty.

Democratic dimension of social change in embedded and consolidated democracies is defined by the process of deepening the quality of democracy. If in the Iceland, the UK, and the USA, the core quality to improve is the equality, as many of the new actors, including those who emerged during the protests (first of all protest publics and active citizens' groups), were not equal participants of the political game. In the polyarchies of the Global South and European South, the key qualities to expand were participation and responsiveness (Morlino 2004). Institutional change in Arab countries is perfectly explained by the concept of

"eventful democratization" (Della Porta 2014), when democratization took place due to the current political situation "here and now." If the chance is missed because of lack of some condition, factor, or activity of a particular actor, the autocratic trend can override the democratic one, like it happened in Egypt. In Russia, Turkey, and China, the common knowledge about the recent decades of institutional development is the rise of authoritarianism (or its preservation on the highest level as in China). However, this thesis is blind toward the alternative dynamics happening in these countries, such as the rising unconventional and underground activity, development, and participation of political opposition; emerging protest publics and independent from the government civil society actors in solving local policy problems; and accumulation of democratic practices of collective actions and conflict resolution.

Social changes described above have a multitude of diverse causes for each country, but within the documented models, we can define several similar reasons of the depicted trends of social dynamics. First, the model countries have similar political, geo-historical, and geographical context (see Table 4). Second, social changes were caused by certain factors and actors along with the protest publics' activity. Table 4 summarized similar economic, social, and cultural factors within each group of model countries. Economically developed countries of Global North and Southern Europe, for example, differ according to the level of vulnerability to changes in economic crisis: in the UK, the USA, and Iceland, economic crisis has had less of an impact on changes than in Spain, Greece, and Italy, where each economic crisis is associated with the new waves of protests and subsequent reforms. Economically developing countries also have different levels of vulnerability: from Arab countries, where economic crises are a crucial factor of change, to authoritarian states with high level of resistance, to economic turbulence, to Global South countries, where perceived economic development is more important than the real economic dynamics.

The common problems to all models are social problems of inequality and corruption. Corruption is comparatively less problematized in the countries of embedded democracies (Kolstad and Wiig 2016; Rock 2009). Embedded and European democracies also suffer from population aging. Unemployment is a serious factor of change in those countries where economic crises have the most serious social consequences (e.g., European South and Arab countries).

For cultural factors of change, we analyzed the post-materialist value shift according to the results of the World Value Survey (2015), testing the Inglehart and Welzel's idea that in the last decades, we were the victims of post-materialist shift worldwide, when the percent of population with survival and traditional values became lower and secular-rational and self-expression values increased in the whole structure of the society (Inglehart and Welzel 2005, 2010). This shift has different speeds in different parts of the world, but, in general, affects the entire world. The waves of 2010s protests worldwide are known as the protests of the post-materialist generation. Therefore, this factor is very important to understanding the social changes and the role of protest publics there. From Table 4 we can see that countries differ greatly: protest publics have more success in countries where the social

Table 4 Factors of social change

Parameters (main features and trends)	"Challengers" of the status quo in embedded democracies	Watchdogs raising concerns about the quality of democracy in consolidated democracies		"Triggers" of democratic development in hybrid regimes	"Democratic innovators" in authoritarian environments
Political	Embedded democracy	Consolidated democracy		Hybrid regime	Authoritarian regime
Geo-historical	"Euro-atlantic" block countries	Recent "dictatorships"	Former colonies	Former colonies	Former "inner empires"
Geography	"Global North"	"European South"	"Global South"	"Arab countries"	"Border countries"
Economy	Developed	Developed and vulnerable to the recent economic crisis	Developing	Developing and vulnerable to the recent economic crisis	Developing and not too much vulnerable to the recent economic crisis
Society	Inequality, population aging	Inequality, unemployment, corruption, population aging	Inequality, corruption	Inequality, unemployment, corruption	Inequality, corruption
Culture	Self-expression	Mixed		Survival	Survival
Countries (examples)	USA, UK[a], Iceland[a]	Spain[a], Greece[a], Italy[a]	Brazil, India[a], SAR	Egypt[a], Morocco, Tunisia	Russia, China, Turkey

[a]Countries with the high perceived inequality based on the analysis of the World Value Survey data (World Value Survey 2015)

structure is dominated by self-expression values (the model of embedded democracies) or mixed values (the model of consolidated democracies), but is limited, with dynamics of further democratization less promising, in hybrid and authoritarian regimes, where survival values are stronger.

Table 5 demonstrates different actors that are the driving force of changes or the main opposing party of changes. In addition, it describes the function or role of protest publics in the model countries, with clarification of the protesters' main demands for social changes and channels of their interests' representation.

Protest publics meet the allies in traditional actors in the left-right spectrum of embedded democracies. However, protesters are not recognized by these traditional actors as equal players in the political game. This is why the protest publics act as radical marginal wings of the dominant political parties (either inside them, trying to reform them like in the USA, or outside, including creation of the new parties).

Protest publics in consolidated democracies cause the creation of new political parties that become their representatives in political establishment. In addition, the function of outside watchdogs is strong as this association with new political parties is not dominant and leaves space for the permanent independent actions in the streets. Protest publics are also strongly associated with contra-elites as all elites, without any exceptions, are suspected of corruption and have very limited public trust.

Protest publics in Arab countries are a victim of broader social split between the modernist and Islamist parts of the elites and society. Protest publics are also divided. The modernist part of protesters tries to become the catalyst for democratic development. The demands for economic development meet more responses from the government than demands for democratization.

In authoritarian regimes protest publics represent the progressive part of the society with their natural allies among opposition political parties and politicians independent from the government NGOs, interest groups, and new mass media. Together they try to concentrate the limited resources to establish some democratic patterns and practices in authoritarian environment—new social movements and citizens' associations, independent from the government, public volunteering, election observers, pro bono groups of professionals supporting diverse forms of civil participation, and creation of new media mostly in social networks, including the purpose to expose the state propaganda. Contrary to them are the coalitions of the dominant actors—the political elites and their natural allies: conformist-oriented part of the society with conservative elitist values and attitudes, loyal to regime political parties, government-organized nongovernmental organization (GONGO) and interest groups, mass media with wide broadcasting coverage around the country, and big businesses usually owned by the people close to the national leader. They monopolize major resources and provide the main trajectory of social change described above. The function of the protest publics here is to erode authoritarian consensus, propose democratic alternative, and develop social capital when the vector of social dynamics changes its direction due to the impact of some strongest factors such as economic or stateness crisis.

* * *

Table 5 Actors of social change

Parameters (main features and trends)		"Challengers" of the status quo in embedded democracies	Watchdogs raising concerns about the quality of democracy in consolidated democracies		"Triggers" of democratic development in hybrid regimes	"Democratic innovators" in authoritarian environments
Actors' coalitions		"Left" vs. "right"	"Elite" vs. "contra-elite"		"Modernists" vs. "Islamists"	"Conservators" and "progressists"
Protest publics	Function or role in social change	Challenge status quo, promote new agenda for raising the quality of democracy and social change	Permanent control over government and monitoring governmental decisions		Catalyze democratic development	Establishment and institutionalization of democratic practices parallel to the authoritarian environment
	Field of demands for social change	Democracy and public policy (social policy, fighting inequality)	Democracy and public policy (social policy, fighting corruption)		Democracy and public policy (development policy)	Democracy and public policy (social policy, local governance and institutions, civil society)
	Channels of interests' representation	Polarized and radical "active publics" inside current institutions (political parties) and outside them	New political parties		Head of the state, civil society organizations	New social movements, citizens' associations, democratic practices (volunteering, observers, groups, and new media in social networks)
Countries (examples)		USA, UK, Iceland	Spain, Greece, Italy	Brazil, India, SAR	Egypt, Morocco, Tunisia	Russia, China, Turkey

In the first part of this book, the authors hypothesize and verify that collective actors of the mass political protests of the 2010s in many countries have features of protest publics. This chapter follows the main logic of this book, taking protest publics as a core concept and research focus. If the first part of the book verified to what extent mass protests of the 2010s can be viewed as protest publics, this chapter opened the section with chapters that attempt to identify and describe the model of protest publics' participation in social change. Each chapter is trying to catch similarities and differences cross-nationally.

In conclusion we want to encourage the reader to not only look through the current chapter but also read the next five chapters about the regions that are of special interest as they provide much more information, insights, and interesting punchlines that can overturn the usual, explained-from-the-TV picture of the political world and its dynamics.

Acknowledgments Authors express their gratitude to Dr. Valentina Kuskova, Head of International Laboratory for Applied Network Research, who has been supervising this research.

Funding The chapter was prepared within the framework of the Academic Fund Program at the National Research University "Higher School of Economics" (HSE) in 2016–2017 (grant № 17-05-0018) and by the Russian Academic Excellence Project "5-100".

Appendix: Variables for Cluster Analysis

1. Magnitude score of episode(s) of civil violence	40. Some other executive have the power to introduce legislation	79. Institutionalized Democracy	118. Transparency Index
2. Magnitude score of episode(s) of civil warfare	41. Legislature's Ratification of International Treaties	80. Regime Durability	119. Demographic Pressure
3. Magnitude score of episode(s) of ethnic violence	42. Some other executive have the power to use force abroad	81. Polity Fragmentation	120. Poverty and Economic Decline
4. Magnitude score of episode(s) of ethnic warfare	43. No Parties Allowed	82. The Competitiveness of Participation	121. External Intervention
5. Magnitude score of episode(s) of international violence	44. Religion Based Banning of Parties	83. Regulation of Participation	122. Factionalized Elites
6. Magnitude score of episode(s) of international warfare	45. Dichotomous democracy measure	84. Combined Polity Score	123. Fragile States Index
7. Autonomous Regions	46. Number of previous democratic breakdowns	85. Revised Combined Polity Score	124. Group Grievance

(continued)

8. Is Chief Executive a Military Officer?	47. Consecutive years of current regime type	86. Executive Constraints (Decision Rules)	125. Human Flight and Brain Drain
9. Checks and Balances	48. Dichotomous democracy measure (incl. missing for some countries)	87. Competitiveness of Executive Recruitment	126. Human Rights and Rule of Law
10. Executive Electoral Competitiveness	49. Democratic transition	88. Openness of Executive Recruitment	127. Public Services
11. Presidential Election Held	50. New Constitutional System	89. Regulation of Chief Executive Recruitment	128. Refugees and IDPs
12. Finite Term in Office	51. Year in which the Constitutional System was Promulgated	90. Press Freedom Index	129. Security Apparatus
13. Government Fractionalization Index	52. Freedom of Assembly and Association	91. Deliberative democracy index	130. State Legitimacy
14. Largest Government Party Orientation	53. Disappearance	92. Deliberative component index	131. Uneven Economic Development
15. Number of Seats of Largest Government Party	54. Freedom of Domestic Movement	93. Electoral component index	132. Independent Sub-Federal Unit
16. Number of Seats of 2nd Largest Government Party	55. Electoral Self-Determination	94. Egalitarian component index	133. Independent Judiciary
17. Number of Seats of 3rd Largest Government Party	56. Empowerment Rights Index (New)	95. Egalitarian democracy index	134. Legislative Chamber
18. Number of Government Seats	57. Freedom of Foreign Movement	96. Women political empowerment index	135. 2nd Legislative Chamber
19. Legislative Election Held	58. Independence of the Judiciary	97. Liberal democracy index	136. Business Freedom
20. Legislative Electoral Competitiveness	59. Extrajudicial Killing	98. Liberal component index	137. Government Integrity
21. Margin of Majority	60. Physical Integrity Rights Index	99. Participatory component index	138. Economic Freedom Index
22. Number of Other Government Parties	61. Political Imprisonment	100. Participatory democracy index	139. Financial Freedom
23. Number of Seats of Other Government Parties	62. Freedom of Religion (New)	101. Electoral democracy index	140. Tax Burden
24. Number of Other Opposition Parties	63. Freedom of Speech	102. Political corruption	141. Freedom from Government
25. Number of Seats of Other Opposition Parties	64. Torture	103. Executive bribery and corrupt exchanges	142. Investment Freedom

(continued)

26. Number of Opposition Seats	65. Women's Economic Rights	104. Public sector corrupt exchanges	143. Labor Freedom
27. Number of Seats of Non-Aligned Parties	66. Women's Political Rights	105. Executive corruption index	144. Monetary Freedom
28. Total Seats in Legislature	67. Workers' Rights	106. Executive embezzlement and theft	145. Property Rights
29. Number of Seats of Largest Opposition Party	68. Electoral Process	107. Public sector theft	146. Trade Freedom
30. Number of Seats of 2nd Largest Opposition Party	69. Freedom of Expression and Belief	108. Legislature corrupt activities	147. Corruption Perceptions Index
31. Number of Seats of 3rd Largest Opposition Party	70. Functioning of Government	109. Judicial corruption decision	148. Control of Corruption
32. Political System	71. Level of Democracy (Freedom House/Imputed Polity)	110. Media corrupt	149. Government Effectiveness
33. Fractionalization Index	72. Personal Autonomy and Individual Rights	111. Public sector corruption index	150. Political Stability and Absence of Violence/Terrorism
34. Number of Non-Aligned Parties	73. Political Pluralism and Participation	112. The Bayesian Corruption Indicator	151. Rule of Law
35. Chief Executive Years in Office	74. Political Rights	113. Effectiveness	152. Regulatory Quality
36. Banning of Anti-System Parties	75. Rule of Law	114. Legitimacy	153. Voice and Accountability
37. Some other executive have the power to call elections	76. Freedom Status	115. State fragility index	
38. Constitutional Court	77. Level of Democracy (Freedom House/Polity)	116. Accountability Transparency	
39. Ethnicity Based Banning of Parties	78. Institutionalized Autocracy	117. Information Transparency	

Source: Quality of Governance Dataset. Teorell, Jan, Stefan Dahlberg, Sören Holmberg, Bo Rothstein, Natalia Alvarado Pachon & Richard Svensson. 2018. The Quality of Government Standard Dataset, version Jan18. University of Gothenburg: The Quality of Government Institute, http://www.qog.pol.gu.se. doi:https://doi.org/10.18157/QoGStdJan18

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Protesters as the "Challengers of the Status Quo" in Embedded Democracies: The Cases of Iceland, the United Kingdom, and the United States



Nikita Shmaltsev and Dmitry G. Zaytsev

1 Overview of the Protests

Iceland was the first country to face protests in the aftermath of the financial crisis of 2008. Protests began in mid-October 2008, a few weeks after the collapse of three biggest Icelandic banks. Protests began as one-man demonstrations by singer and activist Hordur Torfason on October 11, who spoke and sang songs against "banksters" and their subservient politicians. After someone uploaded his video to the Internet, one-man protests transformed into weekly demonstrations in front of the Icelandic parliament (Castells 2012). By October 25, around 2000 people were protesting and demanding resignation of the prime minister and of the chief of the Central Bank, dissolution of the parliament, and early elections. By November 22, around 6000 people protested, and police was not prepared to handle so many people. On December 31, protests turned violent due to actions of more coordinated but small groups of anarchists. Protests intensified on January 21, on the parliament's opening session after the winter break. By January 24, protests reached the climax, as around 8000 people gathered in front of the parliament, shouting "New, Proper Government," "A New Democracy," and "Disqualified Government." The government stepped down on January 26, 2009, after 4 days of continuous protests. Resignations of chief of the Central Bank and chief financial regulators followed immediately. Snap elections were held in April 2009 and brought the left coalition to power.

Protests started with concrete demands—resignation of politicians, dissolution of parliament, and snap election. But during the months of the protest activity, they

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N. Belyaeva et al. (eds.), *Protest Publics*, Societies and Political Orders in Transition,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5_11

formulated one more demand—to reconfigure the republic through the process of drafting a new constitution. For this, protesters and supporting grassroots organizations created the "National Forum" to discuss the possibility of a new constitution. This was the start of the transformation of the protests into a peaceful cooperation with the government. Protesters were acting as the "parliament of streets" (Burgess and Keating 2013).

National referenda defined the next 3 years of Icelandic politics. Two were on the "Icesave" dispute—to decide on the payment of the loan guarantees owed by the collapsed Icelandic bank Landsbanki to the British and Dutch depositors (Hallgrímsdóttir and Brunet-Jailly 2015). The post-protest government consisting of left-green coalition supported the compensation to the United Kingdom and the Netherlands. It promised to start the EU application process and wanted to keep good relations with the European Union. The majority of people rejected the idea of repayment. The president of Iceland, traditionally only a symbolic figure in Icelandic politics, decided to put the issue to the national referenda due to strong public opposition to the deal. It was the first referendum in the modern history of Iceland and was held on March 6, 2010. 98% of voters were against it.

However, the issue was not resolved after the first referendum. The Icelandic government continued negotiations with the United Kingdom and the Netherlands, trying to reach better conditions for Iceland. The government put the second version of the bill to the national referenda on April 9, 2011. It presented better conditions for Iceland but was again rejected by 57% of the voters.

The process of the constitutional reform, initiated by the protesters and grassroots organizations in 2010, led to the third referendum. It was held on October 20, 2012. People approved all six proposals to the draft, but as the referendum was non-binding, the draft had to be approved by the parliament as well. However, the coalition of the Social Democratic Alliance and the Left-Green Movement did not manage to finish the constitutional reform before parliamentary elections on April 27, 2013. On these elections, the coalition lost the dominant position due to unpopular austerity policies and support of the "Icesave" deal. Right-wing Independence Party and Progressive Party, which were in power before the crisis, won the elections. The process of the constitutional reform was frozen (Fillmore-Patrick 2013).

In the United States, massive protests began in autumn 2011, when the "Occupy Wall Street" campaign began. It started in New York on September 17 and later spread all over the world including the United Kingdom and Iceland. Protests took the form of an occupation, settling in the Zuccotti Park in New York. People also organized many demonstrations across the city. Main issues which caused protests were the high level of corporations' influence on politics, income inequality, and unemployment. November 15 was the "Global Day of Action," when the "Occupy Movement" spread over 951 cities in 82 countries. Occupy camps were established in many American cities and in countries all over the world, including Iceland ("Occupy Reykjavik") and the United Kingdom ("Occupy London"). Over time, Occupy Wall Street in the United States received union support from 14 of the country's largest labor unions and received political support from Congressman Ron Paul, Senator Bernie Sanders, and former Senator Russ Feingold and from numerous celebrities.

Occupation of the Zuccotti Park in New York ended on November 15, 2011, when occupiers were evicted from the park by the police. The eviction sparked the biggest Occupy protests since the beginning of the protests. Occupy camps in other cities and countries continued to exist, but efforts to mobilize protests again were not successful. There were single protest actions and demonstrations over the following years: in late January 2010, people protested against the World Economic Forum; on March 17, 2010, people attempted to celebrate the anniversary of the "Occupy Wall Street" as it was 6 months old; on May 1, 2011, when the "May Day Strike" was organized; on September 17, as the mark of the OWS' anniversary; and others. Outside of the United States, different Occupy groups organized numerous protests as well. In the United Kingdom, Occupy London protests organized to four camps by December 2011 and were evicted from all camps by June 2012.

Over time, the "Occupy Wall Street" became a worldwide brand for protests against inequality, austerity policies, and sometimes capitalism in general. Due to its commitment to direct democracy, leaderless nature, and wide coverage in media and over the Internet, Occupy Wall Street exerted a long-standing influence on public discourse in the United States. Their rhetoric was used by Barack Obama during 2012 presidential elections, by numerous politicians during the parliamentary elections, in 2013 by Bill de Blasio in his victorious run for mayor of New York City, and by Seattle's new mayor Ed Murray. Issues, popularized by the Occupy Wall Street, became a central topic of discussions during the 2016 presidential elections. Occupy Wall Street officially endorsed Democratic candidate Bernie Sanders, whose platform was built around the issue of income inequality. Other candidates had comments on the issues of inequality, which previously was an obscure topic in the United States' political landscape. Occupy Wall Street also motivated and supported many public and protest movements including minimum wage movement, fast-food workers movement, environmental movement, and movement against student debt.

The United Kingdom has also gone through extensive waves of protests in 2010–2013. Mass protests started after the general elections of 2010, when Conservative Party and Liberal Democrats were forced to form the coalition due to hang parliament. The main discontent was caused by austerity policies and budget cuts, more specifically, the fact that government bailed out banks but refused to increase spending on education and public health (The Guardian 2011). This led to anti-austerity protests which began in November 2010 with students protesting against cuts to education. Protesters organized four large demonstrations in London over the next 2 weeks. By March 2011, student protests transformed into protests against budget cuts in general starting from the "March for the Alternative," which gathered around 300,000 people in London. Anti-austerity protests continued over the next years: TUC organized marches in London, Belfast, and Glasgow over the next 2 years. In 2015, after the Conservative Party formed the majority government after the parliamentary elections, protests intensified.

Occupy Wall Street came to the United Kingdom on the Global Day of Action on October 15, 2011. Initially, only one camp was established, at St Paul's Cathedral near the London Stock Exchange. Protesters had planned to occupy the London Stock Exchange itself but were blocked by the police. Occupiers in London were the

first to agree on a public statement and to publish it. It was called "The Initial Statement" and criticized the current state of democracy in the United Kingdom and the austerity policy of the government and expressed solidarity with the protests in other countries. On the first days of protests, there were around 2000–3000 protesters coming during the day and around 300 campings overnight. On October 22, the second camp in Finsbury Square was opened, and by November 18, the third camp known as "The Bank of Ideas" was organized in an abandoned office building owned by a bank. From the very beginning, protesters faced numerous attempts of eviction from the City of London Corporation, the municipal governing body of the City of London. By June 2012, occupiers were evicted from all of their camps, which made Occupy London one of the longest occupations among the global Occupy network.

In October 28, 2011, protesters published their second statement with a set of demands. They called for the democratization of the City of London Corporation, saying that City institutions were "unconstitutional and unfair." In December 2012, the Corporation of the City of London acquiesced to one of the Occupy London demands, releasing information about a previously secret bank account called City's Cash.

Sporadic protests continued over next years, but in 2016 they intensified in all three countries. In Iceland, in April 2016, after the Panama Papers were published, tens of thousands of people protested against the government calling the prime minister to step down after the Panama Papers revealed that politicians were involved in tax arrangements and had offshore and private economic connections with the collapsed Icelandic banks. Prime Minister Sigmundur Davíð stepped down after 3 days of protests, and early elections were announced for autumn. In the United Kingdom, protests unfolded around the Brexit referendum which had to determine whether the United Kingdom would stay in the European Union or not. And in the United States, massive protests took place in response to the presidential elections campaign of 2016. The majority of the protests were against Donald Trump, the Republican presidential candidate with a radical anti-globalist political agenda. Protests were increasing during the campaign and intensified even more after the announcement that Donald Trump won the elections. The presidential elections of 2016 sparked protests against other presidential candidates as well. Democratic nominee, Bernie Sanders, the so-called democratic socialist, attracted support from activists and sympathizers of the "Occupy Wall Street" protests. Hundreds of his supporters organized the "Occupy CNN" rally, protesting CNN's coverage of the presidential elections, which, according to them, ignored Sanders' campaign in favor of another Democratic Party nominee, Hilary Clinton. During the presidential campaign, there were also protests against Hilary Clinton, including one protest organized by Sanders' supporters. Yet, the majority of protests were either pro or against Republican Party candidate Donald Trump. Anti-Trump protests started after Trump announced his candidacy on June 16, 2015, at Trump's first public speech and continued throughout 2015 and 2016. The number of protesters increased over time: from 100 to 200 people in 2015 to thousands at the anti-Trump protest in New York on March 19, 2016; around 2000 protesters in Costa Mesa, California, on April 28, 2016; and "thousands" on May 1, 2016 in Los Angeles.

Protests were intensifying as the popularity of Donald Trump was rising, and his chances to win the elections were increasing. The protests peaked after Donald Trump's inauguration protested by millions on January 21, 2017, during the Women's March, making it the largest single-day protest in the history of the United States. Protests were fragmented, mostly self-organized and spread all over the country. Most of them were held in response to Trump's actions or policy proposals, such as after Trump issued executive order placing harsh restrictions on travelers from several Muslim-majority countries; protests broke in JFK Airport in New York in January 2017.

The geography of protests varied. In Iceland, the vast majority of mass protests took place in Reykjavik, the capital of the country. Protests in the United States began in New York but later spread over the country. The group of protesters in New York, however, remained the most iconic. In the United Kingdom, all major events took place in London, but people all over the country echoed major demonstrations with dozens of local actions for each major one.

2 Protests as Protest Publics

"Occupy" protests in the United Kingdom, the United States, and Iceland, the "Pots and Pans Revolution" in Iceland, and subsequent protests in the countries represented the formation of a new political actor—protest publics. They played the role of the challengers of the current political institutions (the status quo) and tried to create new public space for discussions (thus changing the public discourse) and—within that space—to attempt to develop alternatives, more democratic solutions. People did not trust their governments, and political parties, but believed that democracy itself was the key value, thus often revoking forms of direct democracy and denying any forms of leadership. Occupy was inspired by previous protests around the world—the Arab Spring in the Middle East and anti-austerity protests in Europe, especially in Spain. Pots and Pans Revolution in Iceland in 2008 is rarely mentioned as an inspiration for the Occupy Wall Street, but it is strikingly similar in many aspects.

Protest publics are groups with the capacity to organize themselves outside of existing political institutions with their own identity and demands for changing social reality according to their own ideas about the imaginary alternative world that is discursively constructed by them (Warner 2002; Belyaeva and Dzhibladze, 2014; Mahony and Clarke 2013). Unlike social movements, protest publics operate outside of the existing infrastructure, often have no clearly distinctive leadership, and are much more spontaneous. According to Clarke and Mahony, such complex social phenomenon must be distinguished from the classical definition of social movements, because publics have their own features, based on the heterogeneous nature of these formations and particular orientation on networks and creation of specific "troubling message" (Mahony and Clarke 2013).

Both protest publics and social movements are concepts and come to the real world in their pure form. Rather, mass protests in the selected countries share some characteristics of both concepts. Viewing protests in the United Kingdom, the United States, and Iceland not only through the lenses of social movements but also—and more so—as protest publics enables us to reveal latent characteristics of these protests.

According to Warner and Belyaeva, a public has the following features: it is self-organized and "comes into being by the virtue of being addressed"; functions as "relations among strangers," as publics "have to include strangers that come out to react to the same publicly broadcasted text or a message"; "both personal and impersonal" and "a public is constituted by mere attention"; represent "the social space created by the reflexive circulation of discourse"; "act historically, according to the temporality of their circulation"; and represent "a unique function of creating a poetic view of the alternative world they create through their discourse," claiming that being a public "is a poetic world-making" (Warner 2002; Belyaeva and Dzhibladze 2014).

Protests in Iceland, the United Kingdom, and the United States share many of these characteristics. The most explicit are their attempts to create alternative solutions for the current crisis of democratic institutions.

Despite popular opinion, Occupy Wall Street was not mostly spontaneous but rather planned by activists with past protest experience. There were several independent attempts to launch protest campaign on the basis of income inequality and anti-corporatism, but these attempts had not become as viral as the call made by anti-capitalist Canadian magazine "Adbusters." "Adbusters" reached a wide audience via Twitter with the proposal to "Occupy Wall Street." The message quickly became viral and spread over the social network audience (Milkman 2014).

Both during the "Occupy" protests and the "Pots and Pans Revolution," the majority of people found out information about the protests via social networks or word of mouth. Only 11% of the occupiers reported that they used radio or TV as the main source of information and even less used newspapers (Goodwin and Jasper 2014).

Initially, "Occupy Wall Street" protesters were predominantly white and male; most of them were in college or graduate school or had already had graduate or postgraduate degree. At the same time, many of them had substantial debt—usually student debt—or had recently undergone a job loss. The core organizers were "more privileged and more college-educated, and sometimes beyond college-educated." Also, there were much less Republican Party supporters than Democrats and a large proportion of Independents who supported neither Democrats nor Republicans. However, as protests grew and gained more popularity, they were able to attract supporters from a wide variety of backgrounds.

Most slogans of the protests were poetic and often relating to the alternative world. Among the most popular slogans of the Occupy protests were "We are the 99%"; "Wall Street is Nero, and the Rome is Burning!"; "Privatize profits, socialize losses!"; "I won't believe corporations are people until Texas executes one!"; "No bulls, no bears, only pigs"; "The beginning is near"; and "Banks got bailed out, we got sold out!." The high level of creativity and humor attracted more attention to the

protesters and their ideas. In Iceland, protests of 2008–2009 became widely known as the "Pots and Pans Revolution" and "Kitchenware Revolution," which referred to the protesters making noise with kitchen supplies during protests. The popular titles of the protests show high level of symbolism, similar to the Occupy's, and drew media and popular attention to them as well.

The slogans of the protests in Iceland were more concrete and focused on the quality of democracy in the country: "New, Proper Government"; "The USA is Getting Rid of Bush Today, We Get Rid of You"; "Yes, We Can!" (The Reykjavik Grapevine 2009); "A New Democracy"; "Disqualified Government"; "Iceland for Sale"; and "Everything's has gone to the dogs" (Reuters 2008).

Occupy Wall Street sympathizers saw themselves as part of a global movement, linked to the Arab Spring and movements in Europe like Spanish indignados, as well as to earlier protest movements in the United States (Goodwin and Jasper 2014; Kerton 2012). They came to share their frustration, knowing that protests in the Middle East and Europe faced the same problems. People who came were not showing authorities they wanted something in return but creating a space for discussions and sharing of ideas (Gitlin 2013). The income inequality was followed by issues of "money in politics" and "corporate greed," student debt, and access to education. Most OWS supporters were skeptical of the mainstream political system. Some were disappointed after Barack Obama was not able to bring the expected changes. Others had lost hope long before. But despite skepticism toward mainstream politics, most of them remained politically active (Goodwin and Jasper 2014; Jacobin 2014).

While Occupy Wall Street and Occupy London were branches of one global network, British protests quickly gained their own unique features. They were better organized, which let them publish their "Initial Statement" after a week of protests. They used newspapers to distribute information and inform public about their actions, and more importantly, they made official demands. Occupy Wall Street had never published or talked about demands, for which it was widely criticized. The protesters themselves saw the lack of demands as strength, as they wanted to start a broad discussion which would be limited to their demands had they made any. London protests also shifted their focus from unfairness of the government's policies and inequality to the role of territory, public spaces of London, and its municipal governing body (Halvorsen 2012).

Thus, the "troubling message" for the protests was shared frustration with the lack fairness, growing inequality, inadequate governments' policies, and the lack of answers. People declared what they think went wrong but could not suggest anything in return. This was the common point for the "Occupy Movement" all over the world, but in many cases, Occupy camps in different cities and countries quickly gained specific characters and a different modus operandi. Thus, "Occupy London Stock Exchange," or "Occupy LSX," set the tone of discussion inside the camps, and media coverage quickly shifted from general angriness about bank industry, capitalism, and austerity policy to struggle over control and assertion of the right to the city, questioning undemocratic nature of the Corporation of the City of London (Dowling et al. 2012).

Protests were not only mostly self-organized but also explicitly leaderless, democratic, and open. Within the Occupy Wall Street and Occupy London, General Assembly was the only decision-making body, and it was open to anyone who wanted to participate and aimed to establish consensus among all participants. Within the General Assembly, there were Working Groups that operated the same way but focused on specific issues or topics relevant to the participants. There were more than 70 Working Groups in the Occupy camp in New York only, which included Think Tank, Direct Action, Arts and Culture, Politics and Electoral Reform, Tech Ops, Vision and Goals, and many others (Gitlin 2013). Most of them were also live-streamed and had pages in social networks such as Twitter, Facebook, or Tumblr. The lack of demands shows the inner focus of the protests. On the "Occupy Boston" Facebook page, one protester wrote: "The process is the message" (Gitlin 2013). Rather than making demands, camps tried to create an alternative and discuss possibilities. Thus, they were involved in "a poetic world-making."

In Iceland, protests were managed by a newly created group called *Raddir fólksins* [Voices of people]. It had no connections with older organizations or any institutions of Iceland. In this process of social mobilization, the role of the Internet and social networks was absolutely critical (Castells 2012).

There was notable emphasis on informal educational activities in both the United Kingdom and the United States. In New York, there was "Tent City University" and in London "Bank of Ideas," where lectures on international banking, philosophy, theology, the Arab Spring, and even knitting and other topics were held (The Guardian 2012). In Iceland, many scholars and professors were invited to deliver a speech, but it was institutionalized the same way as in Occupy protests (Ávörp og ræður 2008). Popularity of education further highlights the focus on discussion and the "idea sharing nature" of the protests. Most camps in the United States and London refused to issue any demands to the state or politicians. Combined with the leaderless nature of protests, this made communication with the protests rather difficult for authorities, as it was not clear whom to address and what solution to offer.

Protests in all three countries were organized around public places. Zuccotti Park in New York, in London, and in Iceland—public square near the Parliament. Pots and Pans Revolution was not exactly an "occupation," but protests, demonstrations, and public talks were organized every Saturday at the same place. As protest publics in general focus on creating the social space by the reflexive circulation of discourse, the availability of a physical space makes the discourse circulation denser.

To recapitulate, mass political protests in the United States, the United Kingdom, and Iceland should be considered as a new social phenomenon and a new political actor. The distinctive features of the protests are the following: absence of organization as a basis for collective action, diversity in self-expression forms with street activity playing a dominant role, absence of a planned and clear campaign and/or political program, and sporadic and only few in total interactions with the authorities.

3 Factors of Political Changes

3.1 Economic Factors: Global Financial Crisis and the Lack of Confidence in the Future

The history of economic development of the 2000s can be divided into three parts: before, during, and after the financial crisis of 2008–2009. Before the crisis, from 2000 to 2007, economies were growing: the GDP levels were rising, unemployment was stable, and levels of household consumption and wages were rising. The level of household indebtedness was also growing. From 2008, after the financial crisis broke, economies entered into recession, and unemployment skyrocketed. The levels of consumption, however, stayed at the same level, while wages and indebtedness started to decrease. Curiously, the level of inequality, a central issue for protests, was not affected by the crisis. From 2011, when economies started to recover, GDP growth stabilized, and rates of unemployment started to slowly decrease. Also, in 2011, the "Occupy Wall Street" protests began, initially in the United States, later spreading to many countries including the United Kingdom and Iceland. However, the initial wave of protests in Iceland began in 2008, making it the first European country to face mass protests after the financial crisis. This leads us to the conclusion that economic factors, while important, did not cause mass protests alone. Rather, they played the role of trigger, the last drop for angry citizens.

In 2007, Iceland's average income was the fifth highest in the world. Icelanders earned 1.6 times more than the Americans (Castells 2012). Up until 2008, the GDP per capita grew in all three countries (World Bank n.d.). But from 2008, they had undergone recessions as the growth fell to negatives: −5.01% in the United Kingdom, −7.3% in Iceland, and −3.6% in the United States in 2009.

The rate of unemployment has skyrocketed after the crisis as well. By 2010, it increased threefold to 7.6% in Iceland and doubled to 9.6% in the United States.

The increase of income inequality was one of the main issues of the "Occupy Wall Street" protests, but the Gini index did not change significantly over the 2000s. The rise of income inequality is more evident in the long-term period (Saez and Zucman 2016). In the United States and the United Kingdom, it had been increasing since the second half of the twentieth century (Saez and Zucman 2016). From 1979, Gini index in the United States rose by 6.5% to 41.1% in 2009. Same trend applies for the United Kingdom as well.

Another long-term trend is the growth of consumption. Household consumption per capita was rising from the 1970s. Only from 2000 to 2007, household consumption grew by 22% in Iceland, 18.7% in the United Kingdom, and 15.1% in the United States. During the crisis, consumption notably decreased in Iceland by 20% and slightly in the United Kingdom (by 5%) and in the United States (by 2.7%).

The household debt had been also growing together with the level of consumption. From 2003 to 2007, the household debt measured as percentage of net disposable income grew by 19% in Iceland, by 25.4% in the United Kingdom, and by 19% in the United States. By 2007, the household debt to income constituted 175% in the

United Kingdom and 143% in the United States. From 2008 and onward, the level of indebtedness has been decreasing.

The indebtedness was one of the reasons people were so frustrated during the crisis. Used to growing economy and positive predictions about the future, they were not prepared to radical economic changes. Governments made loans procedure easier and more acceptable, to increase consumption and economic growth. Economic disruptions, rapidly growing unemployment, and stale rate of wages made people uncertain about the future.

3.2 Sociopolitical Factors: Crisis of Trust in the Current State of Democratic Institutions

Sociopolitical factors in the selected countries display high level of satisfaction with people's lives but very low level of trust in parliament and political parties. Legitimacy crisis of traditional democratic institutions led to popularization of nonconventional political actions—demonstrations and petition writing campaigns. However, crisis of trust of democratic institutions was not the crisis of trust of democracy per se, as the importance of democracy remained high and maybe even the key value of the protesters and citizens overall.

Level of trust in societies remained high throughout the 2000s. It decreased for the time of the financial crisis in Iceland and the United States but quickly returned to the pre-crisis levels. The level of satisfaction was, notably, significantly lower in the United States than in Iceland and the United Kingdom.[1]

Satisfaction with democratic institutions was in a severe decline, while the majority of people were happy with their lives. In 2004, confidence in the parliament was only at 28.3% in the United Kingdom and 37% in the United States. By 2014, only one out of five people was confident in the parliament in the United States. Icelanders generally were more hopeful about the parliament's work before the financial crisis, but then their confidence halved by 2014 (Norwegian Centre for Research Data 2016).

The level of trust in political parties was even lower. In 2004, only 15% of people trusted political parties in the United States and in the United Kingdom. In Iceland, it decreased by 19.2% in 8 years. Overall, less than one fifth of the populations of the three countries were confident in political parties (Norwegian Centre for Research Data 2016).

People did not trust political institutions but did trust police and courts. Confidence in the police was increasing in all three countries. Confidence in courts was

[1]Level of satisfaction stayed at 79% in the United Kingdom and at 90% in Iceland. In the United States, it was only at 58% in 2012 (Norwegian Centre for Research Data 2016).

also much higher—58% in the United Kingdom, 67% in Iceland, and 55% in the United States.[2]

Despite—or due to—dissatisfaction with the work of the government and political parties, interest in politics was high. In the United Kingdom, it grew from 47% in 2002 to 58% by 2014. In the United States, interest in politics was decreasing. Yet, even the lowest point as 58% in 2012 represented a high level of interest in society (Norwegian Centre for Research Data 2016).

The level of political participation increased significantly. Participation in lawful demonstrations over the last decade increased from 15.2% to 26.7% in Iceland and increased fivefold in the United States. In 2012, 54% more than the half of the population participated in demonstrations. In the United Kingdom, the number of demonstrators was also growing, but it hardly exceeded 5% by 2012. Popularity of petitions also grew by around 8% in the countries from 2004 to 2012 (Norwegian Centre for Research Data 2016).

The democracy was important for 80% of the UK and US citizens. At the same time, satisfaction with the level of democracy in their countries was almost twice lower[3] (World Value Survey 2016).

Deepening legitimacy crisis in institutions traditionally associated with politics—parliament and political parties—resonates with high level of confidence in more neutral, less political institutions of police and courts. People's distrust is a long-standing trend, which might indicate some systemic problems in embedded democracies of Iceland, the United States, and the United Kingdom.

4 Political Changes in Iceland, the United Kingdom, and the United States

Low trust in political institutions combined with high interest in politics led to the rise of nonconventional political actions. Among these actions are the "Pots and Pans Revolution" of 2008–2009 in Iceland, the "Occupy" protests in 2011 in the United Kingdom and the United States, and subsequent protests in the countries. In Iceland and the Unites States, it led to changes in rhetoric and popularity of traditional political parties. The growing number and popularity of populist and joke parties is also a common trend for the United Kingdom and Iceland. In the United States, the distrust to the establishment political forces led to the rise of populist rhetoric, which peaked during 2016 presidential elections.

Prior to 2009, Iceland had four "traditional" political parties, which participated in every election during the twentieth century. After 2009, however, we see the

[2]Confidence in courts was growing from 2000 to 2014 in Iceland and the United Kingdom but stayed at the same level in the United States (World Value Survey 2016).

[3]In the United Kingdom, from 36.8% in 2006 to 44% in 2014, in Iceland, from 58.4% to 59%, and in the United Kingdom from 62% in 2006 to 65% in 2014 (World Value Survey 2016).

rising amount of new parties, many of which were created or inspired by protesters. In 2009, there was only one post-protest party, the Citizens' Movement, which gained four seats in the parliament. In 2013, there were three: the Bright Future, the Pirate Party, and Dawn party based on the Citizens' Movement. The Bright Future and the Pirate Party were created in 2012, and the leader of the Icelandic Pirate Party, Birgitta Jónsdóttir, was an active protester in 2008–2009 and an ex-member of the Citizens' Movement. Both parties entered the parliament. The Bright Future gained six seats and the Pirate Party three. In 2016 parliamentary elections, the Pirate Party gained 10 seats and became the third largest party in the parliament. The Bright Future gained four seats, and one more new party called "Reform" gained seven seats.

On the municipal level, Best Party, the municipal sister party of Bright Future, won 2010 municipal elections gaining 34% of the votes and beating established parties with the "best manifesto," promising to "beat corruption by participating it openly" and cancel all debts. None of the party's members had any political experience, yet the leader of the party, Jon Gnarr, became the Mayor of Reykjavik, the capital of the country. While the Best Party was a joke party, it also was a caricature of Icelandic political system, which discredited itself during the financial crisis (Boyer 2013).

New parties were reformist by nature when compared to the traditional ones. Their agenda often had non-political arguments, while those political were often radical.[4] For example, the "Pirate Party" focused on direct democracy and reforms of copyright and patent law and free sharing of information. The "Bright Future" supported the EU membership for Iceland and included a few very eccentric politicians. The Best Party described their platform as "anarcho-surrealist" (Boyer 2013). Then there were the "Next Best Party" and "L-List"—also new parties, who gained more than 43% of the votes (Boyer 2013). These results show us that traditional political forces lose their popularity.

In the United Kingdom, there were only two major populist parties, the UK Independence Party (UKIP) and the British National Party. Both had long failed to present themselves as credible alternatives to the mainstream parties (Goodhart 2017). However, the UK Independence Party's popularity was slowly growing since 2004, but up until 2010, populist parties in the United Kingdom failed to make a great impact at national level. Its vote share in European elections grew from 7% in 1999 to 27.5% in 2014, becoming the second largest party, but in general elections the party never achieved more than 3% of the vote share. However, the 2010 general elections resulted in the first government coalition over 70 years. By the end of 2012, public support for UKIP in the opinion polls increased five times from around 2% to 10%. The number of mentions in mass media doubled from 2009 to 2012 and then from 2012 to 2013 as well. The average support for UKIP in 2014

[4]Interview with Jon Gunnar Bernburg, Professor of Sociology, Faculty of the Human and Social Sciences, University of Iceland, 2017.

was 29%. By appealing to emotions rather than facts, the party managed to attract older, working-class, white voters who lack qualifications and skills.

Then, in 2016 the Brexit referendum took place. National referendum was organized to let people decide whether they want to stay in the European Union. The first call for the referendum was made by David Cameron, a Conservative prime minister, in 2012. On June 24, 2016, the results of the referendum were available: citizens voted to leave the EU with 51.9% for leaving and 48.1% against. The society was extremely polarized on the issue. The campaign for "Leave" was appealing to the emotions of the people, while campaign for "Remain" focused on economics and rationality of staying in the EU. According to Inglehart, "even in countries without many elected populist representatives, these parties can still exert tremendous "blackmail" pressure on mainstream parties, public discourse, and the policy agenda, as is illustrated by the UKIP's role in catalyzing the British exit from the European Union, with massive consequences" (Inglehart and Norris 2016).

Thus, Brexit catalyzed support for UKIP in part because of the decision by the Conservative Party leader, David Cameron, to offer a referendum on Britain's European Union membership as a way to consolidate Euro-skeptics within his party. However, Cameron was under pressure from Euro-skeptics in part because of the growing popularity of the UKIP. Thus, the Brexit referendum campaign was the apogee of the populist revolt in the United Kingdom.

The most prominent change in the United States was the change of the rhetoric of political parties, as they fell under the partial influence of the "Occupy Wall Street" slogans and ideas. The debate over inequality initiated by Occupy led Elizabeth Warren, currently the party's most dynamic leader, to Senate in 2012 elections. Her campaign was largely based on the "We Are 99%" message (The Atlantic 2015). During the presidential campaign of 2012, Barack Obama emphasized unfairness and inequality among Americans and the need to redistribute wealth (The Atlantic 2011). Bill de Blasio, early supporter and participant of the Occupy protesters, participated in 2013 New York mayoral elections, building his campaign around inequality and policing. He suggested to "tax the 1%" and won (The Guardian 2013).

Many young people who had supported the Occupy Movement aligned around more radical democratic agenda of Bernie Sanders. According to Goldstone, protests did not cause changes but predicted and empowered the process of political polarization which had already been increasing since 1994[5] (Pew Research Center 2014).

However, the most radical change in political discourse in the United States happened during the 2016 presidential elections. Rise of two antiestablishment candidates—Donald Trump and Bernie Sanders—changed the usual presidential campaigns. Donald Trump's anti-immigrant rhetoric, deep-seated misogyny, conspiracy theories about his rivals, and isolationist "America First" policies abroad were reflective of general anti-elite and antiestablishment sentiments (Inglehart and

[5]Interview with Jack Goldstone, Virginia E., and John T. Hazel, Jr. Chair Professor of Public Policy at George Mason University, 2017.

Norris 2016). His populist rival, Democratic nominee Bernie Sanders, presented antiestablishment from a different angle, borrowing many issues of occupiers and placing heavy emphasis on inequality. Trump's populism was expressed through his remoteness from US politics. Bernie Sanders, who presented himself as "democratic socialist," was against the excesses of Wall Street greed while calling for a financial transaction tax and a breakup of the big banks and was officially endorsed by the "Occupy Wall Street" (The Guardian 2015; The Atlantic 2015). The issue of inequality became the main topic in the elections among other candidates as well. Hillary Clinton compared the salaries of America's richest hedge fund managers with kindergarten teachers. Jeb Bush, Ted Cruz, and Marco Rubio, Republican presidential candidates, also extensively discussed these issues (CNN 2016).

5 Policy Changes in Iceland, the United Kingdom, and the United States: Financial Crisis and Austerity Measures

System of embedded democratic institutions ensures relatively stable policy formulation and implementation process (Merkel 2004). This guarantees that the majority of aspects of the government's functioning should be relatively high. And while this is true, most of them have been in decline over the last 10 years. The most notable downfall experienced the effectiveness of the government.

The effectiveness of the government decreased by 25% in Iceland, by 13.5% in the United States, and by 16.8% in the United Kingdom.[6] The decline began in 2004, and the growth restored in the United Kingdom, Iceland, and the United States is still declining (World Bank n.d.). Partly, the decline was caused by the economic crisis and subsequent economic downfall. Economic issues, in turn, led to public outrage about invoking the need in highly criticized austerity policies. As a result, governments were split or had to form a coalition.

In Iceland, public pressure led to three national referenda over 3 years. In the United States, during 2010 midterm elections, the Republican Party gained 63 seats in the House of Representatives, restoring the majority. It was the largest seat change since 1948. In 2014 Congress elections, Republicans stretched control, getting majority in both houses. Combined with the rise of political polarization in the United States, where the share with a highly negative view of the opposing party had more than doubled since 1994, it led to a divided government and absence of cooperation between the president and the senate until the end of Obama presidential term (Pew Research 2014).

[6]Effectiveness of the government dropped from 2.12 in 2004 to 1.5 in 2012 in Iceland; from 1.8 to 1.46 in the United States; and from 1.9 to 1.48 in the United Kingdom.

Respectively, "Regulatory Quality," which defines the ability of the government to formulate and implement sound policies, was in decline as well.[7] The "Voice and Accountability"—the openness of elections and freedom of speech, expression, and association—did not change significantly.

6 Institutional Changes: Stable Decline

Legitimacy crisis of democratic institutions is reflected not only in people's attitudes but also in decreasing efficiency of the government and regulatory quality. The United States fell into the category "Flawed Democracy" in 2016 Index of Democracy of the Economist Intelligence Unit, after a period of negative dynamics over the last decade.

Level of freedom in societies remained very high. Elections were open and fair, and press is considered free, albeit slightly less free over time. Freedom of the Internet remained unchanged in Iceland and slightly decreased in the United Kingdom and in the United States. Both countries increased Internet regulation, and revelations of former FBI agent Edward Snowden about mass surveillance programs developed by the US government might have also played a role (Freedom House 2017).

According to *The Economist*, the level of political participation, which includes both conventional and nonconventional political activities, is high in Iceland and relatively low in the United Kingdom and the United States. In the United Kingdom, it grew from 61% to 72%, the same level as in the United States. People do trust conventional institutions.

Political culture is also more developed in Iceland, where it sequentially reached its maximum level. In the United Kingdom and the United States, political culture was at 81% in the 2010s and grew in the United Kingdom by 6%.

Functioning of the government and regulatory quality were sequentially decreasing.

Functioning of the government in all three countries decreased by 8% over the last 11 years in Iceland, by 9.4% in the United Kingdom, and by 11% in the United States. It coincides with the decrease of "Regulatory Quality" in the Worldwide Governance Indicators and indicates that there are political problems, which reduce effectiveness. However, all three countries had undergone a political gridlock over the last 10 years; in some countries the policy formulation and implementation process are still hindered due to frictions between branches of power (Freedom House 2016).

Overall, the United Kingdom shows the best dynamics of institutional changes according to the "Democracy Index": its political culture and political participation

[7] In Iceland, from 1.51 in 2007 to 0.9 in 2010; in the United Kingdom, from 1.86 in 2007 to 1.59 in 2009; in the United States, from 1.65 in 2006 to 1.40 in 2009 and 1.26 in 2013. It has been growing from 2010 in the United States (World Value Survey 2016).

are growing, unlike in Iceland or the United States. The United States is also the only country where the level of "civil liberties" is decreasing—by 8% over the last 7 years.

As a result, the overall rating of the "Democracy Index" places the United States under the category of "flawed democracy" for the first time in its history—its rating is 7.98. Ten years ago, the final score of the United States was 8.22, and the dynamics of 10 years is only 2.5%. Iceland's score is 9.5, the highest among the selected countries, and the dynamics is also negative as it went down from 9.71 in 2006. The United Kingdom scores 8.36, and it is the only country with overall positive institutional dynamics: in 2006, its score was 8.16. Overall, institutional changes in Iceland and the United States are negative, their scores declined by about 2% over the last 10 years, and in the United Kingdom—positive—its score improved by about 2% over the same time period. On the one hand, these changes are very minor and not significant; on the other hand, institutions change very slowly; and negative dynamics, even this small, might indicate a long-term trend.

7 Why Protest Publics as the "Challengers of the Status Quo" in Embedded Democracies?

In the selected countries, protests played the role of challengers of the current state of democratic institutions, the quality of the government, and politicians who were not able to meet the requirements of the protest publics. The result of this challenge varies in these countries, and, of course, we are not able to fully evaluate the consequences of the most recent events, but there is a common trajectory.

In Iceland, after protests in 2008 and 2009, and attempts to establish communication between protests, grassroots organizations, and various activists, traditional political forces returned to power. The attempt to slip into mainstream politics by creating new political parties and coalitions seems to have slowed down. Popularity of the reformist parties is decreasing according to the 2016 and 2017 parliamentary elections in Iceland. In 2016, the Pirate Party, the most successful among new parties, secured ten seats in the parliament and became the third largest party in the parliament. In 2017 elections, however, traditional parties secured the leadership, while the Pirate Party did not gain any seats. At the same time, another new party, Centre, being populist, center-right, and Euro-skeptic, secured seven seats. So, if by challenging old establishment and traditional political forces, which had lost trust of the people, protest publics inspired changes, the results are undefinable yet, as this is very much in progress.

In the United States, the Occupy protests influenced mainstream enough to make their ideas and issues mainstream in the American politics. The popularity of the antiestablishment candidates rose, but the result—the presidency of Donald Trump—is appealing to the somewhat different groups of the US population. Protesters' official candidate, Bernie Sanders, did not succeed in becoming president or even becoming the nominee of the Democratic Party. However, he drew attention to

the issues of inequality, paid education, and student loans at much larger scale, and after the presidential campaigns of 2016, they are now officially mainstream. Moreover, politicians inspired by the Occupy Movement, such as Sanders and Warren, have increased their influence within the Democratic Party.

Another important outcome of the protests of 2011, which partially affected anti-Trump protests as well, is that OWS created new political subjects: young people with no previous involvement in any protest activity.

The Occupy protests served as a motivation for a national worker-led movement, the fast-food workers' movement, and environmental movement and provided US activists with all sorts of new followers. Thus, while the result of the presidential elections of 2016 might seem to be a defeat and radical change on the course of US politics, actual results are yet uncertain.

The United Kingdom seems to be the most troublesome for the protest publics. They were overshadowed by traditional labor union demonstrations and anti-austerity movements. Occupy London presented one of the most unique and bright cases of Occupy protests worldwide, with their focus on alternative education at the "Test City University" with high-profile lectors and wide choice of topics and, which was more important, their ability to alert self-organization and to maintain a public dialogue with politicians or bureaucrats. The fact that they managed to achieve a direct answer from the Corporation of the City of London suggests that protest publics in the United Kingdom have prospects.

Funding The chapter was prepared within the framework of the Academic Fund Program at the National Research University Higher School of Economics (HSE) in 2016–2017 (grant № 17-05-0018) and by the Russian Academic Excellence Project "5-100."

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Protest Publics as the "Watchdogs" of the Quality of Democracy in the Polyarchies of the Global South



Sanjay Kumar Rajhans and Sambhavna Biswas

1 Introduction

> There may be times when we are powerless to prevent injustice, but there must never be a time when we fail to protest.—Elie Wiesel

In the large swathes of land in the non-western space that has been increasingly integrated into the neoliberal socioeconomic order of the world, the emerging powerhouses of the Global South, viz., Brazil, India, and South Africa, have undergone major socioeconomic transformation in the past quarter of the century. While the general indicators of economic progress have been positive, the political landscape in the three emerging powers that are spread out across the three continents in the southern hemisphere has changed over time, with the growing aspiration of the citizenry that it is no more content with some of the redistributive policies of the state. They have become increasingly emboldened with the desire to monitor the policies that are made on their behalf, often at times without taking into consideration their inputs or objections.

The cumulative paralysis of the government, especially in the sphere of ethical governance, is increasingly being interpreted by the public as the actions of an institution without accountability. The issue of ethical governance, a normative expression, added an extra layer of frustration in the minds of the public who expect "ethically good or acceptable behavior in terms of justice, fairness, equality, and integrity" from the government (Salminen 2010). When citizens in these three countries voiced their grievances against the government, they received a cold shoulder from the authorities, which they did not find acceptable. This loose motley crew of public belonging to disparate sections of the society with a curious mix of ideology started channeling, mediating, and articulating their various grievances by

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N. Belyaeva et al. (eds.), *Protest Publics*, Societies and Political Orders in Transition,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5_12

forging them into a meta-issue, be it an anti-corruption campaign or the abject failure of the state to govern and protect the vulnerable section of the society, thus bringing legitimacy of regimes in the dock.

This chapter makes an effort to observe and examine the ways in which the citizenry of the three countries (South Africa, Brazil, and India) has made an impact on the overall health of their representative democracies. It observes and enumerates the stages of changes in the content and quality of the demands of this increasingly empowered citizenry that wants to show that its right to vigilance is coupled with its fight against a system which is not able to perform its duties. By identifying and observing these "actors of changes," this chapter tries to observe the changing dynamics of the protest publics and its ability to represent very diverse social and ideational group. The manifold demands by these diverse groups are forged together in such a way that it echoes the aspiration of all inherent elements by projecting and rallying for the meta-issue. Navigating through the different sociocultural and socioeconomic realities spanned across the three continents, this chapter will try to show the array of changes that have been brought in the space of the governance which has in turn consolidated and revitalized the democratic space that aspires beyond the limits of the mainstream political cyclical circumference.

In order to address the issues mentioned above, we start by giving a detailed overview of the protests to understand the need and logic for choosing these three countries that vary not only geographically across the continents but are also anchored in different societal and normative moorings. The overarching developmental aspiration of the population of these countries and a set of institutional semblances provide us a tempting reason to study them as a group which has been explained in the different models in the previous chapters of the book. We follow this by observing the formation of these protests and examine them against the theory of publics and protest publics as detailed in the conceptual section of this monograph.

In the first section, the chapter examines the emergence, evolution, and convergence of the protest publics with a set of demands that posits itself as a fluid- and plasma-type counterpower and analyzes the process of its increasing actorness with its own ethical and normative power buildup. We also examine the social composition of the protest public—the key characteristics of these diverse communities in each of the protests and their diverse agendas converging around the meta-issue that keeps them compact and committed followed by the sharp edges in the protest landscape where the acts of polarization have occurred.

In the second part of this chapter, we investigate the set of factors that necessitated the emergence of protest publics as an actor for change. In the third section of the chapter, we examine these factors by understanding the role of protest publics as "actors of change" against the set of events. We show how these actors design the agenda for deliberation and debate both with the enlarged circularity of the citizenry. In the fourth section, we detail the changes (in policies, in politics, and, in some cases, institutional changes) at the social and political space that happened in these three countries (Brazil, India, and South Africa) as a consequence of protests and how these in turn consolidated and revitalized the democracy.

Finally, we conclude that these protest publics are diverse, articulate, and nimble with smart organizing capacity in a very non-unionized space. Their demands and concerns over the functioning of the democracy have revitalized the democratic symbiosis between the elected and the electorate of these countries.

2 Connecting the Thread: Curious Case of Amalgamating India, Brazil, and South Africa

2.1 Why Study the Three Countries?

India, Brazil, and South Africa have weaved their democratic structures in different ways. India was formed through an active independence movement to end the British Empire. In South Africa, democratic politics and constitutional rule managed a transition from a white minority to the black majority rule with minimal conflict, and Brazil managed to neutralize the military and put in place a broad party-based system (Heller 2013). All three countries in their formative years of development were guided by leaders who were sympathetic toward the problems of marginals and destitutes. The leaders who came to power—Jawaharlal Nehru in India (1947) and Nelson Mandela in South Africa (1994)—had visions which promised a new future and had explicit policies of affirmative action for social groups, who previously were marginalized. In Brazil, Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva (2002) is widely regarded as one of the most successful presidents (with an 87% approval rating when he left office) (CNN 2018). While there have been brief spells of democratic instability in India and Brazil, all three countries are now widely considered as stable democracies where the likelihood of democratic reversal or even destabilization seems farfetched (Heller 2013). In all the three countries, state repression is not mainstream and is vociferously denounced when it occurs. Associational life has been mostly free of state interference, the media is relatively diverse and quite active, the judiciary despite the coercive politics is relatively independent, usually social movements are tolerated, and there is a vibrant NGO engagement.

These three countries are highly unequal societies with pronounced social divisions, and in recent times there has been an increasing measure of power being wielded by the elite along with widening economic inequality. The citizens of the subordinate group, who are active in the electoral politics, find it hard to engage with the state where political interests generally prevail over civil society demands. Yet, through the process of democratic contestation and regular electoral cycles, in the past few decades, they have experienced a fast pace of economic development, varying degrees of democratic deepening, and inclusive development. In the recent years, these three democracies have seen several protests aimed at the government for perceived injustices and, in particular, "creeping usurpation of the state by the elites." These countries have witnessed what Tarrow and Tilly (2009) termed as contentious politics—episodic, public, collective interaction among makers of

claims and their objects. In such politics it is usually the government which is a claimant or an object of claims, and the claims would, if realized, affect the interests of at least one of the claimants (Tarrow and Tilly 2009). These protesters belonging to different social and economic backgrounds are against the consolidation of political and economic power in the hands of elites and are angry at the subordination of democracy to wealth. The urban middle class which formed the base of much of the protests (that we will discuss later) was largely absent from the political sphere for a long time. However, in recent times, this burgeoning middle class has stepped up to demand for basic political rights, accountable governments, and a fairer share of resources. These groups of middle class and corporate elites who reaped the benefits of such development started to feel increasingly politically disenfranchised (Rajhans 2017). The main demands of the protesters in the three countries are related to better accountability and governance, higher standards of state capacity such as law and order, transparency, and rule of law. There are several common themes that run across the protest publics of the three countries—corruption, law and order problem, poor regulatory policies, poor service delivery, etc.

Corruption is a big issue which all three countries have been grappling with. According to 2017 data from Transparency International, out of the 180 nations, India stands at 81, while Brazil and South Africa stand at 96 and 71, respectively. The corruption allegations leveled on the ruling party/leadership have led to political changes in all three countries. For example, we see a shift in the political regime in India, the center left coalition (the UPA) was voted out, and the right-wing party (the BJP) hitchhiking on the tsunami of discontent against the ruling party came to power. Besides, in the case of India, amidst the churning of the protest publics, an unconventional political party was born—the Aam Aadmi Party (Common Man's Party). We see similar trends in South Africa and Brazil where a shift in the leadership was witnessed—Zuma was ousted in 2018, and Cyril Ramaphosa was put in charge by the ruling ANC party. In the case of Brazil, the unfolding of incidences was not that linear yet the leadership in the country Dilma Rousseff was impeached and Michel Temer was put in charge not to mention the corruption allegations against Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva. The chorus calls against corruption have attracted the common masses irrespective of their socioeconomic position, because this issue has affected people at all levels of society in the three countries.

These protests have some similarities with the Arab spring. For example, there was a persistent effort to bring down corrupt officials and elites; many of the protests saw the involvement of the middle class unlike earlier, and most individuals were mobilized through the use of social media networks like Facebook, Twitter, and WhatsApp. In these three countries, there were a few aggressive responses from the citizens sometimes simply jostling with the police personnel as the last resort to make their voices heard. Government's reaction to the protests in the three countries has also been quite similar. In many cases, stern actions were taken against the

protesters. The police have lashed out with tear gas, lathicharge (in India),[1] used stun grenades, and rubber bullets (Brazil and South Africa) (Reuters 2016) at the protesters on several occasions to stop the protesters from protesting. In South Africa, police picked their fight according to who protested—police molested protesters who were black, and repression against anti-Zuma protesters was much more that those protesting in favor of Zuma.[2] The anti-corruption protest movement in Delhi in 2011, despite being largely non-violent, saw 53 protesters including 23 policemen getting injured in the early morning raid because of the crackdown (The Telegraph 2011). In Brazil, police repression took three forms depending on who was targeted. "The police forces were very violent against Black Bloc autonomous group, less violent against traditional left and very kind to the right conservative groups in Brazil" (Interview with Esther Solano).[3] It has also been studied by scholars such as Alonso and Mische that the protests in Brazil went from being small to big after the public realized the excessive use of force employed by the police. It provoked "indignation and anger among a broader swath of the population and generates a 'scale shift' [in] the movement" (Alonso and Mische 2017).

The protests of all three countries, as we will explain, have sporadic characteristics. Different groups with different approaches come together to confront authority. Self-organized publics as collective social actors with unique features and capacities (Belyaeva and Dzhibladze 2014) are one of the distinguishing features of the protests in all three countries. These protests cannot be clubbed together as part of the social movement because they did not involve "prior organizational work or including creation of stable organizational structures, or 'special purpose coalitions'" (Tarrow and Tilly 2009). These protests in India, Brazil, and South Africa, as would be in subsequent sections, often lacked prior organization either by civil society organizations or movement organizers and had an "active public" or an *agent public* that was capable of performing as a social actor (Tarrow and Tilly 2009). These protests in the three countries that will be discussed below have some common features of a political actor—autonomy from the state and composition of diverse groups of people who are non-unionized—around a common identity over a meta-issue.

While traditional protests mostly by the poor in the respective countries were ongoing (related to right of labor and right to land, forests), the recent protests were new and unconventional having sporadic characteristic coalescing a large group of diverse people across geographical space around issue-based politics. Rhizomes represent non-hierarchical structures where any point can connect to any other point (there are multiple entry and exit points), generating links that can stretch,

[1]"Lathi" in Hindi means sticks. It is a tactic used by police in India to disperse the crowd with the use of sticks.

[2]Interview with Fabio Andres Diaz, Research Associate at the Department of Political and International Studies at Rhodes University in South Africa, Researcher at the International Institute of Social Studies in the Netherlands.

[3]Interview with Esther Solano. Professor of International Relations at the Federal University of São Paulo (UNIFESP), Brazil.

unevenly and asymmetrically, across spaces and times, scales, issues, or strategies (Funke 2012).

3 Increasing Inequality and an Unfortunate Set of Commonalities: Overview of the Protests in South Africa, Brazil, and India

3.1 Increasing Inequality and Democratic Unrest: The Case of South Africa

Resistance and struggle have been a constant feature of the South African political landscape since independence. Many of the protests in South Africa are sporadic and localized and do not have a consistent campaign; they can be clubbed together as service delivery protests (Heller 2013; Alexander 2010). These protests consisted of the urban poor, the students, and the middle class protesting against poor service delivery in the informal settlements, universities, and townships of urban South Africa. Their grievances were around the poor delivery of services such as housing, water, electricity, land, unemployment, education, and other public infrastructures, as well as livable minimum wages and good working conditions for workers (Heller 2013). These service delivery protests which started in 2005 have been increasing every year and saw a new record of 191 protests in the year 2014 which was a significant rise from 82 protests in 2011 (Municipal IQ 2018). In 2017, this number was 173. These protests focused on issues related to lack of governance, ineffectiveness and lack of responsiveness of the municipalities (Atkinson 2007), and lack of accountability (Powel 2009). According to Afrobarometer survey of 2014/2015, when citizens were asked if they trust their local governments, 31% stated that they do not trust their local government, and 33% stated that their local government councilors never listen to them. Sixty percent of the people surveyed either strongly disapproved (25%) or disapproved (35%) the performance of their local government councilor. This points toward a general notion among the public that officials are incompetent or they do not care about the concerns of the community. In October 2011, an Occupy South Africa movement inspired by the Occupy Wall Street movement was staged by citizens from all walks of life and economic backgrounds in five cities—East London, Grahamstown, Durban, Cape Town, and Johannesburg (Tolsi 2011). These protests were on issues related to unemployment, inequality, and tuition fees where between 100 and 300 people took part in the protests across these five cities (Redmond 2011). These protest publics created a poetic view on the alternative world through discourse to make their action successful, attractive, creative, and appealing. “Corporate power structures are killing us” and “to hell with the ANC (African National Congress) and DA (Democratic Alliance), greed, greed, greed” (Redmond 2011) were some of the poetic messages having a contagious capacity that connected and conveyed the core of their angst.

It was only in 2017 that these protests took a national character. The new wave of protests from diverse groups marched through Cape Town, Durban, and, the capital, Pretoria calling for President Jacob Zuma to resign. Colorful, fiery, and provocative slogans such as "We want Zuma to fall," "Guptas get out of our country," "This is the last straw," and "South Africa is not for sale" (Aljazeera 2017; News24 2017) were heard on the streets. Jacob Zuma's ascension to power was largely built on a platform of Zulu nationalism and charisma where he was an active member and was widely regarded as having the best interests of the people at heart (SAHO 2017). However, over time, various scandals such as the one in 2010 where Zuma failed to declare his assets and in 2011 when he was alleged to have used state funds to build his own residence coupled with people's anger over the lack of significant improvement in their living standards created the general feeling of resentment against the government. Zuma allowing the Gupta family to wield undue influence over government appointments, contracts, and state-owned businesses and his dismissal of the finance minister Pravin Gordhan stoked public anger over corruption scandals, acute unemployment, and slowing economic growth. The subsequent junk status downgrade given by rating agency Standard and Poor's also added fuel to the fire (Mahr 2016). Tens of thousands of people marched in Pretoria along with the opposition parties making it one of the largest marches in post-apartheid history (Runciman et al. 2017). A survey conducted by the research team of the University of Johannesburg showed that the protesters were predominantly middle class. All these publics have in some way or the other organized themselves as a body independent of state institutions. The surveyed respondents stated that they were not part of any political group and with more than half of them (57%) stating that they arrived with their family to protest. All of them were self-created and organized through a discourse (Warner 2002) which raised the meta-issue of corruption (through an anti-Zuma sentiment) along with an overall protest against lack of governance. When apartheid was abolished in South Africa in 1994, the country introduced a new ideology in the name of nation building—rainbowism that was meant to fight racism and discrimination. Protests in 2017 invoked the failed promise of the "rainbow nation," which had vowed to deliver a post-racial and equal society (Diaz 2017).

Zuma resigned in 2018 under considerable pressure from the ANC. He was succeeded by Ramaphosa (a former trade union leader, a successful businessman, and Zuma's deputy in government) who has promised to change the culture of impunity and arrest the self-enrichment project of "state capture" (Callard 2018).

3.2 *Mass Protests from 2013 to 2017: Polarization of the Brazilian Protesters*

Protests in Brazil—which started in 2013—signified discontent among a large middle class population who were on average richer and better educated than average Brazilians (these protest publics were three times more likely to have a university degree according to the polling firm Datafolha) (Winter 2013). These protests which took place throughout the country were on issues such as increase in bus fares, excessive spending during the World Cup, the impeachment process of President Dilma Rousseff, lack of reforms in education, violence against women, lack of land rights, negative impacts of the 2016 Olympic Games, and government profligacy. The initial protests in June 2013 were triggered by rise in bus fares, but these soon morphed into something much bigger, with protesters soon demanding action against corruption, police brutality, poor public services, and excessive spending on the FIFA World Cup. The June protests unfolded in diverse ways and quickly started including different actors, issues, and processes. Organized, initially, by the Free Fare Movement or the MPL, the diversity of the groups expanded to include "relatively new micro-movements such as MAL (Autonomous Libertarian movement), MAU (Unified Autonomous Movement), and Acampa/Ocupa (Camp/Occupy), along with the new independent media (e.g., Ninja Media, Black Media, Várzea Radio, Brasil de Fato), and some established social movements, such as the Black, LGBT, and housing movements" (Alonso and Mische 2017). Public discontent mustered support when it was found that immense amount of money had flown toward a tournament catering to international audience. These generated a demand for "FIFA standards" of improvements in issues of domestic concern such as in schools, employment, transportation, health care, and so on and so forth.

An estimated 110,000 marched in São Paulo, 80,000 in Manaus, 50,000 in Recife, and 20,000 in Belo Horizonte and Salvador, between 21st and 23rd of June 2013, shouting slogans like "Stop corruption. Change Brazil," "Halt evictions," and "Come to the street. It's the only place we don't pay taxes" (Watts 2013). Ever since its inception, Brazilians protested with incredible fervor, with protests happening over similar issues across the country.[4] The protests in 2013 borrowed three broad repertoires of contention. The first was the traditional socialist left repertoire; the second was the autonomist repertoire group; and the third was the nationalist patriotic repertoire.[5] The traditional socialist left repertoire consisted of highly committed activist communities having a centralized and hierarchical organization.

[4]Labor unions started a nationwide strike in June 2017 against Temer government's legislative changes to Brazil's labor and pension law and protest by state workers against pension reforms in May 2017 and against the killing of Rio Councilwoman, Marielle Franco, and, her driver, Anderson Gomes's murder to name a few.

[5]Interview with Esther Solano. Professor of International Relations at the Federal University of São Paulo (UNIFESP), Brazil.

They used different symbols such as red flags and banners, party badges, and T-shirts with party or movement symbols to gain attention (Alonso and Mische 2017). The autonomist repertoire rejected centralized leadership and authority, particularly those of the state, while the last, nationalist patriotic repertoire, which was "more to the right"[6] unified "under a master frame of 're-democratisation' and used symbols of the anthem, the flag, national colors to prove their point" (Alonso and Mische 2017). All these three repertoires coexisted together in the June 2013 protests. These protests, triggered by rise in fare of public transit, quickly morphed into something bigger encompassing a multiplicity of diverse demands such as redistributive policies in education, health care, and public transportation along with a fight against corruption. These protests were larger than the protests of 1992 (the impeachment and resignation of President Fernando Collor de Mello) and arguably larger than those surrounding the 1985 transition to democracy (Moseley and Layton 2013; Saad-Filho 2013).

In March 2015 a major protest took place, triggered by a multibillion-dollar corruption scandal at the state-run energy company Petroleo Brasileiro SA or Petrobras. This corruption scandal shook the country, and protesters seething with anger called for the impeachment of President Dilma Rousseff. These protests subsequently became greatly polarized with the right conservative patriotic movement demanding impeachment of the president (*anti-pete*, *anti-workers party*, *anti-lula*, *anti-dilma*) and the socialist left defending the president (impeachment is illegal, fight for democracy, etc.).[7] Corruption scandals have affected every presidential administration since 1985. Even President Luiz Inácio "Lula" da Silva's term which was hailed as a period of prosperity for Brazilians was replete with several corruption scandals such as Caixa Dois, Bingos, and the Mensalão scheme (Lagunes and Ackerman 2017). So when it was revealed through Operation Car Wash that the state oil company Petrobras had accepted bribes from construction firms in return for contracts at inflated prices (BBC 2018), the public got infuriated. On March 15, 2015, there were nationwide protests, mostly organized through social media where around 300,000 to 2 million protesters participated and used slogans such as "Out with the PT!" (Pitts 2015). There was another nationwide protest in April and subsequently in August in different cities of Brazil. Following allegation of Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva's involvement in a money laundering case, the public also demanded the impeachment of Dilma Rousseff. In March 2016, there were protests in all 26 states of Brazil where the polling company Datafolha estimated around 450,000 protesters and Globo estimated 3.5 million protesters chanting anti-Dilma slogans. There were inflatable dolls of former President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva in a cage doing the rounds (Watts 2016).

[6]Interview with Esther Solano. Professor of International Relations at the Federal University of São Paulo (UNIFESP), Brazil.

[7]Interview with Esther Solano. Professor of International Relations at the Federal University of São Paulo (UNIFESP), Brazil.

Subsequent protests were large and raucous, taking different shapes over time and consisted of different groups. Youth who took a lead in 2013 slowly started taking a backseat in the protests that took place in the later stages.[8] Following the corruption charges against President Michel Temer in May 2017, fresh protests have sprung up demanding his resignation. His efforts to pass a series of economic reforms which involve capping the budget, loosening labor laws, and reducing pension benefits have made people angry. There was a huge clash between the police forces and the protesters when protesters demanding the resignation of President Michel Temer set fire to a ministry building in Brasilia prompting the police to unleash volleys of tear gas, stun grenades, and rubber bullets to halt tens of thousands of protesters (Soto and Boadle 2017). The political environment is heated in Brazil with Lula being sentenced to 12 years of imprisonment and fresh corruption charges against Temer surfacing, for receiving money from the boss of meat packing firm JBS (BBC 2018).

3.3 Mobilization of the New Middle Class in India: Anti-corruption and Nirbhaya Protests

India usually sees small localized protests every year.[9] However, in the recent times, a few of these protests have taken a pan-India form. They were constituted by a special kind of a "public" who occupied a space "out of nowhere" and refused to leave in response to a particular "troubling message" (Belyaeva and Dzhibladze 2014).

In 2011, the anti-corruption protests started, in which large number of protesters from various parts of the country demanded a strong anti-corruption (Jan Lokpal[10]) bill to be passed after the country had been shaken by three major scams[11] under the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) government (Yadav and Chopra 2015). The idea of a strong Lokpal which could investigate the big and the powerful that are let off the hook every time was an appealing idea for protesters. Mass demonstrations in the April 2011 protests can be seen as a "certain public" who were from all walks of life united in thousands by a common discourse to demand a stronger anti-corruption bill coalescing around hunger-fasting renowned Gandhian activist Anna Hazare. While

[8]Interview with Esther Solano. Professor of International Relations at the Federal University of São Paulo (UNIFESP), Brazil.

[9]Protests against Vedanta bauxite mine in Niyamgiri, Orissa, in 2012 and in 2018 in Tuticorin, Tamil Nadu, against Sterling's copper operations; localized protests by upper caste "Jats" in Haryana in 2016 and "Patidars" in Gujarat asking for reservation in 2015; protests by farmers in Maharashtra in 2018 and by Tamil Nadu farmers in Delhi in 2017 to name a few, Dalit movements (Rohit Vemula case).

[10]Jan Lokpal or Public Ombudsman is an anti-corruption bill drawn up by civil society activists in India to appoint a Jan Lokpal, an independent body to investigate corruption cases.

[11]Commonwealth game scam, the corporative housing scam, and finally the 2G spectrum scam.

Anna Hazare was the face of the movement, it was strengthened and bolstered by a nimble mix of publics, some supported by religious and spiritual leaders who rose and fell behind his leadership. It was led more like a congregation rather than a cadre with organizational and logistical needs (Rajhans 2017). The movement started gaining heat in January 2011 when people took out march against corruption in over 60 cities of India to demand an effective anti-graft Lokpal bill. The first peak was in April 2011 when more than 5000 gathered at the Jantar Mantar to support Anna Hazare in his 3-day fast (IBNLive 2011). The second peak was in August 2011 when tens of thousands turned up to support Anna Hazare for his indefinite hunger strike (BBC 2011). Slogans like "I Am Anna Hazare" which was similar to the "We Are All Khaled Said" campaign from the Egyptian uprising became a common symbol. This movement was hailed everywhere to be "India's Arab Spring" as it was spontaneous and urban, organized through social networks on cyberspace and was supported by tens of thousands of largely young middle-class workers and professionals throughout India's major cities who increasingly felt marginalized from public power and were affected by corruption in one form or the other (Juergensmeyer 2011). While the middle-class character of the protests was retained, it also struck a chord with migrant workers, auto-rickshaw drivers, and college students who joined the protests in solidarity with Anna and the issue of corruption. Political parties such as the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) also rode on these protests movements with its leaders such as Govindacharya and Subramanian Swamy who were said to have connections with the movement. Most of these movements were funded by volunteers with barely any foreign involvement, organizational or, otherwise, unlike what was alleged (Sinha, a detailed interview).

The anti-corruption protests also gave birth to a new unconventional political party, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) which translates to "Common Man's Party." The party was formed by Arvind Kejriwal, one of the activists of the protest movement, who, unlike many others involved with the movement, felt the need to be directly involved in politics to change the corrupt system.

Another pan-India protest took place in the subsequent year after a woman was brutally raped in a bus in New Delhi, the national capital, in December 2012. She later succumbed to her injuries. "We want justice!" and "We want rape free India" were some of the typical slogans used by the protesters who demanded justice for the victim and stronger laws and harsher punishments to ensure the safety and security of women, better patrolling, and fast-track courts. The peak of the movement was on December 21, 2012, in the heart of Delhi, the India Gate, with tens of thousands of people who were mainly galvanized through Twitter and Facebook (Bakshi 2017). They comprised of a networked community which saw people from all walks of life—not just the middle-class communities, but also the poor lower classes and slum dwellers, who were all fighting a battle in the war against sexual violence (Agarwal 2013). For years, public conversations of sexual violence were evaded in the fear that it would tarnish their reputation. This protest was a result of a long history of women's movements throughout India like the Pink Chaddi Campaign (or Pink Underwear Campaign) in 2009, movement against moral policing, campaigns for

freedom in college hostels, rural women's movement like the Gulabi gang movement, and so on.[12]

Recent protests in July 2017 have been against the rising mob violence and cow vigilantism. Protesters from across 16 cities in India carried placards such as "Not In My Name," "No place for Islamophobia," and "Shed hate not blood." Hundreds of people gathered at the Jantar Mantar in Delhi after a 15-year-old was killed by a mob on a train while he was returning home to his village (AP 2017). Protests in India in 2018 also garnered significant attention when two rape cases (one in Kathua district of state Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) and the other in Unnao district of Uttar Pradesh (UP) state) which saw the involvement of public officials made the public outraged. In J&K an 8-year-old girl belonging to a nomadic tribe was gang raped and killed, and in UP a 17-year-old girl was raped, allegedly by a politician of a political party, and her father was beaten by the politician's brother before he died in police custody (Express Web Desk 2018). Protests erupted over police inaction, the silence or delayed response from the political leaders and the inability of the political parties to find a cohesive response to the number of crimes against women in India. These protests were organized over the Internet, and thousands joined in marches, carrying placards (Gupta and Sanyal 2018) which ranged from being emotional such as "Cow → safe, deer → safe, why am I not safe" and "Am I next?" to bashing the government such as "Modi hatao, beti bachao (remove Modi, save the girls)" and "Forever been pawned in your games, no more!" (The Quint 2018). Many also formed human chains in cities such as Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, and Goa.

Nirbhaya and subsequent protests were completely leaderless with a decentralized structure organized primarily through social media. While India did not have an occupy movement per se, the spirit of occupy movement was invoked several times. The word "occupy" means to enter and stay in a space without authority and often forcibly. In India, historical spaces like the India Gate, Jantar Mantar, Parliament Street, and Ramlila Maidan were occupied by demonstrators for an extended period of time. There were also several common features between the protests in India and the occupy movement—for example, attacking the ruling class through social media and huge middle-class support for the causes, which had been mostly dormant in the previous years. The recent protests were horizontal in structure, spontaneous, and unstructured, and the young (overwhelmingly middle class) who were dismissed as apolitical took on the baton to unsettle the establishment by harnessing the powers of the social media. Though this newly charged middle class initiated this fight against corruption, it was the urban poor and the marginalized that made the movement a classless affair and provided the critical mass base and combativeness without which it might have been difficult to create the tidal wave of assemblage in a sustained manner (Rajhans 2017).

[12]Interview with Subir Sinha, Chair of the Centre for South Asian Studies at the School of Oriental and African Studies, University of London.

4 The Consolidated Factors of Change in South Africa, Brazil, and India

While economic factors were important reasons for the protests in the three countries, this alone fails to explain the protests and the political changes that they brought along. Brazil witnessed huge positive economic changes during 2003–2014 when inequality dropped significantly (the Gini coefficient fell by 6.6 percentage points in the same period, from 58.1 down to 51.5) and the income level of the poorest 40% of the population rose 7.1% on average in real terms (World Bank 2016). This was also the period when the middle class heaped the benefits of economic development which formed the backbone of the protests (Zaytsev 2017). The year 2012 was however a turning point for Brazil as it started witnessing economic slowdown. Brazil faced recession in 2014 which was the maximum drop in Brazil's GDP growth since 1990—there was a sharp fall in growth rate from 7.5% in 2010 to negative 3.8% in 2015. In 2014, during President Dilma Rousseff's second term, Brazil's current accounts registered a record deficit of $90.95 billion, well above the 2013 deficit of $81.1 billion (Stiftung 2016b), and inflation rate shot up to 9% in 2015 which has been the highest recorded rate in the last several years.[13] South Africa's inflation rate hovered around 4–5% since 2010 but shot up to 6.3% in 2016. Inflation rates in India were very high during the periods of protests and in 2012 it was around 10%. However, this was managed well in the subsequent years (average inflation of India in 2016: 5%).

South Africa, akin to Brazil, saw a sluggish growth rate. The GDP growth rate saw a steady decline from 2.4% in 2013 to 0.27% in 2016. Since 2011, the GDP per capita growth rate of Brazil and South Africa has decreased by approximately 34%. In India, while there has been a slight increase, the overall per capita income is much lower than that of Brazil and South Africa.[14]

High levels of unemployment (between 24% and 26%), particularly among the youth among whom more than 70% are unemployed, remain a serious cause of concern in South Africa (Stiftung 2016a). In Brazil, the unemployment level was 7.1% in 2013 which reduced to 6.8% in 2014. However, in 2016 the unemployment level shot up again to 11.5% which has been the highest since 2007. In India, the unemployment levels have remained fairly constant hovering around 3.5%, but the main problem according to center's top think tank NITI Aayog is "underemployment" (FE Online 2017).

The unemployment data indicates serious inefficiencies in resource allocation and lack of opportunities for the youth who constitute the backbone of a growing

[13]It was 5.4% in 2012, shot up to 8.7% in 2016, but was managed later and was brought down to 3.4% in 2017.

[14]The GDP per capita in India, Brazil, and South Africa in 2011 was $1461, $13167, and $8049, while in 2016 was $1,709, $8649, and $5273, respectively.

economy in Brazil and South Africa.[15] According to the 2014/2015 Afrobarometer data, 51% of those surveyed stated that they do not think that current government is handling job creation properly. When Zuma came to power, employment generation was one of the key policy proposals. However, under his watch, the economy shrank, unemployment spiraled, and violent crime surged.

In India, increasing violence against women year after year was also a very crucial factor. The National Crime Records Bureau in India found that crimes against women are on the increase—there was a 7.1% hike in recorded crimes against women between 2010 and 2011 (with a total of 228,650 incidents). The biggest jumps were in the cases of the "dowry prohibition act" (up by 27.7%), kidnapping and abduction (up by 19.4% year on year), and rape (up by 9.2%) (Pidd 2012). In a survey conducted by Centre for Equity and Inclusion in 2009 in Delhi, 95% stated that "their mobility was restricted because of fear of male harassment in public places" (Harassment S. S.).

Brazil's and South Africa's inequality levels remain among the highest in the world with millions of people living in abject poverty. With a Gini index[16] of 52.8 in 2013 and 63.38 in 2011, Brazil and South Africa, respectively, rank among the world's most unequal societies. The percentage of income held by the top 20% of the population is the highest in South Africa, followed by Brazil and then India[17] (Alison 2015). India's Gini index rose from 33.4 in 2005 to 35.2 in 2009, reflecting an increase in inequality, as measured by consumption. The problematic trend, as elucidated in the Global Wealth Databook 2014, is that the wealth share of the top decile of India's population rose from 65.9% in 2000 to 74% in 2014; the wealth share of the top percentile rose from 36.8% to 49% in the same period. The growth in income of the rich is disproportionately high in India which has the largest absolute number of poor people worldwide (Stierli et al. 2014).

In all three countries, we also see the emergence of less redistributive social, economic, and political policies. In Brazil under Temer's government, the senate has passed a controversial spending cap by limiting public spending to inflation for the next 20 years until 2037. This implies all future governments will have to limit expenditures in health, education, social welfare, and public services for the next two decades. In India too, there have been several instances of corporate collusion with the executive, legislature, and judiciary to bypass constitutional processes (e.g., the Nira Radia tape). Since 2005–2006, taxes and duties for the corporate world and the rich have been written off at the rate of Rs. 7 million a minute on average, and the duties waived on gold and diamonds in the last 36 months (2010–2013) equal the 2G scam amount (Sainath 2013). In the first year of the Modi regime (2014), it was Rs. 62,399 crore—about 8% higher. In South Africa too, Zuma, despite being one of

[15]Unemployment, total (% of total labor force) (modeled ILO estimate) from World Bank Data (https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/SL.UEM.TOTL.ZS?locations=BR-ZA-IN).

[16]Gini index of 0 represents perfect equality, while an index of 100 implies perfect inequality.

[17]69% of South Africa's wealth is concentrated in the hands of just 20% of the population compared to 58% in Brazil and 44% in India.

the ten highest-paid national leaders in the world, spent $17 million in public funds on his private house. South Africa's 2015 budget, despite increasing the government grant for the poor, failed to keep up with inflation and in fact increased the country's offshore allowance from R4 million (US$282,500) to R10 million (US$706,500).

The powerful and the rich had tightened their grip on the political and economic levers in the three countries, and the poor were increasingly falling behind. "Tarrow emphasizes various processes that impact the life of a protest cycle, including, framing, diffusion, externalisation as well as how capitalism generates its own countermovement" (Tarrow 2005). Such non-redistributive policies as prevalent in all the three countries are also one of the reasons behind the distress faced by their citizens. The economic problems coupled with widespread corruption allegations reinforced the sense of alienation faced by the population. People in all three countries were unhappy with the speed of the policy changes that were promised and angry at the elite usurpation of power and wealth.

One of the key trends since 2006 has been a decrease in public trust in the government in both Brazil and South Africa.[18] In Brazil, according to Datafolha polling institute, in 2018, seven out of ten (68%) said they did not have confidence in the political parties; 67% said they had no confidence in the National Congress (the highest in the historical series). Public actions, like signing of petitions, have dropped in Brazil and India, while in South Africa, a slight increase was observed.[19] Attending peaceful demonstrations has increased in India but decreased in South Africa and Brazil.[20] Active membership in political parties declined in Brazil and India (Brazil, 5–2.5%; India, 18–8%), while in South Africa it increased from 7% to 12.5%.[21]

[18]In 2006, close to 10% of the Brazilians trusted their government and this number reduced to 5.1% in 2014. Similarly, in 2006, close to 30% of South Africans trusted their government and this number reduced to 14.5% in 2013. In India, 15% of the people trusted their government and this number increased to 19% in 2012.

[19]In 2006, close to 55% of the Brazilians signed petitions and this number reduced to 44% in 2014. Similarly, in 2006, close to 11% (10.8%) of South Africans signed petitions and this number remained more or less the same (11.3%). In India, 22.6% of the people signed petitions and this number decreased to 13.7% in 2012.

[20]In 2006, 18% of the Brazilians has attended peaceful demonstrations and this number reduced to 16% in 2014. Similarly, in 2006, 12% of South Africans attended peaceful demonstrations and this number reduced to 9% in 2013. In India, 15% of the people trusted their government and this number increased to 18.4% in 2012.

[21]Survey date for Brazil is 2006 and 2014, for India is 2006 and 2012, and for South Africa is 2006 and 2013.

5 Protest Publics in South Africa, Brazil, and India: An Actor for Socio-political Change

> History shows that all protest movements rely on approaches which are common across countries—boycotts, strikes, sit-ins, flags, songs. symbolic actions on whatever scale—from the Montgomery bus boycott to wearing a simple wristband—are designed to disrupt our everyday complacency and force people to think.—Huge Evans

The protest publics in the three countries have played a crucial role in bringing ethical governance at the forefront. They have been important actors of change and played a major part in putting pressure on the government to address their demands. There has been a common understanding among people that they are being wronged and that a few people are siphoning off taxpayers' money when there are a plethora of social problems that need ardent attention.

Some of the key features of the protests in the three countries were that they were self-organized and self-creating through a common discourse (Warner 2002) around the "meta-issue" of *lack of governance* and its many manifestations. All the actions in the protests were free and voluntary, and the actors were part of the movement when they engaged with it and ceased to exist when attention was no longer predicated (Warner 2002). In South Africa, it was around service delivery issues and the ousting of Zuma; in India, it was around corruption and women's safety; and in Brazil, despite starting out to protest the rise in transport fares, it escalated to address corruption which subsequently led to the impeachment of Dilma Rousseff. All these protesters were anti-elite, anti-inequality, and anti-corruption. There is no explicit indication that the protests in the three countries were pre-planned and organized campaign by the mainstream political parties or for that matter a group of trade unions that had a structural platform.

The second feature of these actors which make us identify them as a protest public is that they constituted people from diverse backgrounds who are strangers to each other. These publics set their boundaries and organizations through their own discourse rather than through external frameworks (Warner 2002). The protests in the case of India, Brazil, and South Africa were initially started by individuals from urban middle-class background with access to smartphones. However, it soon metamorphosed to include people from all sections of the society. In South Africa, a research team of the University of Johannesburg conducted a survey of the protests and found that of the 185 people surveyed, 56% were black African and 30% were white. Of them 58% could be considered middle-class occupations (either professional or managerial, technician, and associated professions or clerks), 10% could be regarded as holding traditionally working-class occupations (either skilled manual labor or trade work, domestic work, or elementary), and 13% were self-employed (Runciman et al. 2017). In Brazil, the young constituted most of the initial protests from 2013 to 2015. However, during the impeachment of President Dilma Rousseff, there was a jump in the age group—middle-aged people (40–50 years old) started taking an active part during these protests (Interview, Esther Solano). The research conducted by research institute DataFolha in 2016 showed that among the 500,000

protesters present at Avenida Paulista, 57% were male and the average age was 45.5 years. The most educated demonstrators, with higher education, were 77%, and the others had average (18%) or fundamental (4%) schooling (DataFolha 2016). The anti-corruption protests in India were supported by hundreds of students' groups, farmers' groups, senior citizens' societies, sex workers' unions, taxi drivers' unions, and small vendors' associations. Civil society also played an active role in these protests. In Brazil, some of the protests were organized by certain civil associations (the Free Fare Movement, the Homeless Workers' Movement, the Sao Paulo subway workers, the Teachers' union), while others were organized through Facebook (MBL-Movimento Brasil Livre, Vem Pra Rua Brasil, Povo Sem Medo, etc.). In South Africa, campaigns such as "The Save South Africa" campaign were also actively calling for Zuma to step down.

In all three cases, we observed strangers from diverse socioeconomic backgrounds coming together to participate in a united discourse, thus building their own collective identity. For example, in India, the anti-corruption protesters came up with two symbols to create a collective identity—the use of a Jhadu (broom), metaphorical of cleaning the corruption in the country, and the second was Gandhi Topi (cap), metaphoric of freedom. Old songs like "Ae mere watan k logo" (Our Country's People), which are very patriotic in nature, were being played. The main point that people were trying to make was that they were true heirs of the Gandhian streak of the national movement and that the ruling party were the corrupted political elite from whom the reins of power are to be snatched. In Brazil too, football-themed chants were being reworded with political slogans to rouse the crowd (Lesser 2015).

Interaction in a social space is the key to creating a public. Conversations, answering, talking back, and deliberating kept happening online as well as offline. However, the key characteristic of these protests is the crucial role played by social media, which evolved to become a platform where individuals completely unknown to each other engaged on a shared discourse bringing an alternative source of political information. It was used passionately and aggressively by all these people not just to share information about events, but to share the details of the protest and to criticize the government. Facebook and Twitter were extensively used to spread the word about rallies and campaigns, while WhatsApp turned out to be more suitable for careful coordination. It became an agent of public discourse around these meta-issues and drove participation by raising political and democratic consciousness among the masses. Hashtags became a new way of associating with new resentments against political class. These metamorphosed into a tribe with their own value system, morality, prejudices, judgments, cultural symbols, and civic ethos (Biju 2016).

6 Social Changes as a Consequence of Protests: Consolidation and Revitalization of the Democracy

6.1 The Gradual Unfolding of Changes: "Political and Institutional Changes?" in Case of South Africa, Brazil, and India

In Brazil, according to the sociological studies conducted by the Associated Press (2017), 46% of the citizens had given their support to Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva in 2010. Moving up from a citizenry support of 48% in 2011, Brazil experienced rise in approval ratings to 62% in the following year (2012) when Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva handed power to Dilma Rousseff's Workers Party. However, ever since the 2013 protests in Brazil and the impeachment process of President Dilma Rousseff, the ratings have been falling consistently. Even Michel Temer who came to power after President Dilma Rousseff's impeachment saw his approval ratings drop to 27%. About a third (34%) of the public had a favorable view of the impeached President Dilma Rousseff, and more than four-in-ten (45%) had a positive opinion of former President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva (Russo 2017). In South Africa too, President Jacob Zuma who had been ruling the country since 2009 faced a steady decline in his approval ratings, and according to a study conducted by Kantar TNS in 2017, his ratings were at an all-time low of 20% in March 2017 across the country's seven major metropolitan areas (Kantar TNS 2017). His approval ratings saw a steady decline from 55% in February 2012 to 20% in March 2017 (BusinessTech 2017).

There was a general sense of anger prevailing in South Africa over the corrupt system and the slowing down of economy (economic growth slowed to 0.3% in 2016 and unemployment topped 25%). This, coupled with the two ratings agencies' (Fitch and Standard and Poor's) downgrading of South African debt to "junk status," made South Africans very skeptical of the ruling party, ANC and Zuma, who was accused of corruption and cronyism following allegations that the wealthy Gupta family influenced cabinet appointments. So in February 2018, under pressure from the people of the country, the ANC sacked Mr. Zuma from his post and put in charge Cyril Ramaphosa because the party risked losing power nationally if he continued in power (E.C.S. 2018). Even though the power space remained the same in South Africa, the protests put pressure on the ruling party to change its leadership.

India had a similar trend during the protest period which changed considerably after the election of 2014. The protests between 2011 and 2013 in India caused the sharpest decline in approval ratings—from 65% in 2010 to 59% in 2011 to 52% in 2013 (D'Souza 2012; Stokes 2015) of the then Prime Minister Manmohan Singh of the United Progressive Alliance (UPA). The UPA, during the protests, was unable to recognize or refute the corruption allegations and massively mishandled the crowd building around the anti-corruption and Nirbhaya protests. This drop in popularity of the UPA government was capitalized by the leading opposition party Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) with Narendra Modi as their prime ministerial candidate (D'Souza 2012). In 2014, BJP won the elections, Indian political leadership

changed,[22] and India recorded a sharp rise (63%) in the citizenry support for its new Prime Minister who had led the party to a landslide electoral victory. Pew Research Centre found that the support for Modi's government continued to be high in 2015 (at 87%), but in 2016, it dropped by a margin of 6% (81%) (Stokes 2016). Shortly before the elections of 2014 took place, the Pew Research Centre conducted a survey which showed that seven-in-ten Indians had been dissatisfied with the way things were in India and when asked said that they would prefer the opposition Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) by a margin of more than three-to-one rather than the ruling Indian National Congress (INC).

The protests in India also led to the emergence of a new political party founded by one of the organizing members of the anti-corruption protest group called Aam Aadmi Party (Common Man's Party). The party, led by Arvind Kejriwal, won a landslide victory in the state assembly elections in Delhi winning 67 out of 70 seats. He rode on to the prevailing sense, in India, that politicians are aloof and arrogant and that active involvement in politics by the common masses was imperative to change the corrupt and self-serving system of politics.

The instances of Brazil, South Africa, and India pointed toward a crisis in leadership in the three countries as the protests continued. As explained earlier, citizens were increasingly unhappy with their leaders and wanted to see change or wanted their leaders to step down. The protests which took place in Brazil, India, and South Africa happened in the midst of an expanding middle class. The protests did not create massive institutional changes—freedom parameters such as political and civil rights have been mostly stable over time.

However, all three countries are put in the category of "flawed democracies" by Economist Intelligence Unit's index of democracy, and their data further indicate that in the case of the three countries, the scores have been decreasing over time[23] (5% reduction in Brazil, 6.3% in South Africa, and 3.3% in India between 2010 and 2016). Besides, some parameters such as laws and regulations over media limits on content have seen changes since 2010 which are undesirable for the necessary preconditions for stable democracies, for example, increasingly the backlash from the governments' criminalized dissent. Freedom house parameter which measures political pressures and controls on media content show that there has been increasing pressures on the media in these countries since 2010 (highest in Brazil followed closely by India and then South Africa).[24] In all three countries, the freedom of press status is "partly free." The score for Brazil in this case is the worst among the three. This can be partly attributed to the fact that "most mainstream media outlets belong to families or politicians who control its editorial line, most often for their personal

[22]A new political party named Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) came to power.

[23]From 7.21 in 2010 to 6.9 in 2016 in Brazil, 7.79 (2010) to 7.41 (2016) in the case of South Africa, and 7.1(2010) to 6.9 (2016) in the case of India.

[24]Between 2011 and 2016, political pressure in South Africa which was low initially compared to the other two countries increased from 13/30 to 17/30 points, in India it increased from 17/30 to 21/30, and in Brazil it went up from 19/30 to 22/30 (Freedom House).

interests" (Nunes 2016). The Grupo Globo conglomerate, which is a privately owned media house, dominates the media landscape in Brazil and controls the principal television, cable, and satellite networks as well as several radio stations and print outlets (Wikileaks 2013). Such a scenario necessitated the creation of new independent media collectives and networks (such as Jornalistas Livres, Midia Ninja, Postv.org, etc.) as more and more Brazilians felt that their problems were being misrepresented in traditional media outlets (Levy 2015).

Over time, all three countries are observing an increase in censorship of content and restrictions on the media. For example, in South Africa, reporters sometimes face physical attacks, unlawful arrests, or other obstacles while attempting to cover sensitive news stories. In January 2015, during a spate of xenophobic violence in the country, police officers forced journalist Mpho Raborife to delete photos she had taken of a Somali-owned shop that had just been looted (Freedom House 2016c). A total of 567 people were arrested during Fees Must Fall protests in 2016 (Herman 2016). Amnesty International reported that young people and black men, mainly those living in favelas and other marginalized communities, were being disproportionately targeted with violence by law enforcement officials (Amnesty International 2017). In Brazil bloggers face high levels of judicial censorship (Freedom House 2015). Google consistently cites Brazil as one of the countries with the highest number of content removal requests in their transparency report (Freedom House 2015). During the protests, ABIN, the Brazilian Intelligence Agency, had supposedly admitted monitoring social networks in search of public information including WhatsApp (communication app whose information cannot be considered public) (Digital Rights Lac 2013). In Brazil, journalists, especially those who focus on organized crime or corruption, were frequently subjected to violence. At least 20 journalists have been killed in direct relation to their work since 2011, including 6 in 2015 alone (Freedom House 2016a). India has also been involved in blocking, filtering, removing, and manipulating content on several occasions (Freedom House 2016b). India's Daughter, the documentary which chronicled the 2012 gang rape, was banned in the country (Freedom House 2016b).

6.2 Policy Change in India, Brazil, and South Africa

Protesters with their varied demands shaped the sphere of policy in several ways. After the first round of intense protests in Brazil in 2013, the government stepped back and decided to not increase the cost of using public transportation in São Paulo and Rio de Janeiro. Some other cities like Porto Alegre, Cuiabá, Recife, and Joao Pessoa even decreased the fares (Bevins 2013). After the anti-corruption protests in India, the UPA led Indian government agreed to strengthen the Lokpal or ombudsman bill (anti-corruption bill) and create a new watchdog authority. The bill was passed in the lower house in December 2011 and was passed in the upper house in December 2013 after making certain amendments to the earlier bill.

In Brazil too, there were a few policy changes with regard to corruption. The Clean Company Act was passed in 2014 which could hold companies responsible for the corrupt acts of their employees (Ramirez 2017). It imposed strict civil and administrative liability on domestic and foreign companies for engaging in corrupt practices against either the Brazilian government or foreign officials (Tobolowsky 2016). Brazil also enacted the Access to Information Law in 2012 which gives the public unfettered access to information regarding violations of fundamental rights (Human Rights Watch 2014). After the backlash from the people and from the party over the scandal at state-run oil giant Petrobras, President Dilma Rousseff introduced an anti-corruption package which included 10 years of imprisonment for individuals convicted of corruption and fines 5–10 times the amount of money in any transaction. It also brought more members of the executive, legislative, and judiciary in the ambit of 2010 Ficha Limpa Act[25] (Langlois 2015). In South Africa, President Zuma signed the Financial Intelligence Centre Amendment Act (FICA) into law in April 2017 which would strengthen the "transparency and integrity of the South African financial system" by "combating financial crimes, which include tax evasion, money laundering, and the financing of terrorism and illicit financial flows" (ENCA 2017). After Cyril Ramaphosa came to power, South Africa's public ombudsman announced an investigation into two high-ranking members of the ANC because $21 million of public funds, meant to help struggling black farmers, had gone to politically connected companies and individuals.

In July 2014, Brazil under President Dilma Rousseff transformed the national education plan (PNE) into law which includes a goal to invest 10% of the GDP in education by 2024 (The Guardian 2015). Some of the other key policy changes in Brazil have been to open up its pre-salt oil fields to foreign investors (in October 2016) to get new investments in the country. This means companies other than Petrobras (which was heavily mismanaged forcing it to slash jobs and production targets) can now operate blocks in the largest deepwater deposits of Brazil. This could be seen as a way of bringing the economy back to life and producing more employment opportunities for Brazilians. In South Africa, an important policy document called National Development Plan (NDP)-2030 was introduced by the government in early 2013 for socioeconomic development of the country. It is a policy blueprint for eliminating poverty and reducing inequality in South Africa by 2030 (Saho 2014). It aims to reduce unemployment to 6% by 2030, raise economic growth, promote exports, and focus on key capabilities such as skills, infrastructure, social security, strong institutions, and partnerships both within the country and with key international partners (National Planning Commission 2015).

In India, after the 2012 rape incident in New Delhi, the government passed The Criminal Law (Amendment) Act of 2013 which widened the definition of rape and set out stricter punishment for the guilty. Several Indian states also set up new

[25]The 2010 Ficha Limpa Act makes a candidate who has been impeached, has resigned to avoid impeachment, or has been convicted by a decision of a collective body (with more than one judge) ineligible to hold public office for 8 years, even if possible appeals remain.

committees and helplines to address issues related to women's safety. More female officers were added to Delhi's police force; security was tightened and night patrolling was increased. The police now had to undergo gender sensitization courses. Six fast-track courts were set up to specifically deal with rape cases; laws against sexual assault were made stricter; and, since one of the accused was 17 years old at the time of the Nirbhaya crime, a debate for changing juvenile laws opened up. Most importantly, a space for public discussion of sexual violence, which had not existed before, was created (Bakshi 2017). Both the anti-corruption and Nirbhaya movements in India involved the coalescing of the different social groups around the social evils of corruption and issues relating to women's safety. In both instances, empowered, informed, and engaged Indian citizenry challenged the cynicism of the party politics and increased the possibility of agent-based participation in the new democratic space (Rajhans 2017).

7 Highlighting the Glitches and Holding the Government Accountable: Protest Publics as Watchdogs in India, Brazil, and South Africa

An important question to ask is, what must be the criteria for observing and measuring the level of effectiveness, impact, and outcome of the action by protest publics? One of the ways to answer this is to invoke Gamson who highlights two critical aspects of success as a set of outcomes that fall into two basic clusters. The first is the antagonists accepting the challenging group as a valid spokesman for a legitimate set of interests, and second is new advantages gained by the group's beneficiary during the challenge and its aftermath (Gamson 1990). Kitschelt evaluates the success of a protest on the "structural impacts" that involve "a transformation of the political structure process" (Kitschelt 1986). Schumaker makes a similar argument by observing the criteria of responsiveness by the political system to the demands by the protesters. On those benchmarks it can be concluded that the "actorness" of the protest publics was not nominal but substantive. It managed to set the agenda and generate the necessary debate which appeared rather difficult at the initial stage. In all the three countries, we see that these actors have brought down the leaders in power. In the case of India, there was a change in not just leadership but also in the leading political party. In the case of South Africa and Brazil, the leaders were changed midway, while the leading political party remained the same. Through reflexive discourse and increased and enlarged horizontal platform for the policy formation bottom-up, the public managed to emerge as an actor of significant consequence. Such protests have appealed to the individual sense of morality and ethics rather than to any particular ideology (the ideological affiliations have ranged from left to right). The structure of these protests have been non-hierarchical, led mostly by the middle class but joined by people from all walks of life across a varied geographical space around issue-based politics, giving it a rhizomatic characteristic.

In each one of the three countries, we witness that in place of being co-opted by the system, the protesters remained ahead despite being shaky at times at the end of each curve of the agenda setting and demanded the deliberation for the changes at each one of the levels: political, level of policies, and institutional. The focus remained on the individual citizens who were willing to leave their comfort zone and step out into the streets, protesting to demand greater accountability, thus demonstrating a watchdog-like characteristic.

To conclude, the capacity of the state in all three countries has been audaciously questioned, and the governments in all the three countries have formulated policies and have at least partly given in to the demands of the protesters. In all three countries, anti-corruption legislations have been strengthened. In cases where there are structural problems with the institutions in the country, like in the case of Brazil and South Africa with respect to certain economic parameters (inflation, unemployment, economic growth), the governments are formulating policies which can be effective in the long run. Despite the corrupt nature of the governments in the three countries, individual citizens, civic organizations, the relatively independent judiciary, and specially created independent state institutions have been able to take over the task of improving the quality of governance. At the same time, there have been no holistic changes: there are still several political leaders accused of malfeasance in all three countries, several serious problems in the economy remain, and political turmoil in Brazil and South Africa continues to prevail.

Even though they are yet to generate a bannered rallying point and have witnessed a few setbacks, the overall vigor and vitality of the democratic space have been strengthened by the "watchdog capacity" of the publics in these countries. These publics vigil and pay a close attention to issues that affect them. They are unique in their inner formation primarily because they are composed of diverse individuals and because of their non-unionized nature. There is no formal membership to these publics and they do not have any uniform political or ideological affiliation. All individuals despite their political affiliations (extreme-left, left, center, center-right, etc.) converged together on a single meta-issue which has been plaguing these communities. Their resistance has a multiplicative and reconfiguring characteristic with a constant reconfiguration of leaders and coordination community. It also has a capacity to mutate at a multilayered governing environment at the horizontal level (within the locality and the region) and at the vertical level (from local to regional level). Finally, these protest publics are unique because they coordinate and facilitate interaction in a more pluralistic, liquid, and versatile way unlike the design of an unionized movement which has certain monolithic and static characteristics. The publics because of these characteristics have been able to monitor the performance of the government and have been unforgiving to those found complicit in wagging the tail for those in power.

One of the key outcomes of these protests in all the three countries has been the consolidation of participatory spirit of democracy which has led to a gradual shift from "top-down project implementation to the bottom up participatory policy implementation" (Rajhans 2017). It has proved the power of fury of the informed

citizenry that challenged the incompetence of party politics and brought in the possibility of agent-based participation in the democratic space.

Funding The chapter was prepared within the framework of the Academic Fund Program at the National Research University Higher School of Economics (HSE) in 2016–2017 (grant № 17-05-0018) and by the Russian Academic Excellence Project "5-100."

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Protest Publics as the "Triggers" of Political Changes in Hybrid Regimes: The Cases of Tunisia, Morocco, and Egypt



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1 Protests in Tunisia, Morocco, and Egypt: An Overview

Tunisia exploded in protests as street vendor Mohamed Bouazizi self-immolated on December 17, 2010, in a protest against humiliation and abuse of his human dignity by local authorities. This was the milestone which ignited "Jasmine Revolution" events across the country. Post-revolution protests continued under the Islamist-led government which remained on power for 4 years before the new "liberal" President Beji Caid Essebsi formed a new government in February 2015, which could still not have helped sustain the new wave of protests which many call a version of the "Arab Spring" protests. Morocco has also gone through extensive waves of protest during the "Arab Spring" in 2011, when the "20th February Movement"[1] occupied the streets, demanding sociopolitical reforms and protesting against corruption, which resulted in the adoption of a new constitution that outlined the expansion of democracy. Yet, protests led by unemployed graduates, trade unions, teachers, representatives of NGOs, and sometimes common citizens continued to "disturb" the leading powers demanding more democratic assets and protesting corruption. Meanwhile, Egyptian uprising brought the military back into power in 2013 after former President

[1]Movement was titled in the name of the date when first major protests occurred in Morocco.

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N. Belyaeva et al. (eds.), *Protest Publics*, Societies and Political Orders in Transition,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5_13

Morsi failed to reform the economy and introduced constitutional reforms that increased presidential power to dictatorship level. Yet, the role of the military in the "Arab Spring" political changes is still debated by scholars and researchers (Goldberg 2014; Droz-Vincent 2013; Gaub 2014). In Egypt, we can observe how the Supreme Council of the Armed Forces backed the fall of President Mubarak (Mekouar 2016) and then, to preserve their own interests, the generals had to leave their comfort zone as political veto players working behind the scenes. This was a position they had held under Mubarak (Albrecht and Bishara 2011), and they took direct political responsibility with their coup against President Morsi.

This chapter is therefore about exploring the commonalities of the protest publics' impact on the sociopolitical changes that the three countries underwent. The chapter also seeks to test if "protest publics" that emerged during the "Arab Spring revolutions," as well as the protests that followed along the ensuing 6 years, can be described as "triggers" of democratic development in Egypt, Tunisia, and Morocco. To do this, we tried to analyze factors and actors connected with the protests in all three countries and conducted a number of expert interviews with scholars and activists who are studying events and consequences of the "Arab Spring."

The "Arab Spring's" early protests erupted in late 2010 without preparation or protest programs that could not be predicted by authorities or the entire world. Another variable reinforcing the thought of public's occupation of the streets during the "Arab Spring" is the "responsiveness" to police assaults against previous protesters, which led to an escalation of protests and public mobilization campaigns. In Tunisia, after Mohamed Bouazizi set himself on fire on December 17, 2010, citizens reacted to that event by holding a series of demonstrations with no pre-existing agendas or support by civil society organizations. As soon as protests escalated, security forces started to intervene frequently, which drove more citizens to join the protests. Hence, "responsiveness" as well as lack of an organizational aspect was outlined by the theory of publics (Warner 2002; Mahony and Clark 2013). This indicates that publics tend to be a driver of change in Tunisia, despite the absence of required technical and professional expertise in grassroots activism. Meanwhile, protest movements, represented by experienced NGOs' labor unions and syndicates, showed weak participation due to their institutional limitation and restricted opportunities. Regardless of the fact that the Tunisian labor union "Union Générale Tunisienne du Travail" (UGTT) has been historically active against the government policies, its presence in the "Arab Spring" uprising appeared just when the regime of Ben Ali was about to collapse. About 130,000[2] people protested in different locations in Tunisia against Ben Ali's regime and Mohamed Ghannouchi's interim government from December 17, 2010, to February 26, 2011. During the Islamist liberals' struggles in 2013, no less than 88,000 people held protests, most of the people gathered in the capital Tunis. Between 2015 and 2017, about 5000 people took to the streets of Tunis to demonstrate against plans of reconciliation with figures

[2]Numbers are estimated, compiled by authors from each protest event, based on available news reports and data from expert interviews.

from the former Ben Ali's cabinet. In the same period, protests also occurred in other marginalized towns and oil-rich regions where young unemployed graduates demanded jobs and protested for equal distribution of oil and gas revenues. According to the OECD, unemployment is a serious issue for Tunisian youth during this period of time because more than a third of young people are unemployed in Tunisia, with 62% of graduates ending up without work (OECD Report 2015). The reality of unemployment remains a dilemma since the "Arab Spring" uprising, regardless of outstanding scores in democracy compared with Morocco and Egypt or even with the rest of the Arab countries.

In Egypt, protests succeeded to summon up to 2 million people across Cairo, Alexandria, and other big cities during 2011–2013. During the first uprising against Mubarak's regime, only in Cairo, the number of protesters attending Tahrir Square was estimated at around 1 million (Anufriev and Zaytsev 2016). Working-age people represent the majority of protesters (Beissinger and Putnam 2013). Despite the fact that the protests of 2011 responded to political and economic issues like political censorship, increase of food prices, disruption of corruption, and police brutality, newly elected Morsi's cabinet failed to improve the situation.

The Moroccan protests during the "Arab Spring" imply a great extent of actions led by social movements, represented mainly by the "20th February Movement." This movement was supported by 11 different human rights organizations, Moroccan trade unions, leftists, and Islamist political parties known for their constant opposition to the monarchal regime. According to the interview conducted with Dr. Abderrahmane Rachik[3] by the authors in 2014, the net of protest activities increased 25 times in 2012 compared to the year 2005, marking about 17,186 protest activities in the public sphere, which is equal to 52 protest activities each day across Morocco. Generally, protests take place in Rabat and Casablanca, but during the "Arab Spring," geography of protests occurred to be in most urban places.

During these events, the number of participants in 2012 protests reached 321,000 in Morocco. In the interview to the authors, Idriss Yazami[4] also revealed that the number of protest activities during 2014 and 2015 reached 16,000, which is almost equal to 31 protest activities per day. But the Moroccan Center for Human Rights estimated that the number of protesters during 2014 amounted to 17,000 protest activities, which is equal to more than 50 protest activities per day. This number therefore contradicts with the statistics presented by Idriss Yazami in which he compiled the 2 years with just 16,000 protest activities only. As we can see from the abovementioned numbers, the number of protests and public assemblies saw a significant increase in the recent years in Tunisia and decreased in comparison with the peak amount after the "Arab Spring" events in Morocco and Egypt.

Most scholars and analysts on the Arab Spring uprisings agree that the initial factors for changes in MENA countries were directly linked with the reasons of protests themselves and based on socioeconomic grievances (Beissinger and Putnam

[3] Abderrahmane Rachik is a Moroccan expert from Casablanca.

[4] Idriss Al Yazami is the director of the National Council for Human Rights in Morocco.

2013). Mohammed Masbah,[5] in his interview to the authors explained that protesters at the local level in Morocco, Tunisia, and Egypt have all moved from socioeconomic-based protests into nationwide demonstrations addressing a *political component*, such as constitutional reforms, fostering democracy, or call for regime change. Hence, the political climate and nature of polities being authoritarian or hybrid regimes have left limited opportunities for exercise of democracy, especially in Egypt, Morocco, and Tunisia, who share common political features as evolving hybrid regimes.

Economic grievances (and to a lesser extent, grievances over corruption) were the common agenda for participants of protests in all three countries, but demands for democracy, openness, and civil and political freedoms were also usually mentioned. In all selected cases, protesters disproportionately consisted of males, professionals, government employees, teachers, private sector employees, and managers. But whereas participants in Morocco and Egypt were mostly middle-aged, middle class, professional, and religious, participants in Tunisia were younger, more secular, educated, and significantly more diverse in social composition: workers, students, and unemployed people.

According to our assumption, mass protests played a very similar role among these three hybrid regime countries—they sharpened the political agenda toward issues with democratic institutions and led to visible changes, at least in the first period after the mass protests. This statement based on preliminary outcomes of the past 5 years existed in academic literature and information from expert interviews. Despite the different trajectories of change in the countries after the protests and first initial changes, we argue that protests had their effect on policy, political, and institutional changes. It is worth analyzing similarities and differences in processes of change to improve first assumptions of the basic model of "triggers."

2 Troubled Democratization and Slow Policy Change as an Aftermath of the "Arab Spring" and Protests in Tunisia, Morocco, and Egypt

The political situation in Tunisia, Morocco, and Egypt after the "Arab Spring" revolutions witnessed a wide range of sociopolitical change. Based on current data and observations, we can track different political, institutional, and policy changes that occurred in these three countries after the "Arab Spring" uprisings and protests that followed since 2011. These changes and connected processes were in focus of several recent studies (e.g., Achcar 2013; Albrecht et al. 2016; Gelvin 2012; Koehler 2017; Mekouar 2016; Perra 2014), but these authors mostly focus on particular changes separately, while we want to bring more attention to the multidirectional

[5]Dr. Mohammed Masbah, research fellow at the Crown Center for Middle East Studies in the United States.

nature of such changes and their links with different actors and factors which influenced the character of change.

2.1 In Search of the Fragile Balance: Military, Islamists, and Old Political Elites in the Struggle for Power

During the "Arab Spring," there was a situation where ruling parties and head of state/government changing in certainly short periods of time became quite usual for the MENA region. Some changes were related to serious political crises and even civil war; some were launched by continuous protests or developing democratic institutions. However, protests in the region in general and in Tunisia, Morocco, and Egypt, in particular, launched a wave of imbalance in those countries' political landscapes.

In Tunisia, for example, three presidents (Fouad Mebazaa as an acting president after ousting of Ben Ali, later Moncef Marzouki, and then Caid Sebsi) and six prime ministers came to power in just 6 years, which illustrates a serious struggle for power and heightened level of political competition, notably after the Islamist party "Ennahda" lost credibility in its political fight with liberal parties after the Ennahda prime ministers (Hamadi Jbali and Ali Larayed between December 2011 and January 2014) failed to respond to existing social and economic challenges.

The same changes occurred in Egypt after new free elections happened in 2012, when the new President Mohamed Morsi, representing the joint alliance of Islamic parties, failed to deal with the social and economic demands of the protesters and, moreover, tried to create an even more authoritarian regime than it was under Mubarak. As a result, Egyptian military forces under the leadership of the minister of defense Abdel Fattah el-Sisi ousted Morsi from power and sent him into jail. After the fast coup d'état, el-Sisi won the presidential elections in 2014 with 97% of the total votes and became the president. The case of Morocco is different, because of the fact that the power structure has been stable regardless of continuous mass protests. The Moroccan King remained in power since his ascendance to the throne in 1999, and even during the major protests of 2011, his position was almost unshakable due to the nature of the monarchic power legitimacy in the country. At the same time, parliament of the country experienced a political crisis on the wave of protests, and as a result, first post-Arab Spring parliamentary elections in the country brought Abdelilah Benkirane from the moderate Islamist party to be elected for the first time in the modern history of Morocco as prime minister representing the Islamic party, before he was replaced by his partisan colleague Saadeddine Othmani as the new prime minister in March 2017.

The most important political trend common for all three countries is serious reconfiguration of the balance of power in the parliament and changes of ruling party in the state. Despite the fact that Tunisia and Egypt actually faced revolutions against authoritarian leaders such as Ben Ali and Mubarak while Morocco

experienced only a major political crisis because of mass protests, all these countries were in the same condition with regard to reconfiguration of their parliaments. This reconfiguration was strongly connected with two common features: the first one is the *growing presence and influence of Islamic political parties and second one is a response of different actors to limit the power of these parties after major protests*. In the case of Egypt, it was the "Muslim Brotherhood," in Morocco "Party of Justice and Development," and in Tunisia "Ennahda" Party. All these parties got their popularity during the protests, won the elections on a wave of protest sentiments and society's disappointment in traditional parties, and then faced a situation of extraordinary elections where they lost majority in the parliament.

In 2011, "Ennahda" Party was a dominant political force in Tunisia; right after the establishment of interim government, they used contradictions between new figures in Tunisian politics and members of Ben Ali's cabinet to strengthen their popularity among ordinary citizens. This strategy led to an unconditional victory on October 23, 2011, parliament elections. "Ennahda" got 37.4% of votes and 89 seats in the parliament, while the closest opponent "Congress for The Republican Party" got only 8.7% and 29 seats. After 3 years, on extraordinary parliament elections, "Ennahda" got only 27.8% of votes and 69 seats and lost majority to the new party "Nidaa Tounes," established by the new Tunisian President Beji Caid Essebsi (37%, 86 seats).

Even more crucial for the Islamic party was the case of Egypt. After the resignation of Mubarak, previously banned organization "Muslim Brotherhood" united its efforts with other Islamic groups and organized the "Freedom and Justice Party" which won the elections in 2012 by getting 47% of the votes. But political initiatives of "Muslim Brotherhood" leader Mohamed Morsi (who was elected president at this time) brought the party from serious success to complete disaster. Around 16,000 members of the "Muslim Brotherhood" were arrested, and after these events, the party mostly lost its structure in Egypt and did not participate in elections of 2015. In 2015, more than 500 members of the "Muslim Brotherhood" were sentenced to death, the organization itself was considered terroristic, and Morsi was sentenced to life imprisonment for abuse of power in 2016.

In Morocco, Islamic "Party of Justice and Development" faced the lightest outcomes compared to Tunisia and Egypt, but the case of Morocco is quite complex because it contains a lot of hidden parties and agreements which are not available for the public and could serve only as an object of speculations. Mass protests in February 2011 led Moroccan King Mohammed VI to announce extraordinary elections as well as a process of constitutional reform granting new civil rights. On the wave of protests, Islamic "Party of Justice and Development" (PJD) got its highest result in history—22.8% of votes and 107 seats in the Parliament. Based on this result, party leaders tried to set more Islamic-oriented agenda in the parliament, but these attempts led to the weakening of their positions and pressure from other political parties. As a result, PJD agreed on series of compromises, the party formed a coalition with three parties that had been parts of previous governments, and PJD leader Abdelilah Benkirane was appointed as prime minister of Morocco.

Another *important common trend for all three countries is the process of the adoption of new constitution.* Reasons for such reforms were the same in all cases—mass protests and citizens' demands for justice and democracy.

2.2 Constitution-Making Processes and Institutional Reforms as a Result of the Arab Spring

The scope of political and constitutional reforms after the end of the intensive demonstrations or other, more or less spectacular, forms of citizens' engagement, as well as the way of introducing the institutional changes, may serve as one of the indicators of the Arab Spring as seen through the prism of its political outcomes. The greater—in comparison with Morocco—radicalism of this social and political phenomenon in Tunisia and Egypt resulted in a quite different way of preparing the constitutional reforms. The collapse of political leaders in the two countries meant that such changes could not be a form of concessions granted by the elite ruling the country in previous years. This meant that the dynamics of the constitutional reforms following the emergence of the protest actions was much more visible. The course of the Arab Spring and the then proclaimed political demands can be regarded as a key factor of acceleration of the constitution-making process in the aforementioned group of countries. Besides, modifications that have been introduced at the constitutional level can be seen as a criterion for assessing the effectiveness of postulates that were proclaimed by leaders of diverse social backgrounds involved in the Arab Spring. It can be assumed that the degree of organization of the protesters, their relationship with the established political environment, and their ability to adapt to changing circumstances significantly influence their impact on the direction and extent of expected reforms, including constitutional ones.

In Tunisia, deepening internal conflicts (including the escalation of violence) led to further mass social protests which contributed to speeding up the constitution-making process. The breakthrough came after some nonparty organizations were strongly engaged in solving the political crisis. After the creation of the Tunisian Quartet for National Dialogue, exiting the political deadlock finally allowed for a relatively quick adoption of a constitution. The Quartet presented a plan that included, among other things, the completion of a new basic law and the conduct of new elections. It should be noted, however, that the access of civil society organizations to the constitution-making process was in practice rather limited, although such participation was not formally excluded (The Carter Center 2014, pp. 67–71). It is important to emphasize that the new Tunisian constitution of 2014[6] was not submitted to a nationwide referendum, which makes it different from new

[6]*Constitution of the Tunisian Republic. Translated and printed by: Jasmine Foundation.* http://www.jasmine-foundation.org/doc/unofficial_english_translation_of_tunisian_constitution_final_ed.pdf. Accessed 25 June 2017.

constitutions adopted in Morocco and Egypt. Finally, the act can be seen as an outcome of a compromise between Islamists and secular parties. This gives the opportunity to create a sustainable basis for coexistence of various political forces based on the principles of democratic rivalry (M'rad 2016, p. 85).

In any case, the Arab Spring caused religious political formations, previously suppressed by the authoritarian regime of Ben Ali, to gain considerable political subjectivity. Islam has been recognized as a state religion (Article 1), but at the same time, this act does not refer to Sharia as the source of the law in force. Islamists postulated the introduction of such a constitutional reference, but it was eventually rejected after several months of discussion (M'rad 2016, p. 80). The constitution also contains a comprehensive regulation of individual rights and freedoms, including the equality of women and men (Article 21). Regarding the system of government, the act adopts an institutional structure that is based on a semi-presidential model. Although the president is elected in popular elections and has the power to influence considerably the functioning of other organs, the constitutional position of the government headed by the prime minister cannot be neglected. The task of the prime minister is, among other things, to define the general policy of the state (Article 91), but in some fields (foreign affairs, defense, and national security), the president has a primacy (Article 77). Anyway, the executive branch of government based on two components, the head of state and the government led by the prime minister, seems to be more balanced internally. It may be regarded as a departure from the model adopted in the Constitution of 1959, which consisted in the concentration of competencies in the hands of one political actor—the head of state (Kalai and Skhiri 2018, p. 25). In line with modern constitutional standards, the constitution also emphasizes the rights of the parliamentary opposition (Article 60). More and more newly enacted or amended constitutions contain such regulations.

When it comes to Morocco, exclusively reformist character of the Arab Spring has had a significant impact on its final constitutional effects. The relatively mild course of protests in this country contributed to the fact that the constitution-making process was basically under control of the monarch. As a consequence, it was the king who presented the political initiative, which would result in the enactment of a new basic law. The reaction to the protests was the monarch's speech delivered on March 9, 2011. The king then announced the adoption of a new constitution, but the promise did not make the mass protests complete. The immediate effect of this monarch's reaction was the establishment of a special commission composed of jurists and representatives of other disciplines relating to public affairs (Rousset 2012, pp. 59–60). As a result, for the first time, the constitution was not imposed directly by the king himself. Although the initiated constitutional process was subject, despite differences in comparison with the mechanisms used earlier, to supervision of the monarchy, it was particularly important that the king's initiative was a response to the social demands expressed during numerous street demonstrations (Zemni 2013, p. 149). Such a situation had not taken place before. This proves that the Moroccan Arab Spring had a direct impact on the nature of the constitutional process itself, which, as noted above, did not resemble previous reforms of this kind.

Hence, it cannot be surprising that the new Moroccan Constitution of 2011[7] did not mean far-reaching changes. It was rather a moderate response to the expectations of the protesters. This does not mean, however, that the basic law is not a step forward.

First of all, the constitution strengthened the principle of division of powers. Beneficiaries of these changes were the legislative power and the judiciary. One of the goals of the reform was to realize the idea of a balance between each of the three segments of the state apparatus. It is worth mentioning that the principle of division of powers was indicated by the monarch in his speech of 9 March as one of the most important aspects of the initiated changes (Laachir 2014, pp. 49–50). The new constitution also led to some modifications within the executive power, which included relations between the monarch and the government. The latter organ had to become somewhat more independent of the king and more closely linked to the parliament. Moreover, a new body has been set up—the Council of Government (*Conseil du Gouvernement*) headed by the prime minister who is now referred to as "the Head of Government" (Articles 87, 92). However, the king retained important powers, including the crucial influence on the determination of state policy through the Council of Ministers which he chairs (Articles 48, 49). It is this organ that possibly allows the head of state to correct concepts formulated outside his own political environment (Bendourou 2012, pp. 523–524). The monarch can also freely dissolve the parliament (Article 96). Maintaining a strong king's position (minor concessions do not change this basic assessment) does not fully correspond to Article 1 of the constitution, which states that "Morocco is a constitutional, democratic, parliamentary and social monarchy." The concept of a parliamentary monarchy assumes a political neutralization of the head of state, which is limited to the function of a political arbitrator, without the possibility of permanent influence on the process of governance. The idea of a parliamentary monarchy was promoted by the February 20 Movement, but the current constitution surely does not go so far. Although the position of the king has been slightly limited, the system of government adopted in 2011 seems to be based on the most typical assumptions of a semi-presidential model, not a pure parliamentary one (Jakubiak 2015, p. 183). Moreover, the new constitution provides for a greater protection of rights and freedoms. Important changes have affected the status of women, previously not highlighted in constitutional regulations. Equality between women and men—a controversial social issue in the Arab states—has been identified in many articles of the 2011 Constitution. The emphasis put on women's rights (Articles 19, 27, 30, and other provisions) corresponds to the expectations of those who opted to limit the role of Islam in public life. Besides, the 2011 Constitution contains fairly extensive regulations on citizens' participation. Attention should be drawn to the establishment of the Consultative Council of Youth and of Associative Action (*Conseil consultatif de la jeunesse et de l'action associative*) (Article 170) as a body that seems to be designed in response to the social structure of protests.

[7]Morocco's Constitution of 2011. https://www.constituteproject.org/constitution/Morocco_2011.pdf. Accessed 25 Jun 2017.

Other effects of the Arab Spring as seen through the prism of constitutional reforms could be observed in Egypt. The process of constitutional change in this country was dominated by Islamic and military political elites, and the public was restricted to accept new basic laws in popular referendums. It distinguished the elaboration of these acts from the analogous process in Tunisia. It cannot be said that both fundamental laws expressed the most important expectations of participants in mass protests that led to the overthrow of Mubarak's authoritarian rule. Islamists dominated the process of preparing a new constitution, which was to replace the 2011 provisional constitutional regulations introduced by the SCAF (the latter document was imposed directly by the military). Anyway, the new composition of the political scene became one of the factors leading to further mass social protests in 2012–2013. Tens of thousands of Egyptians took to the streets, demanding Morsi's resignation (Brownlee et al. 2015, pp. 124–125). This contributed to the further undermining of the social legitimization of constitutional reforms initiated by Islamists. Hence, the constitution adopted in 2012[8] and approved by 64% of voters (however, only 33% of the eligible voters took part in the referendum) did not turn out to be a lasting achievement (Debbeche 2016, pp. 454, 459). In 2014, it has been superseded by a new legal act.[9] It deserves to be highlighted that the latter was passed in considerably changed political conditions, namely, after banning the Muslim Brotherhood as a terrorist group and after the beginning—once again—a military rule.

All in all, the dynamics of the Egyptian political life after Mubarak's fall resulted in the introduction of three constitutional acts. The first of them was considered temporary, but two more were conceived as final constitutions. The constitution-making process in 2011–2014 was dominated by Islamic and military political elites. It distinguished the elaboration of these acts from a similar process in Tunisia. The changes adopted in Egypt were marked by a deep conflict between the army and the Muslim Brotherhood—the main actors in Egypt's post-revolutionary political scene—which ruled out the possibility of compromise. Significant differences between the two constitutions relate to the role of Islam. Many controversies concerned the special position of Al-Azhar, a religious institution dealing with the interpretation of sharia law (Article 4 of the 2012 Constitution). It was also possible to create political parties based on religion. The ban on the existence of this kind of political organizations has been restored in the constitution enacted 2 years later (Article 74 of the 2014 Constitution). It is legitimate to believe that excessive emphasis put on the religious component in the act of 2012 (often described as the Brotherhood constitution) was one of the factors contributing to mass mobilization against Morsi's presidency (Fombad 2016, pp. 31–32; Hefny 2016, pp. 103–106). In turn, the 2014 Constitution started to be applied under the authoritarian rule

[8]Egypt's Constitution of 2012. http://www.wipo.int/edocs/lexdocs/laws/en/eg/eg047en.pdf. Accessed 25 Jun 2017.

[9]Egypt's Constitution of 2014. https://www.constituteproject.org/constitution/Egypt_2014.pdf. Accessed 25 Jun 2017.

established after the military coup of 2013. Under these circumstances, the very content of the new basic law seems to be of no great importance. Extensive constitutional regulations regarding civil rights and freedoms or the rule of law can hardly be considered as an indicator of the actual state policy in this respect. When it comes to the system of government, the 2014 Constitution is still based on the model of a strong presidency, which is by no means unique in this part of the world. President's supremacy is confirmed by describing him not only as the head of the state but also as the head of the executive branch (Article 139 of the 2014 Constitution). Hence, although the executive power also consists of the prime minister, who heads the government and manages its work (Article 163 of the 2014 Constitution), there is surely no balance within this branch of the institutional system. Despite the fact that the current system of government seems to maintain some fundamental structural similarities to the semi-presidential regime of France, it is undoubtedly a much more presidentialized variant of this model.

2.3 More Democracy But for the High Cost

While Morocco saw only minor changes, mostly top-down and oriented on soothing protest attitudes in society by demonstrative reforms, protesters in Tunisia and Egypt succeeded to peacefully overthrow authoritarian leaders and created a more solid ground for possible democratization. According to Dalacoura: ". . .by a wide margin Tunisia has the potential to go the furthest in terms of democratization. It is a country with longstanding, effective state structures and institutions" (Dalacoura 2012, p. 73). The UGTT party, human rights activists, journalists, and professional associations, as well as existing political organizations, became the source of real political competition and alternatives. Egypt's prospects in terms of democratic development are much more uncertain and limited. There were a number of improvements in political contestation, police accountability, and economic sphere, but the dominant position of the army following the overthrow of Morsi is an advantage in terms of continuity and stability even if it creates serious obstacles to democratic reforms.

In regard to common trends for institutional changes, it is worth noticing that the case of Morocco is standing alone, because the complex nature of protests in this country and the strong position of the Palace during the events which started in February 2011 prevent the country from significant institutional changes. According to the range of ratings, Morocco stays stable in spheres of corruption level, rule of law, freedom of press, and civil and political rights. But even in this country, protests led to minor positive changes in the level of political participation, pluralism, and joint democracy index. Tunisia and Egypt in these matters showed more shift but with serious backdrop in the case of Egypt.

Changes in democracy index, the level of pluralism, and political participation could be highlighted as common for all three countries. According to the Economist Intelligence Unit's democracy index and Arab Barometer, after events of the "Arab

Spring," the situation with democratic institutions improved for selected states: in the case of Tunisia, drastically, from authoritarian regime in 2010 to flawed democracy since 2013; in the case of Egypt with ups and downs from hybrid regime to military rule; and in the case of Morocco very slowly from authoritarian regime in 2010 to hybrid in 2015. With focus on general qualitative data and rankings, we can notice that protests launched a set of quite important preconditions that inevitably led to certain institutional changes. Despite the fact that in some cases processes developed in a pendulum way and after positive changes we trace authoritarian backlash, countries with rooted authoritarian past and strong military presence in power experienced positive changes, even in institutional dimension. The same tendency might be traced for political pluralism and participation: significant positive change in a scale for Tunisia, remarkable changes in Morocco, and ambiguous dynamics in Egypt. These indicators directly linked with protest activities and efforts that were accumulated "by the street." After first collaborations with authorities, spawning of citizens' demands to change something still could be traced, at least in a form of "silent threat" of new mass protests.

All other indicators which could possibly be used to reflect institutional changes do not show many similarities, and it is quite understandable, because after initial "trigger" explosion in regard to changes, different factors and actors, which will be discussed in consequent chapters, affected the course of changes and character of protests.

Tunisia performed quite well after Ben Ali's exit and improved its position in almost every ranking. Egypt survived after a short and chaotic period of political dominance of Islamic organization "Muslim Brotherhood" and is now demonstrating mostly negative performance in regard to democratic institutional changes. Military representatives came back to power and are trying to present their dominant position on the political scene as a return to the roots of Egyptian State established by Gamal Abdel Nasser. Morocco stays stable, with minor democratic improvements which could be considered as a slow form of political stagnation. The King of Morocco managed to stay above the fight during each wave of protests due to the strong legitimacy afforded him by his specific position as head of the state and religious leader at the same time and by the protection from loyal elites which are interested in current status quo.

3 Protest Publics as an Actor of Change: From Common Start to Diverse Outcomes

During the "Arab Spring," Tunisia, Morocco, and Egypt faced with new phenomena—protest public—which played a major role in organization of protests and affected outcomes of these protests. It is observed that among combination of social, economic, and political factors as well as different actors involved in change

processes, protest publics could be considered as one of the key actors of change in selected countries.

Moreover, the new character of this actor could partially explain why in all cases protests were more or less successful. Traditional political actors faced with unexpected opponents who used technological progress as a tool of effective mobilization and agenda setting. This new type of "warfare" confused forces involved in politics and led to a situation where demands for changes from protest publics' side cannot be fully ignored.

Over the recent years, the "protest publics" as special communities with their own identity and demands for changing social reality according to their own ideas about the imaginary alternative future world that is discursively constructed by them have manifested themselves in various countries of the world. Focusing on the mass protest activity of the recent years, we can speak about the formation of a special type of publics, ones that are directly linked to the protests that feed their ability to exist and develop (Uldanov 2016). According to Clarke and Mahony, such complex social phenomenon must be distinguished from classical definition of social movements, because publics have their own features, based on the heterogeneous nature of these formations and particular orientation on networks and creation of a specific "troubling message" (Mahony and Clarke 2013).

Over the period from 2006 to 2013, the world witnessed a significant rise of protest activity from the events of the "Arab Spring" and the "Indignados" movement in Spain and Latin American countries to the international "Occupy" movement. According to a research conducted by the Friedrich Ebert Foundation, analysis of 843 mass protest events reflects a steady growth of protests every year, from 2006 (59 protests) to mid-2013 (112 protest events in only half a year) with a major increase from 2010, when different governments adopted new austerity measures. Protests are more prevalent in higher-income countries (304 protests), followed by Latin America and the Caribbean (141 protests), East Asia and the Pacific (83 protests), and sub-Saharan Africa (78 protests). An analysis of the Middle East and North Africa region (77 protests) shows that protests were also prevalent prior to the "Arab Spring" (Ortiz et al. 2013). As we can see from this data, protests became a routine, and this fact cannot be explained only by effects of the world economic crisis, crisis of representative democracy, or growing presence of postindustrial values in societies. This significant growth could be explained by the fact that we are observing new emergent actors of political life—"protest publics"—which are influencing existing patterns toward a form of political participation and establishing more demanding behaviors in the pursuit of participatory democracy.

It cannot be claimed that each protest forms its public, as it cannot be claimed that any mass protest activity in Egypt, Tunisia, and Morocco was based strictly on a public. A public itself must meet a number of criteria, for example, Nina Y. Belyaeva highlights seven of its most important features: informedness; competence; involvement; interest; freedom of thought, opinion, and action; cohesion into a group; and readiness to act (Belyaeva 2011). The cases of Tunisia, Morocco, and Egypt provided us with evidences that protesters there met most of these characteristics and were "summoned" around a political "troubling message" that united

representatives of very different social groups in a common attitude to act for changes. They were actively using the Internet and social media to find and spread information, resisting state's propaganda and creating networks based on shared discourse. According to our interview with Dr. Marina Sapronova,[10] in the case of Egypt, we can observe participation of "diverse social ethnic and religious group unified by common demands and discourse".

Another important factor which affected the level of public involvement into mass protests was the simplified communication through social networks and the Internet. Despite the fact that the percentage of people with Internet access in all three countries is not very high, the majority of active citizens are included in this number, which allowed them to overcome state censorship and share news at the beginning of protests. Young bloggers and journalists contributed into creation of protest agenda and at the same time highlighted the state's inability to neglect such discourse and disseminate mass protests. The tactics of the state to conceal information have failed, and more and more people clearly saw the discrepancy between official information and what was actually happening. Attempts to expose protests as minor speeches by radicals and bandits failed, social media were filled with photos and informative videos about the brutal suppression of protests, and activists spread information about corruption and government pressure on ordinary citizens, which led to the rapid sewage of protests. If, in the case of Morocco, the King's authority resisted the accusations and the protest moods were directed to elites and moderate Islamists who won the parliamentary elections, then in Tunisia and Egypt, protesters united to change the existing regime and its authoritarian leader.

Abdullah Al Jenaibi mentioned that social media significantly expanded citizens' possibility to get relevant information about real events and their understanding about injustice of current regime (Abdullah Al Jenaibi 2013). As it was mentioned before, protesters in all three countries were mostly educated professionals, representatives of middle class, and unemployed youth. Such mixture combines youth's readiness to act and freedom of thought with informedness and competence of middle-aged people, so that the combination makes protesters a real "public" (Beissinger and Putnam 2013).

In cases of Egypt, Tunisia, and Morocco, "protest publics" formed the core of protests, a driving force that created mechanisms of sharing information and promoting of common discourse. "Poetic messages" such as "Leave! Go!," "Freedom, bread and justice," "Game over!," and "Our hearts are burning" were mixed with standard social movement claims and demands, such as "Deal with growing unemployment," "Increase the salary for teachers," and "Stop repressions against the activists." Common discourse of change actually brings very different people together; protests were events where one could witness Coptic Christians standing together with members of the "Muslim Brotherhood" or representatives of Western-oriented intelligentsia together with workers or trade union members. Heterogeneity

[10]Marina Sapronova, Doctor of Historical Sciences, Professor of Oriental studies, specialist in history and politics of the Arab World.

of participants was clearly mentioned in interviews gathered by authors, for example, Tunisian activist Aya Chebbi[11] said: "...in 2010/2011, protests didn't even need funds, you make a placard at home, each person arranges their own transport, and that's it. But I think that even for today, most protest activities are still decentralized in terms of funds. For example, the core initiators are youth who fundraise among themselves but the supporters come from different parties, mainly civil society and political parties and each of them fund their own resources (t-shirts, banners, transport, etc.)".

"Troubling message" of social injustice and lack of democracy in Egypt and Morocco transformed over time under the effect of different circumstances to more particular demands concentrated around economic issues and political rights, but we cannot claim that "public" simply disappeared and all efforts were spent in vain. Experience of joint actions and memory of achieved results were not washed away, but participation in authoritarian states demands right conditions and burning issues. It seems that in Morocco and Egypt, "protest public" was oppressed by the complex environment and became "silently agreed" on current course of events and prefers recent stabilization over continuation of democratic changes, but examples of Russia, Brazil, or Turkey demonstrated that well-developed mechanisms of social mobilization could be used again and "protest public" may be summoned over and over again if "troubling messages" and common discourse will be relevant.

In Tunisia, the "public" formed during the protests is still playing a major role in political life. According to the interview with Y. Cherif,[12] the level of public participation and involvement through protests in Tunisia has been growing since "Jasmine Revolution". For example, in April 2017, hundreds of protesters occupied an oil and gas facility in Southern Tunisia to attract local authorities' attention to poor social conditions and job places issues. After negotiations with protesters, government accepted their main demands and protests ended. The success of such activities seems to signify that the decentralized, highly participatory approach that these Tunisian protesters adopted after the revolution can achieve real gains when participants make achievable demands of their government. Former protesters are actively participating in the political life of the country, organizing their own political groups into existed political parties and creating new independent media outlets (Angrist 2013). Activists are trying to keep the way of democratic development that was chosen in 2011, and as we can see from different indicators mentioned in paragraph two of this chapter—they did it successfully. In the case of Tunisia, we could see that "protest public" in the country is evolving; after the establishment of more democratic government and achievements with human rights and freedoms, it is no longer concentrated on push for changes but takes position of a "democratic watchdog," the task of which is not only to promote policy change but also to save democracy from authoritarian shifts.

[11] Aya Chebbi, an award-winning Pan-African feminist activist and renowned blogger. She is the founder and chair of Afrika Youth Movement.

[12] Youssef Cherif is a Tunisian award-winning blogger (Fayla).

4 Non-protest Actors of Change in Tunisia, Morocco, and Egypt

Morocco, Tunisia, and Egypt can't give the credit to only protest publics for initiating change. Resources and power were in the hands of different structures and groups such as military forces, Western-oriented technocrats, Islamic organizations and parties, powerful nobility, and business. All these actors left their trace in different aspects of change, so authors cannot get around them without attention.

The 2011 revolts brought good news for Islamists in Tunisia, Morocco, and Egypt to get into power when the first post-Arab Spring elections gave three Islamist groups to govern and rule in the three countries. Ennahda Party in Tunisia, the Muslim Brotherhood in Egypt, and the Party of Justice and Development in Morocco gained the trust of voters in transparent elections. Since then, Islamists are coming to power on the wave of hopes that they will be able to recover the economy and remedy the demands that the protest youth raised in 2011. Nevertheless, only Morocco's Party of Justice and Development survived in the government, while Egypt's alliance of Islamist parties dissolved under strong military involvement in 2013, and Ennahda Party in Tunisia is facing firm political rivalry with liberal and modernist parties, forcing it to lose the presidential race in 2014. The Islamist groups being actors of change in Tunisia, Morocco, and Egypt brought the discussion about what could be the reasoning behind their decay 6 years after the Arab revolts in 2011.

Moreover, the steady power of the *monarchy* in Morocco is seen to play a clever game with PJD party to stay the main political initiator. In Egypt, *military* gripped on power from elected Islamic brotherhood's Morsi after unprecedented coup in July 2013. Lastly, in Tunisia, new *technocratic and old political elites* managed to find a way into power after Ennahda Party leaders failed to revive the economy and ensure security in the country.

Given the critical situation between Ennahda Party and the opposition in the aftermath of the assassination of Mohamed Ibarhimi and Chokri Belaid, the Tunisian General Labor Union (UGTT) called for a national dialogue between the ruling parties and the opposition on July 29. The parties agreed to participate in dialogue, given the worsening of the situation. On September 17, 2013, the initiative was made public and placed under the aegis of the UGTT and three other civil society organizations: the Tunisian Union of Industry, Trade and Handicrafts, the Council of the National Bar Association of Tunisia, and the Tunisian Human Rights League. These organizations formed what was called the Tunisian Quartet for National Dialogue. At the same date, the quartet prepared a draft consensus among the parties that agreed on a compromise allowing the parties to begin the negotiations. This roadmap draft consisted of four points: the government's resignation and replacement by a government of technocrats, choice of firm dates for the completion of the Constituent Assembly and presidential and parliamentary elections, preserving national identity in the new constitution, and the negotiation of the necessary procedures for the final transition and certain transitional arrangements to democracy. These sessions resulted in choosing Mehdi Jomaa as head of government on

December 14, 2013, and ratification of the new constitution on January 24 besides the organization of legislative elections and the presidential in December 2014. It has been apparent that Tunisian Quartet for national dialogue played a crucial role in reaching consensus over the crisis that swept Tunisia after the "Arab Spring." It should be therefore considered an actor of the political changes that occurred after their work. Consequently, the quartet was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize in 2015 for their significant contribution to the stability and democratization of Tunisia.

While in Morocco, the constitution was adopted to consecrate the slight removal of the monarchy vis-à-vis the executive power, the King used all means at his disposal to gain legitimacy of his powers. His hyperactivity makes of him an ideal reform performer. Almost every day, he participated in different events around the country, be it training institutes, mosques, or factories. To cover his intense actions, Mohammed VI counts on a loyal press that makes sure to show the best of him and his relatives. The state media therefore follows him step-by-step, whether in Morocco or abroad. The Moroccan royal is also known for expressing his "anger" over alleged mismanagement or misgovernance by high public servants. The case of former Minister of Youth and Sports Mohamed Ouzzine, following a scandal on stadium at the FIFA Club World Cup in December 2014 when due to heavy rain in Rabat, pools of water appeared on the field, which created significant problems for the players, despite the guarantees that new turf on the stadium will solve this problem. This case reflected dissatisfaction by the King, forcing him to discharge the minister from the cabinet. Nevertheless, his authority over the judiciary remained unquestioned for his capacity to pardon whoever he wills without public consultation or conventional criteria. Though he followed the issue by removing the director of prison services and delegating a Minister of Justice to solve the legal matters, he faced angry protests led by civil society organizations. Mohamed Masbah in his interview to the authors, sees that: "the main actor that is above and for sure the one who has much power to enact change in Moroccan society is the monarchy." However, there are, according to Masbah, other political groups who influenced the change, including the Islamist parties, such as the banned Al Adl Wa Al Ihssane and cabinet leader PJD (Party of Justice and Development) as well as a mosaic of civil society organizations.

With regard to Egypt's current supreme power—the army—it is worth noting that there is a cluster of thoughts who gave credit to armed forces as "traditional agents of change" before and after the 2011 revolutions, notably Egyptian and Tunisian armed forces who sided with protesters during the "Arab Spring" revolts. This trend has apparently left Egyptian President el-Sisi free in domestic affairs as the judiciary and the media—Egypt's most influential institutions—are firmly in the Sisi camp and are willing to lend their institutional weight to the president's goals.

However, at a time when many pro-electoral democracies condemn General el-Sisi's move to topple Morsi from power and seek to end the Muslim Brotherhood from any further influence, the Egyptian military is seen as a savior through *a guardian of coup d'état*, one which removes a corrupt, inefficient, or incompetent government, rather than the breakthrough *coup* (one which changes the political

system, such as the Iraqi *coup* of 1958). The allegations of funding anti-Morsi protests by the army in 2013 could still prove the military's constant power in bringing about change in Egypt and even closely similar countries in the region. Revelations that began to emerge in late 2014 about the military's direct role in financing anti-Morsi protests, as well as the leadership's overt manipulation of the legal system and the media, may undermine trust between the regime and its liberal supporters.

As we may see, specific capacities and position of such actors as army and Palace in cases of Egypt and Morocco, respectively, shape the direction of policy change in these countries. These strong institutions were able to turn protest activities in their favor and stay in power, despite the fact that protesters and formed "public" have tried to impose their own agenda. In case of Tunisia, only Islamic political parties and radical group have tried to occupy protest agenda, while old political elites mostly decided to cooperate with the protesters. Without strong influence of army or other actors, such division created a fragile balance where no party had a meaningful advantage as in Egypt and Morocco. This situation helped Tunisia to avoid one actor's domination on the wave of protests and stimulates pluralistic development of existing political system.

Tunisia is currently the only country in the Arab world, about which we can reason in Western categories of democracy, such as Dahl's "polyarchy," including the electoral cycle and its mechanisms. However, the democratic accomplishments met with difficulties in economy as well as large protests demanding jobs in oil-rich regions of Tunisia in 2016 and 2017, but there is no visible threat that could bring Tunisia back to pre-Arab Spring era, although, even now, we can say that the country in this respect is much ahead of its neighbors in the region. In many ways, the whole Tunisian phenomenon was determined by a positive combination of factors and actors of change, which formed a fragile balance in politics without dominance of one particular actor, and this balance had a significant impact on the development of Tunisian society and brought it to its current position. It is interesting to track how the role of protest public in Tunisia evolved from clear "trigger" of democratic development to a sort of a "watchdog" which tries to keep the way of democratic shift in the country. In this regard, Aya Chebbi (interview, Chebbi 2017) stressed that the recent Tunisian protests had the same motives as those in 2010 and 2011. She asserted: "it is youth led and mainly until this year (2017) the same generation of the movement of 2010 comes back to the street every time, it's about the same demands." Therefore, it is evident that the protests of 2016–2017 emerged as democracy watchdogs to keep democratic achievements of "Jasmine Revolution" safe.

5 Why Protest Publics Could Be Considered as the "Triggers" of Democratic Development in Hybrid Regimes?

In selected countries, mass protests served as specific triggers for changes that led to multidirectional democratic development. Features of every state and combination of involved actors and key factors determined the nature of such changes, but taking into account general patterns, we could say that main trend to political changes in direction of democracy was certainly close in every case.

Egypt went the other way, actually returning to military rule as it was even before Mubarak period, but with minor modifications (primarily renewal of the elites and some "democratic remarks" in the new constitution and legislation). There are many reasons for this, the most important of which are the conservative and less flexible nature of Egyptian society, where institute of army plays a crucial role. After the events of the "Arab Spring," army leadership apparently had no problem in reversing all democratic gains after 2011 and re-establishing a military dictatorship under President el-Sisi, which found the approval of many Egyptians on the presidential elections. Even the rising protests against the government of President el-Sisi in the second half of 2016 was not connected with the issues of democratic legitimacy or power abuses but mostly focused on his policy results, particularly in the economic sphere. In this regard, the armed forces must be understood as the strongest veto player in the Egyptian political system (Tsebelis 1995). For example, Roll stated that an anonymous Egyptian observer confirmed that without the army's consent, parliamentarians, ministers, and other bureaucrats could not be sure of continuing their tenure. And this claim was clearly illustrated by the 2013 coup against President Morsi (Roll 2016).

Both Islamists and army were not ready to really implement protesters' demands of democracy, social justice, and accountability. Moreover, negative experience after short rule of democratically elected Mohamed Morsi also affected the attitudes of the public, because the new military government started to associate with more stability even if the nature of the regime remains autocratic. The military as the key deterrent, the mediator who enjoys irreverent respect, once again plays a leading role in the political arena of the country, being in fact a system-forming and uniting element. A charismatic, bright leader from this environment came to power, enjoying popularity and respect, but problems that were raised by protesters in 2011 mostly remained the same, and there are no clear signs that military government are ready to solve them. "Protest publics" in Egypt, after a very bright, but short period in 2011, when it was the real initiator of democratic change, became less active and almost disappeared after coup against Morsi. It is another interesting example of public's evolution from "trigger" of change to democratic innovators in conditions of tightened control from the government, where space for public participation is limited and "public" is forced to seek for unconventional ways of participation.

Morocco is an example of a different process. Changes here were inspired by "public," but the King and the institution of the Palace easily used their authority and, in Bourdieu's terms, "symbolic capital" to co-opt protesters and use them as a

part of politics in the country. Concerns and efforts of the protesters led to a number of positive democratic changes in the country, but the dominant role of the King is still an obstacle to any serious changes. Combination of actors and factors which brought Egypt and Tunisia to sizable changes didn't work out in Morocco. Protest public here, almost immediately after the beginning of protests in 2011, was precisely divided and demotivated from further activities. King Mohammed VI demonstrated a flexible approach and readiness to deal, at least formally, with the issues raised by protesters. The King's quick response on constitution and economic reform initiatives took the momentum out of the Moroccan mass protests. Political action was moved in a safe for regime direction—new parliamentary elections, the first to be held under the new constitution which was adopted as a part of answers on protesters' demands. As it was mentioned by a number of scholars, namely, Yom and Gause, Arab monarchies in general were more resilient in situations of protests and growing political crisis than republican authoritarian regimes. It is mostly connected to the nature of the monarchy rule where the king usually appears as an *arbiter* and he is not afraid to sacrifice some representatives of elites in favor of regime's stability. Moreover, King Mohammed VI learned from the events of the "Arab Spring," and after the death of fish vendor Mouhcine Fikri, which caused ongoing mass demonstrations in Morocco's north since October in 2016, he responded fast and effectively. The Moroccan police have not interfered in the protests, and the government made all the right moves to prevent participants of the protests from turning violent or going out of control. The King ordered investigation into Fikri's death and sent the Minister of Interior Affairs to deliver his personal condolences to Fikri's family. Minister Mohamed Hassad even issued a statement expressing solidarity with the protesters: "No one had the right to treat [Fikri] like this. . . We cannot accept officials acting in haste, anger, or in conditions that do not respect people's rights." In this case we cannot observe evolution of "protest public" model of participation; after bright flash of activities in 2011, the King and the government used all their resources to decrease protest activities, so emerging "protest public" was not able to resist these efforts. Divided and misguided by the Palace efforts, participants of protests silently agreed with new reforms and lost important characteristics of protest public, such as readiness to act and a common vision of the future.

The size of the social resistance, its nature, and the rapid spread to other places were largely an effect of mass media communication (especially social media). This constitutes a key factor in explaining characteristics of the protests under discussion. Hence, the engagement of different lasting organizations (primarily political parties) was not so important. On the other hand, these slogans were rather general and did not express any more detailed political demands. Consequently, concrete constitutional changes did not attract particular attention of the demonstrators. However, Morocco may be treated, at least to some extent, as an exception. In this case, there was a direct link between the expectations of the protesters and the royal decision to introduce clearly limited constitutional reforms. Anyway, although the Arab Spring had to launch democratization processes allowing to move away from authoritarianism, organizational weakness resulting from the spontaneity of the protests has not

contributed to the creation of lasting and stable political forms that could have a permanent impact on constitution-making processes, as well as on their final outcomes. Despite the Arab Spring in Tunisia and Egypt has led to the collapse of dictatorships, the rebuilt area of political rivalry started to be occupied by well-organized political groups or the army. With regard to the constitutional reforms, short-term effects of the mass protests are best seen in the case of Morocco. The 2011 Constitution did not bring about a real political breakthrough. However, one of the consequences of the Moroccan Arab Spring was the inclusion of fundamental constitutional problems into the policy area of the ruling camp. It is due to the fact that the promise of a constitutional reform became much more a means of pacifying a tense political situation than an effect of the mass social protests. Obviously, the constitution itself remains an immediate effect of the Arab Spring. On the other hand, although the changes have gone in the direction demanded by the protesters, they were only marginally closer to the idea of a parliamentary monarchy known from some European countries.

The fundamental distinguishing factor of the constitutional reforms in Tunisia and Egypt from those in Morocco was that they were introduced not by the political leaders ruling these countries before the outbreak of the Arab Spring but by the elites created in its wake. In these two countries, the procedure for drafting new basic laws was quite different from that of the monarch-controlled constitution-making process in Morocco. All this shows that the specifics of the Arab Spring protests in North Africa (related to the factors typical of each of the three countries under consideration) have brought radically different outcomes. In the post-revolutionary period, the process of constitutional change was under control of various political forces, for whom the mass anti-government protests became a useful springboard. In Tunisia, it gave a chance to pass, although not without difficulty, a constitution that could create a relatively stable constitutional order. Egypt plunged into the political chaos resulting in a new incarnation of authoritarian rule. As for Morocco, the Arab Spring was quickly neutralized (as the most moderate form of social protests) by the king. Far-reaching demands formulated by the protesters were not taken into account. Thus, the creation—during the Arab Spring—of a new, strong space for the articulation of social interests had only limited influence on the process of building cohesive constitutional institutions. However, it should be taken into account that, despite rather limited effects of the events that took place in early 2011, the mobilization capacity of at least some of these societies proved to be a relatively permanent phenomenon. Consequently, although the protest publics as new political actors have not been transformed into traditional forms of activity with decisive political influence on the public sphere, the social potential revealed in recent years may remain its relatively permanent component.[13] Anyway, when the political

[13]For example, demonstrations against the military government established after Morsi's overthrow took place in Egypt on the fifth anniversary of the Arab Spring in that country. *Arab Spring anniversary: Protesters defy crackdown.* 25 January 2016. http://www.aljazeera.com/news/2016/01/arab-spring-anniversary-protesters-defy-crackdown-160125061915269.html. Accessed 16 Oct 2017.

system does not operate in the conditions of profound destabilization, this type of social activity itself cannot bring significant political effects in the form of a radical change in the mechanisms of governance that could be confirmed by binding legal regulations (including constitutional ones).

Throughout the years since the "Arab Spring" events, we witnessed how protest activities increased in these countries and how citizens were able to make a difference. Despite the fact that most of these attempts were not really successful in the formulation of sustainable public policies, enhancement of institutions, and launch of fundamental political reforms, they were important for the creation of the message that triggers different types of change in policy and society. Citizens were able to create "publics" heterogeneous but unified by common vision of the future. It was a moment when unemployed graduates, workers, residents, and teacher trainees with different social background and political views gathered out of a sudden in a *response* to a "troubling message."

"Trigger" is an important word here, because changes were driven by many factors and actors, but "protest public" summoned around the "troubling message" related to democracy became the thing that launched changes in the way that it happened. In hybrid regimes, citizens usually do not have mechanisms to participate in politics; even elections and some independent media are just an imitation of such attempts. But the lack of mechanisms does not mean that people are not interested in politics or not ready to participate—example of these three particular countries clearly showed that in the situation of economic difficulties, visible injustice from authorities and meaningful contradictions between elite citizens are able to find their place on political arena and act in terms of direct democracy—through protests and rivals. It is not the most efficient way, but in diverse and traditional societies with high importance of religion, any sort of unifying discourse that can bring heterogeneous social groups together in attempt to somehow change existing course of events is already a big deal. "Protest public," through creation of solidarity discourse and focus on common problems rather than on existing contradictions in the society, not simply united diverse groups of citizens during the protests but created a "critical mass" that helped to get rid of authoritarian leaders and forced authorities in taken countries to react and launch political changes.

Funding The chapter was prepared within the framework of the Academic Fund Program at the National Research University Higher School of Economics (HSE) in 2016–2017 (grant № 17-05-0018) and by the Russian Academic Excellence Project "5-100."

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Protest Publics as Democratic Innovators in Authoritarian Environments



Artem Uldanov, Tatiana Davtyan, and Fedor Alekseenkov

1 Protests in Russia, Hong Kong, and Turkey: An Overview

In Russia, multiple mass political protests began after the elections to the State Duma, lower chamber of the Russian Parliament, which took place on December 4, 2011. These elections showed an unprecedented level of electoral fraud in the context of ruling party United Russia's victory, and it was a trigger for protests. On December 5, the day election results were published, many protest actions took place in the biggest cities of Moscow and Saint Petersburg. Started in 2011, the protests continued in the period of 2012–2017 with several waves caused by authorities' repressions, Crimea annexation and war with Ukraine, murder of oppositional politician Boris Nemtsov, and massive corruption in the government. In terms of numbers, since December 2011 until July 2017, there were dozens of protest actions, but we can identify eight peaks of protest activity. First peak is December 10, 2011, when up to 150,000 people came to Bolotnaya Square in Moscow. Moreover, thousands of people were protesting in other cities. Overall, protest rallies took place in 20 Russian cities. The second peak is December 24, 2011. That day, up to 120,000 people were protesting in Moscow, on Academic Sakharov Avenue. Besides Moscow, protests also took place in Saint Petersburg and in other 24 cities all over Russia. Overall, approximately 150,000 protesters came to the streets that day. The third peak is February 4, 2012, when one of the largest rallies against rigged results of the election meeting "For Fair Elections!" took place—it was a rally through Yakimanka Street with a meeting at Bolotnaya Square in Moscow. According to different estimates, this meeting collected up to 120,000 participants. The fourth peak of protest activity is May 6, 2012. That day the march against Vladimir Putin's third term inauguration took place. According to organizers, 120,000 protesters came to the streets. September 21, 2014, is the fifth peak. It was a *March for Peace*,

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N. Belyaeva et al. (eds.), *Protest Publics*, Societies and Political Orders in Transition,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5_14

which took place in Moscow and gathered up to 100,000 protesters against the war with Ukraine and Russia's aggressive foreign policy. The sixth peak was defined by the murder of oppositional politician, former vice prime minister, deputy of Yaroslavl Regional Duma, Boris Nemtsov. He was killed on the Bolshoy Kamenny Bridge, near the Kremlin on February 27, 2015. As society was shocked, on March 1, 2015, up to 100,000 protesters came to the rally from Kitaygorodsky Proezd through Bolshoy Kamenny Bridge in his memory and against Vladimir Putin's political regime. The seventh and eighth peaks took place in 2017 and were connected with activity of oppositional to current regime politician Alexei Navalny. His Anti-Corruption Foundation had released a movie about Russian Prime Minister Dmitry Medvedev's corrupt activity. The protest rallies took place on March 26 and June 12 and gathered up to 92,000 and up to 98,000 people, respectively. One important feature of anticorruption protests was their coverage: in the first case, protest actions took place in 80 Russian towns and cities, while in the second case, protests covered 154 towns and cities all across the country.

As for Hong Kong, which is a very specific part of China with some privileges with regard to citizens' freedoms and political rights, there have been several waves of protest actions since 2011. The first one was the so-called Chinese Jasmine Revolution, which was triggered by an anonymous online call and consisted of prodemocratic demonstrations and public meetings since February 20, 2011, and continued until March 20, 2011, in different cities across China, including Beijing, Shanghai, and Hong Kong. Another example is the Occupy Central movement, which took place in the central business district of Hong Kong from October 15, 2011, till September 11, 2012. This movement, inspired by Occupy Wall Street in the USA, was one of the longest-running occupations. In 2012, Hong Kong students organized a group called *Scholarism* in order to express their protest against the introduction of patriotic, pro-communist education in Hong Kong public schools. One of the largest-scale examples of protests was the so-called Umbrella Revolution (also known as "Occupy Central with Love and Peace") in Hong Kong, which took place from September 22 to December 11, 2014. These prodemocratic protests were triggered by the decision of the Standing Committee of the National People's Congress, suggesting an electoral reform limiting Hong Kong's autonomy from Mainland China. The point was that central government in Beijing would be entitled to authorize candidates for Hong Kong elections, so that, without their permission, it would not be possible to register as a candidate. Students and other citizens from Hong Kong were conducting a civil disobedience campaign against this reform. As for Hong Kong, in terms of numbers, the Jasmine Revolution has not managed to gather a large number of participants, but it has still shown sustainability, longevity, and scale. Several hundreds of protesters came to the streets during 3 years in Hong Kong. Occupy Central was also not a massive movement, but it lasted 10 months with hundreds of protesters. Scholarization protests against patriotic education in September 2012 gathered more than 120,000 protesters who occupied the government headquarters of Hong Kong. The peak of the protest activity in Hong Kong was reached during the Umbrella Revolution on September 30, 2014, when more than 200,000 protesters came out to the streets 2 days after police dispersed pepper spray

against peaceful demonstrators. Summing up, we can observe that there are examples of mass, multi-thousands protests in Hong Kong, but there are also examples of long protest actions that lasted for months, even though they did not attract many participants.

In Turkey, mass protests that started as an environmental action in defense of Gezi Park took place in May to August 2013. A wave of demonstrations in Turkey began on May 28, 2013, initially against the urban development plan, which included construction of a new shopping center in the center of Istanbul, where Taksim Gezi Park is located. At that day, about 50 environmentalists camped out in Gezi Park in order to prevent its destruction. In the morning of June 1, the government blocked the passage from the Asian side of Istanbul to the European one, where Taksim Square is located, and dispersed the protesters with abuse of excessive force. It was a trigger for the mass protests, which immediately spread on other Turkish cities such as Izmir, Ankara, and Antalya. A new wave of protests came up in 2017 with the Justice March, which was organized as a response to massive repressive reactions of Turkish authorities to the attempt of coup d'état in 2016. In terms of participants, for Turkey, we can identify three peaks of protest activity. The first one is May 31, 2013, when approximately 10,000 protesters gathered on the Taksim Square. They were violently cracked down by police special forces. Many protesters were injured or arrested. The brutal reaction of the state triggered a new wave of protests, which covered not only Istanbul but also other large cities such as Izmir and Ankara as well as more than 60 cities all around Turkey. The biggest protest action took place on June 16, 2013, when 30,000 took to the streets. The last peak of protest activity in Turkey was June 30, 2013. Overall, more than two million protesters participated in protests.

2 Character and Dynamics of Protests in All Three Countries: Revival of Protests in Conditions of Raising Authoritarianism

In Russia, 2011–2012 protests started in Moscow and Saint Petersburg, but shortly after, they spread across other cities. Overall, from December 2011 to February 2012, protests took place in 24 cities. Further protests were concentrated mostly in major big cities like Moscow, Saint Petersburg, and Novosibirsk. However, the protests expanded geographically in March 2017, when after the call of oppositional politician Alexei Navalny, tens of thousands of protesters came out to the streets of 82 cities against corruption. On June 12, 2017, people in 154 cities all over the country protested against the current political regime. Thus, we can see that since 2011, the core of protest activities is located in Moscow and few big cities, while protest agenda spreads across the country.

In Hong Kong, protests were inspired by increased presence of China's central government in the political life of the city. Hong Kong was formerly a colony of the

British Empire, since the forced cession of Hong Kong Island from Qing China at the end of the First Opium War in 1842. Originally, it was not a highly populated area with several farming and fishing villages, but in consistence of the British Empire, due to its advantageous location and large investments, the city has become one of the largest financial centers and trade hubs in the world. Hong Kong remained under British control until 1997, when, according to the rules of the lease agreement between these two states, it was returned to China. It is important to note that as a special administrative region, Hong Kong maintains a separate political and economic system and enjoys rights and freedoms which do not exist in Mainland China.

Turkish protests started in Istanbul, rapidly covered other big cities like Izmir and Ankara, and consequently spread across the country, including medium and small cities. The 2017 March of Justice was conducted as a long march from Ankara to Istanbul and included many rallies in other cities. Summing up, we can observe that geographically, protests in these countries covered all major cities and further spread across the countries.

The agenda of the Russian protests in 2011–2012 was devoted to electoral fraud and rigged parliamentary elections. The main demands were "We demand reelection," "My voice has been stolen," "Let's return the choice to the country," "I do not believe to Churov,[1]" "Churov resign," and "We are for fair elections." Moreover, protests targeted Vladimir Putin's political regime with such slogans as "Russia without Putin," "Putin out," and "Putin is a thief." In 2014 the main demands were about war with Ukraine and Crimea annexation, such as "Bring Russian troops back home" and "For Russia and Ukraine without Putin." The protests of 2015 were triggered by the murder of Boris Nemtsov. The main demands were to conduct a thorough investigation of Nemtsov's murder, to bring those who had ordered the murder to justice, to free political prisoners, and to conduct political system reforms. As for 2017, agenda of these protests was focused on fight against corruption in Russian government but also against cronies, unaccountability of public servants, and current political regime. Thus, we can observe that protests did not target local problems but the defects of the whole political system.

In Hong Kong, demands were mostly concentrated on prodemocratic slogans and resistance to slow and steady spread of Mainland China's control over political institutions in the city. Moreover, protesters also raised issues on the necessity of democratic reforms in China. Organizers and protester of Jasmine Revolution urged China to make reforms or changes, to respect human rights and fairness, and to change the Constitution and demanded "the government and officials to accept the supervision of ordinary Chinese people" and "an independent judiciary." As for the Umbrella Revolution, the main demands were resignation of Chief Executive Leung Chun-ying, withdrawal of the NPC Standing Committee's decision, universal suffrage, and submission of a new electoral reform plan. And basically, the protest campaign aimed to save Hong Kong's right to run their own affairs under the "one country, two systems" model promised by China.

[1]Head of Central Electoral Commission of Russian Federation.

Turkish protests took place under the following demands: "Everywhere Taksim, everywhere resistance"; "Down with some of the things"; "It's full of petit bourgeoisie, here!"; "Tayyip: Connecting People"[2]; "Everyday I'm chapulling"[3]; "Help, police!"; "No Recep, no cry"; and "Winter is coming, Tayyip." Among demands, which united protestors, experts mentioned protecting Gezi Park and the public places, defending freedom of speech and right to assembly (to allow demonstration on squares, as it is banned to organize street actions, demonstrations on big squares as Kızılay in Ankara), banning the usage of tear gas by state forces against protesters, resignation of Erdogan's government, free media, fair elections, and the removal of the 10% threshold on elections.

When it comes to responsiveness, all abovementioned protests drew, in one way or another, reaction of the state, mostly through different legislative and political restrictions. They were realized mainly in the following spheres: freedom of assembly, freedom of media and speech, freedom of the Internet, and independent NGOs. Several weeks after Putin's inauguration, on June 8, 2012, the amendments to Administrative Offences Code of the Russian Federation were adopted. They increased fines for participation in unauthorized demonstrations from 5000 rubles to 300,000 rubles. In 2014, the freedom of assembly was restricted by amendments to the Criminal Code of Russian Federation. The Article 212 devoted to punishment for mass riots had been updated and included the Article 212.1, which reads "Repeated violation of the established procedure for organizing or holding a meeting, rally, demonstration, procession or picketing." The new article made legal double punishment for one single crime, which is basically unconstitutional. The restrictions also targeted independent channels of information, including independent media and the Internet. As protests were organized via the Internet as an alternative channel of mass communication, which was not under control of the state, shortly after the protests, it became a target in the process of restrictions (Volkov 2012). Using the notorious term of extremism, in 2013, the Bill on Extrajudicial Blocking of Websites was signed into Federal Law №. 398 and entered into force in February 2014. This law allows Roskomnadzor (Russian Agency for Control in Sphere of Telecom, Information Technologies and Mass Communications) to immediately block sites on the order of the General Prosecution Office without warrant of the court. As for independent media, in 2014 the share of foreign participation in Russian media was limited by 20%. Along with other measures, it led to a consequent decrease in freedom of press.

Another point was the struggle against NGOs, many of which were involved in monitoring of the elections as well as in defense of human rights activities. The authorities took legislative measures against them as well. On June 29, 2012, State Duma adopted amendments to the "Law on Non-Profit Organizations." In these amendments, the term "foreign agent" was introduced in line with the traditions of

[2]Reference to Recep Tayyip Erdogan.

[3]Neologism originating in the Gezi Park protests, coined from Prime Minister Erdogan's use of the term *çapulcu* (roughly translated as "marauders") to describe the protestors.

the Cold War era. According to these amendments, nonprofit organizations, which were engaged in political activities (through organization or founding of political actions in order to have an impact on state policies) and were financed from abroad, were now called "foreign agents." In practice, this term is interpreted as "an organization which has an impact on the political situation of the country." The same goal was pursued with the introduction of Federal Law on Undesirable Organizations. According to this law, any organization activity could be stopped once it is considered to be "undesirable."

We can see that the Chinese Government was sensitive to protests. Their reaction was expressed in the form of arrests, freedom crackdowns, increased control over the Internet, and tight control over students to prevent their participation in protests. They also forced major Internet search engines to block various words such as Egypt and Jasmine in order to prevent the protest agendas from spreading. Moreover, the Chinese Government issued a ban on sale of jasmine flowers. In the case of Umbrella Revolution, the government's reaction was also restrictive and was based on censorship. They were blocking any information about Hong Kong protests from the Internet. Moreover, messengers and web resources such as Weixin [WeChat], Facebook Messenger, and Instagram were blocked in major Chinese cities.

Summing up, we can conclude that 2011–2017 protests were significant enough to attract serious attention from the side of authorities. It was the first time since the early 1990s that street actions attracted so many people in Moscow and other cities. People all over Russia started to come out to the street to express their positions and opposing views. Reaction of authorities was highly repressive with restrictive legislation amendments, arrests, and other restrictions. In Hong Kong, we can observe sustainable protests with clear prodemocratic attitudes. In both cases of Hong Kong protests, they were numerous and relatively successful. Protests addressed the distrust to the Chinese authorities and dissatisfaction with the authoritarian regime. The reaction of Chinese authorities was also restrictive. In Mainland China, protesters were cracked down and activists were arrested. In Hong Kong, police tried to disperse protesters with tear gas and by other means. As for Turkey, Gezi protests were sustainable and numerous and covered a big number of cities all over the country. The March of Justice in 2017 attracted tens of thousands of protesters and touched a lot of cities, including major ones such as Istanbul and Ankara. Protesters' demands were focused against political regime and its repressive politics. Also in the cases of Russia and China, the authorities' reaction was repressive and expressed in multiple arrests and restriction of civil liberties and freedoms.

Thus, in Russia, Hong Kong, and Turkey, protests were numerous and sustainable and gathered tens of thousands of protesters, which is significant for these countries. Protests were caused by unchangeability of power and restrictions of freedoms and civil rights. Demands were devoted to political regimes' systemic problems and demands for political changes. In all cases, we can observe a massive reaction from the state, which was mostly repressive. Thus, in these cases, protests played a significant role in the process of political change.

3 Political Changes and Post-Protest Environment in Russia, Turkey, and Hong Kong

Russia stands out among these three cases by the fact that some of the demands of the protesters were officially met. According to one of the experts that we interviewed, Denis Volkov, sociologist from Levada Center, protests led to the strengthening of authoritarian tendencies in Russian policy. The parliament introduced a number of laws aimed at strengthening of control over independent actions. Nevertheless, authorities, to some extent, made some steps to satisfy protests' demands. On December 22, President Dmitry Medvedev commented on the protests in his annual address to the Federal Assembly of the Russian Federation: "I hear those who talk about the need for change, and understand them." The President said that he proposed "a comprehensive reform of our political system," which included transition to the election of regional governors by direct vote of the inhabitants of the regions, the introduction of a simplified procedure for registration of political parties, removal of the need to collect signatures for elections to the State Duma and regional legislatures, reduction of the number of signatures required to participate in the presidential elections, etc.

According to political scientist Irina Soboleva,[4] "From the formal point of view, government has made concessions. The ruling elite constantly put emphasis on the fact that the laws that meet the requirements of the protesters were taken. But if we consider each 'liberal' law, it will be obvious that these laws, on the contrary, were to 'tighten the screws' if we consider the political system as a whole, and there was strengthening of authoritarian tendencies." Freedom House assessment of political rights in Russia proves Irina Soboleva's statement as the rate declined from 5.5 in 2011 to 6 in 2012 and put Russia into the category "not free" (Freedom in the World. Russia 2015).

Political change, policy change, and institutional change that took place in Russia, Hong Kong, and Turkey are mostly connected with authorities' repressive reactions. In Turkey, political changes were connected with the fall of Erdoğan's international image due to corruption scandals and strengthening of power of ruling elites and Erdoğan in person because of a range of legislative acts that was adopted after the protests (Acemoglu and Ucer 2015). The Chinese Government considered protests as illegal activities and violation of law. By state media, it was estimated as a revolution made with the support of Western countries. The following political changes took place in Russia after the December protests of 2011: strengthening of power of Vladimir Putin and the ruling party, a number of prosecutions against journalists, and opposition leaders and participants of protests. As for support of government and president, on the president elections in March 2012, Vladimir Putin won 63.6% of votes with a decrease of 8% compared to elections in 2004. As for the support rate for Vladimir Putin, in December 2011, 63% of respondents supported

[4]Irina Soboleva is a PhD in political science.

him, which is the minimum rate for the whole period of research. During 2012, the rate was fluctuating between 63% and 67%. At the beginning of 2014, the rate grew rapidly and reached 82% in April 2014 (Assesment of Situation in the Coutry, 2015). Forty-four percent of respondents in December 2011 approved the government, while 53% disapproved. After that, government support rate started increasing steadily and reached 53% in May 2012, but in June 2012, it dropped to 46% (Levada Center 2015).

Another political change is the emergence of alternative media and enhancement of civic participation practices in all three countries. For example, in Turkey, most of them were founded on the basis of "park forums" that appeared during the Gezi Park protests. The most influential and successful example of democratic practices was "Öy ve Ötesi" [Vote and Beyond] organization. Civil initiatives such as #OccupyCHP, Oy ve Ötesi, and others prove intention of young people to play an active role in political life (Incenoglu 2014). The Gezi Party was founded as an environmentalist party in October 2013, inspired by summer protests. The Turkish American Gezi Platform (TAGP) is a nonprofit organization founded by an independent group of individuals inspired by Gezi Park protests. The aim of TAGP is to unite and organize the Turkish American community around a set of core values and promote these values through public events, such as seminars, lectures, art exhibits, forums, discussion groups, etc. The United June Movement is inspired by the June uprising of 2013 and founded on the principles of equality, freedom, democracy, solidarity, and socialism.

In Russia, events of May 6, 2012, which served as the impetus for the emergence of the camp at Chistye Prudy, led to the emergence and renewal of a number of human rights initiatives. The "OVD-Info" arose as a reaction to the need to keep track of the exact number and the names of people detained by the police during mass celebrations in May. For a couple of years, its site became one of the most authoritative sources of information about detentions on protest promotions. The "RosUznik" project aimed at providing free legal information appeared before the described events but started operating more effectively afterward. 6 May Committee was created to help prisoners of Bolotnaya and their families (Uldanov 2016).

It is a significant fact that such local initiatives appeared in major Russian cities, independently of each other. Such initiatives exist (or existed until recently) at least in 17 of the 125 areas in Moscow. In the Moscow region, there are around nine of these initiatives—four in Saint Petersburg and six in the Leningrad region (Zhuravlev et al. 2014).

Policy changes are quite similar in all three countries: substantial changes in the media policy, censorship, limitations of fundamental rights and freedoms, and restrictions in the Internet. The rate of laws and regulations that influence media content and legal environment in Turkey is 21 in 2013 (against 22 in 2012). Political pressure and control on media content also worsened from 22 (2013) to 24 (2013). Freedom of press significantly dropped from 56 in 2012 to 62 in 2013, and Turkey entered into the category "not free." The rate of freedom on the Internet declined for 46 in 2012 to 49 in 2013 (Freedom on the Net Turkey 2013).

Several steps on tightening of legislation in the media field, Internet and electronic payments, activities and funding of NGOs, holding rallies, actions of volunteers and independent observers, the laws on libel, insulting the feelings of believers, propaganda of homosexuals, etc. had been taken in Russia. On June 9, 2012, a law on rallies entered into force, toughening penalties for violations of the rules of protest actions. On July 13, 2012, the State Duma adopted amendments to the "Law on Non-Profit Organizations." In accordance with this law, several Russian nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) received the status of foreign agent, which put serious limitations on their funding possibilities and stigmatized their image in the eyes of the general public.

According to the Freedom House, in 2012, the Internet in Russia has ranked 31st out of 60 countries in terms of freedom of speech and entered into the category of "partly free" (Freedom in the World. Russia, 2015). The level of political pressure and control over media worsened and reached the rate of 32 in 2012. The suppression of all kinds of independent initiatives was launched. The judicial prepetition of political opponents of the regime started: trials on participants of the protests on May 6, girls from the Pussy Riot group, Alexei Navalny and Sergei Udaltsov, Taisiya Osipova, and so on. According to BTI Political Transformation Index, the level of stability of democratic institutions in Russia regressed from 5.5 in 2008 to 2.5 in 2014 (The Worldwide Governance Indicators (WGI) Project 2015). The rate of civil liberties dropped from 4.71 in 2011 to 3.53 in 2015. The Economist Intelligence Index of Democracy declined from 3.92 in 2011 to 3.39 in 2015 and posed Russia as a country with an authoritarian regime (Democracy Index 2012 2012).

Chinese Government issued a censorship directive to delete all information about Hong Kong protests from different websites. The Main players on Chinese telecom market, China Mobile and the Chinese Unicom, blocked the word "jasmine" in almost all search engines. At the same time, searches for "jasmine" have been also blocked on the biggest microblog service in China; Sina Weibo and status updates with this word on the Chinese social network website, Renren, have met error messages and a warning to refrain from publishing "political, sensitive... or other inappropriate contents." On February 25, the police contacted several foreign journalists and told that they could not conduct interviews with participants of the protests without government's permission. On May 10, 2011, *New York Times* reported that the police of Beijing has forbidden sale of jasmine flowers in various flower markets, forcing wholesale prices to collapse. Some sellers declared that the police of Beijing wanted written guarantees that no jasmine flowers would be sold in their booths.

According to Polity IV index and the Economist Intelligence Unit, the political regime in China is highly authoritarian, and it is the most consolidated authoritarian regime among China, Russia, and Turkey group of countries. Polity IV index evaluates China with −7, while −10 is strongly autocratic. This ranking remained stable during the 2010–2016 period. This assessment is also proven by the Economist Intelligent Unit, which scored China as an authoritarian regime for these years.

The level of political rights, according to Freedom House, remained constantly low: it scored 7/7 (where 7 is the least free). The situation is similar with civil liberties, which was estimated by Freedom House as on the least free level (6/7, where 7 is not free). Freedom House index shows us the negative dynamic with the level of freedom indicator from 83/100 (where 100 is the least free) in 2011 to 88/100 in 2016. Freedom of net in China was declining from 83 out of 100 (where 100 means least free) in 2010 to 88 out of 100 in 2016. The level of net freedom was declining before, during, and after protests. The freedom of press remained consistently restricted.

Significant institutional changes took place only in Turkey, while political regimes in Russia and China have not been changed. As for the institutional changes in Turkey, taking into account Erdoğan's influence, we may make a conclusion that Turkey in fact is changing its form of governance from parliamentary to presidential republic. Another institutional change that was also caused by a range of legislative acts is the limitation of civil liberties. Later in April 2017, the parliamentary system was changed into a presidential system by the constitutional referendum. Many elements in this constitutional reform package increased concerns in Europe regarding democracy and separation of powers.

International indexes, such as Freedom House, reflect all the above mentioned changes. The rate of civil liberties declined from 3 in 2012 to 4 in 2013. According to BTI Political Transformation Index, Turkey's democracy status declined from 7.65 in 2011 to 7.55 in 2014 (Transformation Index BTI 2016 2016). Economists' Index of Democracy declined from 5.76 in 2012 to 5.12 in 2014. The rate of civil liberties significantly declined to 2.94 in 2015 from 4.12 in 2012, reaching 3.82 in 2013 and 3.53 in 2014. The rate of electoral processes and pluralism and the rate of functioning of the government also declined from 7.92 in 2012 to 6.67 in 2014 and from 6.79 in 2012 to 5.36 in 2014, respectively (The Economist Intelligence Unit 2017).

Summing up, we can conclude that political changes that occurred in Turkey, Russia, and Hong Kong were mostly connected with authorities' repressive reactions such as censorship, adoption of laws, limiting freedoms of assembly, and freedom of speech. Protest publics' activities in authoritarian environments usually led to opposition's crackdown and further limitation of civil liberties. The abovementioned political changes let us reach the conclusion that protest publics' activities did not cause substantial liberal or democratic changes in these countries but, on the contrary, became the trigger of strengthening authoritarian tendencies. Nevertheless, right after the protests, a number of civil society organizations or, as we also can call them, local movements had appeared.

4 Factors of Change: From Protest Revival to Forced Innovation

To reveal which factors may lead to appearance of political changes in Hong Kong (and partially in Mainland China), Turkey, and Russia, we analyzed the following group of factors: economic, political, social, and cultural. All the data used her were taken from electronic databases of the Economist Intelligence Unit, Polity IV, World Bank, and World Values Survey.

As for economic factors, all selected countries were damaged by world economic crisis in 2008–2009. The GDP per capita growth was consistently declining in China (from 10.1% in 2010 to 6.37% in 2015) and was more drastically declining in Russia (from 4.46% in 2010 to −3.93% in 2015). Turkey's GDP per capita growth rate was declining since 2010 till 2012 (from 7.57% to 0.31%) but then started to increase till 2013 (2.31%), and then, in 2014, it was declining to 1.29%, but in 2015 the growth rate increased to 2.46%. Thus, only Russia experienced a negative GDP per capita growth rate. GDP per capita was gradually growing only in China: from USD4560 in 2010 to USD8027 in 2015. In Russia, it was growing from 2010 to 2013 from USD10,674 to USD15,552 and then was declining to USD9092 in 2015. Turkey has a similar situation: its GDP per capita was slightly growing from 2010 (USD10,111) till 2013 (USD10,800) and then fell to 9125 in 2015, but both falls happened mostly because of the drop of national currencies' rate to dollar and therefore do not reflect the real economic situation. At the same time, Hong Kong almost did not suffer from the world economic crisis, and its economy sustainably grew since 2010 with an annual rate of 3–5%. This city is a big finance and transport center of Southeast Asia and has the highest degree of economic freedom in the world since the inception of the index in 1995.

Unemployment rate was quite stable in all three countries. During the 2010–2015 period, it declined in Russia from 7.3 to 5.72 with youth unemployment 15% on average. In Turkey, it increases from 8.57 to 8.85, and then, in 2015, it declined to 7.67. But in the meanwhile, the youth unemployment rate was considerably higher, and during the period of 2010–2013, it was between 15% and 20% on average. In China, it was slightly growing from 4.2 to 4.7. Although the overall unemployment rate in Hong Kong remained steady at about 3.3%, the unemployment rate for residents aged 15–24 was at a much higher rate of 9.4%.

When it comes to inflation, it was changing its direction during the 2010–2015 period in all three countries. In Russia, it started with 6.8% (2010) and then reached 8.4% (2011). In 2012, inflation in Russia declined to 5.07%. But, since 2013, it was drastically growing, reaching 6.77% in 2013, 7.81% in 2014, and finally 15.52% in 2015. As for Turkey, the inflation rate was changing its direction during the given period: it was declining from 8.56% (2010) to 6.47% (2011), then was growing to 8.89% (2012), and then was quite stable between 7.49% (2013) and 7.67% (2015). There was a relatively stable situation regarding the inflation rate in China: it was growing during the 2010–2011 period from 3.31% to 5.41%, but since 2011, it started consistently declining and reached 1.44% in 2015.

In terms of inequality, Russia and Turkey showed negative dynamics during the given period, while the inequality issue was improving in China. According to the Gini index (measure of the deviation in income distribution, where 0 is absolute equality and 100 is absolute inequality), in China, it was slightly going down from 42.8 (2010) to 42.2 (2012) but rising up in Hong Kong to 53.9 in 2017. In the meantime, in Russia, it was gradually growing from 40.94 (2010) to 41.59 (2012). As for Turkey, there was the most significant growth of inequality: from 38.79 (2010) to 40.18 (2013). Thus, we can observe the similarities in inequality dynamics of Russia and Turkey, while in China the inequality was high and stable. Accordingly, we can observe several common features concerning economy in all three countries: instability in economic development, high level of economic inequality, and lack of opportunities for young people.

As for political factors, we can observe the significant increase of participation in boycotts and peaceful demonstrations in all countries, while the level of interest in politics is relatively low. Active membership in political parties was decreasing in China and Russia (6.4–1.5%, 0.8–0.5%, respectively), while in Turkey, there is a slight increase from 2.3% to 2.4%, but generally the level of membership is quite low. When it comes to social factors, in all three countries, we can observe the increase in the level of trust: from 9.9 to 10.9 in China, from 13.5 to 20.4 in Russia, and from 14.5 to 21.9 in Turkey. General satisfaction with life was decreasing in all three countries: from 45.1 to 42.8 in China, from 32.3 to 29.6 in Russia, and from 56.9 to 51.5 in Turkey. As for demographic factors, we can observe consistent increase of human development level as well as literacy and the number of PC users.

Summing up, while in Russia and Turkey there is a strong dissatisfaction with the economic situation and perspectives for the future, citizens in Hong Kong care much more about political interventions from the Mainland China and are interested in conservation on the current "one country-two systems" scheme. Political systems of these countries do not respond to the interests of a significant amount of the population; that is why they do not participate in formal political organizations but more and more often use peaceful protests in order to express their opinion.

5 "Protest Public" in Russia, Hong Kong, and Turkey as an Actor of Change

Protesters in Russia, Hong Kong, and Turkey can be considered as actors of political changes in these countries. By reconstructing the "troubling message"; exploring the process of the public self-organization; identifying the public spaces, where the unique discourse of this public is being produced; assessing the intensiveness and regularity of discourse exchange and circulation; and evaluating the creativity and attractiveness of the poetic message of the alternative world this public is creating and representing, we are going to prove that we are dealing with protest publics in Turkey, Russia, and Hong Kong.

The "troubling message" (initial reason of the public assembling in Turkey) was connected to police violence and dissemination of peaceful demonstration against the reconstruction of Gezi Park. As a result, acts of violence committed by police became one of the crucial factors that made it possible to gather a great amount of people on the streets. As far as Russia is concerned, reconstructing the "troubling message" was focused on electoral frauds and election results, which cause a wave of discontent and anger. Moreover, results of the election called into question the principle of changing power through elections. According to our expert Irina Soboleva from Columbia University in the City of New York, the trigger of protests in Russia was falsification of the election results. Her colleague, Denis Volkov from Levada Center, also considers election fraud as a key event that led to mass protests in Russia in 2011. In Hong Kong, the protests began once the Standing Committee of the National People's Congress (NPCSC) issued a decision regarding proposed reforms to the Hong Kong electoral system. The decision was widely seen to be highly restrictive and tantamount to the Chinese Communist Party (CCP)'s pre-screening of the candidates for the leader of Hong Kong.

The next step is "to explore this public self-organization." Relying on results of expert interviews and electronic resources, we could say that Turkish protest public was autonomous and quite well self-organized. According to the expert Can Irmak Ozinanır, "On the one hand, protests public definitely was not consolidated. It was a chaotic thing. There were many different groups with different values and without one leader. Moreover, some of these groups consider each other as enemies. But on the other hand, even if LGBT, anti-capitalists, Muslims, socialists, anarchists, vegans have different political approach, many different parts of the activists, being able to fight together, explored ways to communicate with each other as comrades." Another expert, Dr. Altuğ Yalçıntaş (associate professor at Ankara University), is sure that in the absence of an organizing party or an individual to make decisions and give orders to the masses of demonstrators about what they should do, the protesters spontaneously created higher levels of order in which politics has now become impossible without calculating the possible unintended consequences of the absurd and bizarre nature of political rhetoric. In short, Gezi protestors were able to create an art space for themselves in which both individually and collectively, they expressed political messages in novel ways.

His colleague from Economic Policy Research Foundation, Dilara Peker, agrees with him: "As everybody knows, the values of leftist, nationalists, LGBTI people, women, handicapped etc. are all very different from each other. The main reason they were in the field all together was to overthrow AKP government."

As for the protest publics' self-organization in Russia, it managed to organize itself for a quite short period of time. According to some sources, for less than a week, the number of participants grew from 10,000 to 150,000 people. This public organized itself without any participation of state structures or civil society organizations. Moreover, according to expert Oleg Zhuravlev, "paradoxically, the condition of unity and consolidation of the protest public was its rejection of the political and ideological self-determination. People wanted the different fractions of the protests to stay together, because in this they saw the strength of the protest."

As for the public spaces, these are where the unique discourse of this public is being produced and where this public shares their views and discusses plans for future events; on the one hand, we consider them to be limited in all three countries, as the issue of protests was sensitive and there were few opportunities to organize some public discussion through media. In Turkey, the government took quite violent and severe measures against protests (Anufriev and Zaytsev 2016). Erdoğan took a tough line on the protests, branding the demonstrators as "extremists" and "looters." He said the unrest was being encouraged by foreign forces to undermine Turkey and its economy. Erdogan gave a number of speeches condemning protests: "Whatever you do, we've made our decision and we will implement it" and "Where they gather 20, I will get up and gather 200,000 people. Where they gather 100,000, I will bring together one million from my party." But on the other hand, in the unique case of Turkey, "park forums" became an important public space where protesters share their thoughts and discuss further steps. The open stage, where individuals queue for and take turns to express their thoughts, ideas, and vision freely, is another element of this movement's repertoire that is becoming more and more common. Moreover, as official media ignored protests, an alternative online media, Çapul TV, was created.

Russian authorities also tried to prevent fast spreading of news about the protests, and opposition had less opportunity to discuss protests and explain their view of the alternative world behind the wide audience. What played an important positive role was media support from the part of "official media, which created and aired a number of public appeals from opinion-makers to join the protests" (Belyaeva and Dzhibladze 2014). Nevertheless, meetings, demonstrations, and "Occupy Abay" and "White Circle" initiatives were public places where protest publics produced and shared their discourse. Protests in China also had some problems with public spaces, because China Mobile, China Unicom, and China's largest microblog, Sina Weibo, blocked the word "jasmine." As the word "jasmine" was forbidden in the Chinese blogosphere, millions of users of the network used the term "two conferences" instead, a widely used expression in the official news that is originally indicating the two conferences of the "Fourth Session of the Eleventh National Congress" and "Fourth Session of the Eleventh CPPCC," which took place in March in Beijing.

Discourse exchange in all of three countries mostly happened only during public meetings themselves, when a great number of participants were creating their own slogans, which expressed their identity, their concerns, their claims to authorities, and their "visions of the future," which were mostly remarkably creative but either individual presentations or manifestations of small issue—group identity and demands (Belyaeva and Dzhibladze 2014).

As for the "poetic message," participants of Gezi Park protests called for respect for the rights in a really creative way. Protesters called themselves *çapulcu* [looters], reappropriating Erdoğan's insult for themselves (and coined the derivative "chapulling," given the meaning of "fighting for your rights"). Many users on Twitter also changed their nickname and used *çapulcu* [looter] instead (Varol et al. 2014). The word quickly caught on, adopted by the demonstrators and online activists, and led to a viral video. Many took the concept further by integrating the unique nature of the demonstrations

and defined it as "acting towards taking the democracy of a nation to the next step by reminding governments of their reason for existence in a peaceful and humorous manner."

Protest public was quite creative in Russia and managed to organize a number of actions, which aimed to represent the poetic message of the alternative world. We consider "White Ring" action being the unique action, when thousands of people with white ribbons and other white objects joined hands around the Boulevard Ring in Moscow manifesting for fair elections. It was rather a flash mob than a protest action, and participants had no need to coordinate the action with authorities.

In the case of Hong Kong, different protest actions were united around the idea of respect for human rights, civil liberties, and democracy—three main topics that Beijing tried to restrict in the city. In the case of the Umbrella Revolution, it gathered up to 200,000 independent and creative protesters protesting against Beijing political regime.

Protests in Russia, Turkey, and Hong Kong should be considered as a new social phenomenon and a new political actor. Gezi Park protest public, the Umbrella Revolution protestors, and protest public in Russia were well-organized, clearly independent from the influence of the government and other actors, and quite creative. They also managed to create more or less of a common identity and develop enough public spaces to produce and reproduce common discourse and ways to approach it.

6 Conclusion

Protests of 2011–2017 were an important part of the process of new political landscape creation in all three countries. With growing attention to reduction of democracy level, freedom of speech, freedom of assembly, and raising authoritarianism, citizens tried to formulate their own discourse of change to be visible in the public sphere. Their message and attitude forced governments of their countries to respond with more restrictions and repressions. In all three countries, these protests were unprecedented in terms of longevity, sustainability, and number of participants. Russia, Turkey, and China are characterized as authoritarian countries; protests there mostly targeted the political issues: lack of representation, poor accountability of authorities, restrictions of civil liberties, and one leader/party political domination. In Russia, it was triggered by electoral fraud, in Turkey by the reconstruction of Gezi Park in Istanbul, and in Hong Kong by restrictive electoral reform and multiple violations of human rights.

We can observe that authorities' reaction in all three cases was highly repressive: expressed in new restrictive legislation, ban of opposite political organizations and criminal cases against their leaders, and arrests as well as excessive use of force toward protesters. It seems that despite the fact that protests under rising authoritarianism did not generate visible democratic changes and moreover became the reason of further freedom limitations and straightening of authoritarian tendencies, even in

such a hostile environment, citizens are still able to form a "protest public" and invent alternative ways of dealing with newly emerged sociopolitical issues. "Protest publics" in these countries represented themselves as independent, sustainable political actors with a high level of self-organization. Such publics were able to create a common identity and discourse. Moreover, with the help of social media, they developed specific channels of communication to produce and reproduce common discourse. In conditions of growing political pressure, we can observe in all three cases that protests led to a significant rise of civil initiatives, creation of political networks, and emerging of multiple local movements.

As a response to authorities' restrictions, "protest publics" in Russia, Turkey, and Hong Kong create a new, independent from the state, set of democratic practices expressed in the creation of new models of self-organization through social media, emerging of independent institutions of judicial and nonjudicial human rights protection, development of new channels of information, and creation of independent media. Many of these practices are organized and founded by the "protest public" itself through fundraising and crowdfunding mechanisms. Therefore, we can clearly observe the democratic innovations—alternative independent practices which involve thousands of people. These practices are based on creative forms of public participation, and it is the way how "protest public" could enhance attitudes toward a process of political change under rising authoritarianism.

Funding The chapter was prepared within the framework of the Academic Fund Program at the National Research University Higher School of Economics (HSE) in 2016–2017 (grant № 17-05-0018) and by the Russian Academic Excellence Project "5-100."

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The Transforming Role of Protest Publics in Processes of Sociopolitical Change in the Global South and Southern Europe: From Occasional Challengers to Institutionalized Watchdogs



Sanjay Kumar Rajhans

In the best-selling pamphlet *Time for Outrage!* (*Indignez-Vous!*, sold 4.5 million copies and translated into more than 15 languages), Stephane Hessel sums up the mood of the multitudes of millions by saying "History's direction is toward more justice and more freedom—though not the unbridled freedom of the fox in a henhouse." The societal strain in the entirety of the Southern Europe in the past decade that has witnessed long recession closely followed by the migrants crisis and the major Greek crisis of 2015, an ambitious referendum getting botched in 2017 and finally the Italian electoral earthquake of the year 2018. Coupled with the massive secessionist movement in Spain has brought over this period the attitudinal changes bringing forth in the spotlight for the protesters' questions such as a demand for the new picture of redistribution and inequality. This goes along that to what extent have the experiences of this period altered elite attitudes on key issues including institutional change demanding to know how significant are the shifts in public opinion? Has Southern Europe become a region of dissatisfied citizens?

This chapter does make an effort to observe and check whether sociopolitical changes in this large and very diverse sociopolitical landscape (Global South, European South) could be examined and explained through a model, where protesting publics have transformed themselves from the occasional challengers of status quo to institutionalized "watchdogs." While on the class debate the new politicization and antagonistic characteristics are identified in the various social groups that have featured in discussions about the Global South (cf. Offe 1985; Laclau and Mouffe 2014), in the context of the European South, the troubles of mass unemployment, the changing labor codes, and the resultant exasperation have been discussed at length by scholars like Duarte and Baumgarten (2015), while the strangulating effects of the austerity in the post-financial crisis have been analyzed where people on the streets and

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N. Belyaeva et al. (eds.), *Protest Publics*, Societies and Political Orders in Transition,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5_15

squares also criticized the financial-oriented redistribution of public goods. Taking cue from the existing literature and existing theories on the protest movement, this chapter tries to examine and identify the role of this new political actor for change—protest publics.

This chapter is an attempt to understand whether the bar of the institutionalized changes as outcomes were different in achieving the necessary changes and has the "punctuated tidal wave" of the publics remarkably altered the political embankment with the new political actors and thus both expanded and deepened the participatory element in the political space? In order to answer these questions, I shall describe in brief the stages for finding the answer to the gradual and sudden transformation of the protest publics' role in the economic and political south regions (both in the Global and European ones) from being occasional challengers of status quo to institutionalized watchdogs. I shall make an observation on the two clusters of the protest movements in the Global South (Brazil, India, and South Africa), while the other cluster is from the European South with a relatively less glamorous titling name (PIGS with the names of member countries, viz., Portugal, Italy, Spain, and Greece).

In this introduction, the characteristics of each major protest that took place in both clusters shall be succinctly listed to comprehend the key characteristics of these protests and to examine them against the theory of publics and protest publics and shall thus try to analyze whether those who assembled and participated in the chosen cases do have the similar DNA of the protest publics as explained in the writings of Della Porta, Warner, and Tilly by the spontaneity in the formation, cooperation of the emergent publics in the social-mediated space, thus converging and co-coordinating on the one general meta-agenda (be it anti-corruption issues, better governance, or some other urgent populist policy demand).

In all the six cases in Global South and the European South, the chapter shall examine the unfolding of the protest with the churning of the publics in the mediated space, which, at a later stage, shall be in position to not only articulate the wishes and personify the angst of the invisible multitude of the millions but is also capable of mounting on the tidal waves to hit the shores of the authorities and regimes. This chapter does try to observe this ground swelling of the demand from the publics for the new policy priorities and policy agendas, thus rectifying and customizing the policy processes including the participation of new actors with new policy outputs, in particular the social policy and the welfare provision.

While discussing the actors for change characteristics of this contentious and protesting publics, this chapter shall observe the changing dynamics of this higher mobility, nimbleness, and novelty of it both in their content and substance with the chosen country cases, thus highlighting one of the key features of the publics such as horizontality in organizing and transforming themselves into a movement and generate the necessary tidal waves hitting the shores of the authorities with their demands, thus expressing themselves with an increasing tidal flow coupled with the vitality of the "increasing actorness." Thus, they demand a change point-blank clarity: situational, political, and if possible institutional.

1 Protest Publics: A Horizontal Collective and Virile Actor Demanding Policy Change

This upsurge of social protest in the industrial and postindustrial democracies in the past several years has generated a wide-ranging discussion about its extraterritoriality, novelty, and unpredictability as what was earlier considered a marginal activity that has become distinctive in the political lexis and practice. While in the industrial age and after that the protests were unionized, formal, invariably with the tinge of the class identity or in some cases the ethnic identity issues, the new avatar is quite a different flag in the town that has a poetic message, nimble and un-unionized, and media savvy and proactive and does have a range of different subgroupings that do rally around the meta-demand which gets further strengthened by the party de-alignment of the individuals, demanding a new social contract with the authorities who are constrained by the neo-corporatist economic setup and further undermined by the withdrawal of the state as someone who can't be in the lead for the economic engagement with its citizens to its benefits, thus further undermining the leverage.

A detailed discussion on the distinctive protest communities, protest groups, and protest publics gives the methodological model for analysis of the influence of protest publics on the political changes, which will be used as a basis to extrapolate the Global South and European South clusters and to observe the changing dynamics of the protest movement in such varied geo-economic spaces with surprisingly similar set of actors and factors that distinguish the protest publics as an actor for change. Needless to say, the major division between those approaches is where the "social actorness" is seen: to what extent the public is viewed as an "object of social impact," the "target audience," or it is viewed as capable of, in fact, realizing its own potential as a social actor, playing a central role in social development.

The synthesis of two methodological approaches, actor and institutional, enables to retrace the impact of collective subjects of political process on political changes. As discussed earlier in the book, there are three types of changes: situational changes, policy changes, and institutional changes. Institutional changes include the establishment of "new" institutions and evolution, devolution, or collapse of "old" political institutions. Protest publics, in the current research, will be evaluated as actors of political change too. That means that they can be not only a second plan player but also have enough weight to make political change. Based on the conceptual framework, I shall try to observe and examine the clusters of our inquiry: Global South and European South. Setting the key criteria of protest publics, I shall try to inquire whether the protest publics of these clusters were enabled in the transformation of them from occasional challengers to status quo to the institutional watchdogs.

2 The Invisible Thread and the Collective Bursts of Angst: European South and the Protest Publics

The Southern European countries are bracketed together for quite a while as the Economic South of EU and thus had to be restrained and trained constantly for the fiscal prudence and discipline by their Economic North brethren, and hence in the contextual understanding, it mirrors somewhat with the Global South's governance and fiscal capacity that is being trained and disciplined in the general terms by their Global North brethren. Overall, has this period with the emergence of the new actors for changes riding on the tidal wave of public's discontent, angst, and frustrations as the critical factors and the necessary preconditions shaped a more participatory policy formation bordering on the populism, thus bringing more democratic defeats or democratic advances?

In the short span of January to November 2015, two national elections as well as one referendum on austerity measures took place in Greece. In addition, the European Asylum Crisis reached its peak in 2015, and Southern Europe experienced a high influx of refugees at this time. Hence, we are also capable of measuring transnational solidarity's effect on euro-skeptic voting against the backdrop of the Refugee Crisis in an economically weak setting. While some scholarly work does attribute this as the redistribution of anger (Pappas 2014), the protest for the state's withdrawal from the public goods did galvanize the publics around the anti-austerity measures and does question whether collective emotions of anger shape attitudes toward austerity. With the screeching halt of the economic juggernaut in Europe followed by global financial crisis, the popular angst and protest against the overwhelming soft and increasingly darker underbelly of socioeconomic disparity became vocal in the Southern Europe. On the one side, this has led to a growing dissatisfaction with the existing political institutions and a growing demand to fix it by the new political transformation in the Southern Europe, thus challenging hitherto the conventional political hierarchy with the corrosive political corruption, the increasing alienation of the electorate that had been witnessed in the previous decades of the political apathy by the electorates during the political cycle.

This emergence of a well-organized sit-in in the square channeling the demands of the disenchanted that had been doubled down with the forced austerity and coercive politics and policies of the authorities did galvanize this southerners' movement in Europe (Italy, Spain, and Greece). Though quite different in their growth trajectory, these protest publics had the consistent characteristics of the power of summoning of the protest publics. In the case of South Europe, being shattered with the financial crisis and the social discontent boiling over the range of socioeconomic issues (endemic corruption, raising unemployment, and the wreckage of the public goods) did have the scenario ready where they could tune their notes of protest for the common ensemble!

The political landscape in all the three countries is structured not very far from each other. The notable difference can be in the level of autonomy and nationalist aspiration cleavage, as in the case of Spain and to a less extent in Italy, but in the case

of Greece, it is negligible. Yet in all the three countries, the socioeconomic normative cleavage is very strong with a right/left cleavage at the central of the ideational platform both at the national and the sub-national level, which is a point of departure from the other European socioeconomic symbiosis where there is a long tradition of coalitional politics with centrist agenda with a large lead.

Besides, the institutional level of participation is stronger in South Europe at the local level; thus in the protest publics, there is a certain level of maturity by those who have been adept and equipped with the citizenry activism as in the case of the 15M movement (Haro and Sampedro 2011). Finally, there comes the question about the narratives of the South European publics that further wonder about the delicate dance for somewhat seemingly irreconcilable contradiction on the one side the self-professed internationalism and transborder cooperation with the innate resolve to win back national sovereignty on the social policy planning and thus undercutting the integrative EU project. Building upon previous work, the chapter tries to identify the decline of trust in institutions and satisfaction with democracy that was observed in the southern regions (Global and European South) and the efforts of the publics to reclaim the policy formation space through protest thus heralding some long-term consequences with mixed results.

2.1 The Policy of Austerity and the Politics of Protest: Is This All Economy?

The biggest protest in the country in this time period is also aimed against the austerity measures as far as against the decision of the already very powerful troika. Just a decade earlier, the "permissive consensus" term for the EU looks a thing of the past thus confounding EU integration and solidarity being divided into two sides: the fiscal compact states bailing out the states undergoing the austerity measures. This has generated in this disrupted EU project another kind of solidarity: a transnational solidarity in the Southern European debtor protestors that disapprove demands for the shavings and trimmings of the social budget followed by the sudden surge for the national colors defying the integrative process launched from above. This alliance of the transnational solidarity in these weakened economic conditions generated a curious upsurge of the far left and the far right political discourse dragging their respective mainstream national political leadership into the mediated protest platforms. The usurpation of the financial capitalism on the productive capitalism happened just after the great crisis in a major way by the insatiable greed of itself. A set of reforms were announced as usual, but it failed to jump-start the tottering economy that had been hollowed from inside by the dominance of the financial power who had taken advantage of the crisis to gain the overwhelming space in the policy space of the European south.

Bailouts of creditors at the expenses of local economies made the cost of the crisis further unbearable on the society. This structural adjustment made the modification

of the functioning of the power which was subordinated to the power of the financial market leaders. In the guise of the budget and fiscal austerity, a massive hair trimming got started that resulted in the freezing of the pensions and the reduction of the wages for the public employees. While in the economic and political changes in Greece, it is quite easy to understand that the biggest changes since 2010 till 2015 are connected with the austerity measures.

The social and political instability got further exacerbated after the great recession thus resulting into the massive tightening of the belt in all the debt-ridden countries of the European South, generating austerity measures. The comparison between Italy, Greece, Portugal, and Spain takes into account this phenomenon that has stayed for more than a decade. This economic upheaval intertwined with the social instability, a common pattern that one witnesses in the Italian, Spanish, and the Greek party system, substantially failed to channel the discontent at the legislative spaces.

The unprecedented protest led by Indignados brought to the fore in the open this great discontent and frustration of the publics in the European Parliamentary elections of 2014 and the general elections of 2015. Against the symbolic corporatism, liberal inter-governmentalism, and the informal conditionality, the South European states during the 2010–2013 period went through a series of austerity reforms where financial relief was conditional for structural reforms as demanded by the EU. The South European countries have been characterized what we name as "weak corporatism" where trade unions are to exercise their influence through social pacts and general strikes. Besides, a large cut in the funding of the civil society in the Southern Europe occurred in the context of increasing social needs. This has strengthened the cooperation among the citizenry to channel their public dissatisfaction with the representative democracy as a political project going nowhere.

2.2 The Sociopolitical Factor: Withdrawal from the Social Contract of the Welfare State and the Fecklessness of the State Before Market

On the opportune hue and cry of the fiscal discipline, the EU policies were gradually lockstepped with those of the financial elites that have resulted in the unprecedented trimming and austerity on the public expenditure. This has resulted into the freezing of the pensions, reduction of the salaries for the public employees, and the hyper-flexibility in the labor market laws. We can see that these economic disciplines are being "regulated" not only on the periphery of Europe but also on the Asian, African, and Latin American countries. According to Krugman (El Pais, January 31, 2012) and Stiglitz (El Pais, May 13, 2012), among others, the dismantling of the welfare state and the introduction of the neoliberal policies of austerity are going to weaken the European populations for economic stagnation thus bringing an unraveling force to the idea of the EU itself.

The comforted generations of the continental Europe have been most disquiet on the issue of this shrinkage of the public goods and the dismantling of the social support system. It is to be noted that a set of factors like outsourcing, increasing unemployment, and the withdrawal of the state from its various social projects has not consolidated trust for the system among the citizens in both the southern sphere (be it European or Global). Of course, cuts also touched the public sector. Greece promised to reduce 150 thousands of job places for civil servants until 2015. Before 2013, civil service workers were the most protected part of the population. They even could be dismissed. The only case was the ending of existence of the state body. In 2013 the parliament adopted a law, giving an opportunity to fire the workers of the public sector. Biggest cuts were made for the workers close to the pension age. The Euro Barometer's 2015 data further provides the increasingly clear evidence of the impact that economic and political disruptions have held in changing young people's political involvement. Despite frequent bailouts and closer policy supervision and intervention from Brussels, the southern European space witnessed the breakout of the new populist parties on both the strands of the political spectrum. These intervening measures from the EU institutions have further constrained the policy menu of the local mainstream political parties, thus tying their hands with the prescriptive measures suggested by the experts from afar, thus paving the way for new actors who are not hinged/tied acting with the increasing audacity.

2.3 Southern Europe and the Transitions at Different Levels

The great recession in the entirety of Southern Europe in the past decade that has witnessed long recession closely followed by the migrant crisis and the major Greek crisis of 2015, the Italian electoral earthquake of the year 2018, coupled with the massive secessionist movement in Spain has brought over this period the attitudinal changes bringing forth in the spotlight for the protesters questions such as the demand for a new picture of redistribution and inequality. This goes along that to what extent have the experiences of this period altered elite attitudes on key issues including institutional change and European integration? How significant are the shifts in public opinion?

Has Southern Europe become a region of dissatisfied citizens? How extensive are the growth of, e.g., political discontent and euro-skepticism funneled by the protest that duels with all its might the all-powerful pan-European institutions and their lackeys in the form of the national governments? Has social media encouraged or discouraged political participation in the Southern Europe, a new kind of participation that demands the monitoring power in the policy implementation thus gaining the turf of a watchdog? It is in this plethora of questions one observes the new modes of political mobilization and communications where the South European publics have given their best shot to reclaim the agenda setting through circulatory and horizontal citizenry engagement, with innovative organizational skills, thus influencing the

policy outcomes. People on the streets and squares also criticized the financial-oriented redistribution of public goods.

As the region is slowly starting to recover and to put this period of economic turmoil behind (even if it is somewhat unevenly), the timing is right for a more complete evaluation concerning the political effects of the great recession and austerity measures on the protest movement of Southern Europe. The first of these concerns are the types and degrees of party system change in Spain, Italy, and Greece, with an emphasis on patterns of de-alignment and realignment, the emergence of new parties and new dimensions of political competition, as well as changing patterns in interparty dynamics and government formation.

During the years of crisis, public opinion trends in all countries in Southern Europe pointed toward a steep decline of trust in institutions and satisfaction with democracy. In some countries, these indicators have already bounced back (e.g., in Portugal), showing that some of those attitudinal changes were rather ephemeral. Another immediate and midterm effect of this economic and financial crisis in the countries of the Southern Europe and the protest movement that followed with it is the substantial shift in the attitudes toward the European project and the Euro-critical or Euro-skeptic attitude in the old Southern Europe has come to fore. The previous studies have discussed this (Freire et al. 2014; Lee et al. 2014; Serricchio et al. 2013; Braun and Tausendpfund 2014). Besides, one sees that there is also some evidence of a politicization of the EU dimension (Schmitt and Teperoglou 2015). Thus, it is important to observe the emergence or not of a transnational cleavage among the Southern European societies.

3 The Sociocultural Factors and the Protests Across the Boundary: The Diffusion and the Seepage

Citizens in Southern European countries could be expected to favor those forms of political decision-making that do not require substantial involvement from the citizenry. The relatively latter introduction of democratic institutions in the southern Europe has left its mark in their democratic practices with specific behavioral pattern. They are expected to support those social values and institutions that do not require a direct and proactive engagement from the citizenry. After all, the south European citizenship model is characterized by low levels of political trust (Van Deth et al. 2007), low membership in organizations (Morales 2009), and relatively low political interest, low political participations in general.

On the other hand, south Europeans are quite engaged in the protest compared with the other European countries. Spain can be an outstanding case where the representative democracy that came later was labeled as someone that is less participatory and the citizens have a cyclical interest about the policy formation of the state, with the lower voters turn out and lower membership in the social and political organizations. But the protest against the authorities, where the Spaniards

shall have a higher level of participation compared to their peers, a nice point of departure highly emphasized by the 15M movement that had the transborder effect in Greece and beyond, southern Europeans do engage in protest activities more than citizens in the other European countries (Van Deth et al. 2007). Post-materialist societies provide safer contexts for the airing of oppositional views and foster a culture where actors are encouraged to express their grievances directly, if not confrontationally, thus increasing the likelihood of protest.

In all the three countries of our study, the local level of governance has not declined numerically despite the three have been a tendency of recentralization in the past two decades. Italy, with centuries of communal experience, has resisted the power to be dragged from the local institutions. The protest movement, despite having a very organic causality, does get inspired by the external factors, and the external waves influence the internal symbiosis as explained in the multipolar action systems.

As in the very beginning, I did mention Stephane Hessel and his best-selling pamphlet *Indignez-Vous!* that sold 4.5 million copies and translated into more than 15 languages came on the eve of the protest waves that swept the entire south Europe and had in a way channeled the voice of the disenchanted, austerity-laden citizenry that saw themselves being taken for a ride by the regime and the gradual melting down of the public goods on one hand and the piling up of the public debts and growing unemployment on the other hand. Thus the extraterritoriality of the problems provides a stimulation that generates a cross chain of reactions in different contexts. Besides, the content of diffusion that inculcates the issue theme, idea slogan, etc. that is adjusted and adopted by the actors in the recipient state/country is then channeled accordingly. Hence, the diffusion of the protest in south Europe worked both in the content and in the form of styles. A nice example is the close camaraderie of Spanish and Greek protest movements and their mutual admiration.

Tarrow has empirically tested the role of diffusion within the protest cycles. He explains that "protest cycles resemble politics in general in their uneven and irregular diffusion across time and space". He further explains it through the form of the center-to-periphery model, yet the cross-national diffusion of protest takes place through different conditions most notably organizational subculture similarity, similarity in the goals, and an overarching similarity in the general condition of mobilization. We can identify this as a cultural proximity as there is a larger possibility of diffusion of the protest culture in a short geographical space as this enhances the networking, ties and the attributes become further harmonized. As mentioned earlier, a movement imbibes a set of attributes of the other movement or commences a set of actions by being "inspired" by the other movement. In such situations, certain issues pole-vault the political and sovereign borders and generate similar and simultaneous reaction with the capacity of the public and their formative process with strikingly similar characteristics.

Yet the diffusion of the protest is a complicated mix and interplay of the internal and external factors, thus generating resilience at the local level with local issues, agenda, and context that simultaneously adapts the poetic messages and tidal waves from across the sovereign boundaries only when it has the similar situational

preconditions to reinforce the protest publics of their own space. The key elements of the protest waves that seep across the sovereign space have some features as outlined by Sidney Tarrow who describes protest cycles as "periods of generalized disorder" and of "heightened conflicts across the social system", thus having the characteristics of strong expansion and contraction of magnitude, well extended over a larger period of time that covers the large parts of a social space and affects most of the national territory.

4 A Perfect Storm and the Window of Opportunity for the Actors' Emergence: A Case Study of Spain, Italy, and Greece

At the same time witnessed in these protests as in the case of both the Spanish and Greek protest movements and most notably in Italian movement rested with the unpredictability and the insecurity that it provoked among established actors about "the limits and consequences of the protests". This novelty and unpredictability gave the protestors a strategic advantage, while authorities were unprepared for the new political moves, themes, and schemes. While at the initial level of protest movement, the level of flexibility is very high, they appear and disappear in changing settings and times.

A basic division of three types of publics, depending on "the levels of freedom" they are given by those who summon them, and also, we believe, dependent on publics' own capacities to exercise this freedom, it is particularly relevant in understanding the Global South–European South discussion, where we distinguish a similar triad of levels of actors' independence capacities: the minimal level, when activities are performed in the interests of others (similar to abject), when actorness is marginal due to limited resources (audiences' limited choice) and full-fledged actorness, including cognitive ability, free will to unlimited choices, and adequate resources to implement chosen strategies.

These tidal waves occupy an in-between position between a routine protest and a revolution which has the capacity to shake up the foundations of the polity and stir it to take a note of it, generate the policy debate, and inflict limited damage to the existing political regime's legitimacy and/or longevity in their intense and protracted interaction with the regime against which they stand up.

As one can see, the fiscally restrained and stretched states of the European South had been perfect places for the arrival of the new political/policy actors that shall be less conforming to the dictates of the financial market, shall have a better understanding about the obligations of the states to take care of the social goods, and shall have the horizontality of the communication response. Similarly, in the financial crisis stricken Italy, where the proliferated expenditure of the state has yet to come to terms with the demands of the financial institutions for implementing, trimming/shaving a range of wasteful social projects. The decade-long takeover of the bureaucratic

federal government's subtle and not-so-subtle attempts to expand the authorities have further complicated the problems and thus likewise created a window of opportunity for the protest community's convergence.

According to Tarrow, social movements emerge "when new opportunities are at hand—such as a less repressive climate, splits within the elite, or the presence of influential allies or supporters." Subsequently, protests spread through the diffusion of tactical innovations developed by early protesters to other themes, groups, and locations. The overwhelming decrease of credibility of the mainstream political parties has resulted in the decline of the political class, thus paving the way for the mobilization that has taken the form of the non-violent citizen protests and extra-parliamentary street politics (Andronikidou and Kovras 2012). McAdams further argues that the structure of political opportunities may provide protest groups with expanded political access and the incentive to act collectively; these in turn may increase their bargaining power and render repression costlier.

The Five Star Movement is massively surrounded around a comic who thinks and articulates it in a very impressive way, Beppe Grillo, which started in 2009 as a social movement with a cynical and dismissive attitude toward the mainstream of the politics. They started it with the anti-corruption stand, and foray into the electoral politics came after the snowballing of the approval ratings and when the campaign was lapped up by the weary Italian citizens exhausted with the mainstream corrupt politicians, austerity measures, and the shrinkage of the state's economic capacity to consolidate or sustain welfare policies. In a very short time, this political movement has gained an unprecedented success and become the second largest party in the Italian parliament besides leading the local governance in many cities.

4.1 The Collective Action of the Actor for Change: A Case Study of Podemos, Syriza, and Five Star Movement

Indignación [outrage] was the first engine of this process: an accumulated and collectively felt pulsation of outrage that influenced the people transversally with others in the public squares. The mediated discourse and the circularity of the discussion on the issue of crisis and its individual dimension led to the collective listening and deliberation. The sense of pain and fragility that was imposed from the authority under the name of "reforms" went beyond the singularization of the pain in the divided society. In the case of Spain, the consensus on the bottom line that "we are not commodities at the disposal of bankers and the politicians" ran across the Spanish citizenry like a wild fire. The assemblage at the public squares and the web space provided a virtual and real mediated space to multiply the empathy: "a feeling for the other" (cf. Berardi 2011). The 15M generated the counter possibilities where there is this desire to build the new worlds in common, where the wealth is at the service of social well-being. The mediated space and the engagement with the virtual and real

communication platform and the emergence of such manifests mean that there is a high degree of self-government and self-sufficiency.

While on the other hand in Greece, after the year 2010, by being inspired by a set of both internal and external factors, the Syriza party had gained motley of supporters in their grass-rooted growth plan. The protest publics that were highly nonparty affiliated ones consolidated and swarmed with their message to prevail over the opponent, the systemic and neoliberal political and economic policies. Meanwhile, on the other hand in Spain, the same centrality of both parties opened the space as one discussed through the "political opportunity structure" for the Indignados. With more than 20% unemployment, floods of exasperated people around the country followed suit, taking to the streets and organizing meetings in what became known as the Indignados or 15M, short for May 15 movement. 15M and Podemos in both their singular and collective operationalization of their actions maintain the very nonhierarchical, polycentric, and talent-based approach, and 15M decided to process their message across the regions of Spain. This internetworking of the distributed influences was highly effective for generating mutual trust among the very varied sections of protestors and the productive interconnections. It also managed to create the possibility of organizations both in the real and virtual spaces. By this approach of "swarming the enemies" they prevailed over their opponents, deploying the plurality of actors not only by numbers but by their socio-economic variance and attacking the targets. The eruption of 15M as a nonpartisan and nonunionist movement claiming a real democracy delegitimized the existing party system. The clarion called on the street by *Lo llamandemocracia y no loes, esunadictadura* [They call it a democracy but it is a dictatorship], *No nosrepresentan* [They do not represent us]. The poetic message provided by the 15M and echoed by millions across Spain affirmed a yearning for a whole new system based on direct, participative, horizontal, and absolute democracy.

No wonder, these economically troubled countries with their citizens' exhaustion with their political system were a ripe case for the new political stream and here with the vigor to counter the prevailing socioeconomic narrative with unprecedented force dawns the three sociopolitical amalgams in the respective countries, namely, Five Star Movement in Italy, 15M/Podemos in Spain, and Syriza in Greece. They are populist and based on the power of a productive and horizontal body as a desiring machine (Buchanan 1997) that is inventing its own practices of organization and action based on the network's expression and not representing active listening.

Observing the Spanish political class gives us an understanding that two-thirds of the congress is composed of the members of the representatives that are also sitting on the seats of profits and more than 89% of the elected parliamentarians are from higher-up administrative positions. This was questioned by the civil society in light of the talk of the austerity that was not walked by the parliamentarians. Thus, it opens up a wide gap between the political elites and the society and thus damages the legitimacy of the political institutions and creates the necessary fuel of mass frustration.

From the very beginning of the economic crisis, Spain had been harshly hit by a high unemployment rate, sometime reaching a dangerous level of 20%. The youth unemployment was twice higher with a rate of nearly 40%. In such an unenviable situation, the federal government of Spain wanted to implement the labor reform that made the labor market highly employer-friendly.

In response to that, trade unions demanded a general strike. From that time onwards, Spain's social and political space became agitated through the year to contest against the reforms in the employment sector. While the government kept rolling back the social support programs, the economic hardship did not become lighter. By the time the next European parliament elections occurred, the political movement of 15M had given birth to a political party called Podemos that came top in the opinion polls and managed to win more than a million votes and five seats in the EU parliament. Podemos generated a debate focused on political elites and on the political castes.

The opportunity and possibility of street activists to use the party as a vehicle for mobilization and as tool of highlighting the limitations of the present political system and for the demand for the economic distribution and impeccable social and economic function allowed Podemos to a massive range of support even though they had shown their generic frustration with the electoral politics in the very beginning by showing the futility of participation in the election and thus encouraged their core constituency too.

15M was directly inspired by the desire to change the mindset or behavior of political elites. Because the assemblies were only partially successful at attaining this end, more direct means were needed to make the point stick. The decreasing capacity of the organized left and its credibility being mired among the working class coupled with the disenchantment with the trade unions and the PSOE are critical factors for the emergence of the new parties both in Greece and Spain. The horizontals in the policy formation process, the circularity of the communication, and a nimble and highly mobile apparatus of the party that is youthful had caught the fancy and worked as an actor for changing and influencing the electoral agenda in the political arena of Spain. Its sit-in movement and problem-solving approach have their own flip side as these new parties don't have a linear commitment with an ideology and are instead more concentrated with the policy outcomes and systemic change.

These parties are anti-elite and anti-hierarchical in nature, and these new parties are, despite their anti-cult narratives, getting fixated with the central figure of the party, their political Messiah. It can be seen in the context of all the three parties discussed in the chapter (Syriza party, Five Star Party, and Podemos) that the identity of the party is so closely glued with the leadership of the party, namely, Alexis Tsipras, Beppe Grillo, and Pablo Manuel Iglesias Turrión.

This coupled with the political anemia that the body politic has faced in all these South European countries, which has not helped the case but has further complicated it by the further narrowing of the political representation of ideas and agenda and thus deteriorating by the narrowing down of the political positioning of the center-right and center-left political parties on the social and political agenda that became so

similar in their agenda setting that the governance model became highly homogeneous. Meanwhile, in Spain, the PSOE and PP parties had been jokingly named as PPSOE to explain the monopoly of the power maintained by both the political parties. In Greece, the political parties New Democracy and PASOK, despite being different in their political agenda, were caught knee deep in the ineffectual and corrupt policy implementation.

5 The Dilution of the Proper Nouns in the Protest and Forging of the Multitudes of the Invisibles: Global and European South

The other question is if there is a certain level of coherence and if there are similarities in this transformation of the publics in the vast swathe of the varied geographies with contrasting social, economic, and political capacities of the state. The post-2008 protest movement followed by the global financial crisis has broken the ground in its understanding where the power of the mobilization of the collective actor has been recognized as the critical factor where the contemporary reality of anti-austerity demands, mass mobilization against corruption demanding the better governance, operationalizing the contemporary phenomenon of anti-austerity movements (Fominaya and Cox 2013) while occupying the squares and the public places, condemning, naming, and shaming those who want to live at the expense of the invisible multitudes, where the protest appeared and surged beyond the structured conventional leadership of any political party.

The other key questions that kept hanging while examining the nimble and fluid dynamics of this collective actor-publics, are key issues that emerge like how extensive are the growth of, e.g., political discontent, the euro-skepticism in case of the (European South) funneled by the protesters that duels with all its might the all-powerful existing multi-layered system with limited resources? Has social media encouraged or discouraged political participation in the southern Europe, a new kind of participation that demands the monitoring power in the policy implementation thus gaining the turf of a watchdog? It is in these plethoric set of questions that this chapter tries to identify through observing the model of "actors for change," to obtain an understanding navigating through the maze of definitions of protest publics an empirical and deductive clarity for the conceptual frame of protest events through the cases in Italy, Spain, and Greece and while watching some of the mirror acts of the same in the Global South.

The protests of both the Global South and the European South witnessed this feature at all places, something that Podemos termed as the "collective intelligence," through the viral video produced by the citizens. It was witnessed in the case of the protest movements both in Spain and in India where the adroit usage of the professional workforce on the social networks that connects, keeping the information on the

websites with constant updates in the micro-donations that bring transparency, making online platforms in virtual spaces, and complimented with the Muhalla committee to keep at each level of the protesters remain participatory and with the sense of stakeholdership.

The case has been similar both in the Global and the European South with the adroit usage of the images from the popular culture and the dilution among the masses the personal appeal. The message etched on the hundreds of thousands of protestors adorned with Gandhi cap "I am Anna" mirrors the magnitude with "You are Podemos; Podemos are all of us," thus expanding the representativeness of the protest and engulfing even the hesitant peripheral support base and cementing further the turf gains.

This ground swelling of the demand from the publics for the new policy priorities and policy agendas did corner the indifferent authorities, thus rectifying and customizing the policy processes including the participation of the new actors with new policy outputs in particular the social policy and the welfare provision. Both in the cases of the non-Western Global South, with higher levels of agitated protests where there are plaguing issues of mal-governance, nepotism, rampant corruption, and the accumulated collapse of the social capital and crumbling public goods, the new voice of the protest publics both in the Global South and the southern Europe has articulated the populist demands that asked for participation in policy formation, demand for departure from the existing socioeconomic policies, and in certain cases setting the agenda for the policy change. The protest movements of the twenty-first century have a key component that identifies the demand of the civil society that wants a direct say on the issues in the policy space which directly concern their lives (Fominaya and Cox 2013).

5.1 Mediated Engagement of the Protestors: Horizontality and Increasing Circularity in Both the South Spaces

The process of forming of this mediated and converged space of the publics where the diverse social and economic community gets "united" as a formal union or organization has remained strikingly similar both in the Global South and in European South. This aware, agitated and outraged publics articulated the limits of the existing political system and encouraged with acts to keep an eye over the authorities, a regular enumerating and inventorying of the acts of omission and commission by the authorities in their mediated space, the maintained and consolidated a very horizontal distribution of the discussion platform with demands for change, course correction and in some cases complete overhauling of the existing system, thus cementing the formation of the mass jury of the publics, concluding in the arrival of the characteristics of publics in a watchdog role.

In the transferability and contagion capacity of the movement in a certain socioeconomic condition that transcends the geographical space, the increasing

appetite for agenda formation for the policies by the publics transforms consolidates and validates itself in stages. This process of hegemony building with the harmonization of the message, horizontality of the process, and the "increasingly gravitational centrifugal" force of the communication space is coupled with the political savvy to transform the very diverse and un-unionized public into a potent political force as seen both in the case of the Indignados and the India Against Corruption with the birth of the two non-mainstream political parties: Podemos and the AAP. The techno-politics that is knowledge-based and knowledge-generated and shared by the connected mass in the vast space of cyber territory generated a participatory usage for interaction, without much of a physical intervention and demanding change in the social system (action). These savvy self-managed and ever improvising and evolving communication spaces remain dialogical and keep the activism and contentious spirit handy in the 24 × 7 mode.

Communication between protesters was ensured with the help of social networks and chats. They even created web pages for fast communication and sharing the news. They were also discussing troubling messages, the variants of resolving the situation on the place of protests. A vision of a "certain public" that can suddenly emerge seemingly "out of nowhere" as a response to a message, which all those people want to react to by presenting themselves collectively in a public space, can also be applied to different kinds of mass gatherings, as they come together in masses for a common purpose, like a call to collective prayer. A broader view on this problem shows that changing time, changing in culture, technologies, and influence of globalization are working in a specific way.

The concerns of the countless millions of young people on their anti-corruption protest that rocked both the Global South and the European South's establishment have their normative roots somewhere in the common space. This core of an erstwhile apolitical citizen who is otherwise quite/sufficiently empowered in economic and educational terms wants to assert themselves to be a stakeholder in the new power pie with the aspiration. Besides, these six countries are all democratic countries where the freedom of expression and citizen rights are constitutionally protected. All the countries chosen in this category are over-stretched with their functional capacity.

This is helpful to remember that in each of these countries, the protest publics have formed themselves a somewhat operationalizing theoretical understanding of the protest publics. In many countries, their sociocultural and sociopolitical agitation alerted the political regime, and through contestation, they set the agenda both at the policy formation space and equally so in the policy evaluation platform. These protests in Brazil, India, and South Africa have showed the characteristics of a watchdog in the political system that does not only have a high barking capacity to raise the interest of the citizens' rights and to protect it but has also the necessary capacity to bite against the corrupt political practices as the case of Brazil and India has showed with the regime change.

It is timely to see one case from each of these two clusters: India and Spain; AAP (AamAadmi Party [Common Men Party]) and Podemos, respectively. Both of these political actors came up with issues related with the governance and the state's

apathy to the corruption, respectively. Yet, during the intensity of the political process of agitation, assemblage, and protest that shook their societal surrounding and inspired millions, both the Anna Andolan (named popularly after Anna Hazare's Anti-Corruption Movement) and 15M got further crystallized as the new political party vying for electoral victory even though they had started as a mass protest against the perils of poor governance.

In the case of AAP (AamAadmi Party), it has already swept the assembly election in one of the states of India (capital state of Delhi). Podemos is a serious political power in Spain and is from the striking distance from governance at the federal level. Yet, it is in power at the local governing bodies in Spain. One of the key features is that both of these countries (India and Spain) are highly integrated in the neoliberal economic and political system and free market. Yet the emergence of the new political actors that has taken its birth from the womb of protest publics' intense agitation has more of a redistributive and left to the center economic and political agenda where the maximum governance is synonymous with better governance.

The discourse on the meta-narrative is likewise shifted in the gradual manner from the combative streets to the deliberative electoral arena where Five Star Movement, Podemos, AAP, Syriza, and Democratic Alliance (South Africa) transformed as the main political adversary of the status quo, degenerative political corrosion, and a voice against the financial hardship through austerity, thus revamping strategically the discourse and create an "osmotic relationship" with protestors, progressively attracting new voters that reject not one of the core issues that bring them to the protest but are in line with the meta-narratives of the protest: lack of good governance is gently guiding them for rejection of the corrupt old establishment (Aslanidis and Marantzidis 2016, pp. 148–149).

6 Conclusion

Mass protest movements, which have been rolling over the globe for the last several years, are demonstrating that forms of citizens' self-organization have not been exhausted, and when conventional forms do not work or are perceived not to be effective, new forms emerge, like protest publics, whose major resource and transformative power lie in their discursive practices. There had previously been several theoretical frames created by social sciences to analyze various forms of public participation, and because its forms are rapidly evolving, analytical instruments should also evolve in order to keep up with social practice. This chapter suggested yet another theoretical model of addressing public protests, based on analysis of protesting publics, which emerge through those protest, which allows us to distinguish their different types according to the level of their actorness.

The protest publics' framework also allows us to explain their social origin not on the basis of demographic data or belonging to a particular social group, like "students," "workers," or "middle class," and not binding all of the diverse participants by

one "common interest," but, rather, disclosing its formation on the basis of shared discourse and common ethical demands toward the power structures. A completely new capacity of protesting publics is their ability to transform, rather than aggressively confront, their opponents, developing an alternative poetic discourse of the "other world possible."

Besides, the ideological decoupling from the very beginning of their electoral politics provides a better elbow room to maneuver and deliver, but on the other hand, it also generates lots of hitchhiker professionals and careerist to join the organization who might not have the ideological commitment. One of the situational changes that have occurred with the emergence of the new actors, who, in their earlier avatar, were the actors personified of the protest movement channeling the aspiration of the multitude of the invisibles, is the fact that many of them have re-cremated themselves in the mainstream of the political space.

The other cause of worry is that, though participatory democracy has been strengthened through the infusion of the new actors in their respective electoral landscape, it shall be useful to remain committed with the idea of governance as we can see in the case of Five Star Movement's electoral success that has not translated into a very smooth realization of the electoral dreams. Many members of the parliament affiliated with the Five Star Party switched their side, despite it being not a very common sight in the Italian politics. Besides, being a person-centric party creates a policy issue for the true democratic credentials of the new actors in the town, and in most likely of the cases, it is likely that it shall rather learn the tricks of the trade rather than to change the rules of the game if these new actors in the varied landscape of both European and Global do not preserve the horizontality of their discourse process. This is sad to note that in some cases (India), this resulted with the very indecent ouster of the one core of the leadership of the party.

On the positive note, this has to be said that the protest publics' last wave in both the Global South and in European South has resulted into the infusion of a fresh blood in the body politic of their respective mediated political space. Besides, these new parties have made the urbane and so far politically indifferent and mostly unaffiliated youth engage with the politics and thus have helped with the broadening and flattening of the pie of the electoral politics. What may be worrisome is that in some cases the realpolitik and the demand to remain on the top of this wave come with a cost: the actor for change gets trapped in the status quo, and besides the stray situational change and the policy change, the dream of institutional change remains as a verbal agenda.

As there are region-specific and case-specific variants, which one must include as variables as we continue to develop the concept of "protest publics," as such, there is still much work to be done. However, these variables also provide fruitful and pertinent information about the ways in which protest publics can manifest. For instance, as outlined above, Indian protest publics have been vocal and spontaneously self-organized in sustaining the process, and their coordinating capacity has been massively underpinned by the non-ideological common concern that affects the larger mass of the Indian publics. The democratic values and the neoliberal post-liberalized consumerist middle-class are more vocal both as an individual and in

demanding the accountability of the state, and they are quite complimentarily competing with some of the essential features that we found in the group of consolidated democracies both in the Global South and the European South.

On the other hand, the M5S started as an extra-parliamentarian protest movement governed by the charismatic leader Beppe Grillo, channeling the frustration of the public against its prevailing political regimes and the clogged political system that does not allow the circularity of the policy formational process and its expansion.

The idea of the anti-politic and anti-mainstream movement gravitates the publics that vie for less direct and minimum control by the entrenched mainstream political powers. This comparative discussion on the European South and the Global South protest has the primary question that relates with the significance of the participatory nature of the democracy itself, especially in the increasingly integrative transnational economic space as the routine changes in the government do not automatically translate into the different policies (Schäfer and Streeck 2013). Besides, the previous work on the "strange non-death of neo-liberalism" (Crouch 2011) still shows that the change of government does not necessarily translate into the core social and economic policy agenda.

In the conclusion, I do argue that the high hopes of the protest publics have certainly dented the existing political space in a significant way and thus generated the revitalization of the democracy. A popular resilience has thus invigorating capacity for the democratic space both in the Global South and in the European South. Yet in some cases, the dreamy eyes of the protest publics do get an eye opener when the "travails of the system" grip the souls of the very core of the publics who have been found struggling to see their agenda being implemented once in power, and in some cases, a sense of disillusionment takes over for the fragility of the publics who ebb into a watchdog by name only sans barking and in worst cases with the co-optation of the very core of this publics gradually get tamed or castrated with the trappings of the power thus waiting for the arrival of the next tsunami of publics and their protest!

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Conclusion: The Common Features and Different Roles of Protest Publics in Political Contestation



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In this conclusion we provide a summary of the chapters and consider the benefits of applying the protest publics' conceptual lens to the waves of protest that have broken out across the world in recent years. More specifically, we focus on the features of protest publics that were outlined in the introductory theoretical chapter and the extent to which these features can be found in the different country cases presented in the volume and how they help to understand local sociopolitical contexts. In this volume we argue that protest publics are a new phenomenon, though one that is variably connected with existing forms of social activism, and it allows for new kinds of collective civic engagement: protest publics, even though loosely organized and in certain circumstances can provide only modest immediate political results, still can be perceived as a collective actor that is capable of bringing about social and political change. As protest publics are often fluid and dynamic, at least compared with other, more institutionalized social and political actors, it is important to examine and thematize the dimensions of this fluidity. Further, the application of the protest publics framework in different political regimes will have strengths or limitations depending on the different functions that protest publics perform, which also needs to be specified. Finally, as this volume urges a renewed focus on protest studies, we will conclude with some principle questions that can be pursued in future research.

The main features of protest publics were identified in the theoretical chapter, reconstructed from initial features of "public" suggested by Warner (2002). Focusing on a specific type of publics, which are a "necessary part of democratic life" and "crucial to [the] politics of social space" (Blaustein 2004), we identified key features of protest publics. Those features include:

– Assembling in response to a "troubling message"

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N. Belyaeva et al. (eds.), *Protest Publics*, Societies and Political Orders in Transition,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-05475-5_16

- Self-organization beyond the state and other pre-existing authorities (structures)
- Creating open public spaces for the development of a common discourse
- Intensive and regular discourse circulation
- Collective creativity and the ability to produce a "poetic vision" of the new world

We will now explore which of those features are clearly found in the country cases presented in this volume. The *troubling message* that causes broad public concern and provokes mass mobilization can be incredibly diverse: from the self-immolation of a street vendor in Tunisia to raising of the bus fares in Brazil, from the change of electoral law in Hong Kong to the announcement of parliamentary election results in Russia, and from a call on citizens to pay the debts of private banks in Iceland to the broadly spread videos of police brutality against peaceful ecological protest in Taksim square in Turkey. What was common among all such messages is the information about events that became a "symbol of trouble"—of a larger, nation-wide problem that is perceived by citizens as a grave violation of their rights and a dereliction of government duties and responsibilities. It is often viewed as an insult to civic dignity which provokes broad public outrage that results in a quick—sometimes almost immediate—emotional reaction that is shared through social networks and leads to protest mobilization. The authors of the volume demonstrate the importance of the circulation of this "troubling message" because it allows us to understand the deep reasons of the protests and types of publics that reacted to this message. As Olaffson writes in his chapter on Iceland: "It is not the economic crisis as such that led to prolonged protest action, it was the collapse of trust in government. Icelanders now saw themselves as victims of greed, corruption and incompetence."

Self-organization beyond the state seems to be a generic feature of all public mobilizations, because their protest is usually targeted against state actions, but there is an important additional condition in the case of protest publics: they should be organized not only outside the state but also outside of other pre-existing structures, like political parties, unions, or Churches. It means that the organizational connections between protesters have to be new, created by participants themselves.

One good illustration of this kind of self-organization beyond pre-existing structures is the Generation in Trouble [*Geração à Rasca*] protest in Portugal on March 12, 2011. As described in this volume by Tomas et al. (Chapter "Retracing Protest Publics in Portugal: A Generation in Trouble"), the discourse of this protest formed during the concerts of Deolinda musical group with the song "I'm such a fool" expressing the desperate situation of young Portuguese graduates: their jobless status or low-paid precarious work and unclear future. The song was put on YouTube and quickly spread around the country fostering a process of identification within the broader public that was deeply troubled by the parlous condition of the job market. While the protest itself was organized by just four young people—using Facebook—Alexandre Corvallo, Antonio Frazao, Joao Labrincha and Paula Gil—it had brought 200,000 unemployed and low-paid people—young and old—out into the streets in several cities, protesting against a precarious labor market and a lack of social welfare. Importantly, the protests were organized beyond parties and unions in a way that was usual when compared with

previous cases of protest in Portugal. This case shows how artistic performances can be appropriated by the public and employed in protests.

Another example of self-organization is Occupy Wall Street in the USA and the UK, when protesters created camps, governed by participants, or the Coordination Council of (Russian) Opposition to coordinate protest activities in Moscow in 2011–2012, which was elected by protest participants by internet voting. At the same time some countries had cases which were more entangled with institutionalised actors. For example, anti-austerity protests in the UK were organized by the National Union of Students (NUS) and later joined by Trade Union Congress, whose history dates back to 1866. In Brazil, new organizations were created, like the Free Fare Movement which cooperated in various ways with established movements—such as the Black, LGBT, and Housing Movements. These examples show that "organizing pre-existing structures" may be necessary for relatively sustained protest campaigns.

Creating public spaces that are needed for common discourse development and circulation is understood as an activity traversing on- and offline spaces. It includes arranging physical meetings and rallies made up of protesting people as well as sharing information through traditional and social media, organizing different educational events and public deliberations, and sharing common slogans and demands. Here there is a clear advantage for publics in democratic countries, like the UK, Iceland, or USA, where both the physical and virtual spaces are less restrictively managed than in countries with authoritarian or hybrid regimes. Public meetings and rallies are protected by respect of the right to freedom of peaceful assembly and digital spaces by freedom of expression and the existence of independent media. Thus, in the wake of the 2008 crisis in Iceland when major banks collapsed leading to financial and political crisis, the newly founded "Citizens Association" gathered in the largest cinema theater in Reykjavik without asking the permission of authorities. They invited all members of parliament and ministers to discuss the crisis and its causes. The discussion was broadcasted directly by national TV (Chapter "So Strong, yet So Weak: The Emergence of Protest Publics in Iceland in the Wake of the Financial Crisis").

Similarly, both Occupy Wall Street and Occupy London organized long-lasting, open camps, where people lived in tents for many months and were able to hold all sorts of events there, which were also covered by national and international mainstream media. This made world news, expanding such public spaces of discourse circulation to the global level (Della Porta and Mattoni 2014; Della Porta 2017). In authoritarian regimes, on the contrary, open spaces are controlled by government, and unauthorized street gatherings were met by police with tear gas and rubber bullets, in some cases leading to the loss of life. Mainstream media is also controlled by the government, either ignoring mass protests or labeling them as "traitors." Therefore, protest publics had to rely on social media, with most using Facebook, Twitter, and YouTube. In closed regimes such deliberative spaces were organized by protest participants, informal coalitions, like the Taksim Solidarity group in Turkey. This group brought together 128 different communities from professional associations to neighbor networks. Without centralized leadership or party affiliation, this

group served as an "information hub" disseminating the main demands of the protesters (Chapter "'Shoulder to Shoulder Against Fascism': Publics in Gezi Protests"). Another similar deliberative space was created by the 20 February Movement in Morocco, organized via a Facebook group, and brought together 119,000 participants.

Intensive and regular discursive exchange and development are crucial for consolidating the "actorness" of protest publics, because in all country cases collected in this volume, these publics were extremely diverse, and their initial demands and grievances were different. In order to keep these social groups together as a collective capable of common action, the participants have to invent instruments of regular exchange, in order to have one vision and speak one language. Particularly in long-lasting protests, the circulation of discourse serves three main goals:

- Exchanging information on recent protest events as they are often de-centralized
- Suggesting discursive and other responses to government statements or actions
- Providing a sense of mutual support and solidarity

The conditions are propitious for these goals when such protest emerges in a democratic country, like Italy, and an opportunity to stay connected through the online platform is provided by a personal blog of a famous public figure, such as popular comedian Beppe Grillo, who was assisted by a professional internet consultant, Gianroberto Casaleggio. As described in the chapter "Five Stars of Change: The Transformation of Italian Protest Publics Through Grillo's Blog", the rise of the Five Stars Movement in Italy began from the public discussions on Beppe Grillo's blog, which were sharply critical of the corrupt political establishment in Italy, and promoted ideas of direct democracy. The internet platform of the Five Stars Movement became a "powerful modern 'agora'"—a space dedicated to public speech for thousands of people, transforming them from a passive audience to active citizens. In late 2005, an online "MeetUp" platform was created to promote local autonomous self-organization of activists, allowing them to interact and move from Internet to street protests against the privileged "cast."

After street protests and a number of national "Days of Anger," MeetUp groups transferred into groups of political activists, and on October 4, 2009, the political program "Five Stars" was launched, based on the demands raised through online discussions and interpersonal deliberations. Those demands included five main points: water as public resource, environmental protection, public transport instead of private mobility, free internet connection for all citizens, and the promotion of renewable energy and rubbish recycling. Though those five program points may look very simple, it took almost 4 years of intense online discussions—from 2005 to 2009—to develop this program, and when the first 36 local deputies were elected throughout Italy on the basis of this program, the Five Stars Movement established itself as a recognized political actor.

As for the "intensiveness of discourse circulation," which continued on the Movement's platform after the first electoral success in 2010, there were about 200,000 visitors every day and several thousand comments for each post (Chapter "Five Stars of Change: The Transformation of Italian Protest Publics Through Grillo's Blog").

This intensive communication allows us to predict stable public involvement and support: in the 2013 national election, the Movement won 25% of seats in the National Parliament and in 2018, 32.5%. This could be seen as a success story, but after 2009, the Five Star Movement was no longer a protest public but a part of the political establishment which it initially protested against.

Some contrasting examples in respect of the regularity of discursive exchange come from nondemocratic countries, where protests against the regime are not tolerated or heavily controlled. This means that government would try to prevent communication among protesters, blocking open physical spaces where people can meet, controlling mainstream media so the protesters can rely only on social networks. In this case what becomes extremely important is the quality of publics that participate in protests, their capacities to sustain communication, mutual support and encouragement even under threats and pressure.

Observing the different results of protests in Tunisia, Egypt, and Morocco, we see that Tunisia made a strong move toward democracy, while Egypt re-established military rule, and Morocco made very modest changes to its Constitution, slightly limiting the power of the Monarchy, introduced under the full control of the King himself. One possible explanation here is quality of protest publics: "participants in Morocco and Egypt were mostly middle-aged, middle class professional and religious, while protesters in Tunisia were younger, more secular, educated and significantly more diverse in social composition" (Chapter "Protest Publics as Democratic Innovators in Authoritarian Environments"). This shows that the Tunisian public was more capable of social network communications, and discourse circulation, than in some other countries.

Collective creativity and the ability to produce a "poetic vision" of the new world desired by protesters make the protests memorable even after the protest wave dies away. Such visions, often distilled into short messages, combine the major ideas these publics promote with a strong emotional drive, which makes such messages powerful. A relevant example here comes from Occupy Wall Street's "We are the 99%," counterposing the majority (and its needs) with the unjust distribution of global wealth. In the countries of the Arab Spring—Tunisia, Egypt, and Morocco—there were several shared messages, like "Our hearts are burning," "Game over," and "Freedom, Bread and Justice," that speak for themselves.

India's large rally against corruption began with a one-man protest by an old Gandhian activist Anna Hazare, aged 73. His individual protest against the state machinery, which has been unable to control widespread corruption, was perceived as a symbol around which hundreds and thousands rallied, developing his message to indicate solidarity with his demands, both by extended messages by diverse social and religious groups: "Hindu, Muslim, Sikh and Christians all are supporting Anna" or just by a simple phrase, carried by hundreds of individuals: "I'm Anna Hazare." Net activists created even shorter messages, used as hashtags #ISupportAnna, #quitCorruption, and #CleanMyIndia (Chapter "Emergent Protest Publics in India and Bangladesh: A Comparative Study of Anti-corruption and Shahbag Protests"). But there were also visual symbols that can work as a common expression of the envisioned future, like the symbol of a broom, presumably to be used for cleaning the country and Gandhi Topi as a call to

return to Gandhian traditions (Chapter "Protest Publics as the "Watchdogs" of the Quality of Democracy in the Polyarchies of the Global South").

During the Gezi protests in Turkey, the most popular slogans were "Everywhere is Taxim, resistance everywhere" and "This is just the beginning, continue to struggle." But there were not only slogans; the collective creativity of protesters produced and widely shared many photos and videos that used a common behavioral strategy "disproportionate intelligence" as a response to the disproportionate violence of police. As Ekim Arbatli notes, "this concept of 'disproportionate intelligence' became a prevalent discourse of protest publics about themselves: more resourceful, more educated and more open-minded crowds," involved in "creative forms of civil disobedience and resistance" (Chapter "'Shoulder to Shoulder Against Fascism': Publics in Gezi Protests"). A symbolic image of such behavior was a photo of a young protester standing against the riot police in Gezi Park and reading a book to three (equally young) police officers, dressed for action (Chapter "'Shoulder to Shoulder Against Fascism': Publics in Gezi Protests"). What is demonstrated from these examples is that the poetic vision of the future could be presented not only through words, but also through visual imagery and other artistic forms. These images are not less powerful and can become an enduring part of the public imaginary, calling for a future where intelligent and dignified citizens are the majority.

Speaking of creative forms of civil disobedience during the protest actions, it is worth having a look at Macedonia and its "Sharenata Revolucija"—the Colorful Revolution. Its name had a direct outcome—participants had water balloons filled with paint to vandalize the artificially changed facades of the city and institutions of power, responsible for the political crisis in the country. Clearly, using color gave an excellent chance for publicity, but it was arguably a less interesting innovation than the various forms of protest behavior inspired by the idea of disobedient "misconduct." These behaviors took the following forms: a protest choir "Singing Skopjans;" #protestiram (protesting) through sealing the entrances of institutions to claim a right to them; concerts and poetry at the anti-government camp; plena of all types; alternative educational city tours, to make new ownership claims over the changed city; and symbolic gestures, such as giving flowers to police officers or mocking police authority by using the reflection from police shields to apply lipstick (Chapter "The Grammar of Protest Publics in Skopje, Macedonia, May 2015"). To a certain extent, such behavior can also be recognized as evoking a "poetic vision of the future," where the city does not belong to bureaucrats and security services but to a positive, intelligent, and creative crowd, which welcomes citizens and visitors with music, poetry, and performances of all sorts. This is a vision of the future, presented through direct action. The selected examples of all the five major features by which protest publics are characterized show the tremendous diversity between countries but at the same time suggest the potential for an overarching framework for the analysis of their mass protest events.

The suggested framework proved to be useful for explaining how protest publics emerge, self-organize, create public space, and prove the importance of lasting and

intensive discursive exchange and circulation and a "poetic vision of the future" that inspires and mobilizes protesters for collective action.

In the second part of the book we define and describe in detail four models of how protests publics figure in politics, policy development, processes of democratization and function as drivers of social change. It is generally believed that protest movements effect greater changes in embedded democracies and achieve little or even are destroyed in authoritarian regimes. We come to more complex conclusions beyond this received wisdom that protest publics contribute to social change in polyarchies, where major democratic institutions are already established. However, there is still much more space for further democratic consolidation and deepening the quality of democracy (see Voss and Williams 2012). This has happened due to the special role that protest publics took up as watchdogs that protest publics took up thanks to the specific conditions and configuration of political actors' coalitions that are found in some of the countries of Global South (Chapter "Protest Publics as the "Watchdogs" of the Quality of Democracy in the Polyarchies of the Global South") and Southern Europe (Chapter "The Transforming Role of Protest Publics in Processes of Sociopolitical Change in the Global South and Southern Europe: From Occasional Challengers to Institutionalized Watchdogs"). In authoritarian countries, despite the repression of civil society, protest publics still have a space to establish and develop democratic practices (Chapter "Protest Publics as Democratic Innovators in Authoritarian Environments"). In embedded democracies, protest publics experience great resistance from the established institutions and the consolidated position of political actors that want to keep their monopolistic power position. Here protesters challenge this political status quo and fight for equal political representation (Chapter "Protesters as the "Challengers of the Status Quo" in Embedded Democracies: The Cases of Iceland, the United Kingdom, and the United States"). The most controversial impact of protests publics on social change can be seen in the hybrid regimes of Arab countries. Here we have cases that experienced great success in advancing democratization (Tunisia) along with others which provoked further authoritarianism (e.g. Egypt). Along with the influence of specific conditions, the role of veto players seems crucial for the dynamics of political trajectories observed in these countries. Civil society organizations are driving democratic change and seem to have more progressive roles than military elites in the Arab countries (Chapter "Protest Publics as the "Triggers" of Political Changes in Hybrid Regimes: The Cases of Tunisia, Morocco, and Egypt").

But there is another issue that needs to be explored: as protest publics are usually loosely organized and fluid, what happens to them when the active stage of protest is over? The materials taken from country cases collected in this volume allow us to consider the possible trajectories that protest publics can take and suggest at least five possible scenarios.

First could be called *exhaustive*: it is when the protest exhausts its energy and driving force and disappears from public space. One example here is Occupy Wall Street, which did not effect much institutional change but produced both a very powerful poetic message and a format of lasting protest activity.

Second might be referred to as *delegatory*: when protest publics through their discursive power bring new matters into the national political agenda and then "delegate" it to legitimate authorities to deal with, ensuring that conventional political institutions are working on this agenda. A case here might be Portugal's "Generation in Trouble," where protesters brought the issue of precarious labor into political debate and policy making, trusting that authorities will find solutions.

Third, as often happened in nondemocratic and hybrid regimes, was a relationship between *manipulative* and *co-optative* dynamics which occur when protest publics are "captured" by more powerful actors, like the monarchy or military, such as in the cases of Morocco and Egypt, making publics agree to new rules, established largely without their participation (Chapter "Protest Publics as Democratic Innovators in Authoritarian Environments").

Fourth might be called *openly repressive*, that is, when the protests are brutally cracked down upon by police and government security forces, criminal charges are brought against activists, and the level of rights and freedoms is severely cut. Some relevant cases here are the Bolotnaya protests in Russia and the Gezi protest in Turkey.

Fifth, and the most favorable scenario, is *transformativ*e, when protest publics having mobilized citizens for active political participation are transformed into different conventional actors of the political process. In our cases the most visible examples are Iceland, where protesters had created several political parties, though not very powerful and short-lived, except for the Pirate Party. Another example is India where the Aam Aadmi Party was created, while Anna Hazare created a nonpartisan movement, and Italy, where protest publics grew over a period of several years wherein their internal structure and constitutive discourses changed as it transformed into a Party Movement, becoming a major political force in the country.

There are three main issues that are discussed in the literature on these new waves of protest that recognizes their specific characteristics and how they differ from "traditional" social movements: a lack of institutionalization, an absence of clear leadership, and a focus on common demands, rather than on common identity. The research presented in this volume, provided, among other things, its diffferent cases and foci, does not provide a unified position on these matters; rather, it raises a number of questions that we consider part of an agenda for future research.

The lack of the institutionalization is seen by many authors as a major drawback of protest publics, insofar as it does not allow them to work consistently through a well-organized internal structure, which provides a division of labor, good planning and coordination, and an overall stronger capacity for actorness. But from another angle a loose organization is an advantage, which allows protest publics to be flexible, fluid, adapt easily to unexpected circumstances, respond to arising challenges through the initiatives of regular members—with not much need for overall coordination when unfolding events demand an immediate response. At the same time, the chapters show that in all cases, publics were self-organized, ensuring their actorness through some, internal coordinating structures. Besides, "self-organization"

is one of the key features of protest publics, so the question is about the degree of such self-organization, which may vary from case to case.

Responding to those different approaches, the following research question could be formulated for the future studies: which political context demands more or less internal organization and institutionalization of protest publics?

A similar question arises regarding the leadership. The absence of a designated leader can be seen as an advantage, as it provides for horizontal connections between participants, more spontaneous initiatives and collective decision-making. Leadership becomes somewhat dispersed in the public, when everyone, depending on the circumstances, can try to assume leadership functions and take responsibilities for some local activities, which may strengthen the public. On the other hand, if there is a strategic plan to transform a particular protest public into a conventional political actor, such a legitimate leader may be helpful in providing strong support for such a goal.

Finally, the question of common identity is also seen by our authors from different points of view. Accepting the conceptual view by Warner that publics are united by common discourse, rather than a common identity, many authors in this volume still describe repeated attempts by protest publics to develop such an identity, particularly in the chapters on India and Turkey. This may be yet another avenue for further research: how much is such a common identity needed for the functioning of protest publics, if they demand some immediate policy or political change and do not pursue a strategy to transform into a conventional social movement, where common identity is one of key factors of success? We believe that by applying the protest publics framework, this volume had opened up a new perspective on studies of protests and collective action, citizen mobilization, and political participation, by examining and exploring a new actor of political change: the self-organized protest public. It is our hope that this volume will provoke further dialogue and debate around the theory of publics and its relevance to the wave of protests that has swept across the world in recent years. It is just a first step of many more that, we hope, will follow.

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